All I Hear Are Echoes

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/40864179.

Rating:	Teen And Up Audiences
Archive Warnings:	Graphic Depictions Of Violence, Major Character Death
Category:	M/M
Fandom:	僕のヒーローアカデミア | Boku no Hero Academia | My Hero Academia
Relationships:	Bakugou Katsuki/Midoriya Izuku, Aizawa Shouta | Eraserhead/Yamada Hizashi | Present Mic
Characters:	Midoriya Izuku, Midoriya Inko, Aizawa Shouta | Eraserhead, Sensei | All For One, Okuta Kagerou | Giran, Dabi | Todoroki Touya, Toga Himiko, Tsukauchi Naomasa, Bakugou Katsuki, Iguchi Shuuichi | Spinner, Bubaigawara Jin | Twice, Takami Keigo | Hawks, Yagi Toshinori | All Might
Additional Tags:	Alternate Universe - Canon Divergence, Slow Burn, Midoriya Izuku Does Not Have One for All Quirk, Minor Character Death, Villain Midoriya Izuku, Vigilante Midoriya Izuku, Most everyone is very confused, outsider pov, Nerfed moments of awesome, BAMF Midoriya Izuku, Time Loop, did i say slow burn? i meant glacier pace, Implied/Referenced Torture, Quirk Destroying Drug, Dadzawa, Midoriya Izuku Needs Therapy, The power of friendship, Implied/Referenced Suicide, Bakugou Katsuki's Emotional Constipation, Implied Sexual Content, Izuku's A++ Ideas, Panic Attacks, Implied/Referenced Child Abuse, Amputation, Awkward Romance
Language:	English
Collections:	The best fics, Rhynes MHA favs, MHA Fics that I think about constantly, soul healing comes from fanfiction, 🌌 The Witch's Library, BNHA/MHA, Bakudeku but not toxic, .🌌Thoth's Luxury Library🌌., quetegustandebnh
Stats:	Published: 2022-08-07 Updated: 2024-09-30 Words: 173,353 Chapters: 41/?

All I Hear Are Echoes

by TGP

Summary

When Midoriya Izuku breaks pattern, his mother isn't the only one to notice. She's just the only one to know at first that it's *him*.

A new figure rising to power threatens to topple what little stability there was to the criminal underground but whether he's a friend or foe to the heroes isn't quite clear. One thing's for sure: those that come up against him tend to end up regretting it.

Then again, so do the heroes he keeps contacting with tips.

Notes

Narrative starts out a little weird but hopefully not too off putting. This chap is def more of a "scene setter" type.

Tags will be added as the story progresses.

See the end of the work for more notes

Chapter 1

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

April

All Might didn't have much time left before the sludge villain captured a boy and he certainly doesn't afterward. The boy is polite and calm after he wakes up, barely looking All Might in the face. His breathing sounds clear, he'll probably be fine, and All Might can feel that he just does not have the time to take him to the hospital to be checked out. He's already signed the notebook the boy carried and cheerfully sets off to find somewhere quiet that he can drop out of his muscle form.

He thinks nothing of the boy after. There's no way All Might could possibly remember the face of every person he saves.

May

Midoriya Inko is used to her son's obsessive personality. She's always admired his drive, the way he just keeps trying no matter what. Watching him turning that sort of ambition towards a goal she knows in her heart is impossible has been pure torture, even as she hopes and prays to be wrong.

"Why?" she asks as she looks at his list of high schools to apply for and doesn't see UA. The smile on Izuku's face is the one he uses in photographs to lie about being happy. She's seen it enough times in the pictures they've taken to send to Hisashi to know the difference between it and the real thing.

"Maybe it's just time to start being realistic about my future," he says and it's almost enough for her to believe him, but Inko has been watching this boy for fourteen years. There's no way she wouldn't know he was trying to hide something from her.

She wonders what someone said that finally broke his resolve. A steady beat of guilt fills her chest at her own relief.

They talk about the schools, about possible jobs for the quirkless. Most jobs can absolutely be done without a quirk. Her son has a future, they just need to find what can make him happy, where he can find his place. Izuku's more distracted than usual but they come up with a list of jobs to look into.

When she hugs Izuku and tells him she's proud of him, she tries to believe he shares her hope. It's all that will keep her steady. She concentrates on helping him apply to schools, getting any study materials he needs, even changing up their diet when he mentions wanting to be healthier. Whatever she can do to help her son succeed, she will do it!

Izuku joins an after school study group that meets nearly every day and Inko hopes he makes more friends. In the last few years, she's barely seen Katsuki except at a few school functions and Izuku never has much to say about him, except concerning his quirk. He never talks about anyone else, either. It's… worrying. She can't remember the last time he had a friend over.

No one from the study group ever comes by and she's not sure where it's being held, but whatever will help her son meet his future head on, she's in favor of.

"How was the group tonight?" she asks when he gets home and then blanches at the sight of his face. "Izuku!"

"It's okay," he says with that lying smile, gently nudging her hands away from his face where his eye is bruising half shut. "I wasn't looking where I was going."

Her heart clenches but she just fetches an ice pack to help with the swelling she can already see. It's little comfort that he lets her dote on him. No matter how she prods, Izuku refuses to give her the truth. He says it was an accident, he says he was clumsy, he says he was careless. By the time he goes to bed, she's half convinced that her intuition is wrong.

A week later, she notices dark bruising all down one of his arms like something huge slammed into him, or he into it. He won't tell her what happened.

Another few days and she has to take him to the hospital to get two fingers splinted together because he fractured both knuckles. He still won't tell her anything.

Inko redoes the budget and finds just enough money to enroll him in a self defense class, and the look on his face when she tells him about it breaks her heart. The lying smile is plastered on his mouth and his eyes… She quickly finds a reason to escape to her room to cry because she can't stand how broken inside her little boy is.

He doesn't put up a fight about going to the defense classes. The injuries keep happening, but either they're less noticeable or he just gets better and better at hiding them from her. She's not sure there's anything she can do to make it stop, but at least she hopes the class will help keep him somewhat safer. He won't talk to her but she's getting used to that.

June

The Midoriya kid is… weird. Ojiro Mashirao thought so the first time he showed up a couple weeks back to the beginner's class he assists his uncle with and still does. When he's not directing the youngest of the group in their practice moves, Mashirao can't help but have his eyes drawn over. The new kid is his age, serious personality, non-martial quirk as far as he can tell. Nothing all that notable. Normally, no one Mashirao would spend much thought on when he's got other things to do, but his attention keeps drifting back to him.

Midoriya Izuku moves like he knows what he's doing but his body doesn't. Or, more that his body can't keep up with his mind. In just the last two weeks, he's already topped the rest of the class just by building up his strength and stamina. Mashirao's only sparred with him a

few times but he's pretty sure Midoriya's going to end up a total beast, which just makes him that much weirder with how late he's apparently started martial arts.

"I wonder who trained him before us," Uncle Haruto says after the others have filed out to clean up and go home. Mashirao glances up at him. "Midoriya. Someone must have. You noticed it too, right? His reflexes are slow, but…"

"Yeah. Like he's just out of practice."

Uncle Haruto shakes his head and sends Mashirao off with a little wave and thanks for the help. Mashirao decides he's thought enough about Midoriya's weirdness enough for one day.

Two days later, when he's out on an errand for his mother, Mashirao happens across Midoriya again. The municipal beach park is a total pigsty they all kind of ignore, no reason for anyone to be around in, but Mashirao slows to a stop when he spots a familiar head of curls. And Midoriya's… organizing the trash? Mashirao squints to get a better look but… Maybe Midoriya's just really into community service? Either way, there seems to be some kind of method to his madness. Midoriya tackles each object in specific ways and Mashirao mentally maps out the muscle groups he's working. No wonder Midoriya's been bulking up noticeably if this is how he spends his free time.

Well. There's nothing wrong with taking on a task like this. Still weird but Mashirao guesses everyone's got their idiosyncrasies. He decides it's none of his business and goes on to finish his errand. He has homework to do.

November

Aizawa Shouta doesn't patrol everyday anymore. Not since he started teaching. That doesn't mean his usual haunts are any less protected, of course. He just uses a lot of surveillance when he's not out.

For the last two months, when he's out, he feels eyes on him. He can't ever quite figure out where the feeling comes from, nor does it happen every time. Whether there's someone around or if it's some kind of quirk watching him from afar. His usual suspects don't change their behaviors, nothing else catches his attention. Nothing else has changed.

Until one night when it does.

"Has All Might started training his successor yet?" The question comes out of nowhere when he's two steps away from the edge of a roof, considering his jump to the next one. Shouta's turning before the question finishes, capture scarf already in motion because it's not a voice he recognizes, unlikely to be a fellow hero. The speaker doesn't even dodge the scarf wrapping around his torso to pin his arms nor react as Shouta activates his quirk.

Small, lean, male presenting. Dressed in a dark gray hoodie and jeans with a black mask covering the bottom half of his face. Large eyes, color indeterminate in the low light. The hood is up, covering his hair, but there are a few dark curls over his forehead.

“Who’s asking?” Shouta asks without releasing him. He still doesn’t recognize him so worst case it’s a villain and best case an unlicensed vigilante. Either case he has every right to hold him for questioning.

“Doesn’t matter.” The stranger sounds young and with his frame, Shouta figures a teenager. “Has All Might started training his successor yet or not?”

“I don’t know what you’re talking about.”

The kid sighs. “I don’t know why I thought this might work.”

“How about you tell me why you think All Might has a successor in the first place?” Because the fact that he’s even looking for one isn’t close to common knowledge. As far as Shouta knows, only a few select teachers at UA and some of the police are aware of All Might’s injury and his steadily weakening state.

“That doesn’t matter either.” Ugh, save him from arrogant vigilante punks. “I need you to pass a message to him.”

“And why do you think I’ll play messenger for you?”

The kid doesn’t roll his eyes but Shouta is pretty certain he wants to. “He won’t take it seriously from some nobody. It needs to come from someone he trusts and respects. Tell him to start Mirio’s training immediately or he’ll be dead within six months.”

Togata Mirio, second year, very promising hero in training. Currently interning long term with Sir Nighteye’s agency. The fact that he’s even a candidate for All Might’s successor is even less known than him looking for one in the first place. And as far as Shouta knows, All Might hasn’t settled on him yet.

Shouta’s eyes narrow behind his goggles. This kid knows *way* more than he has any business knowing and is making inferences that could be more than dangerous if he shares it with the wrong people. Whoever the leak is, Shouta needs to get this info over to Nedzu. They need to nip this *quickly.*

“Sounds like you’ve got a lot to say,” he says as he starts walking towards the kid. “How about we continue this conversation somewhere more comfortable?”

The kid says nothing, eyes never leaving Shouta’s face. It’s an unnerving stare that’s quickly getting under his skin. He starts to loosen the scarf as a show of trust because it will be easier to move him if the kid cooperates, but the moment he does the kid’s in motion. A reflex tightens the scarf again but the kid’s already cleared most of it and Shouta only catches his ankle. It should be enough to trip him - It’s not. As the kid’s body twists into a back handspring, a knife practically materializes in one hand and slices through the end of the scarf like butter before it can go taut. The kid vaults back onto his feet, knife sliding away back into his clothing as Shouta shoots after him.

Whoever trained the kid is good. Shouta feels a strange sense of deja vu noting moves that are a little too familiar, a little too like his own. The kid doesn’t try to land a hit nor does he

make any offensive moves, just glides around Shouta's hands and scarf on his way back towards the other side of the roof. Every attempt Shouta makes to cut off his path is deftly avoided until the kid makes a leap to the next roof.

Then it's a chase. Shouta hasn't had someone smart enough to evade him in a while and he's not enjoying it. The kid isn't any faster than him but the eerie similarities to his own moveset keep jumping out at him. He starts wondering if the kid's just been stalking him long enough to have learned through observation but no. You don't get this good so young without serious training with someone who knows what they're doing or years to develop something workable. This kid has been *molded* this way. And that knife? There aren't many that can cut through something like his capture weapon, much less so easily.

Which makes it that much more frustrating when a scream rips through the air and Shouta has to let him escape to take care of an attempted robbery. He makes sure the woman isn't injured, hands over the perp to the police, and then begrudgingly does a circuit knowing he won't find the kid again.

He doesn't.

When he tells Nedzu about it, the principal just gives a little interested hum and tells him to be on the lookout for the kid again. Someone that good is sure to turn up again and maybe even on their side, if the warning is anything to go by. Shouta isn't sure he's got the same kind of hope.

They pass the kid's message to All Might, who thanks them with the most grave expression. What that means for his decision Shouta isn't about to start guessing, but if the boy's life is in danger he knows All Might will make the right choice. He's a lot more worried about how the kid knew anything in the first place. They make a plan to test out the faculty, grimly aware of how painful this is going to be with the entrance exam for next year's new kids only a few months away.

March

Giran doesn't like dealing with untried newbies. Anyone he's talking to has a verified body count or rap sheet depending on their specialty, a string of successful jobs, something that can prove to his clients that they're worth his consultation fee. Thing is, he also knows talent when he sees it, so when he meets up with the kid he'd sold a set of specialized micro edged knives to half a year ago, he lets his gut guide him.

"If you're looking for a *real* debut, I've got just the job," he says with a grin and the kid stares at him from under his hood, green eyes laser focused on his face. He's small game right now, using his head and keeping his hands clean just the way Giran does. Information, strategy, the kinds of things other small fries are in exceedingly short supply of. The quirk analysis Giran accepted as payment for the knives had been ridiculously thorough, probably the best he's ever seen. The kid's not charging much, peanuts compared to what Giran got from selling that one analysis alone, but with a trusted name backing him that'll change quick.

“If you’re trying to recruit me for the League of Villains’ suicide mission, you’re wasting your time,” the kid replies. “I’m not nearly flashy or stupid enough for that.”

Giran snorts. Figures the kid had heard about that. Nice that he’s smart enough to stay out of it. Giran may have pointed a few folks he’d rather not keep around their way. “Nah, you’d be wasted on that one. You figure out what we should call you yet?”

Right now, he’s being referred to as the Green Eyed Brat or That Asshole Who Knows His Shit.

“I didn’t say I hadn’t decided,” the kid says, unimpressed. “I said I wasn’t *telling* you.”

“Kiddo it is then.” Giran grins wider at the sigh that gets him. “I’ve got a real job for you. Good test of your skills for some interested folks, good way to pave your path to better and brighter things.”

“Who’s the client?”

“You know it doesn’t work that way. I’m a broker, not a snitch.”

Kiddo shrugs. “Worth a try.”

“That’s what I like about you.” He tugs a notepad from his inner jacket pocket and jots down the details, then hands it over. Kiddo reads over his notes with the kind of singular focus Giran would expect from a scientist or maybe a sniper.

“Pay?” Kiddo asks.

“Quote me.”

Kiddo glances up at him and Giran wonders what all he’s reading in his face. “Five thousand now, five thousand on completion. Give me a day.”

It’s a ridiculously lowball offer, barely enough for a good pair of sneakers, and he almost feels bad about accepting. Doesn’t stop him from paying, though. He’s not about to turn over a new leaf or anything.

“Great. We’ll meet back here.”

“Sundown.”

“Got it.”

The next day, Kiddo doesn’t disappoint him. It’s another ridiculously good quirk analysis, including details Giran has *no* idea how he got, but that’s just part of the mystery of his dear Kiddo. The kid says nothing as Giran flips through it, doesn’t even move until Giran pulls out the rest of the money and shoves it into his hand.

“Pleasure doing business with you-” he says as he starts to go but Kiddo’s voice stops him.

“The League is going to get curb stomped when they go up against UA,” Kiddo says in a tone that isn’t at all speculative. Like he already knows. “They’re going to start recruiting some actual members after, not canon fodder, and they’ll ask you to do it.”

“You interested?”

“No, it won’t help me in my goal.” He says it like it’s something he’s already tried. Giran ticks up the age he’s got in his mental record about Kiddo by several years. “How much would it cost to keep someone off your list of candidates?”

Giran’s brows lift high as he considers that. Now isn’t that an interesting question. “You trying to protect someone or deprive them?”

“Does it matter?”

No, he supposes it doesn’t.

“Depends on what they want to pay me for the recruitment per person.”

“Figures. Let me know when they offer. I’ll double it.”

Bold claim for a nobody willing to take ten thousand for a job worth ten times that, but Giran’s still intrigued. “Well. If they ask me, we’ll talk then.”

The nod Kiddo gives is resolute, absolutely sure. That’s the strangest thing about him, his confidence. It doesn’t come across as forced or boasting in the least. It’s *earned.* Giran grins back at him and they go their separate ways. His life certainly has gotten a lot more interesting since Kiddo stepped on the scene.

April

If he’s asked later, Togata Mirio won’t be able to describe the feeling that stops him that day before school. He’s still honing the sixth sense heroes get after a while that alerts them to danger or need, but today it’s screaming at him. He stops dead at the entrance of UA, caught by the feeling of eyes boring into him with a level of intensity he’d have expected from criminals or Sir Nighteye, but no one else.

The starer is small but Mirio knows better than to underestimate. Small doesn’t mean *weak.* He glances over him for a second, taking in the thin frame, black pants, gray hoodie, and then smiles brightly because maybe this is a friend in the making! The hood covering his hair and mask over the lower half of his face are a little suspicious but maybe he’s just hiding the effects of an unfortunate quirk.

“Can I help you?” Mirio asks as he approaches, keeping careful note on any body language that might hint this was going to go bad. So far, the starer is relaxed and barely moving past breathing. The moment there’s a slight shift in his stance, Mirio stops.

“Yes,” the starer says, big green eyes focused on Mirio’s almost like he knows him but Mirio can’t quite match him to anyone. “Has All Might been training you?”

…What? Unease starts creeping up Mirio's spine. How does some random person know about that? It's only been a couple months but he's already gotten so much better and All Might keeps saying something about passing on his legacy when he's ready-

"Oh, good, I wasn't sure if Aizawa would pass on the message or not. Okay, this is good."

What does Eraserhead have to do with this?! "Wow, so I have you to thank!"

"If you're thankful, I need a favor." Ah, that's what Mirio has been waiting for but he'll at least hear the guy out. "Class 1-A is going to be training in the USJ today. I need you to find a reason to join them."

Mirio blinks. What? Just what's this guy getting at? But his expression is so serious, his eyes so intense, and Mirio's carefully honed instincts scream that this is important. "Trying to keep me occupied? I'm flattered that you're worried about making sure I'm not bored!"

Something changes in the starer's gaze for a second, softening. Amusement? Fondness? Then it hardens again.

"There's going to be an attack. They're aiming for All Might but won't care if any students get in their way."

Mirio's insides go cold and tight. "Why- why are you telling *me?* One of the teachers-"

"That won't work. You have to find a reason to be there. Either legitimately or just show up. If you don't, there will be casualties. There will be *fatalities*."

He sounds so sure. Mirio runs the options in his mind. All he's supposed to do today is go to class. Nothing that his absence would affect as far as he can imagine. If this is some kind of joke, all that would happen is maybe he gets detention for skipping class and being somewhere he shouldn't be.

"But why *me?*"

"Some day, Lemillion will be a name *everyone* knows," the starer says with a confidence that's hard to discount. "That starts today. The only people who will see it are teachers, students, and the villains who would hurt them, but as long as they all live? That's all that matters."

They should be flimsy words but Mirio feels his heart quicken. "Okay. I'll find a way. And if this is a prank, I'll get you back next time we see each other."

The starer softens again and Mirio thinks he can see a smile under the mask.

"Yeah," he says and Mirio hears the strangest hint of wistfulness. "I'm looking forward to it."

Then he leaves and Mirio sneaks into the USJ with class 1-A. After, when the villains have either escaped or been put into custody and the injured are tended to or sent to the hospital, he sits obediently in front of Principal Nedzu and All Might and recounts the entire strange conversation that prompted his action.

“We need to find this informant,” All Might says and Mirio tries very hard not to stare at his small, unpowered form. This isn’t a secret he wanted to have but it will go to the grave with him if that’s what All Might wants.

“Unless I miss my guess, this is the second time he’s stepped in to direct our actions.” Nedzu doesn’t sound bothered by that, leaning back in his chair. “And we are no closer to knowing who he is.”

Was that what the kid had meant when he mentioned Aizawa?

“I’m surprised,” Nedzu says with a smile. “His original warning, I thought it was about saving *your* life, Togata! But now I believe it was about saving *All Might*.”

Six months ago, Mirio would have never believed something could actually threaten All Might that way. Now, with the man’s injury ridden form before him, he can actually see the man behind the hero.

“That means he’s on our side, right?” Mirio asks, looking between the two. “Since he seems set on keeping All Might safe.”

All Might and Nedzu share a glance.

“I don’t think we have enough information to decide that,” Nedzu says after a moment of thought. “But it’s a good indication.”

“Young Togata, is there anything else you remember about the boy?” All Might’s expression is grave, his gaze focused, and Mirio feels himself straightening up under it.

“No, sir. His clothing concealed anything that might identify him, but I know I’d recognize him if I heard him again.”

“That will have to be enough,” Nedzu says and then dismisses him. Mirio wanders a bit in the halls after, just thinking about the strange informant and just what he might be after.

Chapter End Notes

As a side note, money in this fic is in yen. By current exchange rates, 10k jpy is about 75 usd. Also, this fic is very much being pantsed. I have not decided on pairings and instead will be feeling it out as I go. Let's have some fun here, people.

Chapter 2

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

May

"You're going where?"

"Hosu City," Izuku says as he stuffs a folded shirt into his backpack. "For the class trip. Remember?"

Inko doesn't but things have been hectic at work and she's got so many things to worry about right now that it's not entirely out of the realm of possibility that she gave permission before. Besides, she trusts Izuku not to get into serious trouble.

Even if he's getting more and more secretive, but Inko would rather trust him and be wrong than let him think she's not in his corner. *Someone* has to be.

"Overnight?" she asks and he nods.

"I'll be back Sunday in time for dinner."

They'd be leaving after school and heading to Hosu, then staying in a hotel room. When she worries about the room, Izuku just smiles with fondness that is real for once and assures her he's taken care of it. She didn't know he'd gotten any kind of after school job but she's been trying to trust him more with his own time because the only way he'll learn to manage it is if she gives him the opportunity to do so with the possibility of learning from failures. As long as he goes to school, makes acceptable grades, and keeps up with the self defense classes, she'll deal with not knowing more.

"It… It seems almost cruel, scheduling this kind of thing at the same time as the UA sports festival," she says and sees the way Izuku's hands pause for a moment. His expression doesn't change and he continues packing a second later like nothing happened, but Inko's senses are screaming.

"I don't think I'd get anything out of watching it anyway."

The quiet of his voice does nothing to quell the defeat Inko is entirely certain she hears in it. She swallows back her own grief at her son's loss and instead reaches forward to gather him in her arms. At least he's not too big for that and instead melts into her embrace like some day he won't have her anymore.

"You are going to have so much fun on your trip," she says because if the universe deprives her son of that, she will give it the sternest talking to. He snickers against her shoulder as if he can hear her thoughts.

"Yeah. I'm sure it'll be eventful."

He doesn't usually patrol this early but Iida Tensei can't shake the feeling that there's something he'll miss if he doesn't. It woke him from a dead sleep after a late night of talking his little brother down from the nervousness of the sports festival and all Tensei could do was suit up and head out.

The air is alive with tension and he keeps feeling like he's being watched. Whether that's just the early morning civilians or something more villainous, he's not sure. Usually, the hair on the back of his neck stands when someone wants to hurt him, but he's not feeling that now. He continues on as if nothing has changed, at least until he spots someone standing suspiciously in an alley and doing nothing else.

Tensei isn't stupid. The situation screams trap and is just the sort of thing to catch a hero's attention. The fact that the person there is in a hooded jacket that covers his head and a mask doubles the possibility. That they're staring up between the two buildings and not out at the mouth of the alley is a little weird though.

"Hello!" Tensei greets as he hazards a few steps in. The potential suspect turns to look at him, big eyes all he can see of them.

"I came to help you today," the kid - because a voice like that is either a child or some kind of age affecting quirk - says, entirely serious. Tensei frowns. That costume isn't something he'd expect from a fellow hero, but a lot less flashy than vigilantes tend to be. Some kid who's watched too much tv?

"Well, I'm flattered but I think you'd better leave the hero work to professionals," he says and hopes that's a gentle enough refusal. "There's plenty of hero courses that you can take to get ready to really help out when you're old enough."

The kid's eyes crinkle a bit, like he's smiling behind the mask.

Then he's shooting at Tensei with a knife in each hand and Tensei moves before his brain figures out he should, instincts taking control. But the kid wasn't aiming for him. Instead, his knife deflects a blade Tensei hadn't even seen until it clatters to the ground.

"Don't let him taste your blood," the kid says and then another man lands further into the alley. Tensei takes him in in a second. Tall, muscular, overall sturdy. Katana in his hand and other weapons elsewhere on his body. Bloodshot eyes staring from a pale mask. His stomach drops as he recognizes him.

"Never seen you before, but I've heard of you," Stain the Hero Killer mutters as he gives the kid a narrow eyed look. "Got a problem with me, Kiddo?"

"Wish that name hadn't caught on." The kid is fully focused on Stain with his body poised to move at a moment's notice. As if Tensei isn't even here. "Yeah, I've got a problem with your choice of target. This one's off limits."

Which is incredibly weird. Tensei racks his brain for any reference of someone called Kiddo in the underworld but that's usually info more underground heroes would know, not someone

up top like him. Has he just walked in on some kind of power struggle? And why would this Kiddo even care about him in the first place. Have they met before? Either way, Tensei needs to stop this before it gets more violent.

“Hey, how about we-”

“*No one* gets to dictate which false hero I take out of this world,” Stain snarls as his body shifts, readying for the attack. “Least of all some upstart brat.”

Kiddo sighs. “Hey, Ingenium? You might want to call for some backup.”

A second later the kid is on Stain, forcing the Hero Killer on the defensive. He moves too well for a civilian, agile and quick like he’s been in hundreds of battles. Tensei can’t tell if there’s a quirk in use. Pulling out his phone, he sends out an emergency message to the agency before jumping in as well. With any luck, they’ll have Stain neutralized before anyone shows up.

Ingenium is a team player and it turns out Kiddo is, too. The two of them move well together to push Stain back despite the villain’s high skill, attacking and defending in turns. Maybe Tensei’s never fought with Kiddo before, but he’s teamed up with enough knife wielders to know how to back one up.

Kiddo deflects Stain’s katana and Tensei dodges under to deliver a blow to the Hero Killer’s chest, knocking him off balance only a moment as he recovers and rolls into another strike that clangs off Tensei’s armor. Stain is good, too good to let him continue wandering free out in the world. He’s spent most of the fight probing their defenses, feeling out their skills, and Tensei needs to end this before he finds an opening-

An arm shoves him to one side, a flash of red, then Stain’s head is jerking forward to lick it from the air and Kiddo hits the ground in a boneless heap. Tensei falls back to get some distance and figure out what the hell just happened. The only wound he sees on Kiddo is a small scrape across his cheek that definitely wouldn’t put him down.

“I’ll come back to deal with you once this fake hero is dead,” Stain says with a grin before jumping at Tensei again. The two of them move through the alley, jumping between the walls while Tensei defends himself as well as he can alone and distracted.

“Don’t let him taste your blood,” Kiddo had said. Some kind of quirk? Seeing him paralyzed on the ground from a tiny cut, Tensei figures it has to be. He’s got a lot of armor but half his body is just covered by his suit. Sturdy material but he didn’t trust Stain’s blade couldn’t cut right through it. He concentrates on buying time, even if it feels like only seconds have passed since he sent that message out.

“Why are you doing this?” Tensei asks because maybe if he can get Stain talking it’ll be a good distraction and maybe Tensei will be able to do something other than just dodging.

“Because weak people become fake heroes and it is my duty to kill every one of them.” And as Tensei blocks the katana, he feels a sharp sting on his side and reflexively leaps back. It’s a good thing he aimed for the ground because just as his feet touch, his entire body suddenly

stops responding to him. Tensei hits his knees and then falls forward, cursing when no amount of effort made even his fingers twitch. His head is to one side and he grits his teeth as watches Stain drop down near where Kiddo lays. Stain regards the still prone boy with a sneer.

“You can stop!” Tensei says, glad that at least his vocal cords aren’t paralyzed. “You can stop this right now and no one else has to get hurt!”

Glancing his way, Stain seems to consider his words but Tensei doesn’t hope for much. He just needs the Hero Killer to forget about Kiddo long enough for backup to arrive. However long this paralysis lasts, he’s the only thing between that kid and death.

“Are you trying to convince me you’re a real hero?” The look on Stain’s face is more amused than murderous, but considering both his opponents are apparently down for the count he’s got time to gloat. “Do you even know why you’re on my list?”

“Because I’m a licensed hero?”

Stain scoffs and then crouches down to grab Tensei by the hair, pulling his head painfully back. “Why are you a hero? The fame and glory have diluted the true essence of being a hero and you are just as deluded as the rest of those fakes. All of you are too blind to your greed to ever be known as *hero*.”

…What? As Tensei tries to figure through that logic, Stain lets go and gets back up.

“There’s only one man I will acknowledge. Only All Might deserves to save the just world I’m helping create,” he says as he raises his katana. There’s nothing Tensei can do. He closes his eyes and thinks of his family, letting their memory comfort him in what seem to be his last moments.

Then Stain chokes, gurgles, and a large body hits the ground. Tensei’s eyes jerk open and he sees Stain’s shocked expression staring back at him with blood flowing freely around the hands clutching his throat. The only reason Tensei doesn’t jerk back is because his body literally can’t.

“He always talks too much,” Kiddo says as he steps around so Tensei can see him. He looks down at Stain without pity, far too calm as the villain bleeds out between them. Tensei can barely breathe. As Kiddo wipes blood off his knife, Stain’s eyes remain on Tensei’s face as the light drains out of them.

“We could have captured him alive,” Tensei babbles out and Kiddo pauses to regard him coolly.

“If you’d tried, it wouldn’t have ended well for you or your little brother.”

Tenya?! What does Tenya have to do with this?! Why would anyone like Kiddo know his brother?!

“You’ll be able to move in another minute or so,” Kiddo says, sliding his knife away in a holder under his hoodie. “I know you’re going to include me in your report. That’s fine. I want your people to know about me.”

Tensei tries and gets one of his fingers to twitch. Because the quirk is time based and wearing off? Because Stain isn’t consciously keeping him down anymore? Because Stain is… “Why? What does that get you?”

“Attention from the right people.” Kiddo kneels down as his voice softens. “Don’t let this bother you too much. There was nothing you could do. You just need to concentrate on being a most excellent older brother to a remarkable younger brother.”

He says it like he knows Tenya personally and that is *terrifying*. The skill Kiddo showed in battle, the ease of stealth, the clean kill shot that left no chance of survival… This is a terrible development in the underworld. If it’s someone Tenya knows, one of his friends or classmates, then his brother isn’t nearly as safe as Tensei thought. He needs to tell people, warn UA-

There’s a voice from the mouth of the alley and then Kiddo is gone. Tensei can’t lift his head yet to see where he’s gone but then there are hands on him as he’s rolled onto his back. He’s caught in a whirlwind of getting checked over and giving a quick summary of what happened before his memory has had a chance to distort any of the details.

“Estimate on this new villain’s age?” someone asks him and Tensei startles because he hadn’t quite classified Kiddo as a villain but… It’s definitely true that what he’d done was villainous.

“Young. Sounded like a teenager. And… and he knows my brother.”

There’s quiet around him for several seconds as the others glance between each other. Tensei looks up from the bottle of water someone had pushed into his hands at some point when he had control enough of his body to hold it.

“We need to warn UA that one of their students may have gone rogue,” he says in a grave tone that he barely recognizes as his own voice.

It was one thing when their mystery informant was just a concerned citizen with good information and stunningly on point insights. It’s entirely different when he’s proven himself lethal.

It’s even *worse* if that person is one of his students. Nedzu has always had pride for his ability to analyze and judge the people he meets. Every student that gets accepted into his school has already gone through a more thorough background check than even those seeking top secret clearance for the government. So the idea that any of them might be actively going rogue? No. Not acceptable.

There’s very little known about the villain Kiddo. They have a few cobbled together stories here and there, but before Stain he’d been a small time information broker known primarily

for ridiculously high quality quirk evaluations. What little they've been able to piece together is that he's a highly intelligent newcomer with no strong ties to any one group. There'd been no indication he was even capable of the sort of violence Ingenium witnessed.

Nedzu focuses his attention on the roster of 1-A. The young Iida has already set himself apart from the rest for his leadership skills and is on good terms with most of the class. None of his closest relations seem the type to go outside of the law… and there is no one in 1-A that resembles Kiddo.

The physical description Ingenium gave matches the boy Aizawa met and the one who warned Togata. There are only three students that match up with what they concretely know about Kiddo physically but their quirks don't come close. The going theory is that his quirk is some kind of general physical enhancement to his speed and strength because at no time has any sign of something more specialized been observed. And against Aizawa, he hadn't been troubled not to use it either, so outside of that he's also been highly trained to fight quirkless.

Nedzu steeples his paws and considers the artist rendering of Kiddo. He looks young but resolute. Wide eyes that look young and old all at the same time. Villains murdering other villains isn't unheard of but to have a relatively unknown one take out a big name like Stain is. And the fact that Kiddo had sought to warn them about dangers before that…

"He didn't think All Might would take a nobody seriously," Aizawa had said.

"When I asked why he didn't tell a teacher, he said it wouldn't work. Like he'd already tried," Togata had said.

It's more and more obvious that Kiddo not only knows more than he should, but he knows *them*. As individuals. And more than just what some superfan might have gleaned. Maybe the quirk is less enhancement and something more like shapeshifting. Someone who could get in close to observe them, but then why not just approach them in that form? Something isn't adding up at all.

What a delightful mystery!

Nedzu's next move is to look into Iida's acquaintances outside of UA and his previous school. He's the only link they currently have to Kiddo-

His private phone line rings and Nedzu picks the receiver up without really thinking about it because so few people have the number that it doesn't matter.

"Principal Nedzu speaking."

"Your students will be starting their internships in a few weeks," says a voice Nedzu isn't familiar with at all. "You need to bar them from choosing any agency in Hosu City."

Well isn't that interesting. The caller sounds male, young. And to mention Hosu so soon after the most recent excitement?

“This wouldn’t happen to be the villain known as Kiddo, would it?” Nedzu chances and the caller gives a put upon sigh.

“*Really* wish that name hadn’t caught on.”

A few taps on his computer and Nedzu starts both recording and tracking down the call origin.

“What made you change your mind about using intermediaries to warn us?” he asks because he’s genuinely curious about Kiddo’s methods.

“I figure I’m about as credible as I’ll ever be at this point. If you don’t listen to me now, you never will.”

He’s not wrong. “So, what I’m hearing is that you don’t want any student heroes in your city, hm?”

“Not my city. But no, keep them out of Hosu. Things are going to get way too hot for students right around the time the internships start.”

So Kiddo is based elsewhere? His known clients have been far flung, so they weren’t sure what his usual stomping grounds are yet. Had he gone to Hosu specifically to murder Stain?

“Interesting. Villain activity?”

“You should probably warn the HPSC and have them bulk up the hero presence there, but keep it quiet. That should limit civilian casualties without tipping off anyone too important.”

Hm. Why would a villain care about civilians? “I suppose it would also make it easier to get rid of whoever you’re trying to supplant.”

“Sure, you can take it that way. Whatever gets you to listen to me.”

So he probably *isn’t* looking to take over the territory. Nedzu hums quietly and glances at the tracking application. The phone signal is bouncing off satellites world wide, how clever! He needs a little more time.

“I’m curious. Why are you so concerned about the students?”

“They’re children,” Kiddo replies without hesitation. “They shouldn’t have to lose hope yet.”

“Like you did?”

There’s no answer but Nedzu knows he’s right. He’s been in this business too long not to know the sound of a fallen hero.

“How long were you active before-”

“This conversation has already gone on long enough,” Kiddo interrupts, voice gone cold because Nedzu got excited and pushed too much too quickly. “Bar the students from Hosu

and warn the HPSC or it's on *your* conscience. I've already done everything I can."

The line goes dead and Nedzu sits back in his chair as he considers the conversation. Everything was pointing to this being a newbie, a young villain who apparently had a friendly connection with Iida Tenya, but now… If this *is* a fallen hero, Kiddo has to be eighteen at the least, more likely mid twenties unless his quirk affects his aging. At least it's a lead to go on. He'll report it of course, but now Nedzu is intrigued and he's never been good at letting go of things that catch his attention.

The tracking software hadn't been able to pinpoint Kiddo's location before the call ended but that's fine. Nedzu always loves a challenge.

When it comes to orders, Kurogiri is good at following them. It might seem a strange trait for a villain to possess, but he likes to think that it makes him an excellent second in command and as long as Sensei and Shigaraki Tomura agree, all is well.

Being that he is good at following orders, he doesn't outwardly question when he's told to bring a new villain to meet with them at all costs. Kiddo is a relative unknown, usually giving information to whoever pays him, but the murder of the Hero Killer certainly turned a few heads, including Sensei's. Getting Giran to provide a location to fetch him from is half the battle of doing so, but one Kurogiri wins easily enough.

As his warp opens up, he takes a moment to examine the figure that stumbles through. Small, wide eyed, in a uniform so nondescript it might as well just be every day fair. No symbols, nothing at all that would catch or keep anyone's attention barring the fact that he is as covered up as possible. Kurogiri's almost surprised he doesn't wear goggles.

Kiddo isn't at all surprised by where he's ended up. He glances around but seems like he almost expected to be here eventually. When Tomura sits up at the bar, Kiddo zones in on him immediately.

"Took you long enough," the upstart says in a bored tone and Kurogiri sees the way Tomura's shoulders twitch with annoyance. "I figured you'd at least *ask* first before yanking me, though."

"Who's the idiot?" Tomura asks as his chapped lip curls back.

"Forgot about how much you get maneuvered around at the beginning," Kiddo mutters but it seems absent, like a thought he didn't mean to speak aloud. "You guys are barking up the wrong tree. There's no amount of money that'll make me willing to work with this crusty lunatic and no one else should be either."

Kurogiri feels a sigh forming inside him but doesn't let it out. Then a second later, he's opening a set of warps to keep the two of them from killing each other. Tomura struggles as Kurogiri pulls him back, hand reaching out from where he'd tried to take out their visitor. Kiddo's still got his knives pulled but he backs off on his own. It looks like he'd reacted to the threat, not that he necessarily had planned on going for a kill.

That didn't mean he *wouldn't*. They'd never have thought to bring him on if he wasn't lethal. Their plans preclude a peaceful resolution.

"See, this is why I'm not interested in your boy band," Kiddo says, still tense and watchful but he slides the knives away. "The face is off key."

Kurogiri tightens his hold on Tomura as he hears a growl ratter out of his chest.

"Why are we wasting our *time*-" he begins but another voice cuts him off.

"I think that's more than enough."

Sensei's voice is enough to make all of them go still, even Kiddo. Kurogiri watches the mix of feelings cross through his eyes too quickly to pick anything out, but what remains is a grim sort of recognition.

"Hello Kiddo. It's nice to meet you," Sensei says through the radio, smile clear in his voice.

"Can't say the sentiment is shared."

Kiddo's lucky Sensei decides to be amused. His chuckle still sends ripples through Kurogiri's misty form.

"I take that to mean you aren't interested in joining our group yet?"

"Guess you missed the part where your deranged mutt tried to disintegrate me," Kiddo says, unimpressed. "No. I'm not interested. Now are you gonna have your warper send me back or do I get to know where your super secret playhouse is located?"

"Well, I'm sorry to hear that," Sensei replies with the same calm as if he hadn't just heard a veiled threat. "We will of course return you from whence we found you."

Kiddo's eyes narrow. "Like I don't already know you'll put a target on me."

"I believe the saying goes: 'that sounds like a *you* problem'," is the amused reply.

"Just don't come complaining when you waste a lot of resources trying to get back at me."

Kurogiri warps him back where he'd found him because he's gotten fairly good at knowing when Sensei wants him to warp someone into the middle of the ocean or not, and now is not the time. He must think Kiddo will be useful later.

"I *hate* him," Tomura growls out once the warp closes behind Kiddo, predictably.

"Don't worry, you'll have ample opportunity to eliminate him when the time is right," Sensei reassures him and oh, so *that's* the play. Putting a small stone in Tomura's way so he can destroy it. Build his confidence and experience. Kurogiri sometimes forgets how many steps ahead Sensei thinks. "Just let me get what I want out of him first. I assure you it will be worth the wait."

Chapter End Notes

The "face" Kiddo's talking about is the face of the band, as in the point man. Which boy bands aren't technically supposed to have by design but shhhhh

Chapter 3

Chapter Notes

Figured out the ship lol It'll be forever and a day before we get there though

June

When his mother tells him to go to the corner store for a few things, Bakugou Katsuki begrudgingly tromps out to fetch them but only after they've screamed at each other for several minutes. He doesn't really *mind*, it's the *principle* of the thing. She'd start thinking he'll roll over for her every time if he doesn't make her fight for it.

Sometimes he wonders where he'll find a wife that's as perfect a fit for him as his pushover father is for his hag of a mother, but that's so far away he doesn't know why anyone would bother to think about it. He's sixteen and getting ready for his illustrious career is all he's got time for. Maybe when he's going gray, he'll shack up with some woman to pop out a few heroes in training, but even that idea seems too far away to put any brainpower towards right now. Katsuki doesn't even like kids, but he guesses having them is what he's supposed to do just like the marriage thing. At least, that's what the hag yells at him about often enough to be annoying.

Maybe he won't, just to piss her off.

Shaking the weird thoughts from his head, Katsuki makes his way to the corner store. He finds what he needs quickly, not wanting to waste more time than he had to on this. Exams are right around the corner and like hell is he going to get saddled with extra summer classes just because he didn't study enough. It might be a funny way to piss off his mom but not worth the trouble overall.

As he ducks through the sliding doors, another body collides with his and Katsuki nearly drops his bag before snarling out, "Watch where you're going, you damn extra!"

The other person looks up and it's fucking *Deku*. "Sorry, I-...Kacchan?"

Katsuki hasn't seen him in months, not since they both graduated middle school, and even then their last year was weirdly quiet now that he thinks about it. Deku had kept his head down, didn't bother trying to engage with him, and now their paths just never have reason to cross anymore now that Deku isn't inexplicably on his heels every fucking second. Deku's not much taller but seems less dwarfed by his clothes, like his body's gotten more substantial under them, and he'd been *solid* when he knocked into Katsuki. Is Deku working out? Why bother?

But more importantly, Deku isn't cowering back, looks him in the face like they're equals instead, and Katsuki's mood snaps.

"You're in my way," he growls out and after a full second of staring, Deku takes a wordless step to the side to let Katsuki pass. No stumbling. No muttered apologies. It makes the hair on the back of Katsuki's neck stand on end for just how *bizarre* that feels. He makes a special effort to knock his shoulder into Deku's in passing but it doesn't make him feel any better.

Twenty steps away and Katsuki can't stop himself from looking back. Then he freezes mid step because Deku's just standing there staring at him and the look on his face… It's not an expression Katsuki's familiar with, not from his childhood nuisance. For some reason, Deku looks a hundred years old and like he'd lost *everything*.

"What the hell are you looking at!?" Katsuki yells at him because he can't stand seeing that anymore.

Deku doesn't startle, doesn't even twitch. He just gives Katsuki a smile that's weirdly nostalgic and hurts to look at, which just pisses him off more.

"See you around, Kacchan," Deku says before disappearing into the shop. Katsuki's lip curls back into a sneer and he goes back home to give his mother her goddamn groceries before he can talk himself into storming back after Deku.

Whatever is going on with Deku is none of his business, but Katsuki can't quite shake the gnawing feeling that he should make it so. He throws himself into studying instead because the moment Deku gave up his ridiculous notions of going to UA and becoming a hero, he stopped being of even the slightest importance to Katsuki's life.

At least, that's what Katsuki stubbornly tells himself.

It feels a little weird introducing people to Kiddo but Giran's damned if the kid hasn't made it worth his time. He hadn't realized Kiddo was getting enough clients to pay as promised. Surprising him seems to be Kiddo's specialty.

All he'd asked for was to bar these people from the list of potentials to introduce to the League of Villains, but Giran's pretty good at reading between the lines and Kiddo's interesting. Might as well see what he's got in him when he has more support.

"What are you supposed to be?" the tall, scarred up Dabi says as he looks over Kiddo, unimpressed. His sheer presence fills the whole room, oppressive in all the ways Kiddo's isn't. Looking at them Giran would have thought Dabi the more effective of the two but, while the firebrand has a powerful, well developed quirk, his actions have been more than haphazard over the last few years since he debuted.

"Forgettable," Kiddo replies without pause. "Anyway, I guess my villain name is Kiddo-"

"You *guess?*"

“It just kind of happened.” Kiddo sighs and reaches up to pinch the bridge of his nose as Giran grins to himself. “Go ahead and get it all out now, then we’ll get down to business.”

“I think it’s cute,” Toga Himiko says, bouncing in place. “He’s so small!”

She’s another odd one, just as talented as Dabi but even more aimless. Without someone to point her in any direction, Giran figures she’ll be in Tartarus within a year.

“I still don’t know why we’re here,” Spinner grumbles from where he’s leaning against a stack of boxes. The warehouse isn’t the most ideal of meeting places but Kiddo doesn’t have a base. Yet. Spinner’s not Giran’s typical pick for an ally, too close to the other side of the vigilante/villain slider, but maybe Kiddo’s got an idea on how to use him.

“*You* are here because you’re a small time nobody looking for meaning in your life.” As Spinner stiffens with surprised offense under Kiddo’s sharp gaze, he continues, “The world seems broken. So many heroes are out there doing the job for money and fame instead of just to help people like a hero should.”

He doesn’t respond but Spinner’s focus is entirely centered on Kiddo like every word is a drop of water in an endless desert.

“People with mutant quirks like yours are degraded and ridiculed,” Kiddo says, “and no one with actual power does anything to stop it. The world could be so much better if someone just took a stand and *made it* that way.”

The words aren’t pretty or particularly awe inspiring, but they seem to hit Spinner exactly how they’re meant to. When he looks away, it’s to turn inward in thought. Giran has to hand it to Kiddo, he seems to have won at least that one over.

“Great sentiments, but what do *you* want?” Dabi asks, folding his arms over his chest.

“I want to stop a band of lunatics from destroying society without any plan for rebuilding it.”

Dabi narrows his eyes. “I’m not hearing anything concrete.”

“Just give him a second.” Toga ignores the glare he sends her way.

“It’s a work in progress, just like everyone else’s dream,” Kiddo says without sounding bothered in the least. “I agree that the system we have isn’t sustainable. There wouldn’t be so many villains if it were. But right now there is a group who want nothing but to destroy all of society and watch the world burn, and they don’t care who gets hurt in the process. Heroes, other villains, innocents. If they get the chance, the violence never stops and that’s by design.”

A chilling idea and Giran wonders if maybe he should add the League of Villains to his black list. They pay fine and he usually doesn’t consider politics much nor does he have a heart of gold just waiting for the chance to show itself, but this society is his bread and butter. Take it out and where does that leave him? Dead or worse.

“Why do you care?” Dabi presses, just as cold and dismissive. “Stop sounding like one of those self righteous heroes for two seconds and give me specifics already.”

Kiddo snorts, lips twisting into an almost bitter smile. “To start? I want to take down the League of Villains. Nothing will get better until they’ve stopped stirring the pot with their nihilistic bullshit. They just sacrificed dozens of lower level villains in an unmitigated failure of an attempt on All Might’s life a few months ago. Getting started on a better world means getting rid of the rot that would hinder us.”

“I guess that’d get your name out,” Dabi drawls out with a roll of his eyes.

“God, I hope not. Who the fuck is going to take a guy called *Kiddo* seriously?” Kiddo shoots a glare Giran’s way but Giran just smiles. Shaking his head, Kiddo stuffs his hands into his hoodie pocket and looks back up at Dabi. “This isn’t about being recognized. I’d prefer not to be public at all if I had the choice. What I care about is making the world a better place than I found it. There are some specific false heroes I think should be taken down to get there, ones that should start a cascade in changing hero society as examples instead of martyrs. One of them happens to be someone you in particular would love to get out of the way.”

“Are you trying to pull some kind of cold reading trick?” Dabi’s lip curls and he looks a second away from bailing. “Who do you think you offer me?”

“Endeavor.”

Dabi snaps straight, staring down at Kiddo who doesn’t even twitch under the intensity of it. Toga covers her mouth with her hands and even Spinner’s eyes go wide at the gall of targeting the number two hero. Had Giran not heard Kiddo mutter about his hit list before, he’d be just as shocked.

“More than money or recognition or a better world, you just want that man’s head on a plate,” Kiddo says in a cold tone that makes a shiver run down Giran’s spine. “He’s the type that can only be redeemed through death and probably not even then. A hero obsessed with power, fame, the coveted number one spot.”

The faint glow around Dabi’s scarred hands has Giran’s body tensing to make a run for it but Kiddo either doesn’t notice it or doesn’t care.

“I want to build a world where that kind of man would never have been put in a position to abuse others with impunity in his quest for perfection.” Kiddo takes a few steps further into Dabi’s space, would be nose to nose with him if he weren’t so short. “Like his own *family.*”

There’s a bright flash of blue as flames flare out from Dabi’s palms but it fades almost immediately. The stare off is broken as a dark smile spreads across Dabi’s face.

“Fine. I’ll give you a try. But the moment it’s not worth the effort, I’ll take you out myself.”

“I can live with that.”

As Kiddo wins another subordinate to his side, the last candidate is almost vibrating with glee. Toga looks every bit a normal highschooler getting ready for some fun outing rather than the cold blooded killer Giran knows her to be.

“Me next! Me next!” she says as she rocks from heel to toe and back again, grinning widely with one hand shooting up. “What do I want?”

Kiddo regards her a moment and seems to soften, just a bit. “You? You’re easy. That quirk of yours has made it difficult for others to accept you, but you want a world where they do.”

Her expression fills with exaggerated shock, but under it Giran notes just how focused her attention has gotten.

“I’d never ask you to be anyone but who you are and that includes your quirk,” Kiddo goes on. “While I can’t promise you something so concrete as vengeance or a cause you already believe in, I *can* give you ways to be yourself and build relationships with others like you. I can offer you friendship and a place to belong.”

Toga tilts her head, considering that. “Friendship… with you?*”*

“Pretty sure we can get along well.”

She brightens even more than Giran has seen her in the middle of a kill, and he’d thought that was her favorite thing in the world. Maybe there’s more to the school girl looks than just whimsy. With her face split by a grin that doesn’t look quite as crazed as usual, Toga grabs Kiddo’s hand to shake it enthusiastically. “What’s our first step, Boss?”

Kiddo glances between the three of them, meeting and keeping their gazes for a few seconds each. “The League already has a few recruits that could be troublesome. I want to try and turn them to our side, but barring that just take them out entirely. Anyone who’s stuck on helping the League can’t be left free.”

As Giran watches them from behind Kiddo, he sees no hesitation on any of their faces. Kiddo’s won his new team. Now it’s up to him to use them effectively. Giran’s still not sure which side he’ll end up supporting in the end, but this is more interesting than the underworld has been in years.

He’ll keep watching for now. There’s plenty of time to change his mind later. Once they’ve had a few tasks delegated to them, the three leave and Kiddo turns back to Giran.

“Got something for me too, *Boss?*” Giran asks with a grin.

“There’s a few more names I want to bar from the League,” Kiddo says as seriously as ever, fishing a bit of paper from his pocket to hand over. “I probably can’t turn them to my side, but I still have to try.”

Glancing over the list, Giran is surprised by a few names but not others. Well, Kiddo *had* started out as an info broker, of course he’d have gotten skilled at figuring out who’d be worth his time.

“I’ll see what I can do.” Which just made Giran more curious. “Is your endgame really that flowery shit you were spouting earlier?”

Kiddo snorts and his eyes look ancient. “Yeah. It really is.”

“And where do villains even fit in with that idealized world?”

“If I had my way, there’d be no reason to turn to villainy in the first place.” The mask makes it hard to tell, but Giran is pretty sure Kiddo’s smiling at him. “People like Toga, Spinner, and Dabi would have had the support and understanding they needed from the beginning. And I’m pretty sure you’d be successful regardless of how you decided to spend your time; this is just *fun* for you.”

Well. He’s not wrong.

“And people like Shigaraki?”

Looking upward towards one of the warehouse’s skylights, Kiddo says, “If tissue has started to necrose, aren’t you supposed to cut it out?”

It’s hard to remember most of the time that Kiddo’s lethal. Then he says shit like this and Giran remembers he took out the Hero Killer himself. That makes no difference to him in the long run. Giran’s still a man of limited integrity that can be bought if the money’s good and the client doesn’t piss him off.

“Didn’t think I’d get caught up in some vigilante’s crusade,” Giran mutters to himself but as long as he can milk the situation for his benefit he supposes it’s fine. Kiddo isn’t the first vigilante he’s dealt with and won’t be the last.

“Didn’t think I’d *be* one,” Kiddo replies and then goes off to do whatever crazy shit he’s got planned next.

The underworld of crime has been nothing but a swirling mess of fluctuating factions for years, ever since All Might’s near fatal encounter with the notorious villain All For One obliterated many of the organized power structures that were once its backbone. That makes certain tasks easier, others a lot harder.

If they can’t be tied to specific big name, the small time criminals are easier to pick up but harder to find. If they aren’t being directed by a more singular purpose, their ability to enact wide ranging crime is squashed but that makes them more unpredictable. Tsukauchi Naomasa doesn’t know which he’d prefer, but is pretty sure the alternative of All For One still running wild is the worse one.

That doesn’t make the current rumors and more solid intel any less troubling. Power vacuums are always filled and the police have been keeping their eyes peeled for rising stars to quash before they can solidify their hold. The League of Villains is certainly flashy, what with the attack on UA and more recent activity in Hosu City tied to them, but Naomasa’s attention right now is being drawn by another name.

Kiddo's slaying of the Hero Killer Stain certainly put him on the police's top ten list but they've been aware of him for longer. Suspected intellect enhancing or mind affecting quirk, quickly becoming a go to for anyone needing quirk evaluation or strategic planning. His evaluations are dangerously spot on and his information delves into details no outsider should have access to. How he chooses his clients isn't well understood but he definitely has a method to it. About the only villains willing to talk about him have been those he turned down. Then he murdered Stain and gave them another possibility for his subtle quirk.

Now there are signs he's building a following and that's never a good idea for a villain as smart as Kiddo. No one knows what his intentions are because nothing's been announced, and the confusing difference between his warnings to UA and his criminal behavior is making it difficult to classify him. Vigilantes, by virtue of unlicensed quirk use, are villains and Naomasa has no problem bringing them in just as readily, but he knows many that would let one slide if they kept their nose clean. Kiddo hasn't tried.

"Keep staring so intently at his picture and I'll be sure to let Makoto know she's got a brother in law in the making," Tanuma Eizo teases as he sets a fresh mug of coffee down next to the empty cup Naomasa keeps accidentally picking up before remembering he hasn't refilled it.

"Thanks," he says, gratefully taking a swig. "I just don't get this guy. Why throw in with criminals when private sector quirk analysts can make a couple hundred thousand per evaluation without the risk?"

"Trust fund kid wanting a thrill?"

"And if you're set on being a villain, why go out of your way to take out someone killing off heroes?" Nothing about Kiddo makes sense. "Why warn a hero school of dangers to their students?"

"Brief attack of conscience?"

"And now he's building his own army? Does he even have a plan, surrounding himself with people like this?"

"I could say literally anything right now and you'd just keep going, huh?"

Naomasa clicks back to the artist rendering. They've only gotten a few glancing photographs of Kiddo, nothing showing his face, so the rendering is still the best they've got. Everyone who's seen Kiddo in person confirmed that the artist's mental image quirk had given an accurate depiction. Naomasa could probably redraw it with his eyes closed at this point, he's looked at it enough times.

He's been doing this long enough that he can usually predict what various types of criminals will get up to. Kiddo throws every attempt he's made. There's no sense to his actions, Naomasa is missing some key piece that might let him figure it out.

"I need to talk to him," he says and Tanuma fumbles his own coffee, nearly dumping part of it on himself.

“What?!”

“I need to talk to Kiddo.” Which might be half impossible considering they have no idea who he actually is, or even where his home base is. His clients are from all over the country, though there are a good amount of them in Musutafu. Opportunities due to the proximity to UA? Kiddo does seem to have a preoccupation with it.

“You’re not going to let this bone go, are you?” Tanuma shakes his head but Naomasa knows he’s probably sifting through their information in his mind, picking out details Naomasa might have missed. “Okay. Say you get him to talk. What’s your play?”

“I-”

A knock at the door interrupts them as an officer pokes her head in. “Detective Tsukauchi? Phone call.”

“Transfer it over.” He waits for his phone to ring and answers, “Detective Tsukauchi speaking.”

“Does your quirk work over the phone?”

The voice is young, unfamiliar. Naomasa frowns at the direct question. “Pardon?”

“Your quirk. Can you tell if I’m being truthful or not over the phone?”

Naomasa’s quirk isn’t exactly a secret, but it’s rare someone outside the department or a hero makes mention of it.

“Who is this?” he asks.

“They’ve been calling me Kiddo for the last few months and I’ve kind of given up fighting it.”

Truth.

Naomasa stiffens in his chair and swiftly turns on the recording for his phone line. Across the desk, Tanuma grabs a notepad and shoves it under Naomasa’s hand along with a pen.

“My partner and I were just considering how best to get a hold of you,” Naomasa admits and hears a quiet snort on the other end.

“Yeah. I know.”

Truth.

Dread filling him, Naomasa quickly writes out ‘surveillance? computer hack? surveillance quirk? precognition quirk?’ With every word, Tanuma looks more and more unsettled.

“You seem to know a lot,” Naomasa says as he stubbornly keeps his cool. No sense in letting their new villain know he’d been knocked off base. “Did you call just to tell us that or-”

“Shie Hassaikai ring a bell?”

It does. Naomasa’s not on the case but he knows there’s a thick file on the dying Yakuza group and its various members. They’ve been relatively quiet the last few years, numbers dwindling and territory getting ever smaller.

“Sure. Why do you care about them?”

“They’re developing a few quirk affecting drugs that’ll be in the field within two months. One that magnifies quirk usage, one that temporarily disables them, and one that permanently disables them. And they all *work*.”

Truth.

Tanuma’s eyes widen at the next notes and Naomasa wishes he could let out some really good cuss words right this second.

“Why come to us? Why not report this directly to a hero? You haven’t been shy about communicating with UA.”

“Because you can verify my truthfulness and Sir Nighteye’s agency will listen to you.”

Truth.

Another warning, another sign that Kiddo isn’t nearly as villainous as he should be, or maybe just removing an annoying rival and using heroes to do it. It’s so frustrating that Naomasa can’t get a bead on him.

“Thank you for your info. I’ll be sure to check into it. But I do have another question.”

“One more.”

“What do *you* get out of this? Telling us about the drugs, taking out the Hero Killer, all the warnings to UA. Why bother?”

It’s quiet for several seconds and Naomasa almost thinks Kiddo’s hung up on him, but then his soft voice comes back with, “I just want them all to live this time.”

Truth.

“What-”

The call ends and Naomasa sits back in his chair as he stares at the receiver in his hand. What the hell did that even mean?

“Well?” Tanuma asks, breaking him from the stupor.

“The Kiddo case is now my top priority,” Naomasa says and then checks through his short list of hero agency phone numbers. Hopefully, Sir Nighteye isn’t too busy to take his call.

Chapter 4

July

“Are you saying you can’t find anyone else worth our time?” Shigaraki snarls out and Giran is getting pretty tired of having to juggle him with Kiddo. The dial tips a bit more onto one side every time they talk.

“No,” Giran says, hands raised in a show of harmlessness to try and quell the madman’s rage. “I said the field’s already been cleaned out pretty well by another interested party and that your options are slim. Not none.”

Shigaraki’s probably going to kill him if he isn’t careful. Great.

“Please be patient, Shigaraki Tomura,” Kurogiri says, resting a hand on Shigaraki’s shoulder like it might actually do something to calm him.

“With someone like Stain taken out by another villain, people are getting cautious.” Giran had only just the other day listened to a buddy complain about even support suppliers getting cold feet about supplying items to the black market and those types usually did just about anything for a buck. “The League of Villains name just doesn’t pull as much weight after the way you sacrificed so many of them for basically no reason.”

Shigaraki grips the edge of the bar and part of it crumbles under his hand before he lifts his pointer finger again.

“Look, I’m not coming to you empty handed,” Giran continues. “It just isn’t as many as you were hoping for.”

He’d managed to leave off most of those on Kiddo’s second list, but there are a couple Giran knows for sure would just make things harder for the kid. Maybe Giran’s getting a soft spot for this stupid brat. Maybe it’s just because Kiddo pays better than the League and doesn’t threaten him every time they meet.

He presents the picks he’d brought in, collects his consultant fee for the ones Shigaraki manages to turn to his side, then takes his leave. At least far enough that Shigaraki and his lackey decide to let out a juicy bit of intel about their next move the moment they think he’s out of earshot. Too bad for them his hearing is *excellent.*

Attacking UA again, but this time during a training camp? And they were going to try to snag a kid hero in training? Giran resists the urge to snort and give himself away. When the League of Villains manages a decent plan doing anything, he’ll eat his damn shoe. No doubt, they’ll sacrifice just the people he brought in today. Doesn’t matter if they have a backer like All For One behind them if he’s letting Shigaraki go nuts with bullshit like this.

Giran leaves shaking his head and wonders how much Kiddo might buy his info for. No doubt, his hardon for UA could be milked for quite the pretty penny.

Final exams must be brutal because Izuku looks like he's barely sleeping. The bags under his eyes are worryingly dark and while he's still eating, he lapses into staring at the food and picking at it and just being utterly uninterested. Inko does her best to engage him and sometimes manages for a little while before he fades off again. She counts down the days until exams are over, figuring things will be better after.

Izuku has a lot to prove, she reminds herself. To himself, to the world. She'll support him no matter what, but she wishes he had more people in his corner.

On the last day of the exams, after she gets home from work, Inko decides it's time to deep clean the apartment. She starts in the public areas, dusting and scrubbing every surface with single minded determination. The place will be squeaky clean and welcoming to her hard working son.

When the living room, kitchen, and bathroom are all gleaming, Inko moves on to Izuku's room. She strips the bed, picks up a few clothes from the floor to throw into the wash, and then moves to tidy up his desk. Then she stops.

Spread over Izuku's desk are several notebooks laying open, which isn't odd at all, but these aren't detailing quirks and heroes like she's used to. The first is extensive notes about people she doesn't know and that don't even seem real, less about their quirks and more about them as people. Characters? Is he writing a story?

The second looks like some kind of timeline and when she flips back a few pages, it starts over a year ago. Notes about an encounter with All Might, the attack on UA, events in Hosu City… and then further on into the future. Inko glances over the color coded notes with growing unease as they detail out several years. It seems to be dictating the fall of their entire country and the last ominous entry just says '*Game over'*.

Her son is intelligent, so much more so than she or Hisashi could even understand, and his analytical skills have always been top notch. This *should* read more like speculative fiction than a prediction for the future, but every page of dates makes her belly clench up worse and worse. Is this why Izuku is so tired? His thoughts spiraling and worrying over possible dangers and losses? She flips back to a page only a few months away and a note underlined in thick red jumps out at her:

'Mom dies'

Her chest clenches so hard she can barely breathe and that's when Izuku gets home. She jerks and slams the notebook closed so she doesn't have to look at the words anymore, but she can't do much about the tears that have welled up in her eyes and within seconds, he's in the doorway to his room.

"Mom?" he asks with surprise and concern and her boy is just too good, why would he write anything like this? Why would he ever think something would happen to her?

She can't answer him. She just grabs him up to hug tight against her as she soaks his shoulder with tears she can't quite stop.

“Did something happen?” he asks as he rubs her back. The way he’s trying to soothe her just makes her cry harder.

“I’m not going to leave you.” It doesn‘t come out as fervently as she feels but he still stiffens against her as if it had. Inko pulls back so she can take his face in her hands and look him in the eye. “I’ll always be with you. Do you understand?”

“Mom?”

“*Do you understand?*”

He blinks a few times as his eyes grow wet. With a mute nod, he lifts his hands to cover hers.

“I don’t know why you’re writing those things in your notebooks and I know I was snooping, I’m sorry, but I need you to know that I love you and I am not going to leave you,” Inko says, watching his eyes dart to the desk and back to her face. “I’m not going to pry, yet, but are you okay?”

She expects him to lie and tell her he’s fine.

“No,” he chokes out as he fights tears and it makes her heart break even more.

“What can I do, honey? What do you need?”

His hands shake against hers but neither of them move. Izuku closes her eyes hard enough that it scrunches his whole face, presses her hands tighter to his face, and says, “If… If I tell you to stay home? Please stay home. Don’t ask me why, I can’t tell you that, but please. *Please just do it.*”

It’s not the request she expected but she agrees immediately and hugs him again. Whatever’s going on in Izuku’s head, if that’s what it takes to comfort him? There’s no question. She can handle missing a day of work here and there if that’s what Izuku needs. If that’s what makes him feel *safe.*

“I love you,” he says, muffled against her shoulder.

“I love you too, honey. Always and forever.”

The next time she goes into his room, all of his notebooks are gone. She tries not to feel like he’s just going to hide more from her, but that just means she needs to be better at noticing when he does. Her baby is deep into something she doesn’t understand. It’s her duty to look after him regardless.

August

“Thank you for meeting with me,” Tsukauchi says as he takes a seat at the table with a thin folder and notebook. “Maybe you’ll glean something out of this that I’ve missed.”

“Of course! May I see the file?” Nedzu takes it to flip through as All Might considers the purpose of this meeting.

The villain Kiddo’s strange duality in purpose has been confusing since the first time he contacted them through Aizawa. Intelligent, knowledgeable, intent on giving just enough information to make them act but not enough to really understand him. Most villains will go on and on about themselves and their causes if given the chance, but the moment anyone gets close to finding out more about Kiddo, he ends the interaction. They don’t know why he’s gaining followers, why he keeps helping the heroes at random turns, why he seems to have it out for the League of Villains…

All Might is not an intellectual hero. He will be the first to admit that he solves most of his problems with his fists and brute strength, but most of his problems are ones that can only *be* solved that way. That’s almost by design. Different heroes have different strengths and weaknesses and they tend to play to those. He is intelligent in the ways he needs to be to solve the problems his skills are suited for. This analytical evaluation of such a strange villain? Not necessarily something he’s good for.

He still takes each sheet from Nedzu as the principal finishes reviewing them to squint at and try to find meaning from because any insight might be useful. They have transcripts of the recorded phone calls and interviews with those who spoke with Kiddo, reports on the services he’s provided and his known contacts, impressions police analysts have put together… But they’re no closer to truly understanding the young villain.

“Hm, that’s interesting,” Nedzu murmurs in a distracted tone, one paw resting under a line from a transcript. “I’ve noticed a repeated sentiment through most of the transcripts: an earnest belief that he will be ignored.”

“Ignored?” Tsukauchi cranes his neck to look over the passage, frowning as he considers it. “Now that I think about it… Yeah, every time he’s been asked about his method of communication, he’s always said something about it being a way he might be taken seriously, like he’s used to being turned away.”

“Something of a Cassandra story, perhaps. He didn’t think All Might would listen about training Togata. He didn’t think any of us would take the threat to the USJ and All Might seriously. He didn’t think a hero would listen if he warned about the severity of the Shie Hassaikai situation without proof of his veracity.”

And isn’t that one proving to be a mess. All Might isn’t directly involved in the investigation but he’s heard through the grapevine that it’s turning out to be even worse than just a drug that can take away quirks. If there’s a raid, he may get tapped to go in due to the high number of confirmed combat quirks within the Yakuza sect.

“He sounded desperate,” Tsukauchi says, gaze turning inward, “when I asked him what he got from all this.”

‘I just want them all to live this time.’

The quiet, almost exhausted tone to Kiddo's voice still haunts All Might since he first heard the recording. What happened to this man? Who did Kiddo *lose?*

"Who failed him before?" Nedzu asks, mirroring All Might's thinking. "Well. Without knowing who he is, there's not much we can do to confirm what might have happened to him."

"So, we have a desperate, highly intelligent, highly skilled villain with unknown abilities and unknown motives that is fully willing to kill but not give us a straight answer." Tsukauchi's expression is as unsettled as his voice. "Not a combination I like."

"No one enters a fight with perfect information," All Might says, hearing Gran Torino's voice in his mind. "We can only make the best of what we have. Ingenium's encounter at least gives us some insight into his combat abilities. He appears to be on the level of someone like Eraserhead, so it's likely he has a very subtle enhancement or non-combat related quirk and was instead trained in quirkless fighting techniques."

"Until we're able to confirm his quirk, we can't match Kiddo to any known fallen or current heroes," Nedzu says, "but I'm almost certain he is one. You get a feeling for that sort of thing."

Ominous but now that the idea is out there, All Might can't help but agree. Kiddo's actions, while mixed, fit the profile well. But a hero falling needs a catalyst.

"I'm not aware of any recent tragedies befalling known heroes that might have tipped the scales." Not that All Might knows every hero even just in Japan, but he's always tried to keep abreast of those who might benefit from a little more attention. "Though, it need not *be* recent."

"You're right. It might have been a while back and something recent finally pushed him over the edge," Tsukauchi agrees as he sits back in his chair to rub his eyes. He looks exhausted and All Might doesn't blame him. While not taking point on the Shie Hassaikai case, Tsukauchi's still been neck deep in the whole thing along with trying to unravel the less dire mystery of Kiddo.

"Whatever it was appears to have happened mid last year," Tsukauchi says. He spreads out a few of the reports, running a finger along dates of known contacts. "The name Kiddo is newer, from early this year, but we've been able to confirm he became active several months before that. He just hadn't chosen a villain name yet."

Nedzu shuffles the files. "I get the feeling he didn't really choose it."

All Might picks up one of the quirk analyses they'd been able to recover and scans through it. The work is detailed and well written. Kiddo honed his craft before his debut, All Might's sure of that. "Perhaps we should check into companies that provide quirk analysis and training services. This kind of work…"

"Already done," and by the defeated tone, Tsukauchi didn't find anything useful.

All Might pauses, considering the artist's rendering of Kiddo from Ingenium's memory sitting in the middle of the table. There's not much to go by besides the eyes. He looks young. Tired. His gaze burns into All Might's mind. Had it been him that failed Kiddo? Had he overlooked someone or something, arrived too late? Had he been the one that ignored an earnest cry for help?

"Regardless," All Might says with a shake of his head to rid himself of such thoughts. "Our first priority may simply be opening a more solid line of communication with him. He's shown himself willing to engage with us. Perhaps we can cultivate that relationship into something more solid."

"I'll do my best," Tsukauchi agrees but doesn't seem all that hopeful. Kiddo's gone through a *lot* of trouble to keep them off his tail.

They end the meeting and All Might goes to work on the next semester's lesson plans with a heavier heart.

Sometimes, Magne wonders what life might have been like if she'd never gone villain. She had choices. Maybe she could have dealt with her violent impulses in a healthier way, or at least a more constructive one. Maybe she could have built up a career using her abilities for the betterment of others, maybe worked her way up through a company, maybe had a family.

It would be hard to be *Magne* in that sort of life though, and she's got enough about herself that isn't quite right to cherish the things that are.

This job with the League is just what she's been looking for. The pay isn't great - *yet* - but it's still money to put into the surgery fund and no one's saying a single thing about her womanhood. Shigaraki's an asshole but he could care less if she's a man, woman, or *table* for how much he actually pays attention to people past their abilities and that's just refreshing. She's Mag-*nee* to Twice, both sides of him. It feels so good she could just burst.

The fact that she gets to rob and maim all she likes is a plus, too. Magne's never going to be one of those women that gets shy at violence. It's part of her, just as much as the color of her eyes, and denying that would be denying herself. She's done enough of that over the years. As long as she has one person in her corner Magne can take on the world, and if her dear friend hasn't kicked her aside yet she'll never be alone.

Thinking of that cute girl and her precious smile, Magne lets herself enjoy the warmth in her chest. Then she steps out of her apartment and comes face to face with another villain. It's not a League member but the short stature and simple getup is easily recognized.

"Got a minute?" Kiddo asks, big green eyes looking so very innocent for someone quickly rising in villain society with at least one high profile kill. She glances around but doesn't see any of his crew. Someone surely is looking out for him, right? He looks *twelve.*

"I guess I can spare a few for a cute kid like you," Magne decides after a moment. Might as well find out what he's up to, right?

He doesn't ask to come into her apartment, which is good because she wouldn't have let him. Bad enough he somehow tracked down where she lives.

"I came to offer you a deal," he says, hands stuffed in his hoodie pockets like he's just some harmless middle schooler. "You're skilled and I could use your help."

Magne narrows her eyes behind her sunglasses and sets her hands on her hips. Is this kid really gonna try to convert her?

"You think I don't know what you're about?" she asks and his expression, what she can see of it, doesn't change. "That you're this side of a vigilante?"

"Not like I'm hiding it."

"What makes you think I'd be interested in any goody two shoes bullshit? Maybe I like the violence."

Kiddo snorts and the mask pulls as he smiles under it. "Do I really seem like I care about *avoiding violence?*"

"Look, maybe you don't understand what it looks like from the outside, but there is no way you can give me what I want." It's a waste of time to string him along and Magne's never been that kind of girl. "Not when you're jonesing so hard for heroes."

That gives him pause, judging by the way he blinks and shifts his weight back away from her.

"For heroes?" he asks like he genuinely doesn't know.

"We know who warned UA in April," Magne says because she's kind of sorry for him, a little. Villain like this still caught up in trying to do *the right thing* like everyone tells him instead of carving out a place and being himself? It's just sad. Kiddo could be so much more.

He sighs, shoulders sagging. "Ah. So that's already gotten around."

"Yeah. You're officially on our kill list but I'm in a hurry so how about we pretend this conversation never happened and leave intact? I don't like being late."

As Kiddo steps back, Magne locks her door and steps past him. She's not afraid he'll stab her in the back, ain't his style, but she feels his eyes on him all the way to the stairs.

"I'm not rescinding the offer," he calls after her, "if you want another way to be free of your chains."

Magne doesn't look back or even wave to acknowledge him. Doesn't matter what way he might have. She's already decided on this path and she's going to walk it, no matter what happens. Why waste time regretting choices when she's finally making them in the first place? Stupid.

Shaking the encounter from her mind, Magne heads on to meet up at the bar and figure out their plan for nabbing that mouthy UA kid with just as much fire in his eyes as his hands.

The muttering took a while for Spinner to get used to. Whenever he's not directly conversing with someone, Kiddo mutters under his breath almost constantly. It would be annoying if not for the words Spinner catches here and there, the knowledge that Kiddo is constantly thinking of his schemes and how to further their goals.

Well. It *is* annoying but Spinner's dealt with weirder tics and their progress so far is enough to just deal with it. The last few years felt so aimless but now that Kiddo's around, he feels like he's actually making strides towards a purpose for once. Kiddo laid out the overall plan as thus:

1. Eliminate the League of Villains

2. Eliminate the shadow king, All for One

3. Eliminate false heroes

4. Elevate true heroes

5. Create a better world

They're goals Spinner can understand, concrete even if they seem crazy. He doesn't mind crazy. It's better than useless. Each rung mostly seems easier than the previous so if they complete their *first* objective, well, the rest should just fall into place, right?

The information gathering they've been doing for the last couple weeks has paid off. On an old bulletin board Dabi scrounged up from somewhere, they've organized notes on various targets for their next big raid. Targets and *non-combattants*. Maybe Spinner doesn't quite have the stones to outright murder children, but he's pretty sure some of them could do with getting taken down a peg if the UA sports festival was anything to go on. Sure, class 1-A had seen *some* combat, but not nearly enough to make them realize how unfathomably outclassed they are by real villains. So many of them still have that same disgustingly strong pride and entitlement that's ruined hero society in the first place. If they end up heroes in the end, someone like him is going to take them out sooner or later when they get to step three. Why not take them out before they're a threat?

But Kiddo's adamant. They'll only be temporarily disabling any kids they find to keep them out of the way, nothing more. Captured and stowed away. Seems like a waste of time if they're just going to hinder him later, but he's thrown in with Kiddo. He'll listen for now.

Whatever Kiddo's been scheming seems to have reached a workable point because the mumbling stops and he looks up, blinking owlishly like he's coming out of a fugue state. Spinner waits for him to focus on him.

"Figured it out?" he asks and Kiddo grins behind his face mask.

"Grab the others, let's go over the plan."

Spinner gives a short nod and then goes to corral Toga and Dabi over to the meeting area. There's a few others Kiddo has recruited, but they aren't here and Kiddo doesn't seem to want to use them just yet. He's not sure why.

When the four of them are gathered in front of the bulletin board, Kiddo clasps his hands behind his back and looks over them one by one.

"This is our first major operation as a team," he starts with all the air of a general getting ready to order his men to battle. "I expect we'll make mistakes. We don't know each other that well yet, but just do your best and stay alive."

"How about rule one is you don't coddle us?" Dabi says, eyes narrow and half offended, and Spinner gets it. Sounds more like a high school coach's pep talk than the leader of a villain group.

Kiddo snorts.

"Yeah, I deserved that. Okay. Brass tacks then." He gestures to the list of noncombatants, a picture labeled with their names. "Leave the kids alone unless they get in your way. Otherwise, immobilize them and stash them somewhere safe. We'll send a message to the heroes on where to find them after. I don't want to hear about any unnecessary roughness. That doesn't mean no one gets hurt, some of them have devastating quirks, but minimize harm wherever possible. If you can toss them into the main camp building, do it. Their teachers will want to keep them contained safely as long as possible."

Reasonable enough, even if Spinner eyes a few of the kids with more powerful quirks and somehow is sure they'll cause problems. Well, he's up for the challenge. Wouldn't have gotten involved in the first place if he was the kind of guy who required a guarantee of safety.

"Bakugou Katsuki is our priority one. We make sure he doesn't get taken or seriously injured. The League plans on kidnapping and trying to turn him. He'd die before accepting that."

Said like Kiddo knows Bakugou well. Spinner isn't sure if the others have figured out just how personal this mission is, not when Kiddo's been careful to couch it in the prospect of weakening the League of Villains, but Spinner's not stupid or blind. Kiddo's protecting a friend, or maybe a kid brother. Hell, maybe *his kid*. For all that Kiddo looks and acts young, there's no telling how old he is or what his life has been like. He could be in his fifties with a quirk side effect that slows his aging.

"Why don't we just take him first?" Toga pipes up from her seat on a box, head tilted curiously. "If he's not at the camp to get snatched, isn't that better?"

"We're not equipped to hold him long term. It's a bad matchup and a waste of our time and resources." Objectively true. "Besides, keeping Bakugou out of enemy hands is only part of our purpose. The League will be sending some of their top level members. This is an opportunity for us to take them down, *hard*. If you can turn them away from the League, that's great. Otherwise? Kill them if you have the opportunity. Any that escape will be a thorn in our sides later."

The slow curl of Dabi's lips shows how much he's looking forward to that and Toga brightens as well. Spinner's still not used to the whiplash of how quickly Kiddo goes lethal but he's okay with the idea of taking out future problems.

Kiddo turns to the list of League members he's fairly sure will be there. They discuss each one's quirk, known strengths and weaknesses, and battle strategies. All in all, it's a useful few hours and Spinner's feel pretty confident about the whole thing. Of course, plans fail the moment one meets the enemy, but they've got plans b through double-z to manage if things go tits up.

As Dabi and Toga wander off, Spinner hangs back. He waits until Kiddo notices him, then asks, "Why do you care so much about that Bakugou kid?"

"Maybe I'm just a fan from the sports festival." The tone is flippant but Kiddo's eyes are solid and steady on Spinner's own. Daring him to push the issue. To find a reason to oust him? Surely not after Kiddo worked so hard on their plans that inevitably involved him.

"He some friend's kid?" Spinner guesses and Kiddo doesn't twitch. "Old girlfriend's kid? *Your* kid?"

Kiddo's eyes crinkle like he's smiling but the mask hasn't moved. Without looking, Spinner's hand goes to the hilt of his sword but he doesn't draw. *Yet.*

"I'm nothing to him," Kiddo says and Toga would have probably bought it, Dabi maybe, but Spinner notices what he *didn't* say. Kiddo is nothing to Bakugou… but that doesn't mean Bakugou's nothing to *him*.

Knowing he's already risked going this far, Spinner lets it drop. Fine. Kiddo doesn't want to talk? Wants to make a personal issue everyone else's problem? Fine. It's still more action than Spinner was seeing before he joined up and he's still pretty sure it'll be a net positive for the kind of change he desperately wants to see in the world.

Besides. If they keep the kid safe, surely that means the heroes that would have lost him will owe a favor, right? Always good to have leverage.

Chapter 5

There are things Dabi knows about the world: It's unfair and cruel, it must be broken if a mad dog like Endeavor is held in such high esteem, and he's pretty sure Kiddo might be its best chance of being formed anew into something even a person like him can breathe easily in.

That's the only reason Dabi is here in a forest, staying out of sight of a bunch of brats trying to scare each other while patiently waiting for an enemy to arrive. Between Giran and Kiddo, they'd gotten a roster of names and quirks, but Kiddo had admitted there were unknown factors that couldn't be accounted for. Something about changes in routines, changes in probabilities, all sorts of things tumbling freely out in muttered snips that Dabi doesn't have the patience to sort through. It's not like Kiddo doesn't summarize his thoughts eventually anyway.

Dabi had been aimless for years before taking up Kiddo's offer. Now his goals feel entirely attainable and he doesn't even have to do it alone. That's the deal. The League of Villains goes down first, then he will finally be able to rid himself of even the memory of Endeavor. Victory is so close he can *taste* it.

There's no feeling when fire comes to life in his hands, but the light convinces him it's really there. Dabi sets his fires carefully, letting the super hot flames catch and cool to a smoldering gold once he stops pumping power into it. There hasn't been a drought so it takes a while for the trees and plants to really start burning but he makes his way around their arbitrary barrier line dutifully. The eventual investigation will know this is arson, but there's no reason to let the kids and heroes in on the joke.

Smoke and steam from the burning start to waft up above the treeline as he goes, half concealed by the dark sky, but the smell is sure to reach the camp quickly. They're down wind and there's a pretty steady gust feeding his flames.

He straightens up from his crouch when he smells the very faintest hint of gas in the air. Bingo. Seems like his target has arrived. Digging his gas mask out of his pocket, Dabi puts it on and then starts hunting.

Shouta stops mid step while taking his students to Vlad King for their supplementary lesson as something catches his attention, just at the edge of his vision. A light flickers out from the treeline and it takes him only a moment to recognize the code.

-.. .- -. --. . .-.

Danger

"Go to Vlad King. If any of you leave the building while I'm gone, I'll expel you," he says and ignores the whining of the failing students as they step inside. His hackles are already raised before the door closes behind them and he raises a hand to his scarf as he spots a short figure walking his way.

“What do you want, Kiddo?” he asks, watching the villain slide a small pocket mirror away into his hoodie pocket.

“The League of Villains is gearing up for an attack on your students that’s going to start in the next ten minutes,” Kiddo says in the most uncomfortably casual tone Shouta has ever heard for a situation like this. “I have my people looking for them, see if we can’t slow them down or take them out first, but I need your help with one.”

So far, Kiddo has never lied to them as far as anyone can tell, but that doesn’t make this any more believable. There *has* seemed to be some kind of power struggle starting to pick up between Kiddo and the League though, so maybe it’s enough for Kiddo to proactively involve himself.

“Why would I help you?” Shouta still asks.

“Because if we don’t take Muscular down quickly, he’ll tear a path through every one of you heroes and the students. There will be deaths.”

Muscular. His mind immediately flashes through all the information he knows about the infamous villain. A-Rank, murdered the duo of Water Hose, but that was simply the most recent of his crimes. Quirk involved manipulating his own muscle fibers to give himself monstrous strength…

“If it helps convince you,” the villain adds after a moment, “he’ll start with Mandalay’s boy.”

Kiddo’s styled himself far more like a vigilante but that doesn’t mean Shouta will trust him. It *is* easier to give him the benefit of the doubt however.

“Where?”

“Up the mountain. There’s a cave the kid likes to hang at.”

Shouta doesn’t ask how Kiddo knows that. He won’t get a decent answer. Instead, he just nods and the two of them speed off towards it. They don’t have a trail to follow but Kiddo seems to know exactly where he’s going. If this isn’t on the level, Shouta’s not sure he’d get out scott free from a trap, but he wouldn’t be able to forgive himself if something happened to that kid.

“The fires should get the Pussycats’ attention quickly,” Kiddo says as they run through the dense trees. “Some villains are set to attack them and the students soon, but my teammate will be right on their tail.”

Fires? But Shouta can pick it up faintly already, a rich smell not unlike the camp stoves they’d used the last few days to cook. He grits his teeth and ups his running pace as much as he can without exhausting himself.

“Why did you even get me involved then?” he asks and Kiddo laughs.

“None of my crew or yours is a good match for Muscular’s quirk, so the best solution is to take it away from him, right?”

It makes sense and that pisses Shouta off to no end. They find a rocky trail that Kiddo turns down without hesitation, Shouta hot on his tail. Every second it takes to get there grates on him further and further.

“I’m giving you permission under my situational authority to use your quirk in this fight with Muscular and this fight alone, do you understand?” he says and Kiddo jerks his head to stare at him for a second before shaking his head.

“Boy, don’t I feel special?” he says with bitterness lacing every word. Shouta doesn’t have time to wonder about that before they turn a corner and abruptly their target is right in front of them with a young boy in the middle. Without pausing even a moment in his run, Shouta darts forward to grab the kid and dodge as Muscular’s gigantic fist slams into the ground where Kota had just been standing. A second later the villain is snarling as Shouta’s quirk activates and his body shrinks down again.

“What the fuck-”

Kiddo’s fist interrupts him, landing a solid hit without Muscular’s quirk to soften the blow, but the man’s the size of a mountain even without it and the surprise advantage doesn’t hold. He twists with the blow and makes one of his own that Kiddo just barely dodges, setting the pace for a game of skill more than power and giving Shouta a moment to study the way the strange villain moves. It’s familiar. It’s like *him*. He’d noticed it before but seeing it from the outside? There’s no denying Kiddo’s style is a match. Just how closely has this guy been watching him?

“Go down the mountain and stay out of the way. Hide if anyone comes for you that you don’t know,” he tells Kota before running in to join Kiddo. His erasure won’t last long, not after his injuries from the USJ, but he’d make it enough. Between his scarf and Kiddo’s knives, they put Muscular on the defensive. When one of them goes to strike, the other distracts. When one evades, the other makes sure the path is clear. Not only does Kiddo fight like him, but he’s *good*. Outside specific duos, villains just don’t *do* cooperation like this. Maybe Nedzu has the right idea about Kiddo being a fallen hero.

When Shouta has to blink and rest his quirk for a few seconds, Kiddo doesn’t have to be told. He just presses his attack, baiting Muscular into focusing on him. A solid punch to his gut sends Kiddo flying into the rock wall with bone crushing force as Muscular bulks up hideously, but then Shouta’s back in the fight and able to give Kiddo a few precious seconds of his own to recover his breath.

Reaching for his face, Muscular only manages to graze Kiddo and tear the mask away but all it nets him is a deep cut across his chest. He knocks Shouta off his feet but the scarf wraps around his arm as Shouta uses it to both pull himself back up and throw Muscular into the rock wall the same way he had Kiddo. The villain’s used to falling back on his sheer power, not technique or skill, and that’s something both Shouta and Kiddo have in spades.

Muscular starts getting desperate and his strikes become less coordinated, more wild. They’re harder to predict but easier to evade and then Shouta gets a break. His scarf wraps tight around the villain, pinning one arm to him and tangling up his legs. Muscular hits the ground and yells as he tries to use the scarf to drag Shouta in, but he’s too well rooted for that measly

leverage to work. His eyes are burning from the strain of keeping them open but they need to secure Muscular before he can rest again.

Shouta starts to say something when Kiddo darts past him. He sees the knife in Kiddo's hand and knows immediately what's going to happen, but there's no time to stop him. Kiddo lands on Muscular's chest, grabs his head to jerk it forward, and then stabs into his neck with enough power to hilt the blade, expertly slicing through the carotid artery in a bloom of blood that streaks across Kiddo's hoodie and face. A jerk of his wrist and the scream Muscular might have uttered is rendered moot as Kiddo shears through his vocal cords.

It only takes seconds and then Muscular is limp. Kiddo pulls his knife free and gets up, wiping blood off onto his pants. Then he jerks back as the end of Shouta's scarf streaks past him.

"He could have been taken alive!" Shouta snarls, chasing Kiddo back several feet. "How dare you-"

"He can't be rehabilitated!" Kiddo yells back and though Shouta knows he's fully capable of retaliating, he only evades as Shouta tries to capture him. "We don't have time for this! Shouldn't you be more worried about your kids?"

He should, he knows that, but it's so frustrating to have been right there and unable to stop Kiddo from murdering another villain. And now Kiddo isn't even attacking him, like he doesn't see Shouta as an actual threat.

Both of them freeze as a telepathic message comes through. Kiddo was right. Villains have attacked the Pussycats and his students.

"You'd better get down there," Kiddo says, looking off towards the edge of fires spreading through the trees. "Ragdoll's a secondary target."

"Who's the primary one?" Shouta asks because taking Kiddo in will have to wait until the students are safe, no matter how bile burns in the back of his throat.

Kiddo reaches down and picks up his discarded mask, wincing with an arm wrapped around his middle. He gives the torn elastic an annoyed sigh. When Shouta can see his full face, big eyes and freckles and a petulant expression, he thinks of his students and wonders again who the hell Kiddo is and what made him into this killer.

"Bakugou Katsuki," Kiddo says as he stuffs the useless mask into his pocket and tugs his hood further forward. "They want him alive. They won't care about killing any of the rest."

However many people Kiddo's got with him, he'd only indicated one would be backing up the Pussycats. The bulk of his students will be with them, a few others scattered in the forest. It's not a good situation either way but he needs to make sure the majority are in a good spot first.

"Go after him," he says as Kiddo glances his way, "but when this is over, I'm coming for you."

Kiddo snorts and his smile isn't pleasant but there's something weirdly nostalgic about it. "Yeah. I know."

They part ways and Shouta grabs Kota on his way back, hoping he's making the right choice.

With Spinner going to support the heroes and Dabi off starting fires and trying to locate the poison gas user Kiddo's sure is hanging around, Himiko has a more nuanced sort of job. She's been watching the students as they make their way back to camp, offering a little help here and there from the shadows as she verifies who the League sent and what they can do. Sure, Himiko can be a force to be reckoned with, but she's a lot better suited to this stealthy kind of thing! She's so happy Kiddo understands that and knows how to use her.

He might be the only one who's ever accepted her this way.

//*Everyone in A Class and B Class! In the name of pro hero, Eraserhead, you are granted permission to engage in combat! Additionally, the villain's priority is capturing Bakugou Katsuki! Bakugou should try to avoid combat and acting independently. Understand, Bakugou?*//

Oh, was that the area burst telepathy ability Kiddo talked about? Neat! And she even warned the boy Kiddo wants saved at all costs, how nice of them. Maybe when this is over, Himiko will go and thank Mandalay herself. What if they can be friends?

Loud crashing draws her attention and Himiko stealthily makes her way toward it. Had the guy with the gigantification quirk come? Kiddo had warned about him but said the League probably hadn't convinced him to join up yet. Still, something big is definitely going on! Skirting around a duo of very cute girls, Himiko races after the noises.

About the time she gets there, she has to shield her eyes as an explosion of light and fire tries to blind her. Spots still dot her vision for several seconds after but the crashing noises have stopped. She sneaks her way closer and spots a group of boys, lighting up inside as she recognizes Bakugou. Kiddo's friend is safe and unharmed! He'll be overjoyed. She doesn't care about the rest except the way they all decide to escort Bakugou back to the heroes that will look after him. Her attention turns to the knocked out villain they leave behind.

Moonfish isn't someone Himiko's ever met and he holds no interest to her now, unconscious and defeated. Squatting down in front of him, she says, "Hey, do you want to follow Kiddo?"

There's no answer of course, but Himiko's pretty sure this qualifies as trying to turn him to their side and failing. With a grin, she draws her knife and sets the sharp tip right over Moonfish's heart.

If a villain isn't useful to Kiddo, he shouldn't stick around, right?

Himiko throws her entire weight into stabbing him through the heart, then leaps back as his quirk triggers. Blade teeth shoot out at random around Moonfish's body in self defense, but don't get far. Himiko watches just outside his range as the villain shudders and whines and then everything stops. Retrieving her knife and filling up a little container with his sluggishly

dripping blood, she looks back to where the hero students disappeared and starts after them. Who knows when they might encounter another League member?

Excitement fills her up inside. Maybe if she does well enough, Kiddo will praise her! She rides the high of that idea with every step.

It does not think. It does not feel.

It is. It is not.

Go that direction and fight until a warp opens.

It has not felt a warp open.

It goes. The trees get less dense as it passes them.

It sees light. It keeps going.

It sees moving things that are not its master.

It will fight.

Oh, that's just great, Spinner thinks to himself as he dodges one of Twice's stupid clones. He gave up trying to talk to the guy and Magne straight up tried to murder him for trying to get between her and one of the stupid heroes Kiddo wants to keep alive, so Spinner's maybe a little on edge.

And then the goddamn *Nomu* shows up and he is *done.*

The kids have evacuated into the camp building so it's just him, the Pussycats, Eraserhead, and enemies that suddenly seem a *lot* more confident now. If he lives through this, he's punching Kiddo in the face. He's pretty sure he's earned that much.

"Do you know anything about what that one can do?" Eraserhead asks and Spinner wants to laugh and scream at how frustrating it is to have one of these stupid, overhyped heroes talking to him like they're on the same side.

"Do I look like the Boss? No! I don't know! Probably super strength, that one's popular!"

If Eraserhead sighed at him, Spinner would tear out his spine. He doesn't, more's the pity.

Tightening his grip on his sword, Spinner gets himself ready to start the frontal assault. He'd decided to follow Kiddo's will and right now, all he can do is survive long enough for Kiddo to accomplish his goal.

"Wait, this guy here means Kiddo's around, doesn't it?" Twice asks, looking towards Magne and then scoffing, "He'd never show."

“That guy over there is one of his, yeah. Hey you! With the sword! Your boss is here, right?”

Spinner glares at her full force. “What’s it to you?”

“He’s definitely here.” Magne grins and hefts up the giant magnet to her shoulder. “Change of plans. Let the Nomu handle these guys and let’s go grab a trophy.”

Shit.

“If I die here, I’m going to *haunt* that stupid runt,” he mutters and then leaps into action. He only manages to slow the two of them down for a few minutes along with the heroes before the Nomu suddenly attacks and takes up all of their attention.

Kiddo better survive this if only so Spinner can be mad at him a little longer.

Bakugou’s been sulking ever since they met up with Shoji and Tokoyami and decided as a group to keep him protected until they get to the camp. Why is a mystery to Todoroki Shoto. He has to understand that their priority *should* be protecting him, right? As heroes in training? What does he expect?

Well. Whatever. Shoto hasn’t managed to figure out what to do with Bakugou at the best of times, much less when Bakugou decides to be unreasonable. Which, to be honest, is most of the time. Shoto guesses he might be annoyed too if his peers were trying to protect him instead of the other way around. Not that he’d ever be in a position to need it.

Up ahead on the trail he spots movement and tenses up, ready to drop Tsuburaba from his back if they have to fight again, but then relaxes as he recognizes Asui and Uraraka.

“Are you two all right?” Tokoyami asks from behind them and Uraraka nods.

“We haven’t met up with any villains yet,” she says and then gives them all a worried look over. “Doesn’t look like you had the same luck.”

“We should get back to camp to tend to any injuries,” Asui adds, which of course they have to wait. There’s no telling how many villains might still be around and if the knife teeth guy is any indication of their strength, then they’re just one bad matchup away from getting annihilated. Shoto’s not at all used to being outclassed like this. Even during the sports festival, his defeat to Bakugou had been close in terms of skill and power, and had really been down to chance. Had the fight with the knife teeth guy gone any further, he’s not sure they’d have survived it, much less actually defeated him.

It’s an uncomfortable feeling he’s not sure how to deal with yet.

“Come on, we’re escorting Bakugou-” he starts only to be interrupted as Bakugou loses his cool *again*.

“Like hell you’re doing anything for me!”

“-back to camp for his safety since he’s being targeted,” Shoto finishes as if he hadn’t been interrupted.

“This isn’t the time to stand around and talk. Let’s go, quickly,” Shoji says and then they slot Asui with Tokoyami as the rear guard considering how well suited her quirk could be to removing Bakugou from danger, Uraraka joining him and Shoji at the front. Tsuburaba’s dead weight gets moved over to Shoji since Shoto’s starting to tire - and that’s just another thing he needs to work on, his physical endurance.

They’ve only managed a few steps when a man in a top hat is thrown through a set of nearby tree branches and hits the ground only for another to drop right on top of him. There’s no time to guess who might be in the right - whether either is a hero - as the first man manages to kick off the second and dart back a few feet, his yellow jacket torn and stained with blood. The second person is smaller, dressed in dark grays with a knife in both hands, and stands between the first and the students like a sentry.

“Seriously Kiddo, what did I even do to you?” the first complains.

“You decided to join those lunatics over coming to my side,” the second says and he sounds… young. And Kiddo? Why does that name sound familiar? Some rant of his father’s maybe. “Now go crawling back to Shigaraki with your tail between your legs. Your mission is *over*.”

Is Kiddo a hero? With the blood soaked into his hoodie, Shoto is pretty sure he isn’t. Are they both villains? Is there some kind of power struggle going on? Shoto has no idea how to act, frozen with both hands raised like he means to defend the others, but against *who?* Usually his targets are pretty clear.

“You know that’s not how this works,” the first villain says and then squeaks when Kiddo goes right after him again. The villain ducks under Kiddo’s next swipe, evades another, and then starts towards the trees.

“Shoto, capture!” Kiddo yells in the same tone his father used training him and Shoto reacts before he can even think. A spread of ice shoots quickly over the ground, catching one of the villain’s shoes tight and tripping him. It slips off his foot as he falls but Shoto sends another wave to grab him more securely.

“Why did you help him?” Shoji whispers and Shoto doesn’t answer because he *doesn’t know*.

Without relaxing much, Kiddo walks up to the captured villain and Shoto gets a better look at his face. He *is* young. A little roughed up, like he’s been fighting for a while. He’s-

“What the hell?” Bakugou says from behind him. “Deku?”

Deku? Not Kiddo? Whatever his name is, the boy just sighs and then tugs down his hood. Dark curly hair, probably green? Freckles, big eyes. No different than any of his classmates, probably. In any other setting, no one Shoto would pay much attention to. Is he a friend of Bakugou’s?

“Hey Kacchan,” Deku says, turning back to the villain. “Sorry, I don’t have time to talk. You should all get back to the camp as quickly as you can-”

But Bakugou has no intention of letting whatever this is drop. He pushes past Shoto and Shoji to grab Deku’s arm, jerking the other to face him.

“Oh no, you’re explaining what the *fuck* a loser like you is doing here!” Oh. Maybe they aren’t friends after all.

“Hey, maybe this isn’t the right time-” Uraraka tries and Bakugou entirely ignores her.

“Listen to your classmates, Kacchan,” Deku says in a more strained tone, jerking his arm free of Bakugou’s grasp. “*You’re* the one the League wants.”

Bakugou starts to say something but Asui’s tongue jolts out to wrap around his belly and jerk him back several feet before another person leaps into the open, just barely missing opening Bakugou up with her knife.

“*Toga, no!*” Deku yells even as the girl sets herself defensively between him and the hero students, watching the way Bakugou scrambles back to his feet and shoves Asui away from him.

“He’s not being nice at all to my bestie,” the blond girl - Toga - says, “or his own friends.”

“I’m not friends with these fucking extras!” is the predictable response.

Deku grabs Toga’s shoulder and says, “Remember the rules. The students aren’t harmed unless they get in the way.”

And that… sounds like this not-friend of Bakugou’s is involved in the villain plot somehow. Shoto glances between him and Bakugou, wondering if this is a situation he should be letting play out. Aren’t they in kind of a vulnerable position?

“You’d better start explaining yourself *right now*, you shitty nerd,” Bakugou says, glaring for all he’s worth as if he isn’t in danger in the least.

“Right, I keep forgetting you don’t have a reasonable bone in your entire body.”

Which only pisses Bakugou off more, shouldn’t this guy know that’s what would happen?

“Guys?” Uraraka says, and then a second time louder to get their attention before pointing to the ice block. The ice block that no longer holds the first guy.

Shit.

“Tokoyami’s gone too!” Shoji says with a curse and when the hell did that happen?!

Muttering something under his breath, Deku lets go of Toga and instead draws his second knife again, starting to look around them for whatever threat he seems sure is coming. “Okay.

We'll do it the hard way this time. Toga, run defense for the students. I mean it about them all surviving intact."

"You got it, Boss!"

"I'm not dropping this," Bakugou hisses out and Deku just sighs.

"Yeah. I know. But you're going to let me help you for once or so help me, I'll kill you myself."

Chapter 6

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

There's a stench in the air that Bubaigawara Jin recognizes. Burned flesh is unlike anything else and part of him wonders if that should concern him but the rest scoffs. They already *knew* there would be fires because one of Kiddo's crew is a firebug, why should they think no one would get caught in it?

He's worried about that. It's fine.

Still, he's a little surprised not to find any bodies at all. Did the students manage to avoid Kiddo's crew as well as the League members? They must be good! The villains just sucked at hunting them. Not that the students at large are the goal, of course. Jin remembers that.

Part of him, anyway.

Magne's arm shoots out in front of him and Jin grunts as she nearly clotheslines him, but it does stop him from running headlong into a bolt of blue fire that makes his eyes burn behind his mask. He sways back and follows it back to the source.

Dabi's infamous in their circles for his prowess and surliness in equal measure. He'd apparently laughed when Giran tried to recruit him to the League of Villains but somehow Kiddo convinced him to join up instead. Those cold blue eyes glance over Jin in stark contrast to heat so high it makes the air around Dabi waver visibly.

"Spinner tried to make you join with Kiddo, didn't he?" Dabi asks and yeah, Jin's pretty sure there was something like that when Spinner popped up while they were attacking the heroes, but he hadn't really been listening much?

"I already told your boss I'm not interested," Magne says as she hefts up the magnet, getting ready. "Why would Spinner be any more convincing?"

Slowly, Dabi's lips spread into a wide, toothy smile that sends a shiver down Jin's spine. It's all the warning he gets before he and Magne are running for their lives from a guy who really should be on their side - fuck that guy, he's an asshole anyway. The lush forest around them burns unnaturally well and even when they stumble into a spot that's already burned to a crisp, the heat is no less oppressive.

There's a crispy corpse in the middle of it and Jin thinks he recognizes the melted remains of Mustard's helmet, but he's got better things to think about.

When Magne uses her quirk to drag Dabi in, he just takes it as an opportunity to burn half her face off. When Jin doubles and triples up with Magne clones to try and get a numbers edge on him, he just uses one of them as a human shield against Magne's strength. When she repels Dabi, it just means he's got the freedom for distance attacks.

This isn't a good matchup.. This is really bad - *they'll be fine.*

A few more of the Magne clones - was the original in that mess? - melt out of existence while Jin tries to think of some way to counteract the powerhouse Dabi's proving to be. Fire quirks are ridiculously versatile and Dabi seems to have trained extensively in how to use his in the most devastatingly skilled ways. Jin can't keep up, so the only thing he can do is hope they whittle down his energy. An active quirk like that has to be absolute murder on available calories.

Then Jin freezes as he spots Dabi behind who he's pretty sure is the real Magne through the haze of thick smoke and refracted blue light. There's no time to prevent it. Almost as soon as a warning wells up in Jin's mouth, Dabi's fingers curl around Magne's throat from behind and then…

And then Magne is no more. She doesn't even have time to scream before her throat is blackened by blue flames. Her scorched form seems to drop in slow motion before Jin's eyes. No mud, *it's really her.*

"One to go," Dabi says and the moment is instantly broken.

Magne clones flood the clearing, giving Dabi a target to concentrate on while Jin makes a run for it. Taking down Kiddo's crew isn't the mission and letting Dabi kill him in an attempt to do so would be the height of stupidity.

He still wants to. Rage at Magne's loss boils within him because while they hadn't known each other that long yet they'd still been friendly, but dying to her killer won't bring her back. He needs to make sure Mr. Compress grabbed the brat and get back to Shigaraki so they can plan out how to get even with Dabi and Kiddo both.

For once, all sides of him are in total agreement.

Apparently, Asui Tsuyu is the only student who recognizes the name Kiddo. She doesn't bring this up because they have enough to worry about and he seems to be on their side right now, but the way no one is on guard against him after Bakugou starts treating him like a friend - the way Bakugou sees friendship, anyway - makes her pretty sure they haven't realized it.

But Tsuyu talked extensively with Sirius about the Hero Killer incident and she knows just how dangerous Kiddo is, even if they're calling him Deku right now.

She keeps it to herself to make sure no one panics and to keep from giving Kiddo a reason to turn on them. He seems keen on keeping them safe, especially Bakugou, but who knows how long that will hold.

"You were given permission to fight to keep yourselves safe and allow an escape," Kiddo says to the group of them, "and if you weren't *brainless*, you'd be going back to camp together."

“Not without Tokoyami,” Todoroki says and it’s a sentiment shared by most of the others, but…

It’s not smart, what they’re talking themselves into doing. Tsuyu just knows it’s going to turn out terribly and while she’s just as angry and scared for Tokoyami as the rest of them, it would be better to get the adult heroes involved. Since that’s *not* going to happen, the best she can do is fill in the gaps their anger is leaving wide open.

“So here’s what we’ll do.” Kiddo turns his glare full power onto Bakugou like he knows the highest amount of pushback will be from him. “You and Asui will go back to camp to fetch the heroes-”

“Like *fuck!”*

“-because the two of you will be able to move the fastest and she’s good at covering weaknesses-”

“You’re not benching me, you piece of shit!”

“-and you need to keep *moving* so they can’t pinpoint your location as easily-”

“Why are you even here, you goddamn shitty nerd!”

“It’s like watching a married couple on the verge of divorce,” Tsuyu mutters to herself but apparently not quite quietly enough because Ochaco snorts. Oh well, a little levity is probably a good thing.

“He’s right though,” Ochaco says, glancing her way. “We need the heroes if we want a chance to save Tokoyami.”

If Bakugou is their target, the villains aren’t likely to leave without him-

“Todoroki!”

Jerking her head up at Shoji’s cry, she catches the tail end of Todoroki’s two-tone hair before he disappears down the path. Apparently, he got tired of waiting.

“Don’t think I’m letting you take all the glory!” Bakugou yells and shoots after him with fire bursting from his palms to aid his acceleration.

“He never *fucking* listens,” Kiddo mutters bitterly. “The rest of you, be careful.”

And then he’s racing after them, taking off into the treetops. Is that part of his quirk? Tsuyu realizes abruptly that she has no idea what he can do. That girl Toga doesn’t even bother saying goodbye before she’s gone as well.

“Come on,” Ochaco says with a grim expression on her face. “We can at least try to keep them alive if they’re too stupid to think about tactics.”

Shoji nods and the three of them head out after them. Alone Tsuyu knows she could be a lot faster, but she's not willing to leave Ochaco and Shoji like that.

Hold on, Tokoyami.

Sako Atsuhiro has a problem. *This isn't supposed to be a solo show.*

Tricks and running away are only going to get him so far and this pack of teenagers keeps getting a little too close for comfort. Especially that Todoroki kid and his stupid ice, but really his best bet is to get them around the other members of the Vangard because Atsuhiro is the farthest thing from an offensive player as they come. There's a reason he's known for his tricks.

Hopping from treetop to treetop towards the warp site, Atsuhiro glances at his watch. Still a bit before the final pull out time. The kid he's got is a fine enough hostage, might be good for some extortion… but Atsuhiro's not sure he'll live through Shigaraki's wrath if he doesn't nab Bakugou in the end. How the hell to separate them now that he's blown his first strike…

Atsuhiro dodges around a knife before even really seeing it and then his blood boils all over again. Goddamn *Kiddo*, how many of those things does he have!? It's not like he's ever met the guy before but Kiddo seems to really have it out for him anyway. His thoughts go to a standstill as Kiddo himself slams bodily into him, knocking both of them out of the sky and to the ground hard. Atsuhiro doesn't wait to catch the breath knocked out of him before shoving Kiddo back and escaping another swipe of his knife. The sharp ache in his chest is probably a bad sign of injury, but Atsuhiro doesn't have time to take stock of it. Not when Kiddo's matching him move for move like some deranged beast.

"Drop the student," Kiddo says with cold calm even as he tries to tear into him with knives that seem more like a built-in extension of his hands than separate tools. The moment Atsuhiro dodges past one of his strikes, he's got to dodge that crazy blond girl as well and why are all these kids using *knives?* Is advanced knife wielding a new trend!? What happened to good, old fashioned battle quirks?

They're close to the rendezvous spot but he hasn't noticed any sign of the others. Had they all already been taken down or are they still fighting? Their plans must be seriously fucked over if he's the only one that got this far.

At least it's only Kiddo and the girl that were quick enough to keep up with him. If the rest of those brats catch up- And suddenly he's not fighting alone anymore. He doesn't know what Twice has been up to but at least the guy knows to plunge head first into backing him up! Even if it's just three more Mr. Compresses he now has to work around and not someone with a little more firepower, at least it's some kind of relief!

With Twice helping, Atsuhiro's able to get some distance and vanishes into the trees. Hopefully Twice will be able to keep Kiddo and the blond occupied long enough for Atsuhiro to nab Bakugou. He makes his way back towards the group of students with every ounce of stealth in his body.

The first two he meets up with are Todoroki and Bakugou, both of them using their quirks to move faster and burning through their energy reserves before the fight can even start like rank amateurs, it's precious. The others are probably several minutes behind if Atsuhiro's lucky. He rounds behind the two distracted students, matching pace, and then reaches out for Todoroki's back.

The same second Todoroki compresses down into a marble, Bakugou twists and blasts Atsuhiro in the face, that *bastard!* He'd taken out Todoroki first because the ice is a pain to deal with but now he's on the run as Bakugou mercilessly drives him back with non stop explosions and no wonder Shigaraki thought this kid might make a good villain! What kind of hero has a quirk for *exploding!?*

"Aren't you getting tired of the goody two shoes approach of heroes?" Atsuhiro tries and nearly gets fried for his trouble. He can't get close enough to get a firm hold on the kid, not with how skillfully Bakugou uses his quirk for simultaneous offense and defense, even mobility. This kid is going to be an absolute menace if they don't turn him early and Atsuhiro is only barely keeping up with him, feeling the couple ribs he's pretty sure are broken from the fall with every step.

"Haaa? What's this trash villain saying to me now?" That cheeky little *brat*.

"Come on, you're being held back by all their rules- Fuck!"

Another blast to the face and he has to knock his mask off when it catches fire along with his hat.

"How's that for being held back?!"

Oh, he is going to *murder* this brat.

Dragging this out will just put Atsuhiro at a worse disadvantage but Bakugou isn't burning out fast enough for him to use it against him. He's read everything the League was able to find on this kid, there's no reason for his quirk to be *this* strong already when his parents are totally normal. They didn't even find any record of him visiting quirk trainers like some of the other kids. Whatever Bakugou has? It's driven by sheer talent and skill that's only going to be more potent with time. If they don't turn him, Shigaraki better kill him. That is, if Atsuhiro doesn't first.

From further down the path comes an uneven chorus of *Bakugou* and it's the split second of distraction Atsuhiro's been waiting for. He makes contact and compresses the kid faster than he's ever done it before. Cries of dismay are music to his ears. Atsuhiro chuckles and gives the kids a careless grin as he leaps up back into one of the trees, careful not to wince as it jostles his beaten body. Can't let the audience know he's hurt!

"As much fun as all this has been, we're out of time," he says cheerfully then has to start fleeing as the frog quirk girl takes a stab at him, her tongue narrowly missing his arm. Before he's even on the ground again, Atsuhiro taps his ear to open the radio.

“Vanguard Action Squad,” he greets. “Target successfully collected. It was just a short while but with this, our show has come to a close! As arranged, head to the retrieval point in the next five minutes!”

However many of them are still alive, anyway. Atsuhiro takes his leave of the kids and goes to see how Twice is doing.

Himiko doesn’t hear it but she notices immediately when her enemy gets some kind of signal to withdraw. Two of the clones go down pretty quickly, but the last one gives her some trouble as Kiddo concentrates on the main guy.

And oh, Kiddo’s *face!* She could die, he’s so cute. He looks so much younger than she thought he’d be, perfect age for her! When this is over, he better let her ruffle his hair. Just because she’s pretty sure he could kill her with barely a thought doesn’t mean it wouldn’t be worth it.

The last clone finally melts down to mud and Himiko watches Kiddo and Twice running around each other nearby. No more clones, just his razor sharp tape, is he getting tired? There’s got to be a limit to how many clones he can make in a day, right? Well, good for them, but doesn’t that mean they have to kill him now? He seems super friendly!

Getting closer, she can hear them talking anytime Kiddo gets in close to Twice but not quite what they’re saying. Surely Kiddo’s making his case. If Twice joins up, that’s one more step towards getting rid of the League of Villains Kiddo hates so much. And a new friend, too!

Movement catches her attention and oh hey, it’s the compression guy! Definitely the real one, maskless as he is.

“Get the marbles from him!” Kiddo yells and then doubles over as Twice gets him in the gut with a well aimed kick, but Himiko will think about that later. It’s not like he’ll go down for good.

Turning on a dime, Himiko starts after Mr. Compress. Kiddo had been particularly pissed off when he realized the real deal wasn’t still there with the clones but they couldn’t exactly go after him. How nice of him to come to her instead.

Himiko narrowly misses slicing through his achilles tendon but it’s still enough to trip Mr. Compress up. She’s able to grab onto his coat and uses it for leverage to drag herself in. Checking one pocket and finding nothing, she reaches for the second and then jerks her head to one side to avoid his flailing elbow. The second pocket is checked and then she has to disengage to keep from getting marbled herself, but now there’s a couple tiny blue beads in her hand. Jackpot!

Except she loses them a second later to the frog girl as that guy with all the extra appendages races past her to engage Mr. Compress.

“Oh hi!” she greets, ignoring the tense look on the girl’s face. Aaahhh, so cute. “Those are mine.”

“We’re not letting you have our friends,” the girl says, gripping the marbles tighter like she means to keep them forever.

“That just means *we* have to be friends, then we can all have each other.” It seems like sound logic to Himiko but the girl is less than pleased. What was her name again? Oh, Himiko’s terrible at this- Wait, wasn’t there another girl with her last time she saw them?

A tap to her back and Himiko’s body suddenly goes weightless as she starts to lift off the ground. She tumbles back, slashes, but the little hero in training is quick! All Himiko can do is float and watch as the gravity user disregards her entirely for Mr. Compress. It’s kind of impressive if Himiko’s honest with herself, even if a little annoying. They’re on the same side right now!

The fight with Twice is going about as well but Kiddo can take care of himself and Twice seems more interested in escaping than trying to kill him. It’s not like she can really help right now. The height *does* mean she’s the first one to see a purple cloud open up and that warp guy steps through, uh oh.

“Time!” she yells out as loudly as she can and maybe she can’t hear Kiddo curse but reading the tension that races through him is easy. She looks back down to the heroes and sees the frog girl- Tsuyu! That’s her name, how could she forget something so precious? Tsuyu’s gearing up for a leap so Himiko throws one of her knives to thud into the ground next to her. “Hey!”

Tsuyu looks up at her, startled and suspicious.

“Get me over there!” Himiko motions frantically towards the warp guy. “I’ll distract him while you get any other marbles!”

For a moment, Himiko thinks she’ll be ignored. Then a strong tongue shoots out to wrap around her waist and throw her towards the warper. She barely hears a call to Ochaco - oh yeah, that was her name! SO cute - before the weightlessness abruptly ends. Himiko twists herself in mid air and comes down hard on the warper but her knives only hit cloth and smoke, not the main body. A second later, she’s falling forward into a bramble bush.

Well shoot. Himiko lifts her head and then blinks at Dabi not two feet away.

“So Kurogiri is here already,” Dabi says in a flat tone and Himiko sticks her tongue out at him but accepts his hand up.

“Yeah and the marble guy got Bakugou.”

Dabi sighs and they head off back towards the noises of battle.

“Only two of you got here?” the smoke warp guy - Warper for short? - says after sending the blond who knows where. Uraraka Ochaco doesn’t let herself be intimidated by that, not when she, Shoji, and Tsuyu need to get the last marble. They only saw the guy get Bakugou but Todoroki must have been marbled first since the two of them ran ahead together.

“Wait, don’t forget me!” yells yet another villain as he races across the clearing with Deku in hot pursuit. “I don’t wanna go anyway!”

A warp opens between the two and Deku dodges around it but comes to a stop near Ochaco. He’s panting, bruised up and bloodied, but that villain looks worse off.

“Are you okay?” she asks because whatever his purpose here, he’s still helping them.

“Doesn’t matter.”

“Oh, hello again Kiddo,” Warper says. The anger marring Deku’s face only gets worse at the sarcastic wave he gives. “Sensei sends his regards.”

“Tell him to eat shit and die.” He turns to Ochaco next and she freezes at the sheer presence he exudes. It reminds her of a high level pro hero, locking up her body despite her exposure to the teachers. “How many of your classmates did he take?”

“We-”

The marble guy - she’ll just call him Marbles - suddenly starts laughing and Deku’s expression turns murderous before he twists and runs at him headlong. More warps open but Deku seems to be predicting where each will be and dodge around it just in time. That’s not a pace he can keep up for long and then he’s a second too late, disappearing through dark mist. Somewhere not too far off, she hears an enraged scream. Shoji makes another pass at Marbles while he’s distracted and then jumps back to put distance between them as a warp starts opening to drag him in.

One of his hands is tightly clenched and when he catches her eye, she’s sure he’s got the last of their missing classmates. He turns and starts towards her, calling out, “Uraraka, Asui, we’re running *now!*”

They turn to make the escape but Ochaco happens to catch when Marbles smiles and her blood goes cold.

“Were you successful?” Warper asks him, a warp opening up behind them that the last villain slips through immediately. Marbles opens his mouth, showing a last blue bead sitting on his tongue, and then takes it into his hand with a chuckle.

“They seemed so happy that they apparently won, I thought I’d give them a present,” he says cheerfully before snapping his fingers. The marbles in Tsuyu’s hand burst free, becoming Tokoyami and Todoroki, while Shoji’s ends up being a chunk of Todoroki’s ice. “A dummy for the dummies.”

“Confirm it,” is Warper’s only reaction. “Release the last one.”

Another snap and the last marble releases to show a bewildered looking Bakugou for only a second before he’s pulled through the warp.

They failed.

Chapter End Notes

Juggling changes I need to make and and characters' moments of awesome is why most of what I write tends to be emotional rather than action lol

Chapter 7

When Inko gets home that afternoon, the apartment is empty and all she finds is a note in the kitchen from Izuku saying he'll be spending the night with a friend. It's so rare an occurrence that Inko almost calls him to confirm, but she keeps herself from doing it. She already resolved to trust Izuku as far as she could.

So, Inko settles in for a peaceful evening. She catches up on her reading, watches some mindless television, and tries to convince herself that she isn't losing her son a little more each day. He's a teenager, she can't be hanging onto him like a toddler. Those days, wonderful as they'd been, are over. She has to let him figure out how to live his own life.

That thought stays with her until she's gone to bed, then she's startled out of her skin as her front door opens with a crash. The only reason she doesn't panic over possible robbery is hearing her boy's frantic call of, "*Mom!"*

"Izuku?!" Inku rushes out of her room and Izuku plows right into her, nearly knocking her down. His face presses tight to her shoulder, arms wrapping around her as her own settle around him more from routine than will. "Honey, what's wrong?"

He squeezes her tighter. "I need you to promise to tell the truth."

What?

"I- honey, I won't lie to you-"

"Not to me, to the police."

Alarm bells run riot in her mind as her chest suddenly feels ten times too small for her lungs. Getting a grip on Izuku's shoulders, she pushes him back enough to see his face and is horrified by how beaten up he looks. There's blood on his face and clothes, tears in the cloth that must be over injuries.

"What's going on? What happened to-"

"I don't have time-"

"Then *make* time."

He flinches and then lets out a brittle little laugh that's nothing like her baby, nothing she recognizes. His face is pale, eyes glassy and pupils too big, and he's shaking under her hands.

"You wouldn't believe me," he says and she's caught between the urge to hug him and shake him until he stops saying such stupid things. "I can't stay, but I needed to see you. I needed to make sure you knew they were coming and wouldn't try to hide anything to protect me. You *can't* do that, okay? You have to tell them anything they want to know. Let them in my room, let them take my things, just cooperate entirely. *You can't protect me.*"

This is scaring her more and more with every second. “Izuku, no. *No*. Whatever’s happening, we can go to the police station together in the morning and set things straight-”

“I can’t be arrested yet, I have to save Kacchan first.”

What does Katsuki have to do with this? And arrested?! Just what is her boy mixed up in?

“You’re in shock,” Inko says, gathering Izuku against her again. “Come sit with me and we’ll talk about all of this. Just tell me what’s going on. We’ll figure out a plan to fix it.”

Izuku rattles out another choked laugh but clings to her all the more. “I love you, Mom.”

“I love you too, honey. It’s okay. We’ll figure this out.”

Corralling Izuku towards his room, she has him sit down and then goes to fetch the first aid kit. First order of business is tending to whatever hurts he has, then they’ll sort out what's happened and how they should handle it. She’s rattled and unsure, but even that much of a plan helps settle her enough to concentrate on her son.

It probably shouldn’t surprise her to find his room vacant when she gets back but it does. His notebooks are gone and his window is open, curtains fluttering a little with the night air. She sets down the first aid kit and then sits at the edge of his bed for a very long time before she can force herself to close it.

Twenty-six injured or incapacitated students, three injured heroes, four dead villains, one captured villain. The Nomu seems as aimless as the last one they got their hands on from the USJ, but Shouta thinks this one might have even *less* going on in its head than that. The way it fought had been entirely instinctual, nothing higher up, but with the sheer strength and deadly force of those extra appendages it had, maybe it didn’t need to really think. And then how all at once it had simply stopped and no matter what they did, it didn’t respond again? Yeah. This side of brain dead.

It’s easier to think about the Nomu than the fact that the villains succeeded in taking Bakugou Katsuki.

Kiddo’s crew are nowhere to be found by the time things settle down, likely escaping while emergency services flooded the scene. Whatever answers Shouta hoped to get from them, he’ll have to wait for the next time they meet. There’s no doubt they will.

Those with major injuries are sent off to the hospital quickly but it’s hours later before anyone else gets to leave. Minor injuries are handled by paramedics and everyone involved speaks with the police to give as many details as they can. The whole picture of the event is messy and uncoordinated, but Shouta knows they’ll piece it together better tomorrow once they’ve gotten some rest.

The only bright side is that the identified secondary target is injured but will make a full recovery. Shouta doesn’t know Ragdoll very well, but he tries to take solace in the fact that she’s safe. Apparently, someone with a fire quirk had distracted her attacker before she could

be snatched just long enough for her to get away. They match the description with a known associate of Kiddo's.

Only after all the children are on their way home and the police have cleared them does Shouta leave the scene. He has an unfortunate duty to attend to. As he stands in front of the Bakugou home's front door, he wonders just how terribly this might go. There are a hundred ways the Bakugous could react and all of them are valid.

Hell, this late at night, they might not even answer. He knocks anyway.

The Bakugous take being awakened in the middle of the night well. They take losing their son badly. Shouta explains what he can, reassures them that UA is going to be working with the police and other pro heroes to rescue their son, and promises to keep them informed.

When things start to settle, he turns things to the second issue. "Do you recognize the name Deku? He may have gone by something else but your son calls him that. Green hair and eyes, freckles. Non-visible quirk."

"That… Masaru, do you remember that friend of Katsuki's? The polite one. With the curls?" Bakugou's mother says, rubbing tears from one of her eyes as she searches her memories. "What was his name?"

Bakugou's father lifts his head out of his hands and looks at her. "...Oh, Izu. Wasn't it?"

"*Izuku*. They went to school together, but I can't remember seeing him in the last while. I think they had a falling out."

Schoolmates. So Kiddo really is as young as he looks. Shouta feels something inside his chest twist hard at the thought of someone so young already mixed up in whatever all of this is. He's seen child killers before, but something about this one seems even more wrong.

"Do you remember his surname?" he presses and both parents look to one another.

"M-something," Mitsuki starts. "Mido…"

"Midoriya," Masaru finishes. "Midoriya Izuku, that was it. But what does he have to do with any of this?"

"Related to the case, I can't release any details yet," Shouta's mouth says as his mind reels a little. They have a name and a face to attach to Kiddo now after over a year of being led by the nose, maybe they can track down more. Surely there's some sign of what happened to this kid to turn him into Kiddo.

"Is he in trouble?" Mitsuki peers down at the drawing with growing concern. "Has… has he been taken as well?"

"He was such a lovely boy," Masaru says and his gaze is just as pleading as when he worried for his own son's life. "I'm not sure why he and Katsuki drifted apart, but…"

They have no idea, Shouta realizes. Their words and expressions give no indication that they have any concerns about Midoriya's character. Which just makes Kiddo that much more of a mystery, but he's got a name now. He's got something to go on to figure out what happened to this boy. Shouta finishes things with the Bakugous and then makes a call.

"Tsukauchi speaking."

"Kiddo was a childhood friend of Bakugou Katsuki's," Shouta starts without preamble. "His name is Midoriya Izuku."

There's a pause, a scramble for what sounds like a notebook, then, "You're sure?"

"Bakugou's parents made the ID based on the nickname and descriptive details. The boys went to school together at Aldera Junior High so it's likely whatever family he has is in the same area."

"Good work, I'll get started tracking them down. If we're lucky, he won't have jumped ship before we get there and we'll be able to bring him in for questioning about the League of Villains."

Shouta doesn't hold that hope, but he ends the call and goes home. He doesn't even try sleeping, well aware of the way failure likes to linger in his mind long after the fact.

"I want you to find me a permanent base to work out of. Within an hour's walk of UA is preferred."

"About time," Giran says as he lights his cigarette. The alley they're meeting in isn't secure but it'll have to do for now and it's not like he'd even considered *not* responding to Kiddo's emergency call in the middle of the night. And seeing the kid's state now? Yeah, he's glad he did. Some of the blood soaked into his hoodie isn't even dry yet. "Guess this has something to do with why you're showing your face suddenly?"

"No reason to hide it anymore, my cover's been blown." And that's the kind of practicality Giran's likes best. "While you're looking, I need a place to stay for tonight."

"What, none of your cronies willing to put you up on the couch?"

"Are you saying no?"

Giran laughs. "Are you calling me a crony?"

"I prefer the term *lackey*."

The nerve of this brat, Giran just can't get over him. If the cheekiness was more than skin deep maybe it would get annoying, but Kiddo's too tired to be more convincing. Guess the efforts to disrupt the League's actions didn't go as well as they were hoping. Does that change much on Giran's side? He thinks about it only a moment and figures none of this changes how good a customer Kiddo's been.

“You need a medic?”

“Just give me ice and a first aid kit.”

Nothing too serious then. Giran shrugs off his jacket and hands it over. No sense in getting attention showing off blood stains. How Kiddo got there without flagging attention is a mystery. They don’t talk much on the way to one of Giran’s apartments. He’s got a dozen or so, if this one gets compromised that’s not too bad. It’s not near any of his important business centers and ain’t like he keeps anything all that important there.

The two penny tour takes a few seconds and Giran fetches his first aid kit. When he comes back, Kiddo’s already dragged off his ruined hoodie and Giran has to grimace at the t-shirt under it.

“Really?” he asks, lip curling at that bastard All Might’s face staring back at him from Kiddo’s seat on the couch.

“I’m a fanboy,” Kiddo says and either that’s the truth or this kid has just mastered the art of absolute nonchalance. It’s only a small comfort that the shirt is as toast as the hoodie and soon Kiddo’s dragged it off as well. A lot of bruises and scrapes, a few more serious cuts. Giran pulls the coffee table back a bit so he can sit on it and help clean Kiddo up.

They don’t talk through the whole process. Soon enough, Kiddo’s gone to carefully bathe around the bandages and Giran’s trying to find anything there that won’t swamp the kid. He’s got some sweat pants with a waist tie and one of his undershirts, but he’s pretty sure there’s a shopping trip in his future considering all Kiddo came here with is a small backpack. The things he does for this brat…

Finding a place for Kiddo to take as his own won’t be that difficult. Giran’s a connections guy, it’s why he makes the big bucks. But if Kiddo’s getting serious, three subordinates and a broker won’t cut it. They need some security, dedicated supply lines, or hell, just actual uniforms. He’s had a few ideas on support items that might keep Kiddo alive a little longer, especially since he seems set on going up against the underlord of the criminal world himself.

If Giran had any sense, he’d drop Kiddo before he gets dragged under with him, but he’s already in this deep and maybe the brat is growing on him. There’s just something about Kiddo that’s hard to look away from.

“Giran,” Kiddo calls, dressed in clothes that are far too big for him, freckled face uncovered and wet hair hanging in an unkempt heap. Short, young, covered in bruises like he’d been on the bad end of a schoolyard bully’s boredom. He looks like someone’s clout chasing kid brother until you actually look him in the eye and then the rest doesn’t really matter anymore.

“You ready to start taking things seriously?” he asks, even though he knows the answer.

Kiddo smiles and there is nothing friendly or even a little kind to it. “I have a friend to rescue first, but after…”

“Kind of dangerous to leave a loose end like that.” Rescuing the buddy is a clear sign that Kiddo’s got a weakness to exploit.

“Think of it as more of a warning,” Kiddo retorts, his grin slowly widening. “I want everyone to know what happens when someone touches my things.”

The shiver that runs down Giran’s spine is *exquisite*.

Per the records of Aldera Junior High, Midoriya Izuku lives in Musutafu with his mother, Inko. He maintained stellar grades while there and had no history of delinquency. Naomasa is able to confirm his current enrollment in high school with similar results. There’s nothing in the police records about either Izuku or his mother being involved in any kind of trouble, not even the slightest suspicion. Izuku’s father Hisashi is similarly clean but the last Naomasa can find about him is a missing persons report from six years ago. Inko doesn’t appear to have petitioned for him to be declared dead despite what looks like a generous insurance payment waiting for her and her son.

It’s a leap but if the father had disappeared on purpose for some kind of nefarious purpose, perhaps he’d found a way to drag Izuku in with him and that’s what started all this Kiddo business. Getting the child to clear out the competition… But Naomasa has no evidence and frankly, the theory doesn’t really fit what they know of Kiddo.

Maybe he just doesn’t want to believe a sixteen year old boy is capable of the controlled mayhem Kiddo has wrought.

In any case, he can’t put this off any longer. The officer he’d sent to watch the apartment after Aizawa’s message last night hadn’t seen any sign of anyone leaving the apartment but they hadn’t been able to verify who was in there, either. Naomasa steels himself for anything and rings the doorbell.

Izuku’s mother certainly resembles both the updated sketch they’d gotten from the training camp attack as well as his student photo from the school. Her big eyes reluctantly lift to his face with the heaviness of a woman waiting to be led to the gallows.

“Midoriya Inko? I’m Detective Naomasa Tsukauchi. May I have a moment of your time?”

She looks like she’d rather nothing less, but Inko lets him inside and even nervously goes to make tea despite his insistence he doesn’t need it. The apartment is small but comfortable. Well loved, taken care of, with little touches of the family all over it. It could belong to any number of entirely normal families. Naomasa’s eyes catch on several photographs showing a laughing, smiling boy with curls and absolutely no worries. It’s hard to imagine he’s the same one that’s being accredited with assisting in and perpetrating four murders that they know of so far.

“This is about Izuku,” Inko says as she sets the tea tray down on her kitchen table, gesturing towards a chair.

“It is,” Naomasa confirms, sitting down across from her. “Did he-”

“He warned me you would be coming.” Inko doesn’t look at him, eyes on her mug as her hands carefully cup around it. “He told me to be honest with you.”

Truth.

That could be some kind of code, something that told her just what she could talk about, how much she could reveal, but…

“What else did he tell you?”

“To answer any of your questions, let you in his room, or take anything you ask for.”

Truth.

It sounds like she’d been instructed to be entirely cooperative, but Naomasa is sure there’s more. He just doesn’t know how much.

“Do you know what he’s been doing?”

“I know he has a study group after school and he used to take self defense classes, but he asked to stop them recently. He said he can take care of himself now.”

Truth, at least as far as she knows. That was the problem with questioning people about other people. A truth reading is only as good as the speaker’s own knowledge and beliefs.

Making a mental note to look into the study group and class, Naomasa decides it’s time to break through the ice. “I’m afraid I need to inform you that your son has been involved in villainous activities over the last year that led to the deaths of four people and injuries to dozens more.”

Inko goes still, her eyes widening and face draining of color. When she lifts her head to look at him, he’s struck by the sheer level of pleading in her gaze.

“What?” she asks, her voice small and faint.

“Izuku has taken on a villain persona and appears to be building support against another major villain group. We believe-”

“Izuku would never become a villain!”

Truth.

Blind parental adoration is a hard thing to get past but Naomasa has seen this kind of denial far too many times, *especially* when teenage perpetrators are involved. It’s natural for a parent to think their child could never fall to villainy.

“I know it may seem impossible-”

“You don’t understand. I know my son. Whatever he’s doing, whatever he’s mixed up in, it’s because he thinks it will help people!”

Truth.

All the deaths attributed to Kiddo have been villains, but the same can't be said about the injuries. It still fits if Izuku has somehow convinced himself that he's doing this for the greater good, that certain damages are acceptable to innocents. And that makes him even more dangerous. Ideology has killed more people than anything else in the world.

"Even if that's the case, what he's doing is still illegal." It doesn't matter how any of them feel about the validity of their lives, not even murderers should be put down by unsanctioned vigilantes. They have to draw a line somewhere.

And he can tell Inko knows that. Her hands grip her mug so tightly it would crack if she were stronger and she looks on the verge of tears.

"I trust my son," she says with steel behind the waterworks. "He spent his entire life wanting to be a hero and… and if this is how he's going to do it? I trust him to do the right thing."

It's hard to remain impassive to that display of parental support. Had her unflinching support of her son been part of what made him think this a worthwhile path? Given him an arrogance to see his judgment above that of others? Maybe just a need to prove himself? Naomasa can't speculate, not without knowing more about him, but the pieces just keep refusing to fit together cohesively.

He has Inko show him around and ends up spending most of his time examining Izuku's bedroom. Hero memorabilia is everywhere, mostly All Might but there's a spattering of other heroes as well. Nearly every shirt the boy owns that isn't part of a uniform is plastered with some hero's face or symbol and there are dozens of figures in carefully curated shelves.

Maybe being a fanboy just isn't enough for him anymore. He's seen people crack for less.

"Why didn't he go into a hero program if he was so obsessed?" Naomasa asks, mostly to himself.

"Because they wouldn't accept him."

Naomasa turns and the look on Inko's face… He can't tell if she's guilty or just sad.

"Why not? He's definitely skilled and I've seen his school records. He's academically accomplished, no discipline issues-"

"No *quirk*."

What?

"You have to have a quirk to get into hero programs and become a hero," Inko says and Naomasa barely hears her.

Kiddo is *quirkless?* With all he's managed to do, with the way he's rising to be a real, formidable power in the underworld, with how he keeps going toe to toe with villains larger

and stronger than himself and coming out in one piece? Even Eraserhead only operates so well because he can take away the quirks of others to level out the playing ground.

How on earth is a quirkless teenager convincing high level villains to follow him?

“You’re sure?” he can’t help but ask.

Inko nods solemnly. “When he was four and hadn’t shown any sign of a quirk, we saw a doctor. He has the extra toe joint.”

Which is pretty concrete evidence of a lack of a quirk. Damn, he really *is* quirkless. And… in some ways, that makes Kiddo even more dangerous. If he’s gotten this far on his wits and learned skills alone, who knows what else he could be capable of with the kind of firepower his followers possess?

In the end, Naomasa only takes photographs and a used comb so Izuku’s DNA can be inputted into the database if they need to confirm his involvement later. He writes up a report and then doesn’t submit it just yet. Sitting back at his desk, he’s still reeling from what he’s found out about Kiddo so far. It’s maddeningly awful, the mix of facts and observations, the unknowns he still needs to find out. That they need to capture Kiddo is without question, but just what do they do with him after? A quirkless teenager isn’t going to Tartarus, but if he’s used to going up against quirked individuals, would a regular prison even be able to contain him? Is the only option for him imprisonment?

Naomasa nearly jumps out of his skin when his phone rings. “Detective Tsukauchi speaking.”

“You didn’t make my mom cry, did you?”

Turning on the recorder as a reflex, Naomasa tries not to sound as off base as he feels. “Hello Kiddo. She did, a little. Really worried for you. She loves you a lot.”

“Yeah. I’m lucky that way.” Is it just him or does Kiddo sound a little hoarse? Recovering from last night, likely. “Look, I knew you were going to talk to her. I wanted you to meet her.”

Truth.

“Why is that? You’re not afraid she might let slip your weaknesses?”

“She doesn’t know them.” *Truth*. “But it means you’re more likely to agree to my favor if you see how vulnerable she is.”

Interesting. Naomasa considers what someone like Kiddo might want from him. “Depends on what I get out of the deal.”

“I’m going after Kacchan. If nothing goes wrong, he’ll be home in time for dinner tomorrow,” Kiddo says, making no effort to hide how personal this is for him. “While I’m busy, I want you to put my mother into protective custody.”

It had already crossed his mind to have someone keep watch over Midoriya Inko, so this isn't too big an ask. "It's possible. And in return?"

"What, saving Kacchan isn't enough? Well. I doubt you'd believe me if I said I'll kill All For One."

The abrupt change from their comfortable exchange is like cold water flooding over him. He barely breathes for a few seconds, hand clenched tight over the receiver.

"Who do you think is behind the League of Villains?"

They hadn't pinned anyone for it yet, is the thing. They don't have enough information to even begin figuring out the backers for the League. It's still too early in the investigation. But *All For One?* He's been quiet for years, Naomasa had hoped he'd either quietly died or retired after they lost sight of him.

"You're certain?" he asks, horrified at the implications.

"Yeah. But I need you to sit on that information."

What?!

He doesn't realize he's said it aloud until Kiddo responds, "You blab about it and All Might will lose his shit."

"That doesn't mean he shouldn't be told-"

"That is *exactly* what it means." Kiddo's voice is sharp like a blade, unyielding. "It's not time yet. He goes up against All For One right now and All Might *dies*. Especially since I know he gave One For All to Mirio after the USJ incident. He's running on dregs."

Truth.

Naomasa covers his mouth with his hand, fighting horror and nausea.

"I need more time to weaken All For One's hold on the underground," Kiddo says with growing ferver. "I've already started gelding the League but all of this has just been the first stage. Until All For One loses faith in Shigaraki, All Might will be destroyed if he goes near him and there's not a damn thing the rest of us can do about it!"

Truth.

"So considering all that, maybe you could throw me a fucking bone and make sure my mother doesn't end up *torn apart in her own living room* in the next few months while I'm cleaning up this mess."

The call goes dead and Naomasa doesn't move for a long time after.

Chapter 8

Chapter Notes

> Special thanks to Mireya_Humbolt, you solved my decision paralysis in the middle of this chapter and that will also be facilitating some interesting stuff later on. :D

Kiddo is upset. No, scratch that, Kiddo is *pissed*. Since showing up at the warehouse to go over his next plan with them, he's been sharp and abrupt and he hasn't smiled even once. His words aren't overly harsh and he's barely looked at them, but Himiko can tell Spinner and Dabi notice it, too. It's in how neither of them asks questions, how their eyes flicker to the bulletin board barely at all as they keep watch on Kiddo instead, how the tension in their shoulders just doesn't go away.

Is it last night? They did kind of not keep the League from taking that guy, but they did manage to kill off four of their members! They even saved that hero Kiddo said the League was going to target. So, in a way, they're successful! Except Kiddo definitely doesn't see it that way. Maybe he's not screaming at them like some bosses might, but…

Himiko figures maybe she'll just avoid getting his attention. Dabi apparently doesn't feel the same.

"So while we're gone on this mission, what are *you* doing?" he asks when there's a pause in Kiddo's words. Which is a good question because he's been meticulously explaining their parts and hasn't mentioned himself once.

Their glorious leader slowly turns to face them. "I'm gonna go finish the job from last night."

Oh, boy. Himiko was right on the money. He is *so upset* by what happened. "Alone?"

"The rescue's personal," Kiddo says firmly, "and I need you all on this instead."

"You're not trying to recruit that kid, are you?" Spinner asks. "He's a hero student-"

"Of course he is. Why else would he be saving him?" Dabi doesn't quite smirk, but Himiko hears it in his voice anyway. "He's probably halfway to villainy anyway. And if he doesn't join up, we can just kill him-"

She doesn't see Kiddo move, not until Dabi's on his back with Kiddo straddling his chest, one of his hands pinned to the floor and a knife at his throat. His other hand is wrapped around Kiddo's neck and from the way his skin is starting to redden, it must be hot even if he hasn't sparked any fire but Kiddo doesn't let up a bit.

“Kacchan is *mine*,” he growls out so low that Himiko almost can’t hear him, not even caring how close to death he is if Dabi decides it. “*No one* touches him, understand me? He goes back to UA *without a fucking scratch*, and we *never* bother him again.”

The violence, the implied threat, it’s not necessarily something Himiko has come to expect from Kiddo, but she can’t deny it sends a pleasant little shiver down her spine. It’s not often Kiddo does things she expects from a fellow villain.

“I got it,” Dabi says and Kiddo gets up off him. He shoots Spinner a look that has him jolting reflexively back a step, then one Himiko’s way as well. Her whole body tingles with adrenaline.

Kiddo goes back to explaining what he wants them to do while he’s busy and Himiko listens of course, but her mind is suddenly alive with possibilities. That anger and possessiveness isn’t just the *friend* type.

Oh. Oh wow. Is Kiddo in love with that Bakugou kid? He was a little shouty for her tastes but maybe that’s Kiddo’s type? Excitement builds up inside her. Of course she has to help him win Bakugou’s heart! What kind of bestie would she be if she didn’t assist Kiddo in his romantic quest?! And if Bakugou doesn’t come around, well. There’s ways to be with someone even if they reject you.

Himiko grins to herself and wonders how hard it’d be to get Spinner in on the matchmaking.

“-n’t *care* if you think he’s interesting, I want him *dead*.”

His head is full of cotton but Katsuki’s pretty sure whatever they drugged him with is wearing off. He’s not sure how long he was out, not sure how long he spent going in and out as his body worked through the vagueness. Can’t move his hands, flexing brings into his attention something hard and firm around them. Can’t activate his quirk, some kind of dampening?

“Be patient, Tomura. His time will come.”

Katsuki subtly flexes muscles all over his body, just enough to take stock of his situation. Sitting on a chair, some kind of padding on the seat and back but not much. Straps around his chest and hips, secured over his shoulders and likely the bottom of the chair itself. Whatever’s on his hands seems attached to the hip strap. A slight shift in weight is enough to rock the chair just so, it’s not anchored down fully.

“Perhaps think of him as training for our real target?”

“He’s not even a miniboss, don’t pretend he’ll be worth any real xp.”

Three voices so far. Three people or just some who are keeping quiet? He thinks he hears a body fidgeting nearby. Katsuki slits one eye open and then jerks back because one of those fuckers from the training camp is squatting right in front of him.

"*Fuck!*"

"Oh! You're finally awake!" says the weirdo in the gimp suit, rocking back on his heels. "You should have just died."

What?! Katsuki doesn't get this guy but he's got other things to think about. Around them is… a bar? They're in a fucking bar? Small and run down, who the hell would even come to a dive like this? The other guy from the camp attack is leaning up against the wall. There's two more at and behind the bar and he recognizes them from the USJ attack.

A lesser student might be scared but Katsuki sees this for what it is: *a target rich environment.*

Before he can get too far though, a television screen speaks. "I believe there's a news report you'll want to watch."

The voice is creepy, artificially buzzed over the speaker but something behind it seems to seep right into Katsuki's ribs, like ice threatening to tear him to pieces. He grits his teeth as anger sweeps through him at the threat he can sense under that genteel accent. How *dare*…

But the hand weirdo gestures and the cloud turns on a news program and… UA teachers? Katsuki's attention sharpens at the recognizable faces. And apologizing? Like any of this was their goddamn fault!

As the report comes to a close, hand guy gives a creepy little laugh and murmurs out, "It's so strange… Why are heroes being criticized?"

No fucking kidding! But he stops listening. Whatever this guy has to say, it doesn't mean anything to Katsuki. He just has to bide his time. They'll screw up eventually, give him the opening he needs, and then it'll all come up explosions.

Hand guy likes to hear himself talk, so Katsuki will use that against him. Let him distract himself, put himself off guard just long enough for Katsuki to burn through all of them. He just has to be patient…

"Twice, release him," hand guy says and Katsuki barely keeps himself from grinning as the gimp moves closer to him, but then someone's phone goes off. All heads turn over to the shitty magician who gives his phone a perplexed look before answering.

"Who is this? How did you-" A startled pause, then, "It's for you, Shigaraki."

Hand man tilts his head, considering it, then says, "Put it on speaker."

"Oh good, now I can make sure all of your friends get to hear the warning, too. Thanks for saving me time," says the phone in Deku's voice but using a tone Katsuki isn't familiar with. What the hell is Deku doing now?!

"Shut up, Kiddo," Shigaraki grumbles. "You're interrupting."

"Make me, you crusty son of a bitch."

For a second, Katsuki is entirely sure Shigaraki's going to snatch the phone from the magician's hand to disintegrate, but then he just smiles.

"I've got something of yours," he says with a creepy laugh and Katsuki isn't fucking standing for that.

"I don't belong to anyone!"

The phone crackles oddly before Deku says, "You didn't know it, but this is a declaration of war, Shigaraki. I'm coming for Kacchan."

"Oh, that's sweet-" but Deku doesn't let Shigaraki get a word in.

"I'm going to tear your throat open and stuff every one of those hands down it while you choke," Deku says with a cold calm that has the hair on the back of Katsuki's neck standing on edge because what the fuck, *what the fuck*, Deku doesn't say shit like that- "Then I'm going to break every bone in Mr. Compress's body and let Dabi roast him alive."

The magician stiffens and seems like he might retort but the words don't come before Deku continues.

"Twice is salvageable, but if he won't turn to my side I don't mind getting rid of him, too. I'll even make it quick and painless since his only real problem is making the wrong friends."

Everything in the gimp's body language screams confusion.

"Kurogiri's a toss up. I might just give him to the heroes. I'm sure Eraserhead has a few things he'd love to hash out with him-"

"Did you have anything other than threats to offer?" asks the TV screen abruptly and Deku's ridiculously out of character words pause. "It's nice to hear from you again, Kiddo."

"Is it? Because I've got four bodies that say otherwise."

Bodies? What the hell is Deku going on about?

"A regrettable loss," the TV says without sounding regretful at all. "Tell me, what did you think you would gain in making an enemy of the League of Villains?"

"Oh, they don't even rate as an enemy," Deku replies with that same weird flippancy. "This is just a lesson that needs to be taught. No one touches my things."

Katsuki sees red. "FUCK YOU, YOU DAMN SHITTY ASS NERD!"

"It doesn't seem he returns your feelings, Kiddo," the TV says with a low chuckle.

"He's shit out of luck if he thinks that matters."

That's it. When this is over, Katsuki is going to murder Deku. At least after he finds out what the *fuck* is going on with him. There's nothing familiar in this cold, almost bored banter.

When the hell did Deku turn into someone who could discount actual villains like they were ants on the sidewalk?

“Tell you what,” Deku says. “I’ll give you a chance. You’ve got four hours to let Kacchan go, unharmed with his quirk intact. I’ve already said what I’ll do to you all if you don’t. Time starts now.”

There’s a quiet chirp as the call disconnects and then the villains descend into cursing and snarling and fronting. Katsuki watches it all from his seat without mirth. He’s too confused to give a shit what the villains decide, mind reeling and spinning around what the hell just happened. Why is Deku acting like this? What the hell was up with him at the camp? What *happened?!*

All their lives, Deku has just been a clingy hanger-on, chasing after Katsuki like the rest of the extras except even more pathetically. Weak, whiny, with dreams he’d never be able to achieve. It would have been better if Deku gave up the idea of being a hero after finding out he was quirkless but no. No, he kept stoking that impossible little dream like happy thoughts and fairy dust might change reality. Nothing Katsuki ever said to him seemed to matter, nothing dissuaded him.

Except when it did, finally. When Deku went quiet in their final year of middle school, Katsuki figured he’d just finally woken up. Finally faced the facts. There would never be a world in which Deku could be a hero. Now… After seeing Deku cold and bloodied at the camp, hearing him threaten villains as easily as breathing, now he wonders if he should have given Deku a second thought after all.

Something changed then and now Deku’s running rampant doing who the fuck knows. When he gets out of this mess, Katsuki vows to find out just what that change was.

“Perhaps I should make my grand entrance,” the TV screen says, just barely audible under the others and Katsuki has no idea who he is but something makes him entirely sure that spells bad news. More reason for him to escape before Deku embarrasses him all over again with a rescue.

The message itself isn’t surprising. A request for action, mentions of the videos and internet popularity. Alba Manami is more bothered by the fact that the message is hand written and sitting on her desk in her locked apartment.

The front door lock was jimmied open but not damaged. The cameras weren’t tampered with. She reviews the footage and only sees a teenage looking boy break in, walk to her desk, and put down the note before leaving. He touched nothing, barely seemed interested, and was out in less than a minute. She saves stills best showing his face and runs a scan through recent news reports but doesn’t have any hits.

The note is simple.

La Brava,

I'd like to ask a favor and I think you and Gentle Criminal will be interested. It would lead to a huge surge of popularity to the video channel and continue to propel his rise to fame.

I need All Might kept out of my way for a few hours and can provide a complete itinerary of his movements so that you can plan for the most bombastic presentation for your videos. He just needs to get led around a bit. All Might is not to be harmed and I don't believe he would try to harm Gentle Criminal either, as long as he isn't directly attacked and Gentle Criminal doesn't risk civilian lives.

If this interests you, please contact me at the number below for more details. This is time sensitive, please reach out immediately.

- Kiddo

Because she hasn't lived under a rock for the last six months, Manami knows who Kiddo is but not why he thought to reach out to *her*. He's more of a vigilante than anything, as far as she's concerned. The way he's targeting other villains, how he's recruiting some to help him tear at the current power structures she and Gentle have so far managed to stay far away from. His information brokering has definitely slowed down in the last few months but even Manami used some of it for a caper and was thankful he'd underchanged. The last she heard, it seems like he's focused on bringing down a villain group that's been growing in power for most of the year. Is he gearing up for something big and that's why he needs the #1 hero kept out of the way?

All Might is not to be harmed

Tapping her chin, Manami considers the options and then calls Gentle. They may plan these things together, but he'll have final say on whether he's interested. Gentle is intrigued enough for them to make the call. Then Kiddo's idea sounds like so much fun and a great test of skill (as well as a great chance for some premium footage) that they agree.

That's how, an hour later, La Brava chases after her beloved Gentle Criminal as he annoys the great All Might into an extended game of cat and mouse. Kiddo was right. These shots are *wonderful*.

They still have an hour left in Kiddo's ultimatum. Twice has gone to scout the area with Mr. Compress and Kurogiri's checking into some of their contacts to see if Kiddo can be tracked down and taken out first, but Tomura is still just here. Staring at the surly UA student he'd been so sure they could turn.

Three hours hadn't broken the kid's spirit for them to remake. They'd let him free for a few minutes before he immediately went on the attack and had to be restrained again. Even restrained, Bakugou spent every second of it cussing at them and insulting their goals and skills until Tomura had him gagged.

Now, it's just the two of them glaring at one another. He wants to just give up and destroy the brat but maybe this is a good chance to get rid of a pain in his ass. They guessed Kiddo must

have found out about the bar, but that just means they know when and where Kiddo's going to be in an hour, might as well overwhelm him and take him out of the game.

Tomura's lips twist into a smile as he imagines that piece of shit optional boss begging for his life before Tomura dusts him.

"Are you sure you don't want me to be there?" Sensei asks over the speaker and Tomura resists the urge to roll his eyes.

"If we can't handle Kiddo, how are we supposed to take out All Might?"

"Just don't underestimate your enemy, Tomura. I'd hate for you to lose any more of your major pieces."

Jaw clenching, Tomura feels his teeth grind as he glares harder at Bakugou. Already bad enough that Sensei wants to abandon the bar and make a base elsewhere, bad enough that they lost so many in getting Bakugou and the kid won't even turn, now he might lose more of them killing Kiddo off. Good pieces are hard enough to find, especially with Kiddo poaching some of the best ones available.

It's getting to where Tomura hates Kiddo even more than All Might these days.

Moodily, Tomura throws his drink at the wall next to Sensei's screen but the shattering glass isn't nearly as satisfying as he'd hoped. He glares at the liquid slowly dripping down the wall and then pauses as something in his peripheral moves. A… ball?

He jolts to his feet as smoke starts spewing free of it, choking and burning his throat. He stumbles to his feet, shoving his face into his elbow as he turns around and through the swiftly thickening smoke he sees a dark shape moving. Tomura lunges at it but misses and he's coughing so much he can barely take a step without wavering. Something in the smoke, something that's making it hard to think?

Movement nearby he can just barely hear over his own coughing and Tomura reaches for it blindly. All five fingers hit something solid and he grabs hold immediately. There's a grunt of pain before his prize is wrenched free again but he knows he's done damage. More stumbling and Tomura doesn't manage to get hold again. He moves toward the door as well as he can, spotting movement further along. Too big for one person- *Shit*, had Kiddo come for Bakugou early?!

"*You rotten cheater!*" Tomura screams but the smoke is choking him out, making his eyes sting and water so badly that he can't do anything unless he gets out of it. By the time he stumbles out into the night, rubbing at his stupid, burning eyes, Bakugou and Kiddo are no where to be seen on the quiet street.

"Shigaraki Tomura!" comes Kurogiri through a warp right behind him, too fucking late to salvage any of this, and Tomura is so frustrated he can barely stand him.

"K-*Kiddo!"* he manages through coughs, breathing only marginally better now that he's out of the smoke. His throat is *burning*.

“I must get you to safety.”

Before Tomura can protest, he feels himself falling through the familiar warp gate and stumbles into one of the darkly lit labs of Dr. Garaki. There’s no way Kurogiri will take him back in time to catch up to Kiddo and all Tomura can do is scream raggedly with rage.

Deku slumps against the alley wall after they’ve been running a while and finally moves to get the quirk suppressant cuffs of Katsuki’s hands. The first thing Katsuki does is rip off the gas mask Deku strapped on him when he showed up out of no where and then snarl out, “I was going to get myself free you stupid nerd!”

“Yeah, sure,” Deku says in a tired tone as he slides down to sit, tugging off his own mask to breathe more easily. Just how out of shape is this moron that only a brisk run has winded him? He didn’t seem that bad back at the camp.

“I didn’t need you!”

“Okay.”

“I didn’t want you to come after me!”

“Yeah.”

And then he has the audacity to ignore Katsuki while digging into one of the multiple pockets on his dark cargo pants for a phone. Deku punches in a message and then relaxes back against the wall. As Katsuki glares bloody murder at him, he notices something weird about Deku’s breathing. Carefully deep and slow, like he’s consciously controlling it but this isn’t just getting it back under control after exercise. Katsuki flickers his gaze over the other even though it’s hard to get much detail in the moonlight. The clothes are all dark and baggy, a darker design along the side of his jacket where Deku’s pressing his hand firmly-

“Are you bleeding?!”

Deku snorts and then gives him an unfamiliar smile. Almost soft, none of the nervousness Katsuki knows.

“Not your problem,” he says, which means yeah, he’s bleeding, and that’s a *lot* of blood. Deku drags out a wallet with his free hand that isn’t trying to stanch the flow. “Here, there should be enough for a ride back to-”

“The fuck are you talking about?” Katsuki drops down to his knees and shoos away Deku’s hand so he can shove up the torn edge of his jacket. Even in the low light, he can tell this is a bad hit. The flesh seems less torn or burned away as just missing in a swath wider than his hand. “Shit.”

“I’ve got someone coming,” Deku says like that fucking matters. “Just take the money and go home.”

Rage boils up inside Katsuki at the very idea that he'd leave Deku like this. Whatever Deku's gotten himself into, whatever game Deku thinks they're playing, Katsuki's a hero in training. He's not going to run from someone in need, even if they're a *fucking moron*.

"Masochistic piece of shit," Katsuki mutters to himself as he drags off his shirt to press against the wound. His emergency aid training hasn't been completed and huge gaping wounds weren't fucking covered yet! "Call for an ambulance already."

"Can't. They'll arrest me and I've got too much to do."

Katsuki lifts his head, staring at Deku wide eyed. "What the fuck are you going on about?"

"Aizawa saw me kill someone so-"

"Why the fuck did you *kill someone?! HOW*-"

"Because if I didn't take him out, he'd have killed half your class."

With every word, Katsuki feels more and more out of his depth. Is this even Deku or just some look alike?! But he called him Kacchan even when he snuck up in the bar to undo the chair straps while Shigaraki wasn't looking and there's no one who does that other than Deku.

"What happened to you?" he asks even though he's sure he won't get a good answer for it. And he's right.

"Doesn't matter," Deku says through pain gritted teeth. "You need to go."

"I'm not leaving you-"

The noise Deku makes is painful like he's been stabbed as tears well up in his stupid eyes. And then he forces himself to grin but that's somehow worse and Katsuki's chest feels like it's in a vice. The way Deku's looking at him is… It's…

"You shitty nerd," Katsuki says, which just makes Deku laugh, wince, and cry even harder. The entire scene feels surreal and Katsuki's never done well with shit he doesn't understand. If Deku weren't bleeding out after rescuing him - WHICH HE HADN'T FUCKING NEEDED - Katsuki would beat the ever living shit out of him.

"Ahem."

Katsuki's jerking around with explosions in his bloodied hands before he registers Deku grabbing his wrist.

"It's one of mine," Deku says and the tall stranger looks down at Katsuki with his stupid, scarred up face like Katsuki's somehow being unreasonable.

"He needs medical attention," Katsuki snarls and Scars nods, kneeling down to take a look under Katsuki's shirt.

“Shigaraki?” Scars asks and Deku nods. “We’ll get him next time.”

“Just get me out of here.”

Scars helps Deku up to his feet, taking on most of his weight with an arm across his shoulders despite their height difference. As his cold, blue eyes slide over to him, Katsuki resists the urge to tear Deku away from him.

“Keep him alive,” Katsuki says.

Scars’ mouth twitches into something not quite a smile. “You’ll see him again sometime.”

Katsuki watches them go before grabbing the wallet Deku dropped and going to find a ride home. It’s not five minutes before he runs into a group of heroes heading to save him.

Chapter 9

Chapter Notes

This is more of a kind of "transitional" chapter...

There are lots of things Spinner has regretted in his life. Chances not taken, grudges unfulfilled. Choices that turned out wrong, like letting Kiddo go after the League on his own for one stupid hero in training.

The medic Giran pulled out of his ass just left but Spinner hasn't let himself do more than glance through the doorway to make sure Kiddo's still breathing on the camp bed in the office. He'll sleep off the anesthetic by morning but things had been touch and go for a while. The medic was only barely more useful than a quirkless doctor, but Kiddo would live. Terribly scarred and with a long recovery, but alive. When Spinner thinks about the chunk of him Shigaraki disintegrated…

Their group isn't close enough for him to consider them friends but Spinner still vows to take a similar chunk out of Shigaraki the next time they see him. These are *his* people and he doesn't do well with threats.

"Stop looking like a kicked puppy," Dabi mutters without looking away from the bulletin board. "He'll be fine."

"And what if he'd been worse off?" Spinner shoots back. "What if he'd been killed for that brat?"

Dabi marks one of the names off their list of targets before glancing back over his shoulder.

"Then we would finish his plan without him."

It feels weirdly sacrilegious almost, but Spinner knows they would at least try. Their target list is long and varied, each of them hand picked by Kiddo as a threat to their Better World. Dozens of pieces in the whole that makes up the criminal underground. They have another list of potential recruits that is also long but without Kiddo and his ridiculous quirk of talking people into listening to him, Spinner doubts it would be much use to them.

"We can't let him just go off on his own again." Spinner's sure about this one. Maybe Kiddo could kill him without trying but he's still just one guy. Even that bastard All Might has backup when he really needs it. "He's too reckless."

"Are you going to be the one to tell him that?"

Uh. Spinner looks back towards the office again. Well. Shit.

Chuckling low and quiet, Dabi turns away from the bulletin board. His hand lands heavily on Spinner's shoulder before he continues walking past him.

"Maybe I'll just follow him everywhere," Spinner decides sulkily, already knowing how much of an evil eye he'll get if Kiddo figures out what he's doing. Hopefully, he decides to be amused by it.

Yagi Toshinori gets angry at plenty of things, but spending his usable hours running after a phantom thief that got away in the end only to find out his delay caused them to be late to save his student, puts it at another level. That Bakugou was saved by the strange villain Kiddo is little comfort. They still failed and it is still his fault.

"I think he planned this," Tsukauchi says quietly as Toshinori sits in his office and stews. He keeps seeing Bakugo, roughed up with blood on his hands that wasn't his own because Kiddo got himself injured in the rescue.

Kiddo, a sixteen year old quirkless boy that has been leading them around by the nose for a year, who is lethal and apparently thinks he's doing it for the right reasons.

"Why do you say so?" Toshinori asks because he needs to focus on the moment, not his growing guilt.

"That tip we got for the location of the League's hideout. I'm pretty sure it came from one of his followers."

Makes sense. One more manipulation. Had Kiddo been unsure he'd be successful and wanted a backup plan to get Bakugou to safety? Had he been aiming to embarrass them by getting it done before they could arrive? Toshinori hates that he doesn't know.

Tsukauchi flips through his growing case file on Kiddo. "Bakugou was only able to confirm the historical information we had on Midoriya, nothing more recent. It sounds like as soon as he started acting as Kiddo, he cut ties with Bakugou."

Except he hadn't, really. It had to be difficult to forget a friendship that old.

"Did he think young Bakugou would try to stop him?" Toshinori wonders aloud, "or was he trying to protect him?"

Their eyes meet. Toshinori's pretty sure it was a mix of the two.

"We're going to have to start taking Kiddo more seriously, even if he is only targeting other villains," Tsukauchi says. "I've built a little bit of a rapport with him, so I'll see if I can deepen that connection if only to figure out what he's planning to do next."

Taking the file, Toshinori flips to the student ID photo from Midoriya's middle school. He'd been cheerful and full of light then, but between it and the high school ID photo, something drastic had changed. He still smiled but there was nothing behind it. His green eyes held an

emptiness that ached in Toshinori's chest. As far as Midoriya's mother knew, the only thing that happened was him giving up his dream of being a hero. Had that been enough?

"And nothing on the father?" he asks, knowing Tsukauchi was running that lead.

"Nothing new. There's been no sign of him for years. When I asked Inko why he was still listed as missing instead of presumed dead, she said it would have required a funeral and she hadn't wanted to take the hope that he might come back away from Izuku."

"Maybe Izuku figured it out anyway." Was that why he'd become Kiddo, a last straw to push him into action? Betrayal and disappointment could be powerful motivators.

"I've wondered, but that doesn't explain why he's set his sights on tearing down the League of Villains. Or why-" Tsukauchi cuts himself off and turns his gaze down to the file in Toshinori's hands. "Why he's… so vicious about killing them rather than just turning them over to the police."

Something about the way his friend says that trips in Toshinori's mind but he's not quite up to figuring out why. Vigilantes come in two varieties: lethal and not. The nonlethal ones were usually benign enough to ignore and let the police handle. They tended to get arrested or adopted by heroes that helped them get their licenses, if they didn't get themselves killed first.

Lethal vigilantes, on the other hand, almost always end up crossing the line into full villainy sooner or later. Kiddo has two confirmed kills and three he's listed as an accomplice on, which is more than most. Certainly more than the average *teenage* vigilante. His road to villainy is clear and Toshinori hates that he can't figure out what set him on it in the first place.

"You said you'd put the mother into protective custody?" he asks, grasping at straws.

"We're moving her to a safehouse this afternoon," Tsukauchi confirms. "I have an officer staying with her until then."

There's at least one personal hook that might help corral Kiddo, if they're able to use it. If Kiddo doesn't go so far down the rabbit hole that he stops caring about her.

How on earth did this bright young man get pushed so far so young? Toshinori can't stand the waste in his potential. A quirkless boy who managed the things Kiddo has and no one thought to funnel those strengths into something positive?

When they meet, because he's sure it will happen, All Might is going to get to the bottom of this even if it kills him.

Anyone else might get tired of sitting next to a sleeping person for hours on end, but Toga Himiko is as far from normal as Dabi has ever seen. He doesn't mind this. It keeps life interesting to be surrounded by interesting characters, and at least Toga is less aggravating

than the weird fame thief and his follower. He isn't sure what Kiddo wants with them, but he guesses he'll find out eventually.

He doesn't mean to be but Dabi's still hanging around when Kiddo finally wakes up. He stays at the door, watches Toga fuss over him while Kiddo blinks away sleep and the painkillers the medic had loaded him with.

"Where…"

"Our new base! Giran found it for us."

It's not a bad place. A converted office building on the poor side with plenty of space to keep them from driving each other nuts with close quarters. Toga's already moved into one of the offices after nagging Spinner to help her drag a bed in. No doubt, Spinner will be doing the same by the end of the week.

"Remind me to thank him," Kiddo says and tries to sit up but pain immobilizes him faster than Toga can shove him back down.

"No!" she scolds. "You got torn into, you need to rest!"

"I need to get that fucking crinkly bastard back for-"

"That shouty brat is fine," Dabi says as he crosses his arms and watches relief flicker over Kiddo's face. "You've got time to keep your ass laid out since you thought it was such a great idea to go off against the League by yourself."

Kiddo doesn't look guilty about it but Toga picks up that line as perfectly as Dabi thought she might.

"You can't do that again!" she says, leaning right into Kiddo's bemused face. "Don't get yourself murdered trying to do everything by yourself. We're officially besties, you wouldn't deprive me of my *best friend* would you?!"

And that hits harder than Dabi expected. He can tell by the way Kiddo flinches and looks away from her. Huh. That's an interesting hint about Kiddo's personal life.

"Yeah, that was maybe a bad call," Kiddo admits, sighing as he lets himself relax against the mattress. "Okay. Bedrest it is."

Toga backs off to happily continue her vigil at his bedside.

"It's not like our group can grow without you talking people into working with you using that stupid quirk of yours," Dabi says to just twist the knife a little more because it's fun and he doesn't get the opportunity to do it much with this guy.

Except Kiddo doesn't seem more bothered by that. Instead, he looks confused. "Wait, you think I used a quirk to convince you to join me?"

“Didn’t you?” Spinner asks as he pokes his head around Dabi and Dabi carefully doesn’t let himself jump after the asshole successfully snuck up on him.

Anyway.

Dabi certainly hadn’t been a team player before Kiddo, even if he’s still not much of one now. It’s just that Kiddo knows how to use someone like him well in ways that never seem to annoy him. Spinner and Toga are the same as far as he’s been able to tell, even if Spinner’s probably the best at it of them all. If it wasn’t a quirk that made Dabi give him even a bit of a chance, then…

Kiddo laughs, only to groan and wince as it pulls the wound in his side. “*Fuck* that hurts, jeez… No, man. I didn’t use a quirk. I just talked to you.”

Dabi narrows his eyes, looking for any sign that Kiddo’s lying but not finding anything. Huh.

“I thought you all had figured it out by now,” Kiddo says as his lips twitch into a pained half smile. “I don’t have a quirk.”

What.

“There’s no way!” Spinner screeches, shoving Dabi so he can get closer to the bed. “You’ve got to have a quirk. Like super analysis or maybe just a reflex augment or-

“No,” Kiddo says patiently. “That’s just observation, experience, and practice. I’m quirkless.”

How the *hell*. Dabi looks between Toga and Spinner, trying to gauge how much they’re buying this because they’ve all seen Kiddo fight. They’ve seen how quickly he can analyze quirks. The idea that Kiddo is *powerless*…

Except he isn’t, is he? Dabi sees the others come to the same conclusion. Just because Kiddo doesn’t have a quirk, it doesn’t mean anything has really changed.

“You’re crazier than I already thought,” Spinner says in an awed tone, brushing one hand back over his hair.

“I’ve been accused of worse.” And the idiot has the audacity to grin at them. “I won’t take offense if you decide to bail now-”

Toga moves so fast Dabi only notices after she’s already thrown herself against Kiddo’s chest, hugging him as tightly as she can and getting a pained protest for her trouble.

“Do you not understand what *bestie* means?!” she snarls at his chest and despite how much it’s got to hurt, Kiddo doesn’t make any move to dislodge her. Actually- ah hell. He’s getting teary eyed.

Seeing his boss cry is not something Dabi is ready for.

“I have targets to kill,” he says, turning on his heel and marching to the bulletin board to find them.

Bad enough he got captured in the first place but Katsuki puts his foot down on getting rescued by that shitty nerd. He's been in a mood since, snapping at anyone who comes too close or dares disturb him. For some reason, every single one of his classmates has texted him some variation of being happy he's alive and free, at least until he turned the damn phone off entirely.

He doesn't want their well wishes. He wants some fucking *answers*.

The police and heroes tell him nothing. When he calls the bastard by his actual name, they only look between one another and keep mum. Even the lead detective he gets dragged in to speak with won't say anything more than that Deku is a person of interest to them.

As if there'd ever been anything interesting about Midoriya Izuku except for how fucking *annoying* he is.

But then Katsuki remembers the way Deku had looked at him, bleeding out in a dirty alley, and everything is even more confusing. He can't figure out why it happened. Why the sudden anguish of a loss he doesn't understand came about with words he doesn't even want to remember after the fact.

I'm not leaving you-

Ugh, out of context and without what he meant behind it, that seems like something out of one of his mom's shitty romance novels. The ones with long haired men in pristine formal kimonos or battle worn samurai armor on the cover, tenderly embracing some plain looking everywoman heroine-

For a moment, he imagines himself and Deku on one of those covers and almost throws up in his mouth.

This is all Deku's goddamn fault. As soon as he figures out where that asshole is hiding, Katsuki's going to kick his ass from one end of Japan to the other for daring to take up as much space in his brain over the last few days as he has. It doesn't make sense, what Deku's doing. Doesn't make sense that a quirkless, powerless, *weak* person like Deku could both hold his own against villains and also rescue Katsuki.

He can't stop remembering Deku's face or the way watching him crumble made Katsuki feel.

Which is *nothing*, other than *disgust*. He's sure of that. What else would there be? Ugh, he needs to track down that useless moron and beat the truth out of his hide.

Somehow, even after literal years, Katsuki remembers how to get to Deku's apartment. The problem is that no one's home. He visits it a couple hours later and a couple hours after that, but no Deku, no Deku's mom. The place seems abandoned. When he stakes it out the next day, there's no difference.

What is he even doing here?! Deku shouldn't be someone Katsuki thinks about. Just a pebble in the road, tossed out and forgotten. Not someone who looks at him like he's just come back

from the *dead*.

Katsuki doesn't go back to the apartment. Whatever's going on, that place won't give him any answers to the burning questions buzzing around his mind rent free like the shittiest of roommates. The problem is, he doesn't know where to check next. Deku's been absent from his life since starting at UA and had dropped off his radar for the last year of middle school even before that. Which means Katsuki has no idea where to even begin looking for him. Plus with the way some of the police were talking like Deku's some kind of *villain*…

There's no way, but Katsuki will figure this out. He just has to wait for that rotten nerd to crawl back to his side like he always does.

"You're certain?"

"I ID'd the bodies myself."

Chisaki Kai's jaw clenches behind the mask. Just what he needs, more of his men picked off in broad daylight. It almost makes him wonder if those League of Villains idiots are behind it, trying to push him into a corner to accept their offer to meet up and possibly collaborate, but… There's also that upstart he keeps hearing about. Shie Hassaikai even used the brat's analyses a few times because they were just that good and it's stupid not to take advantage of information against their enemies. If Kiddo's behind the loss of Kai's men, he's not sure what he did to put a target on their organization.

The League, though. They have a motive Kai can understand. Maybe if he were as aimless as them, he might try to chip away at a more skilled opponent like a coward as well.

"That's five down," he mutters to himself, considering what he has left to guard their compound and the profitable secret within it. Trafficking Trigger is bringing in money, sure, but they'll lose their supply lines quickly if they don't have the manpower to protect them, and that puts his research in jeopardy. They're so close to perfecting the quirk-destroying drug, to setting humanity back to before quirks ruined things and the Yakuza was *respected*.

"Sir? It was only the weak that have fallen," Kurono Hari says to bring Kai back out of his spiraling thoughts. "The rest of us are ready to do anything to defend your intent."

"Find out who took them out. I want to handle this problem at the root, quickly."

Far be it for Kai to allow their group to look weak when fear of the Yakuza is at an all time low, but soon. Soon, he'll rebuild the world the way it should be.

Quirkless.

Frantic footsteps sound outside the door and Kai turns before it flies open, one of his newest recruits stumbling through.

"The kid's escaped!"

God*damn*it. Eri's getting more bold if she's already slipped her watch again. It's not a development Kai's at all happy about and it'll only get worse if his men don't stop dying.

"Useless," he mutters as he storms past to find the kid. Sometimes, it's just easier to handle the bullshit himself.

Most days Toshinori appreciates not having his civilian form known to the public. This is no different. There's no way he'd be able to peacefully walk down a sidewalk in his heroic form without getting mobbed by an adoring public. He doesn't *mind* the attention, not after so many years, but sometimes it grates and then it's a relief to just be Yagi Toshinori again for a while. Sure, the circumstances leading up to his double life are terrible, but he can see the silver lining.

Which is why he's utterly flabbergasted when Midoriya Izuku steps out of an alley right in front of him. He's dressed in jeans and an oversized hoodie patterned after the silver age All Might costume, complete with a hood that mimics his signature hair. It's such a shock that Toshinori freezes mid step with utter confusion. Why on earth would someone like Kiddo wear his *merch?*

The boy looks him in the face for a moment and then says, "You're late."

"Excuse me?" comes out of Toshinori's mouth before he can think of a proper response. There's people all over, he can't just change form without revealing himself.

"Doesn't matter. Look, can we talk?"

Wait, does Midoriya know about him?! There's been so many things the villain Kiddo knew and warned about, but the idea he might also know of this secret chills Toshinori to the bone.

"Maybe somewhere more private," he suggests but Midoriya shakes his head.

"No. It's safer for both of us to stay public. There's a bench over there. We'll sit down together. As long as neither of us makes an aggressive move, this'll stay just a conversation and we both walk away."

Then Midoriya turns his back on Toshinori to walk away. Like he knows he won't be in danger. Like he trusts him. Or, at least, like he doesn't care if Toshinori might hurt him.

There's no question that he will follow. Toshinori sits down at one end of the bench and Midoriya the other. From Bakugou's description of the injury, Toshinori expected Midoriya to lay low longer, but the boy seems determined to surprise him. Still, Midoriya *does* look to be on the mend. His eyes are darkly rimmed and his face pale. He'd been stiff as he walked, favoring one side. Not fully healed, then.

"There's a villain that's exploiting a little girl's quirk," Midoriya says without looking at him, watching civilians walk past them without a single clue of the danger he could pose them. "I already told Tsukauchi about it and I know Sir Nighteye is on the case, but you need to stay out of it."

“You aren’t in a position to order me around,” Toshinori reminds him and the kid’s lips curl into an almost fond smile.

“Yeah. But if you get hit with a quirk destroying bullet, All Might will cease to be and the road to the apocalypse becomes unavoidable.”

Toshinori stiffens, cold spreading down his spine at the casual certainty in Midoriya’s tone. Like he knows for sure. Like he’s *seen it.* His strange companion turns to look up at him and the determination in his gaze makes Toshinori shiver.

“I’m not losing the Symbol of Peace until Mirio’s ready to take over the mantle,” Midoriya says, the intensity only ratcheting up, “and I’m not letting you get yourself killed for no good reason.”

Those are words that should be coming from a hero and Toshinori can’t help cursing whatever circumstance led to this boy being taken in by evil instead

“What you did for young Bakugou is worthy of praise. Why haven’t you thought about joining the police?” he can’t stop himself from asking. “Or working in hero support. Why would someone as determined and skilled go straight to villainy so young?”

Midoriya blinks, looking honestly startled, and then he laughs. It hurts to listen to because it’s so *broken*.

“Heroes only kill people by accident,” he says in a deceptively soft voice, “and there are a *lot* of people I need to kill.”

It’s such a sudden change that Toshinori feels like he’s getting whiplash. More and more, he’s becoming certain something terrible befell this boy but he’s even less sure the damage can be reversed or soothed.

Midoriya stands and without thinking, Toshinori’s hand snakes out to grab his wrist and stop him. “I can’t let you just leave.”

Glancing back over his shoulder, Midoriya almost looks regretful. “You will unless you want Dabi to incinerate this entire street and all the civilians on it.”

His grasp weakens in shock and Midoriya twists his hand free only to walk away and blend into the crowd. Toshinori tries to pursue only to find the hoodie crumpled on the ground.

Chapter 10

September

All For One isn't used to underestimating people. He prides himself in being able to see the whole character of a man, his wants and needs, his willingness to obtain them. It's not often his estimates are that far off. He's been doing this for a very long time.

And then Kiddo comes along and, not without effort, utterly bulldozes through years of careful setup and planning. He'd thought the boy a passing annoyance, a stepping stone for his heir to cut his teeth on, but Tomura's gotten entirely fixated on him since losing the hero student. With good reason, of course, but All For One needs him focused on growing his presence and getting into place for the grand overthrow of heroic society, not playing games with a mouthy brat.

He doesn't like being surprised by Kiddo any more than by anyone else, but there is a particular sort of vehemence Kiddo keeps showing towards getting in his way. His disdain for Tomura isn't nearly as personal as his hatred for All For One. Idly, All For One wonders what sparked that. Had he killed someone Kiddo loved? Kidnapped, tortured, stolen from? There've been so many, he'd have no way to narrow things down.

Tapping his finger on the edge of his desk, All For One considers his options. There are still a few of his old police contacts in place that he hasn't tapped in a while. As long as he still has leverage over them, he'll get whatever the police know about the young villain. All For One already knows no one closer to him has anything worthwhile and half the information brokers he could tap have either disappeared or turned up dead. The other half seemed reluctant to meet any of his contacts and All For One has a suspicion Kiddo is the culprit. He's been gathering followers quietly, scalping talent before All For One can do the same. It's practically a declaration of war.

His lips twist into a cruel smile. Well, if Kiddo *insists*.

"What would you say if I told you I have a foolproof plan for taking down the Shie Hassaikai group with few if any casualties on the heroes' side?"

Sasaki Mirai pulls the phone away and looks at it in silence for a few moments before setting it back to his ear again. "I would call you a fool."

"I deserved that." The voice is familiar but only because Detective Tsukauchi had shared the recording from his call with Kiddo regarding the Shie Hassaikai that upped the priority on that case. Quirk suppressant drugs that permanently removed a quirk? No, there's no question that it has to be handled quickly. "Seriously, though. I have information."

"I doubt it's worth my time."

"Do you want to die or not?"

“Are you threatening me?”

Kiddo huffs out an annoyed breath. “So the Shie Hassaikai forces…”

Despite his misgivings, Mirai takes careful notes on what Kiddo says. He lists the known members of the gang with brief but well thought out quirk descriptions, defensive strategies, a few ideas on match ups between them and heroes already confirmed to be part of the raid team. How Kiddo got that information, he has *no* idea. It twists in the pit of his stomach to think there may be a mole as Kiddo just keeps going with a rundown on the Shie Hassaikai compound itself. Layout, security features…

“How long has it been since you went there?” Mirai asks as Kiddo pauses because old information is better than nothing, but new is certainly preferable.

“What?”

“They may have changed things since the last time you were there.”

It seems an obvious concern but Kiddo goes quiet for several seconds before finally answering, “Let’s say three months.”

Mirai’s eyes narrow because that doesn’t sound like the truth so much as carefully not a lie. He’s familiar enough with that sort of language that the alarm bells are ringing loud and clear. Kiddo had done the same thing in the call with Tsukauchi.

“A lot can change in three months,” he says.

“Look, either take it or leave it.” Annoyance but also a healthy amount of desperation fills that voice and Mirai isn’t sure what to think about it. If Kiddo’s somehow being put up to this, none of the intel can be trusted. If he’s personally affected by the success or failure, it could go either way.

Mirai’s never liked being unsure.

“You called them the Eight Bullets,” he says instead, tapping the end of his pen under his notes from that section, “but only gave me five names.”

“That’s because I took three of them out already.”

His hand stills. That tone wasn’t overly pleased or boastful. It was quiet, matter of fact. A task that had been completed, no matter that it included human lives. “Took them out.”

“I’ve been weakening Chisaki’s forces for weeks to get ready for this. As long as your team lineup doesn’t change, you should be able to sweep them without much in the way of major injuries.”

“Why?”

“You know, I get asked that a lot lately. Maybe I just want to be top dog.”

Except Mirai doesn't believe that. Kiddo isn't acting like an overeager informant or a power hungry gang leader just waiting for his chance. He's acting like…

"You were a hero once," he says and there's no answer but the more Mirai thinks about it, the more it fits. The way Kiddo had organized his information for presentation is just like the report method laid out by UA and currently in use with the HPSC. Key players, useful details, tactics, environmental concerns… Mirai has written and read enough of those same reports to recognize the format easily.

"Pretty sure the police already know I'm a quirkless teenager," Kiddo says, which is not a denial.

"Then you've trained with a hero. Who was it?" Is that why he'd gone rogue? The loss of a mentor, or perhaps disillusionment due to abuse from the same?

"Doesn't matter. Are you going to use my info or not?"

That remains to be seen. It's not as if Tsukauchi will be able to determine veracity from a recording, which means it will be up to the heroes to decide how comfortable any of them feel taking intel from a known criminal.

"I'll take it under advisement."

"Good, because I want something in return. Get Eraserhead to help me in a parallel side mission."

What. Mirai glares at the phone like it just tried to bite him. "Excuse me?"

"I'm going to get Eri out of there while you guys handle the Yakuza. Eraser has the skill set to sneak in with me and the quirk to take hers out so she doesn't accidentally kill someone when she panics."

"Eri?"

"The kid they're using to make the quirk destroying drugs. Her quirk rolls back things she touches when she's upset and the crack down? Is going to upset her, so I need Eraser on my side while I get her out of there."

"And after?" Mirai asks, his jaw tight.

"After, you should keep her at UA with Eraser. He can keep a lid on her quirk until she learns to control it." A pause, then a quiet laugh that sounds incredibly, distressingly fond, "Plus he'd just be a really good dad."

Not even planning on trying to exploit her himself. Why risk so much? Intentionally putting himself in harm's way, in the sights of heroes who will definitely want to arrest him. Unless that's exactly what he wants Mirai to think

"Oh, and one more thing," Kiddo says, drawing Mirai back from his thoughts. "You should coordinate from outside the building for the entire mission."

Mirai frowns at the very idea of not being on the front lines. His quirk could be the difference between taking Overhaul down and everything failing.

“I-”

“You go in, you’re coming out on a stretcher.” Kiddo’s tone is flat, utterly humorless. “You’ll make it a few hours at most and then you’ll die. It doesn’t matter who’s with you, doesn’t matter which of the goons you go up against or how many of them I murder first. If you go inside that building, you don’t survive.”

It could be a hunch. Mirai knows it isn’t.

“Precognition?” he asks.

“I already said I was quirkless.”

“No. You said the police know you’re a quirkless teenager. That doesn’t mean it’s actually true.”

“Five points for Sir Nighteye. Yeah, sure, if it makes you listen to me you can think I’ve got a quirk like yours.”

Which means he doesn’t. Which instead means… what, exactly? If it isn’t some kind of future sight, then something more analytical? Like the ability to run countless scenarios in his mind with the various outcomes, but that doesn’t feel right either. Mirai is a hero who uses his head far more than his fists but he knows when to trust his gut.

“Timeloop,” he says.

A soft inhalation, a moment of silence, and then the call abruptly ends.

Mirai sets down the receiver. It sounds crazy even though he’s the one that said it. It’s also not possible. Time distortion quirks are rare and aren’t really about time itself so much as the perception of time: speeding up or slowing down cognitive functions. Even with an extreme example that would allow perceptive time to slow to a crawl so that endless possibilities could be experienced, it would still require an incredible mind to keep track of all the moving parts. If Kiddo or one of his associates can do this, Mirai wouldn’t be surprised later on to find them taking over the criminal underworld entirely.

And yet… Something still nags at him. He doesn’t have enough information to make a full judgment on whatever Kiddo’s situation is.

What he can do is call Eraserhead and see if the hero is open to working with Kiddo on what might be a trap.

There’s someone in her house. Shuzenji Chiyo doesn’t let on that she knows as she closes the door behind her, hanging her jacket up on the hook. Maybe she’s not on active duty anymore outside of the school, but she can at least take care of whoever has decided to make themselves a problem for her.

Nothing looks disturbed or missing. Not a thief, then. She doesn't hear or sense any movement so either he's got a stealth quirk or he's already where he means to be. She steps through her living room and there he is, just sitting at the kitchen table and watching her. Tired, wane, either a chronic illness or some kind of injury in recovery, she'd guess. There's only a few reasons why someone would seek her out.

"I need a favor," he says and then sets down an envelope that he slides across the table. Chiyo picks it up and checks the contents. Money isn't really a surprise but she sets it back on the table and gives him a chiding look.

"Villain or vigilante?" she asks, expecting him to lie.

"Does it matter?" he says instead. "It's illegal either way."

"It matters to me."

He sighs. "Probably a villain. I've got a body count and that number is just going to go up."

"Then you need to leave."

The boy is young and old all at the same time. Looking at his gentle face is painful. She flashes back to all of her students, both the ones who disdain her help and those that love her for it, but when he looks her in the eye, she starts remembering the ones who have been lost.

"Please," he says. "You can tell them I threatened you."

"I'm not afraid of any trouble to me if I heal you, young man," she says because he seems to have misunderstood the situation. "I'm of the mind to call the police so you can straighten out your life before it's too late."

That earns her a little smile. This boy seems like he's been dragged through about a hundred miles of bad road and just keeps tying himself back up to the back of the truck every time he gets cut loose.

"There's someone I need to save," he says.

"That's what heroes are for."

He looks at her and she feels her resolve crack, just a little.

"I'm backing up Eraserhead."

"Then you'd better make sure he knows you're injured so he can compensate for it. Or, better yet, turn yourself in to the police and be treated officially."

He smiles again and it's like he knows her, like he's expected every word that's come out of her mouth, and he's so relieved she hasn't changed. What to even begin to do with that, Chiyo doesn't know.

"Yeah. That would probably be the smart thing to do."

It is. It's also not what he's going to do. She knows this type too well.

The boy gets up, stiff and in pain. Her well trained eyes pinpoint the patterns in how he moves despite his care to downplay it and she knows roughly what's happened. A wound like that will certainly hamper whatever rescue he thinks he's going on. Would he tell Aizawa the truth or hide it and risk them both?

Stepping around her table, he walks past her without making any threatening gestures or playing up the injury to guilt her. Chiyo watches him head for her front door. Just as he reaches it, she sighs and calls out, "Wait."

He pauses and looks back with a blink.

"I'm not doing this for you. I'm doing it for Eraserhead."

As she walks to him, he stays perfectly, animalistically still. Not even a flinch when she takes his hand.

"You don't have to do this," he says and she scoffs.

"As if this wasn't *entirely* your plan."

There's no denial. She kisses the back of his hand and he shivers as her quirk activates, slumping back against her door when it saps his energy to work.

"I'll keep him safe," he promises and Chiyo's stern gaze is apparently a lot less potent than it used to be because his smile returns, soft and sweet.

The boy leaves. Chiyo locks the door after him and decides she'll take the money he left over to the food bank in the morning for a donation.

"You're doing it again."

Kiddo doesn't pause in doing the buckles along his new boots. They're sturdy and reinforced around the ankles, the leather soft enough for his more acrobatic moves while still giving support for hard falls. The black finish is perfectly matte, barely picking up light at all, but his laces are an electric green he favors

"I'm not going off on my own," he says. "You'll be there with me."

Except Himiko *won't* be. She's going to be taking on the form of one of Overhaul's men that they captured half an hour ago and paving the way so Kiddo can go be a Big Damn Hero like he so desperately wants to be.

Maybe Dabi and Spinner and even Giran haven't figured it out, but Himiko's a little closer to Kiddo than they are. Of course she wouldn't miss the quiet dream he keeps to himself under all the villainous activity, just like she didn't miss his adoration for Bakugou Katsuki. Maybe she doesn't quite *get* it, but she doesn't have to understand everything about her bestie to support him!

“But what if Eraser decides to arrest you?” she asks.

“Then I guess you’ll have to break me out of prison.”

Any other villain would tell her to kill Eraserhead. She still hasn’t quite decided if she likes that about Kiddo or not. There’s no question that he’s fully willing to get rid of obstacles to his goals but he avoids it when possible. Outside of their designated kill list, anyway. Those are free game and the three of them have been picking off targets with glee.

“Oh,” Kiddo says as he looks up from the protective gauntlets he’s strapping to his arms. “I keep forgetting. If you end up having the chance, don’t forget to try talking some of Overhaul’s guys over to our side.”

They’ve gotten a few new members of their group, but all low level support that won’t be much help in battle. Having access to quality support items certainly will help though! Her new siphons will make it sooooo much easier to gather and store the blood she needs for her quirk and the gear Kiddo’s decked in might keep him alive through all his ridiculous shenanigans.

At least Himiko hopes so. Concentrating on hoping makes her a little less afraid for his safety.

“It’s going to be okay,” he says, dropping a hand on her shoulder, but he’s got the lying smile on his face. “Eraser won’t target me until after we get the girl out, so just make sure you’re ready then.”

Kiddo’s risking everything they’ve worked for on a little girl he doesn’t know and Himiko can’t even make herself hate him for it. It’s probably a good thing he sent Dabi and Spinner off to handle other tasks because neither of them would be as understanding as Himiko.

“If he hurts you, I’ll break him,” she vows and Kiddo snorts with another smile she’s pretty sure is real this time.

“Just as long as he’s still alive.”

She can live with that.

Had anyone else asked him to do this, Shouta would have told them to go fuck themselves. But you don’t say no to Sir Nighteye and you certainly don’t doubt his intentions. Sir Nighteye doesn’t joke around with missions and his schemes tend to be based more in the probable than the hopeful, so now Shouta’s waiting on a rooftop for a murderer. He’s not sure what he did in his life to end up here.

Thinking about Kiddo puts a bad taste in his mouth. It’s only been a few weeks since he watched the boy casually murder a villain in front of him. Somehow, it feels even worse to know Kiddo’s actual name now. From the information Detective Tsukauchi and All Might shared with them, Kiddo is a bright young man who looked at the world and not only chose violence but decided to make it everyone else’s problem.

That he's been *good* at it is even more infuriating.

Shouta doesn't move when he hears footfalls behind him because they're the same careful level of noise his own make when he's not trying to sneak up on someone. It pisses him off more to recognize that courtesy.

"You were briefed?" Kiddo asks, looking out over the Shie Hassaikai complex at Shouta's side.

At least he's not just wearing that simple hoodie this time. There's still a hood but Shouta can tell at a glance that there's some kind of protective mesh woven into the cloth. The black jacket is sleeveless with wide arm holes for ease of movement, some kind of body hugging, reinforced shirt under in a bright, neon green. Lightly armored, Shouta would guess, but thin enough not to impede an agility based fighting style. Protective black gauntlets with green stitching cover his arms from his biceps down over the backs of his hands, leaving his fingers free for more delicate knife work. His pants are loose and his boots clasp up over the whole of his lower legs with padded knee guards above it. They look like they might slow him down but Shouta doubts Kiddo would use them if that were the case. Around his neck hangs an armored mask of brilliantly polished metal, the lines of which seem almost like a deranged grin. He doubts it's *just* a mask.

"Giving up stealth?" Shouta asks because he's half sure the green might glow in the dark.

"According to my designer, only using black and gray is boring," Kiddo says with a grimace that tells Shouta this had been a *conversation.*

Well. They'll work around it. It's not as if they can expect the whole compound to go dark for them on command and there's a lot of ways to be stealthy that didn't include blending into the darkness.

"Ground rules," Shouta says and feels Kiddo's attention sharpen on him. "You're not killing anyone in front of me this time."

"He couldn't be rehabilitated."

"I don't give a shit. You're good enough to know how to take someone down nonlethally."

Kiddo doesn't answer at first and Shouta is almost ready to call this off and go after the girl by himself when he finally says, "Fine. I'll track them down later if they evade capture."

It's not a compromise Shouta wants to take but he'll accept it for now. "No accidents, no mistakes. Until the end of this mission, you hold yourself to *my* standards."

"Yeah, yeah. No loopholes."

Good. He's glad they understand each other.

"Second rule: you don't maim them either. No long term injuries, nothing that will cripple them. If you're going to help with a hero mission, you'll conduct yourself like one of us, too."

“Boy, you really know how to take the fun out of this.”

Shouta glares at him and Kiddo snorts.

“Sure. In return,” he says and Shouta resists the urge to groan, “if things go South, you take Eri and get her out. No matter what.”

Shouta glances over him but Kiddo’s focusing on the complex again, the half joking air entirely gone. If Shouta didn’t know better, he’d think this was a hero in front of him.

“Deal,” he says, understanding the underlying agreement. Now he just has to make sure Kiddo doesn’t screw up so he can get out of having to make good on it.

Chapter 11

Chapter Notes

> So Eri's babysitter was never named, I just googled a common surname and then "Japanese name meaning useless" and wow, actually got a hit. I have literally no idea if it actually means that and probably gave this dude a terrible name that makes no sense.

Ito Mudasuke is having a bad day. First his boss gives him an impossible task and then said impossible task won't stop being impossible. Really, he should be given a raise for his idea to shower her with toys. That's what kids like, right? It's not like he knows any kids!

Ugghhh, this is entirely unfair and he's going to die if he can't get that brat Eri with the program. *Become someone Eri feels like she can trust,* the boss said. *Don't let her feel like running away*, the boss said. Right, like that isn't a totally understandable response to what they put her through. Mudasuke would absolutely run away from that no matter how many gundam figures someone gave him!

Well. Unless they were special editions. Maybe he could try to relate to her that way- Wait, no, he's complaining right now.

Anyway, here he is on his best behavior, playing nice like this brat isn't a total pain in the ass, being so *patient* with her, and she just won't stop staring at him like he's pissed in her cornflakes and shot her dog. Just what does she want from him?! He's tried talking nice and giving her things and patting her head, but he knows the moment she's got the chance, she'll escape again.

All of this is unfair but he'll find some way to break down her defenses. If princesses and glitter-whatever-the-fuck isn't her thing, maybe she's a horse girl at heart. Isn't there a new pony show out? Or maybe something magical girl. He's pretty sure that asshole Deidoro collects the figures, maybe he'd have an idea of what a little girl might like in her heroes.

Ugh. All of this is so stupid-

His head slams back against the wall with way more force than necessary in Mudasuke's opinion, stars flashing inexplicably before his eyes. Before he can even consider pulling for his quick, he's suddenly wrapped up in a tight restraint and tripping over himself only to fall face first onto the concrete floor.

"Don't be excessive," says one of his assailants with glee, "we're supposed to be *heroes*."

"Shut your mouth. You're an intern at best."

Mudasuke gets pulled up and sees two guys he doesn't recognize before one of them uses his own tie to gag him, the other one securing his hands behind his back with cuffs before releasing his capture weapon-

Oh *shit,* that's *Eraserhead.* No wonder they got the drop on him if fucking Eraserhead is training a sidekick. Seems kind of flashy for an underground hero, though.

They stuff Mudasuke into a closet and he tries not to feel offended by how cliche that is and instead try and figure out how to get himself free because if he doesn't manage to warn anyone there are some heroes around, Overhaul will *obliterate* him.

As Eraserhead turns to go, the sidekick looks down at Mudasuke like he's a piece of dirt. Rage floods through him at the audacity of this brat but before he can consider just what he's gonna do to this upstart next time they meet, the kid rears back and kicks him hard in the head.

The door shuts but Mudasuke's already seeing nothing but darkness.

The only thing Eri can do after her keeper has left is lay down on her bed and try to go back to sleep. The things he keeps bringing, she doesn't know what to do with. The boxes are colorful and usually have smiling faces all over them. She tried stacking them neatly but her keeper complained so she left them scattered and he complained some more. Sometimes he takes the current boxes and brings other ones. Once he brought her a new dress that was pretty and sparkly but the rough fabric made her teeth hurt to touch.

Eri knows what he's trying to do. She knows what Overhaul wants from her and she's trying to be good, she's trying, but she can't stand the thought of just being good and *staying here*.

Last time, she almost got outside before someone found her and she's sure they've filled in the security hole she got through before. Why even bother trying again? No matter what, they always find her.

She covers her face with her hands and tries to pretend she's not about to cry.

That's when her door opens again. Eri jolts up, wondering what her keeper wants now, but there are two men she doesn't recognize in the doorway. They aren't wearing suits like the rest of the Yakuza, are they some of the special ones? The Bullets.

"Hi Eri," says the shorter, younger one. He smiles at her and it's almost like he means it, like he's actually glad to see her. She doesn't know how to respond. He walks towards her slowly with his gloved hands in full view but doesn't reach for her even as he stops right next to the bed. "I know you're scared, but we're here to rescue you. Can you be brave and come with us?"

Then… does that mean they're heroes? Her heart thuds hard in her chest at the very idea. Heroes? Here to rescue her?! How had they even known she was there? The man at the door looks a little gruff like the yakuza, but the one at her bedside has a smile so soft, like he could never hurt anyone at all. She wants so badly for that to be true.

“Who.. who are you?”

“My name is Izuku and that’s Eraserhead.” He extends his hand towards her, slow and easy so she won’t startle, and still isn’t *grabbing* her. “I’m sorry, we don’t have much time. Can I carry you?”

And that’s when the tears start because he’s being so nice and he’s asking her things and waiting for permission and he wants to *save her*. His face seems so gentle, even with his sad eyes, and some forgotten memory of her father has her lifting her arms and Izuku picks her up without hesitation. She clings tight as he holds her, rubbing her back.

“It’s okay,” he says, straightening. “Things may be a little scary while we get you out of here and Eraser and I may need to fight some people, but I promise, it’ll be okay in the end. Just trust us”

Eri buries her face against his shoulder and prays that he’s right.

Throwing out his hand, Shouta signals for them to stop as he edges just far enough around a corner to see. The heavy footsteps he’d heard continue fading as he spots one of Overhaul’s thugs disappearing into a room.

The moment they left Eri’s room, the Shie Hassaikai suddenly got a lot more active and Shouta’s not sure why. Had they figured out about the planned attack? But Shouta should still have nearly another hour to get the girl out before anything else starts.

He gestures for Kiddo to follow him as they continue along one of the paths they’d hashed out before. Kiddo’s knowledge of the compound was thorough, enough that Shouta’s half convinced he’d *lived* here for a while, but of course the brat refused to explain himself. In any case, it means they know about six different paths to get out as enemy movements cut them off.

It’s a small comfort that at least the girl is staying absolutely silent. What that actually means is horrific abuse, but he’ll take it over her panicking. What Kiddo told him about her quirk would make that a *terrible* idea. Kiddo’s been careful to keep her face tucked against his shoulder, holding her protectively like an older brother. Had they really only met now? But her caution hadn’t been faked, he’s sure of that.

Not important. They continue on their way through the honeycomb maze of the Shie Hassaikai complex as carefully as they can. The initial infiltration had taken fifteen minutes but it’s already been twice that trying to get out. They can’t risk getting caught with the girl, not when he might have to spend his quirk blocking hers instead of an enemy’s. He won’t be able to jump between targets like usual.

A door ahead of them opens and Shouta barely manages to duck back around the last turn with Kiddo. Damn it. At this rate, they’ll still be deep in the complex when the other heroes begin their attack. Surely someone will come across Eri’s empty room or the Yakuza they stuffed in a closet. He looks back and meets Kiddo’s gaze, seeing the same grim understanding. Time to cause a distraction.

Before Shouta can make a move, Kiddo shifts Eri's weight over to one arm and turns his head to hers. Shouta sees his lips move but can't make out the near silent words as Eri stiffens and clutches him tighter.

Lifting his freed hand, Kiddo quickly goes through a few rapidfire gestures. Later, Shouta will wonder where Kiddo learned hero specific hand signals so well, the one handed versions even, but fallen heroes existed. He had to have picked it up from one of them.

//*take, escape, fast*//

That fucking *idiot*- Shouta barely finishes recognizing the gestures before Eri's shoved into his arms and Kiddo rushes past, making the decision for them. Shouta sees the glint of his knives and then shudders as he feels Eri's quirk click on. Half a second later he's erasing it and on the move. If Kiddo's going to put himself at risk for this, Shouta won't waste the chance he's been given. He'd promised.

He sees Kiddo jump on the goon's back but then he's gone down another hall with his precious cargo held securely against his chest. If Kiddo survives this, Shouta might murder him himself.

The main advantage of fighting heroes is that they aren't out to kill you. It means you can expect they won't go after certain easy targets because it's a good way to end up with a lethal injury. Ultimately, the heroes want the glory of taking you in with chains on your wrists.

At least, that's what Setsuno Toya has always found to be true, which is how he knows the guy he's fighting *isn't* a hero. Not when Soramitsu's body is getting cold two hallways ago after Greenie showed up out of *nowhere* and put a knife straight through his cervical spine. Soramitsu hadn't even had the chance to scream and Toya's not sure he'll be forgetting the gurgle of his death rattle anytime soon.

Just his luck that someone's infiltrated the base looking for blood when Yu isn't here to back them up. Toya hasn't seen him in a couple days, did the boss send them off on a mission and just not tell him? Shit, he's going to be *pissed* when he finds out about Soramitsu.

Toya dodges under Greenie's fist heading straight for his throat and tries not to panic about the deadly ninja out for his blood. He can tell by the way Greenie moves that he's usually got a weapon in hand, but he hasn't used any since killing Soramitsu. Because he already knows what Toya's quirk can do? Shit, he hates it when his opponent's prepared, especially when he doesn't have any back up. When he'd tried to larceny out the knife from Soramitsu's neck, Greenie had just distracted him until he was out of sight, the asshole. So far, nothing Toya's been able to grab has made any kind of difference.

"What did we even do to you?!" Toya yelps because fuck being quiet, he needs everyone to know about this psycho!

"Doesn't matter," Greenie says and suckerpunches Toya so hard he's legitimately surprised his guts don't come spilling out along with the contents of his stomach. "I figured out how to prevent it."

He lets Toya drop to the ground, curling around himself pathetically. Squatting down next to him, Greenie grabs Toya's hair to drag his head back. He's been in the Yakuza for a while now and was a petty criminal before that for as long as he can remember, but the cold disdain he sees in Greenie's face still makes him shiver.

"Your cell have service down here in all this concrete?" Greenie asks.

"No," Toya manages even if he's having trouble drawing in a full breath because like hell is he helping this asshole. What's around him, what can he use as a weapon, what's small enough to *steal-*

"Pity."

Greenie straightens and shoves Toya onto his back, one boot stamping down hard into the middle of his chest with all of Greenie's weight. It knocks the rest of his breath out and Toya's half sure a couple of his ribs break when Greenie stomps a few more times. A few dozen times? It's kind of hard to concentrate with how hard he's finding breathing at all right now.

"Don't move," Greenie says, like Toya might actually manage to. "If you figure out how to scream for help, that'd work for me so go ahead."

What the fuck. Toya can't even flip him off as he turns and walks away. It burns deep in him to be seen as so weak but the bastard isn't even wrong. Toya's not getting up without some serious help. He… might not be getting up at all.

Toya slumps back against the floor and then begins painstakingly easing his cell phone out of his pocket. Every shift of his arm sends surges of pain through his torso, but Toya hasn't lived this long by giving up when he's still got life in him.

It takes a couple fumbles and then he hears the blessed sound of his boss's voice.

"What is it?"

Too bad all Toya can do is gurgle and whine. Overhaul listens for a handful of seconds as Toya painstakingly taps out *sos.*

"Attack?"

Toya doesn't remember any more morse code but tries his best to make an affirmative noise.

"They're earlier than I expected," Overhaul says. "Stay where you are. I'll send someone."

The call ends and Toya sends a brittle grin to the light in the ceiling.

Fuck you, Greenie. Just wait 'til we get a hold of you. You're gonna regret killing my buddy and not making me immediately follow.

She doesn't much like this body but Himiko can't deny it's useful. How Dabi and Kiddo managed to nab him in the first place is a mystery - this mimic quirk is *neat* - but he's got enough pull in the Yakuza that no one questions her trip down into the lab.

Had, anyway.

The lab is right where Kiddo said it'd be! She can't help but grin to herself and is glad for this guy's mask to keep anyone from seeing it. She feels a bit like she's cosplaying some kind of European plague doctor, it's kind of fun. Oh man, maybe she can get a real outfit made up and get Kiddo in on it. He needs to have more fun in his life!

She's maybe, possibly, kind of a little worried he doesn't remember how to do that.

The two goons she finds in the lab don't feel like joining a better group so she dispatches them quickly. Then kind of wishes she'd left one alive a little longer when she doesn't find what she's here for quickly, but oh well. Himiko searches the lab thoroughly, turning through every drawer and box. Not here, not here, not- Bingo!

The little red things look less like bullets than some kind of tranq dart, but Himiko swipes them all the same. There's ten of them in all and she's sure Kiddo knows exactly who to use them on. While the thought of losing her quirk is terrifying, she has no qualms about taking them from others if it means paving the way for her bestie's better world. Heck, when she was little, she'd have *welcomed* an end to her quirk back before she saw the true beauty of it. Himiko tucks the precious little box into her costume and heads off to make sure Kiddo got out successfully.

If that bastard Eraserhead turned on him, she'll show him absolutely no mercy.

Things are going well, Mirai decides. The assault team has gotten in through the stream of low level thugs to infiltrate the building, those left outside are handling the giant. As soon as he gets confirmation that Eraserhead got out with the girl, he'll be able to relax a little. The amount of heroes he'd gathered is surely enough to handle the rest of the Yakuza, even if there are more than Kiddo told him about.

He pretends not to notice that All Might isn't here yet. The man's never been punctual, too easily distracted by smaller crimes he comes across like there aren't several heroes working his usual turf. Or, maybe, he's late because he doesn't want to see *Mirai*.

A sigh rears up in his throat and Mirai doesn't let it free. He can understand why All Might's been avoiding him all this time. It doesn't mean he has to like it.

His phone rings and Mirai brings it to his ear with a by rote mutter of, "Sir Nighteye speaking."

"I'm out, successful retrieval," Eraserhead says and Mirai can pick up the sound of a child weeping close enough that Eraserhead must be holding her. "Any sign of Kiddo?"

What? "He's not with you?"

“We had to split up to escape. He took it upon himself to create a distraction.”

Mirai quickly goes through his mental list of the assault team.They all know about Eraserhead’s side mission, but how many of them would actually be able to recognize Kiddo on sight? And what if Kiddo used this opportunity to pull something over on them all? It seems suspicious that he just happened to find a reason to get separated from his chaperone once the mission objective had been completed.

“What is the girl’s state?” Mirai asks, trying not to feel incredibly foolish for having trusted the vigilante.

“Unharmed. She’s panicked and has no control of her quirk, but I have it handled for right now.” Sniffles and then Eraserhead sighs a little. “We might want a sedative. I can’t keep erasing it.”

“We have medical staff a block away.”

There isn’t much else to report. Mirai slips his phone back into his coat pocket and looks out at the complex just in time for a streak of red, white, and blue to plow into their problem giant. Mirai’s not close enough to hear the declaration of arrival, but he thinks, maybe, that All Might wouldn’t be able to say it so triumphantly if he were any closer.

For such a ballsy pipsqueak, he certainly didn’t put up much of a fight. Rappa Kendo tries not to be too disappointed. The kid is *tiny* and flew so well when Kendo knocked him into a side room after his failed assassination attempt.

“Is that really it?” he asks. He barely got warmed up, but a little excitement returns to him when the kid starts pushing himself back up on his hands and knees.

“Just… catching my breath,” he says and Kendo grins behind his mask. It’s not that he expects an actual workout from the kid, but it’s always great to see a nice fighting spirit in action!

“You should end this quickly,” Hekiji mutters from behind him but Kendo’s pretty good at ignoring him when he feels like it and Hekiji knows not to get in his way *too* much. “You don’t know what he can do.”

Which is true, but Kendo can make an educated guess considering what the kid *hasn’t* done since his sneaky knife attack didn’t work. The knick in Kendo’s shoulder would have been a lot more serious had he not noticed the movement and moved just in time. Sneaky quiet types don’t tend to be good matchups for him after they’ve lost the element of surprise, no matter what Hekiji says.

“Come on, give me a challenge!” he calls out as the kid gets to his feet. Is he concussed already? The swaying is a bit much. Kendo hadn’t thought he hit him *that* hard - uh. Well, he hadn’t exactly *pulled* the last couple punches, either.

“Pretty sure we both know I can’t,” the kid says and that’s fair, it’s good to know your limits, but it’s better that the kid isn’t backing down anyway. The way he settles his body so that most of his weight is being held up by his bones rather than his muscles, the way he reverses the grip on his knives, little signs of him getting serious to meet Kendo head on despite the fact that they *both* know he’s going to die.

Shit, it’d be an *insult* not to give him his all, wouldn’t it?

“Give me all you got,” Kendo crows out and then they clash.

It doesn’t last long; he hadn’t thought it would. There’s not much people can do against him without some kind of devastating quirk that this kid definitely doesn’t have or for some insane reason just chose not to use. Still, he does manage to draw blood a couple times before Kendo puts him to the ground. And when he gets back up a couple times after, Kendo doesn’t disrespect him by holding back as he drops him again and again.

He’ll give the kid this. He at least never complained.

“Are you finished?” Hekiji asks and Kendo nudges the unmoving figure with his boot but there’s no response.

“I guess,” he says and then someone in red slams into him from the side and there’s a new fight and Kendo has a *great fucking time*. A real fight between men with nothing but death in their eyes! If only Hekiji hadn’t ruined it in the end with one of his fucking barriers, but Kendo knocks him out and demands that Fat Gum take care of the hardening kid so they can get into it for real later. A battle to the death is a battle to the *death*, damn it! Next time, he’ll make sure Hekiji isn’t in the way.

Toyomitsu Taishiro has no idea what to think of this villain but he’ll take the chance the guy is giving them. His student intern needs him. Taishiro starts first aid on him while the villain drags in his partner to tie up and then the person he’d been beating when they got there. Taishiro doesn’t recognize him. Another villain? His costume doesn’t match anything Taishiro knows and-

That’s another kid. Not any of the students that were a part of the mission, but… He can’t be much younger than Eijirou and Taishiro’s not sure he’s *breathing*.

“You heroes get younger and younger,” the villain mutters, settling down beside his unconscious partner while Taishiro wavers between the two boys. Kirishima’s stable enough so Taishiro quickly checks over the second boy. He *is* breathing, but it’s faint. Lung damage? Definitely broken ribs, did something pierce? His face is a mess. Pale and clammy skin, shock. Not at all surprising considering the beating he must have endured before they got there. Had moving him made any of it worse?

And then Taishiro remembers something from the briefing. Something about a sub-mission Eraserhead was on with a consultant. Is this kid…?! He’ll find out later, for now, he needs to make sure both him and Kirishima live long enough for real medical treatment.

When an extraction group gets to them, they take the two villains into custody and do a quick examination of Kirishima and the consultant before radioing for stretchers. Taishiro follows them out because like hell is he leaving Kirishima's side before they get to the ambulance. And then it's hard not to climb right in with him but he's got a report to make. The whole place is a mess of injured and those performing first aid, transportation for villains to holding facilities, and plenty of heroes briefing one another. Taishiro spots Sir Nighteye and starts that way only to pause because Sir Nighteye's attention is entirely on All Might and he's not at all sure he wants to get in the middle of whatever has put *that* expression on the number one hero's face.

Finding someone else, Taishiro gets a rundown of everything he's missed. None of the teams got out unscathed but there's no deaths. All of the surviving Shie Hassaikai members at the complex are apprehended, including their leader Overhaul. They found four bodies but no one was sure who had killed them or why.

By the time he gets to the hospital, Kirishima's out of surgery and Taishiro makes sure to commend him for his great work. It sends them both into tears. Taishiro checks on Amajiki and is just as full of praise for his awkward intern. Someday, Amajiki will warm up to him, Taishiro's sure. He rants to anyone nearby how much of a badass his interns are while ducking well meaning medical staff trying to get him on an I.V. Gaining back his fat can *wait!*

Eventually, someone hooks him up with an I.V. stand so he can keep making his rounds to visit the other injured. It's easier, seeing that his coworkers and friends are really all right. Even the ones that will be in treatment for longer than a few hours, seeing their faces helps him keep his hope.

And then he pauses as he notices a man holding a little girl, standing in front of an observation window. There's an armed guard at the door and Taishiro spots another just inside. When he walks his IV stand over, he's surprised to not see a criminal inside but the kid he'd saved.

"Eraser?" he asks and Eraserhead glances over the sleeping girl's head.

"You don't want to get involved. Trust me."

Ominous. Taishiro looks inside at the injured boy and then decides to take Eraserhead's advice because it's hard enough looking after his interns, much less a kid he's not sure isn't a villain.

Chapter 12

For the last two days, either Toshinori or another hero have been overseeing Midoriya's chemically induced coma. With the amount of damage he'd endured, that seemed a kinder option while the doctors stabilized him. He'll live, whole, and won't even have to deal with more than a month or so of recovery. Toshinori waits in his powered form as the doctor dials down the sedatives.

"There. It should be no more than fifteen minutes," the doctor says before leaving Toshinori alone with the villain Kiddo. He looks so unassuming like this. A young teenager with soft cheeks and freckles, not a highly calculating and cold villain with seeming aspirations on taking over the underground. A kid who should be in school worrying about homework and girls, not… Not threatening heroes into compliance and getting beaten nearly to death by villains while trying to save a little girl.

Everything about Midoriya bothers him because of how confusing it all is.

Seven minutes and Midoriya's eyes snap open. He blinks, staring at the ceiling for a few seconds before slowly turning his gaze over to Toshinori.

"Oh," he says, unsurprised. "Is it time for this already?"

His words are just slightly awkward from the lingering sedative but Toshinori doubts it will last. He's more concerned with what that even means.

"You've been in an induced coma for two days. Once you've sufficiently recovered from your injuries, you will be remanded to police custody awaiting trial," he explains and Midoriya just watches him. No surprise, no defeat, nothing. "You are not eligible for bail."

"Sounds about right," Midoriya says and all he sounds like is tired.

"Do you want the list of charges now or once the police arrive?"

"Nah. It's fine. I know what they'll say."

He's too calm about the whole thing. It's not the calm of someone who thinks they can pull something over on them or make an escape. It's the calm of someone who doesn't *care*.

"Why did you confront Rappa Kendo?" Toshinori asks because it doesn't make sense after all the care Midoriya's taken before to keep his matches well suited to his own skills or somehow stack them in his favor. "Were you unaware of his quirk?"

"No, I knew. I warned Sir Nighteye about it." Green eyes roll up to the ceiling and Midoriya stares at nothing for a while before muttering out, "I thought I was fast enough."

"To what? Kill him?"

“I don’t like leaving future problems hanging around when I have the option to remove them early.” His voice isn’t cold, just quiet and tired. Toshinori remembers the smiling boy from the middle school ID photo, the boy with a bedroom full of hero merchandise who wanted nothing more than to be a hero himself, and can’t make that fit with the boy laying in front of him.

“What happened to you?” comes out of his mouth before Toshinori can stop it.

Midoriya snorts and smiles like it hurts, and then he lifts his good hand to cover his face. The other one is entirely immobilized in a cast. There are broken bones in his legs but most of the damage had been to his torso. Had Fat Gum and Red Riot not arrived when they did or beaten Rappa any later, he wouldn’t have survived.

“You know, every time I get to this point, I always think I won’t feel like this,” Midoriya says and his tone is one step away from a sob but Toshinori has no idea why. “That I won’t *miss* you or- or that I won’t want to confess *everything* to you, but… I’m always *wrong*.”

Stepping closer to the bed, Toshinori drops into a chair the doctor had left for him and asks, “What is it you want to tell me, Midoriya?”

He drops his hand and stares at Toshinori with eyes that are so *young*.

“I can’t. If I tell you anything,” Midoriya says barely above a whisper, “you’ll *die*.”

“Young Midoriya, that is a risk I accepted when I became a hero.” He doesn’t know how to soften that truth. Every hero knows that the next fight could be their last. “I don’t want you working evil on my behalf.”

Something in Midoriya’s gaze fractures and then he looks back at the ceiling. “I know.”

“Then why have you been doing it?”

Midoriya doesn’t smile this time. He doesn’t look at Toshinori either.

“Is someone forcing you?”

Midoriya closes his eyes.

“Is it your father?”

And that, finally, gets Midoriya to react. He laughs hard and sharp and then groans with pain, shivering against the sheets.

“As far as you’re concerned, my father’s been dead for six years,” he says through gritted teeth. “And even if he wasn’t, he wouldn’t recognize me now.”

That was a nerve Toshinori just hit, he’s sure of it. It didn’t sound *protective* of Midoriya Hisashi, more… like contempt? Anger at being left behind, maybe?

“So no, my father isn’t putting me up to anything. I haven’t seen him since I was nine and certainly wouldn’t listen to anything he has to say *now*,” Midoriya says like the words are bullets aimed right for Toshinori’s chest. “The only one to blame for my actions is me.”

Many villains refuse to claim responsibility for their actions and will do anything to get out of it. Others enjoy the game of forcing others to prove everything. The rest are so proud of their accomplishments that they can’t help but brag. Midoriya’s doing none of that, just like he’s refused to fit every other mold Toshinori is familiar with.

Midoriya says nothing more before Toshinori has to trade off with the next hero, but he can’t shake off the way Midoriya’s words made him feel. He’s no less confused by the boy than he was before.

Usually when someone is this adamant to claim blame they’re protecting someone else, but Toshinori is sure Midoriya Hisashi isn’t the one he’s concerned about. He’s just doesn’t know who else it might be.

“You’re sure she *will* heal the damage?” Spinner asks because no one else will and he, for one, doesn’t want to risk pulling Kiddo out of the hospital before they’re sure it won’t make things worse. From what Toga had reported, he’d had to have *surgery.*

They’d been warned it was likely he’d be arrested, but Kiddo hadn’t said anything about getting his ass handed to him first. The guy pretends he’s got an invincibility quirk and that is seriously starting to piss Spinner off. Maybe this healer woman can somehow turn off his suicidal lack of regard for his own safety.

He glances at her and then immediately wishes he hadn’t. She’s got the same expression on her face that his grandmother always did before busting his ass with her sandal. At least Dabi had thought to gag her so she can’t yell at them. Bad enough they kidnapped an elderly hero, they don’t need to have her read them the riot act, too.

“I’m sure we can find something to threaten her with,” Dabi says, unconcerned, and Spinner really wishes sometimes he had that same calm confidence.

“Any news from Toga?” Giran asks as he walks into the main office and then stops to give the tied up Recovery Girl a look. “...Is that who I think it is?”

“Well what did you expect us to do? *Not* get a healer for when we bust Kiddo out?” Spinner tries to ignore that he sounds defensive. “It’s not like we can wait for him to be totally healed up. They’ll transfer him to jail before then.”

Giran blinks slowly and deliberately and Spinner wishes he wasn’t able to blush as he feels his face heat up with embarrassment. That guy is just so *good* at looking judgy.

“Okay. And how do you plan on making her cooperate?”

“Threaten her family?” Dabi says like it’s obvious, then shrugs. “Heroes are supposed to help people, right? And she’s someone Kiddo approves of, so she must be a *real* one.”

From the corner of his eye, Spinner sees Recovery Girl jolt with surprise. What, did she think they chose her by accident!? Yeah, healing's pretty rare but Kiddo has a whole list of people with useful quirks they can call on for consulting.

Giran rubs his chin and gives her a look over. "Well. Until Toga gives the go ahead, we ain't moving. Might as well make her comfortable for the wait. Maybe secure one of the other offices, put in a cot or something."

Which is… probably a better idea than making an old woman sit on the concrete floor for the next couple days. They don't have to make her *like* them, but maybe it's better if she doesn't *hate* them. He glances over and flinches at her expression. Okay, that's it. This is officially Dabi's problem. He's the one who didn't want to wait!

Before Spinner can declare that, Giran looks back towards the hallway and says, "You might as well come in."

What, did he scout someone-

Twice looks almost sheepish as he looks at each of them. "So we're kidnapping old women? *What'd she do?!"*

Oh. Oh, Spinner does *not* like this man. He can tell already.

"What's your game?" Dabi asks with a sideways glance to Giran, his hands not glowing yet but the air around them starting to shimmer.

"No game. Twice here just accepted a better offer of employment than what the League could give him. Let's just say Kiddo owes me for this one."

Right, and Spinner's got a bridge for sale. He glances between Giran and Twice, who's simultaneously looking hopeful and waiting to get the boot. It's pathetic. Spinner has half a mind to throw Giran out on his ass along with this guy.

"So I hear we're going to rescue Kiddo?" Twice says. "He seemed all right. *I hate that guy*."

Spinner feels his eye twitch and looks at Dabi, who's utterly unflapped, the bastard.

"If he crosses us, we can just kill him," Dabi says, which. True.

Knowing he won't win this, Spinner just runs a hand back through his hair and says, "*Fine.* But until it's go time, you're working like the rest of us."

"Sure! What-"

"Ready to set up a holding cell?"

Twice has no idea what he means but Spinner gets to enjoy ordering him around the rest of the day while they set up one of the windowless inner offices as a makeshift prison cell for their elderly guest. She still glares at him and he still feels increasingly guilty at her presence, but at least he's not dealing with her glower alone.

The plan is simple. The plan is elegant. The plan will work.

Tomura doesn't like it but he listens to Sensei anyway and prepares. The few villains they've managed to gather to the League's side aren't good pawns but they'll have to do. Tomura considers their stats and abilities, what heights they might reach with the proper training, and figures through the best ways to use them. Who's on the front row, who's in the rear. Who's on offense, who's driving the van…

For a moment, he lets himself hate Kiddo *so much* for taking such useful toys away from him because if they'd managed to grab that cremation quirked guy this would be so much easier and the *shapeshifter*- but Tomura doesn't need them if their wills are so easily lured by such a talentless hack. He'll crush them all to dust. His fingers curl as he imagines how good it'll feel to watch Kiddo's stupid face decay into nothing. Make his voice disappear from the world. He doesn't care how interested in him Sensei is, the moment Tomura has an opening he will take it immediately.

He's allowed to get rid of the things he hates and he hates Kiddo *so very much*.

"Shigaraki Tomura," Kurogiri calls and Tomura jolts out of his thoughts to look back at him. The map of the transfer route lays between them and Tomura moodily pushes one of the little toy cars they're using as markers along the marked street.

"Why does Sensei even want this man?" he mutters to himself as something in his chest tightens and churns the way it always does when Sensei shows interest in anyone other than him. Tomura's supposed to be his favorite, his *heir*. What does he want with some two bit yakuza with a quirk that isn't even that interesting? It doesn't burn as badly as Sensei's interest in Kiddo, who's even *less* worth anyone's time, but it's still there, sitting in his chest, eating away at him.

"I think, perhaps, he's more interested in the quirk itself," Kurogiri says and Tomura tries not to feel like the warper is *handling* him. It's been like that for… for a long time. Tomura doesn't remember the time before Kurogiri, not well enough to matter anyway. His near constant presence at Tomura's side is comforting, in a way.

"We don't need him whole," Tomura says.

Kurogiri nods and then tramples all over Tomura's daydreams of decaying him piece by piece. "But Sensei *does* want him alive."

Thus the ridiculous, convoluted plan before them. But fine. Tomura will give Sensei what he wants even if it burns inside him. He'll show Sensei that he's the only piece on the board Sensei needs to care about. Glancing at the map and their little cars, Tomura picks one of them up and then lets it disintegrate into his palm.

"...We'll need to overwhelm them," he decides, narrowing his eyes. "Our current pieces haven't leveled up enough to manage this on their own."

"Shall we recruit more?"

“Do it quietly. I don’t want that bastard Kiddo getting anyone useful first.”

“Of course.”

It’ll be difficult, finding worthwhile pawns that Kiddo hasn’t already earmarked as his own, but Tomura refuses to lose to him. All Might and the rest of hero society can wait. After he secures the yakuza for Sensei, nothing is going to get between him and taking Kiddo’s last breath.

Victory will be so *sweet*.

Shouta doesn’t want to do this but Tsukauchi’s right. They need to figure out what the hell Kiddo’s deal is while he’s in traction and can’t run away. Shouta’s always been pretty good at getting people to talk. With Eri safely in another hero’s custody and promising to be good, he follows Tsukauchi into Kiddo’s hospital room.

“Hello, Midoriya. We haven’t met in person yet but I’m Detective Tsukauchi,” is greeted with a tired smile and a little wave.

“Was wondering how long you’d let this golden opportunity pass by.”

Tsukauchi sits down at the side of the bed while Shouta remains standing, hands stuffed in his pockets.

“I thought I told you not to kill anyone,” Shouta begins because he’s pretty pissed about the definite kill they have attributed to Kiddo and a second one he suspects Kiddo was responsible for as well. The other two, he can’t link specifically but that doesn’t mean Kiddo wasn’t involved.

“It was an accident,” the brat says with a grin.

“I *specifically* told you no accidents.”

Midoriya’s grin gets wider like they’re joking around and not talking about *dead men*.

“We’d like to ask you some questions,” Tsukauchi says to get them back on topic.

“Sure. I guess I promise not to lie to you.”

“See, this is why I’m the one taking point on your case. Because you literally can’t lie to me like you just tried to and you know it.”

Midoriya’s expression becomes softer. The swelling on his face has mostly gone down, though his left eye is going to be bruised until a more thorough healing is ordered. It makes him look like a kid who got roughed up in sports practice, rather than a villain who nearly died.

“Why were you so concerned about getting Eri out before the raid?” Shouta asks right off the bat. “What do you want from her?”

“Starting off hot, I see.” Midoriya considers what he wants to say, probably thinking about how best to get out of being truthful. “If Eri wasn’t rescued before the rest of that started, she’d have killed at least four people before you got to her to erase her quirk. She’s got no control of it. It’s either on or off and I didn’t want that on her conscience.”

Which fits with what he’d said before, but the specific body count is new. And Tsukauchi doesn’t signal for a lie as he notes that down.

“Why do you think there would be fatalities?”

“Because of a lot of reasons and a lot of things I shifted around beforehand.”

Ugh, that’s the most wishy washy non-answer Shouta’s ever heard but fine, he gets the message.

“How did you find out about Eri in the first place?”

“I’m really good at piecing together information.” Not a lie but also not an answer and when Shouta just *waits*, Midoriya sighs and says, “Look. Can we skip the hows? You won’t believe me. You never do.”

Shouta narrows his eyes because Tsukauchi didn’t signal that to be a lie and it sounds like… “Try me.”

Closing his eyes a moment, Midoriya takes a deep, slow breath like he’s gearing up to do something painful. When he speaks, it’s in an even, measured tone, “Because I’ve done this before.”

Tsukauchi’s eyes widen. When Shouta searches Midoriya’s face, all he finds there is resignation.

“You’ve stolen Eri from the Shie Hassaikai before?” he asks specifically to annoy Midoriya into giving some details.

“Yeah, I’ve rescued her before,” Midoriya says and there’s a bit more in his words. Not annoyance, nothing so passionate, just… *exhaustion*. “I don’t remember how many times anymore, but I know what happens if I *fail*. I know why she has to be rescued.”

“Midoriya, are you saying-” Tsukauchi starts but the kid interrupts him.

“I’m stuck in a *time loop*, I’ve done this *hundreds* of times.”

And it sounds silly, like something out of a novel or a tv show, but Shouta watches as something seems to break in the boy and feels rooted to the spot, unable to help or even stop this.

“If we don’t rescue her, then Overhaul mills her down to *nothing* for that fucking quirk destroying drug of his and he takes out the quirks of a dozen heroes until All For One gets tired of him wasting them and takes over the operation, and then fucking *All For One* has both Eri’s and Overhaul’s quirks and there’s no coming back from that, those are *always* dead

timelines whether he gives either quirk to Tomura or not. And if we're late in rescuing her but still try, Eri panics and takes out half the heroes in the raid party and there are always fatalities. Most of the time, *her included.*"

Shouta can barely breathe because none of this should be even close to credible but he's having a hard time remembering that. *All For One?* Just remembering that the king of the underworld who'd been missing for years now even existed sends cold down his spine. He's not *dead?!*

"When did this start?" Tsukauchi asks, his gaze locked on Midoriya's strained face. "The loop. How long is it?"

"Long as it needs to be," Midoriya says as he slumps against the bed almost like he's been defeated. "The longest I've made it is to my sixty-fourth birthday once. I usually don't go past twenty. The loop resets every time I die."

"And starts a little over a year ago, doesn't it?"

Midoriya nods without looking at either of them but Tsukauchi just sits back in his chair and stares ahead like he's seeing something other than the boy in the bed, hand over his mouth.

"That's what we were missing," Tsukauchi says. "That's the trigger."

"Why not become a hero with this knowledge?" Shouta asks because that's what he's not getting. "If you already know how to help, who will be in danger-"

"You think I didn't try?!" And suddenly Shouta's sure that if Midoriya were able, he'd be at his throat. "You think I *like* this?! I haven't seen my mother in *weeks*. My mentor is tying himself in knots over things he doesn't understand and he doesn't even *know* he's my mentor. I can't see or talk to any of my friends because it'll either put them in danger or *they'll take me down themselves!*"

"You could have come to me," Tsukauchi says and Midoriya laughs, strained and in pain in more ways than one.

"Sure, and put one of the only good cops in the whole country in danger? And just because you know I'm telling the truth doesn't mean you'd believe I wasn't bugfuck crazypants anyway!"

Shouta catches Tsukauchi's eye and sees the grim acknowledgement of that truth. No wonder the kid thought he had to do all of this himself. Even now, Shouta's not sure he actually believes in this time loop thing, but… There are certain things that only make sense if it's real.

"I trained you," he says and knows it's true even before Midoriya nods. "On a loop when you were trying to be a hero?"

"Yeah. I conned my way into UA's general studies course with a made-up analysis quirk and caught your attention during the sports festival in Shinsou's place."

Shouta stiffens because the only people who should know he's taken Shinsou Hitoshi on as an apprentice are him, Nedzu, and Shinsou.

"He's gonna do great with the capture scarf," Midoriya adds, "once he gets the hang of it. A lot better than I did."

Which Shouta's sure of as well, but it's the fondness in Midoriya's voice that's catching him off guard. Like he knows Shinsou and values him. Which just makes Shouta wonder, "You went to UA more than once, didn't you? Why not this time?"

Midoriya sighs and suddenly looks ancient. "Because it doesn't work. I can't save him as a hero."

"Save who?" Tsukauchi asks.

Closing his eyes, Midoriya reaches up with his good hand to cover his eyes and then slides his bruised fingers back over bandages and his messy curls. There's a debate going on in his mind, Shouta can almost see him stacking the pros and cons on either side, trying to figure out how much he trusts them, how much they believe him.

"Who are you doing all of this for?" Shouta presses, resting a hand on the bed to anchor him as he leans in closer. Midoriya's eyes roll open and meet his, and Shouta thinks this is it. Either Midoriya decides to trust them now or it never happens.

And then the answer is so quiet, they can barely make it out.

"*Kacchan*."

"Bakugou Katsuki?" Tsukauchi asks for clarification and Midoriya just nods as tears begin making tracks down his cheeks.

"He never makes it past seventeen no matter what I do."

Chapter 13

Chapter Notes

Uh. This one gets dark.

Himiko has learned a lot wandering around the hospital in the bodies of different doctors and nurses. She's almost memorized Kiddo's chart, savoring the name *Midoriya Izuku* like fine wine. Maybe after she gets him out of here, he'll let her call him Izuku. They're supposed to be close, it would just prove their closeness!

She would certainly let him call her Himiko. Without an honorific even.

"-where that piece of shit is!"

Stiffening, Himiko looks up at a voice that is becoming familiar quickly. The blond boy doesn't back down a bit from the cop standing at reception, hands raised like he means to attack and is just barely keeping his explosions under control.

"I don't give a damn about that, just tell me where that shitty nerd's room is!"

Here to see Kiddo, then? Himiko swoons a little. It's so romantic, how adamant Bakugou is to get to Kiddo's side while he's laid up in the hospital, and Himiko's sure Kiddo would be happy. She knows how much Kiddo pines after him, even if he won't admit why. What kind of bestie would she be if she didn't help reunite them?

But just as Himiko decides to make her approach, one of the heroes on Kiddo's no-go list arrives to take over for the cop. Darn it. The no-go list is short enough that Kiddo would never believe any of them forgot who's on it. She can't interfere.

Disappointed, Himiko lets it go and goes on up to Kiddo's room to check his chart. He's steadily improving and they finally authorized the healing of his limbs. He's mobile when she gets there, sitting up in bed with a prohero guard inside that just gives her a nod because she's wearing the skin of a nurse right now.

"Looks like you have a last quirk based healing scheduled for this afternoon and then you'll be ready for transfer," she says, flipping through the chart and glancing over the top of it to meet his eyes. Kiddo nods, understanding.

"Thanks. I guess I'll look forward to it."

Himiko barely holds back her grin. Go ahead received.

She wants to stay with him but that would blow her cover. Giving the hero a cheerful little wave as she leaves, Himiko skips off to make sure everything is prepared. Down in the lobby, Bakugou's still arguing with Eraserhead and Himiko thinks, *I'll kidnap you later so you can see each other.*

Surely Kiddo will heal faster with his beloved at his side.

"He's secured to the bed for his own safety and ours," Detective Tsukauchi warns and it breaks Inko's heart to hear but she doesn't fight it. She hasn't seen her child in weeks, just knowing he's alive and whole makes everything else possible to handle. "I can't leave you alone with him but I won't interfere with what you talk about."

Kind of him, even if she knows anything Izuku says can be used against him when this goes to trial. What has he said so far without his parent or any legal representation to protect him? Inko rubs at one of her eyes, already wet and ready to overflow. She's a lot like her parents that way. Just about any strong emotions bring on the waterworks. It's something Izuku gets from her.

Izuku, her precious baby, her only son, an accused murderer.

Inko freezes at the door, her chest so tight she feels like she might die. Even more than the horror she'd felt when she read his notebook is a certainty that her child is drifting farther and farther away from her. Like soon he'll be somewhere she can't see anymore.

Tsukauchi puts a comforting hand on her arm.

"You don't have to do this," he says, completely misunderstanding her hesitation, and Inko jerks to glare at him even as the tears spill free.

"That is my *son*," she snarls, only slightly mollified when he jerks back. "I'm not abandoning him! No matter what."

With that, Inko rips the door open and storms past the hero guard to see her boy in bandages and cuffs and her heart just can't take it. With a sob, Inko steps forward with her arms wide only to hesitate because what if she makes it worse, what if she *hurts* him? They haven't even let her talk to the doctor yet! *She doesn't know what's happened to her child.*

"*Mom*," Izuku whispers, lifting the hand not in a sling up as far as the cuff allows and Inko jerks into action to enfold him in her arms.

"I'm here, sweetheart," she tells him as he starts to cry with her, clutching him as tight as she dares and petting his hair. "I'm here, it's gonna be okay now. We'll figure this out."

"Are you okay?" her baby asks because of course he cares more about her than himself. "Are they treating you well?"

"Yes, yes of course they are," she says. "They're being very kind to me, you don't have to worry."

He relaxes in her arms and Inko resists the urge to cry even more. She doesn't understand what's going on, what all her boy has gotten mixed up in, but that she can still make him feel safe seems like a gift. If only this sweet moment could last, but she hears the detective shift behind them and feels the uncomfortable tension in the air between him and the hero guarding the room.

Swallowing back more tears at the situation, Inko pulls back enough to take Izuku's face in her hands. She needs to be strong.

"This needs to stop," she says and can't quite read what's happening on Izuku's face. "Whatever you're caught up in, it stops now. I can't- No more. You're done."

"Mom-"

"*You're done*." And it's not like her to be this firm, this resolute, but if she doesn't do it now the next time she sees Izuku might be to identify his body and she just… She can't. *She can't.* "Listen to me, Izuku. I need to know you're safe and I can't do that if… If whatever this is- Honey, *please*."

Izuku's shaking under her hands and crying just as much as she is, her sweet little boy. She hates how much pain he's in, hates how she doesn't understand how to help him. All she knows how to do is this.

"I can't," he says, shaky and broken. "I have to save him-"

"That's what heroes are for. That's what- that's why heroes *exist*. You-"

"They can't keep him alive! They're going to *fail*-"

"You need to stop this! *You're not a hero and you can never be one!"*

Izuku's eyes snap wide and his body goes absolutely still, barely even breathing, like he's taken a physical blow. And she hates that she has to do this, but Inko doesn't know what else to do.

"You're sixteen," she says, petting her thumbs over his cheekbones as he stares at her. "You're a child, *quirkless*. You can't be a hero and trying is going to *kill you* and I can't take this. I can't lose you. Izuku, you're all I have left."

He doesn't respond, doesn't even blink, and Inko hugs him to her again despite the fact that he doesn't react to it.

"I can't lose you, so this has to stop. Do you understand me?"

He doesn't move, doesn't speak.

"*Do you understand?"*

And then he nods, just barely against her shoulder. Inko swallows back the lump in her throat and squeezes him tighter. Someday, he'll understand what she's doing, why she has to, but it

hurts so badly right now that she wants to break herself into pieces.

Inko never wanted to take away her son's dangerous dreams. This is all the fault of her weak will.

The door opens and she hears someone exchanging a few quiet words with the detective before he calls over, "Mrs. Midoriya?"

She glances over her shoulder to see a doctor waiting and then resolutely forces herself to let go of Izuku. He's not looking at her and Inko doesn't let herself be hurt by that. This is necessary. This is *right*. She can't let him get himself killed chasing after a dream he's never going to achieve.

"I'll be right back," she says and he doesn't answer. Swallowing another sob, Inko turns and steps outside with the doctor to finally hear what his son's actions have done to him.

Kobayashi Keiko has always known her mistakes would catch up to her. She accepted that when she bought a plan through an underground broker on how to take down her abusive husband a year ago, the cheap price would mean there'd be a favor to call on in the future. She just hadn't thought it'd be so soon.

"You won't remember it clearly enough to rat on us," says the man with the missing tooth. "And the hero won't either."

He'd cornered her with two others while she was making rounds. They say they won't hurt anyone. Keiko rubs her sweaty palms on her pants. They say they'll take her off the List if she does this one favor.

Keiko thinks of her twin girls, happier and more alive in the last year than they'd been all their lives before. Without the information broker Kiddo, they'd never have been freed.

"No one gets hurt," she confirms and the man with the missing tooth nods. Keiko takes a deep breath and then gets them to Kiddo's hospital room. The man with the missing tooth does something to the guard outside that makes him confused and compliant. Keiko opens the door and calls over the hero. As soon as he's in range, the man with the missing tooth reaches past her and touches him. The hero blinks and goes as vague as the guard.

"All done," the man with the missing tooth says and touches her forehead. "Goodbye, Ms. Kobayashi."

The next thing Keiko knows, there's a hero holding her by the shoulders and demanding to know what happened, but Keiko has no idea why she's in this ward. It feels like time has passed but it's muddled and strange when she tries to remember it.

"Some kind of memory tampering quirk," the hero says with a curse, looking back at a policeman.

“They might still be around,” the policeman says as he taps out a message in his phone and the hero hurries off to… search the hospital? Yes, she’s still at the hospital. “Do you remember anything from the last ten minutes?”

Keiko shakes her head.

“I’ll need you to remain here for the meantime in case the quirk fades and you remember.” He makes a call and asks someone about getting security camera footage but Keiko just sits down on the bench outside the observation room she’d been found outside of and tries to understand why she feels a deep sense of relief.

“What, no thank you?”

“Have you given me an invoice yet?”

Dabi watches Giran and Kiddo pick at each other with warring amusement and boredom as Kiddo carefully lowers himself into a chair with Toga’s assistance. The trip back to their base went simply enough after they literally walked out of the hospital scott free, but it’s obvious how much that took out of the still healing Kiddo. One arm is still in a sling and he’s favoring that side heavily but according to Toga his bones have all been mended and he could, in theory, just heal the rest naturally if left be.

The main lounge feels a little more cramped with their top members all in attendance, including Twice. Dabi doesn’t know whether or not he’ll be killing that one just yet, but Kiddo hasn’t objected to his presence.

“*He’s early*,” was all Kiddo had said about it.

If Kiddo’s not going to be on guard against him, Dabi guesses Toga will. She’s protective enough that Dabi doesn’t feel the need to step in. Not that he really cares what happens to Kiddo, but… He does. A little. In an abstract way he doesn’t spend much time thinking about.

“So, what’s the progress on the next mission?” Kiddo asks. “Do we have confirmation?”

“I don’t know. Twice, are the League of Villains going after Overhaul tonight?” Dabi asks and maybe enjoys the way Twice twitches at getting called out.

“Maybe they’re not,” Twice says with a wave of his hand, immediately following up with, “Sensei is definitely interested in that guy!”

Kiddo nods, unphased by his switch over. “Good. They’ll try for him during the custody switch. Wait until Shigaraki and Mr. Compress has neutralized Overhaul’s arms, *then* wipe the floor with them.”

“Just make sure Overhaul doesn’t get out alive, right?” Spinner asks to verify.

“And incinerate the body,” Kiddo confirms with a glance to Dabi, who just smiles. “Leave nothing but ashes.”

“Sounds like an exciting first mission!” Twice says, only a little awkwardly.

“You’re not going.”

“What?!”

Kiddo just looks at him, brows lifted. “You’re on probation and this is too big a task to risk. You’re staying here.”

One hand on his chest, Twice looks the picture of wounded pride. “You doubt my loyalty? *Good call!*”

“Besides. Someone’s gotta stay here with me-”

“Oh!” Toga cries, jumping up to her feet. “The healer!”

And she runs off as Kiddo stares after her. “What healer?”

“Oh yeah, I forgot,” Giran says in the most casual of casual tones. “Your kids misbehaved.”

Dabi doesn’t agree with that assessment at all but Kiddo’s suddenly looking at them all very suspiciously. At least until it morphs to something like offended shock when Toga carts out their prisoner- *consultant.*

They’ve been very good to Recovery Girl, far better than Dabi wanted to be but Recovery Girl is on the no-go list, it’s not like they can hurt her.

“What the *hell* is she doing here?” Kiddo asks. He sounds entirely calm. That’s how Dabi knows he’s *pissed*.

“We knew you wouldn’t be 100% when we got you out-” Spinner starts and then freezes when Kiddo looks at him.

“I didn’t authorize this,” he says. “She’s on the no-go list.”

“We didn’t hurt her,” Dabi says in a bid to de-escalate the situation and just gets glared at.

“*What part of ‘don’t fuck with people on the no-go list’ do you not understand!?*” Kiddo snarls. He rakes a hand back over his hair and then looks over Recovery Girl, who they have *not* harmed. They even took care when restraining her to make sure they wouldn’t bruise her up. Maybe Kiddo doesn’t believe it but Dabi takes the no-go list very seriously. He just doesn’t see the problem in making use of useful quirks.

“We can’t have you laid up for long,” Spinner says.

“Just… Get moving. Get into position. All of you. Twice, you stay.”

As they file out, Dabi lingers just past the doorway. It’s not that he doesn’t have faith in Kiddo’s abilities, but he’s not at his best and Twice is… Well. Dabi leans against the wall and turns his head towards the doorway to listen.

“Untie her,” Kiddo orders and Dabi hears rustling.

“Your friends sure know how to treat an old woman,” Recovery girl mutters.

“Yeah, sorry about that. I’ll have Twice take you home.”

“Take me to UA so I can have him arrested, instead.”

Kiddo snorts. He sounds more tired than amused.

“Do you need groceries, too?” Twice asks and Dabi is just sure sarcasm is dripping from his body language for a second before, “Don’t get yourself caught next time!”

“Hush, you.”

Dabi slides just far enough over to see inside again as things get quiet. Kiddo seems exhausted in his chair and Recovery Girl stares at him with her hands on her hips. Like she’s considering whether to help him or take him down herself.

“Still planning to kill more people after this Overhaul man, aren’t you?” she asks.

“Yeah. At least six. More, if they can’t be converted.”

She sighs heavily in a way that makes her entire body seem to be imploding on itself. “Are they villains?”

“All but one. He’s a hero.”

Recover Girl runs a hand down her face and looks around the room at everything that isn’t Kiddo, her shoulders tense and every inch of her screaming with indecision. Kiddo just watches her and looks… Dabi’s not sure. Conflicted?

“Blindfold her and take her to UA,” he says to Twice finally. “Make sure she comes to no harm along the way.”

Twice salutes and then starts leading Recovery Girl out. Dabi moves out of the way and watches them go, Twice securing a makeshift blindfold made from a handkerchief over Recover Girl’s eyes. Once they’re out of sight, Dabi looks inside again and sees Kiddo staring right back at him.

“You didn’t talk her into healing you,” he says, honestly a little disappointed not to see the trick in action when it isn’t being used against him, and Kiddo smiles a little.

“You guys kidnapped her. What kind of repayment would it have been to demand anything from her? I’m already going to have to figure out a way to make this up to her.”

Which makes sense, but only in the twisted way Kiddo’s morals drive every action he makes rather than actual logic. Shaking his head, Dabi turns to go and meet the others.

“Dabi?” Kiddo calls and he pauses, glancing back over his shoulder. “Capture Mr. Compress alive, if you can. I’ve got a few things to discuss with him.”

The cold in Kiddo’s eyes sends a shiver down Dabi’s spine that has him grinning. “If you say so, Boss.”

“I don’t understand why we’re even entertaining this,” Rock Lock says, fingers threaded together where they lay on the table. “Just because some kid thinks he’s stuck in a time loop doesn’t mean it’s real. It could be some kind of mental illness, maybe a bleedover from an illusion quirk someone else set on him.”

“His insight has been scarily accurate,” All Might points out. “To a degree I can’t explain any other way.”

“He started out as an information broker, that’s what they do,” Ryukuu says. “If it was some kind of quirk that allowed him to mentally repeat situations to try different iterations of actions like Sir Nighteye suggested-”

“He’s quirkless,” Fat Gum reminds her. “But someone else might have been able to put him in that state of mind. I’ve seen nightmare quirks that could do similar?”

They’ve been going around in circles for nearly a half hour at this point and aren’t any closer to a decision on what to do about the villain Kiddo. Naomasa knows he’s in over his head on this one. Somehow, his feelings have been compromised, complicated by the two conflicting sides Kiddo keeps presenting. He’s a ruthlessly efficient murderer, he’s a traumatized and desperate teenage boy…

Sir Nighteye stands and switches the picture on display to show a series of mugshots. “These are the ten villains that died in last night’s altercation between the League of Villains and Kiddo’s team. As far as we know, they were all League of Villains members.”

Naomasa recognizes them of course, but his eyes linger on Chisaki Kai’s face. By the time police got on site, the only reason they’d been able to identify him was the characteristic mask half melted in his charred remains.

“Whether Kiddo really is in a time loop or not doesn’t matter,” Sir Nighteye says as he looks out over the rest of them. “It appears that his team were completely knowledgeable about the League members’ weaknesses and had ample strategies to accomplish victory. Given none of them have shown such organized, strategic minded approaches before encountering him, we can assume those plans were conceived of by him. Kiddo is intelligent, resourceful, and dangerous. We can’t take for granted that he’ll be satisfied with just wiping out the League of Villains.”

The image changes to two high school class ID photos. One of Midoriya Izuku, his smile shallow and insincere, his eyes tired and dark rimmed. The other…

“Kiddo has stated that his primary concern is keeping Bakugou Katsuki alive,” Sir Nighteye continues with the same cool, intense stare over the gathered heroes, gesturing towards the

blonde's photo. "So far, the League has put him in direct danger three times and Kiddo has inserted himself into each situation, either directly or not. We can likely expect him to do so again."

Bakugou's photo disappears as a list of data about Kiddo replaces it.

"Trained by *Eraserhead?*" Rock Lock asks, turning an incredulous look to the man in question, who just glares back at him with his arms crossed over his chest.

"Apparently, Kiddo attended UA as a hero student in several of his loops," the underground hero replies like he's trying to pretend that doesn't bother him. "I've fought with him. He's at least observed me closely enough that his style is mostly a match for my movements, if his story is bogus. It's a good enough choice for someone without a powerful offensive quirk to fall back on."

"Maybe we should feel lucky he didn't take to your capture weapon," Fat Gum says uneasily. "The knives are bad enough but that thing is ridiculously versatile."

Which Naomasa agrees with. It might have been worth it to keep him with a less outright deadly weapon set, though.

"What I'm more concerned about is how the criminal underground is shifting around him," Naomasa says and tries not to feel crushed under the weight of their stares. One would think you'd get used to it, but heroes are universally intense people. "There's a schism forming between Kiddo and the League of Villains, and Kiddo is *winning.* His influence just keeps growing and the loyalty he's inspiring is…impressive."

"The bottom line is right now, we're playing catch up with him." All eyes grimly return to Sir Nighteye as he rests his hands flat on the table, looking to each of them in turn. "Be on guard. Report any related activity or changes in your support areas."

They close on that somber news and Naomasa wishes he felt more secure in their chances of actually meeting the kid on level ground.

Getting away from the others is harder than Jin expected. It's not that they're overly friendly, not with him at least, but he's on their radar *all the time*. One of the major players is at his side pretty much all the time. Watching him, talking to him, feeling him out. He gets why, it's super suspicious for him to switch his loyalties, but it means the only time he gets to himself is when he goes to take a piss.

And it's not like they're wrong to worry.

Jin winces a little and forces himself to focus on staring out the tiny bathroom window as he smokes, his mask stuck in his back pocket. Two days isn't nearly enough time for him to forget his mission here. He's not that much of a soft touch.

But there is a pretty big difference in the way Kiddo's crew treat one another and what happens in the League.

His phone buzzes silently in his pocket and Jin hurries to get it out. “Yeah?”

“Do they suspect?”

The voice is all that’s needed for Jin’s chest to clench up tight and the cigarette to nearly drop from his fingers. He’s not sure if Sensei does that on purpose or what.

“No, I don’t think so. They’re wary, but…” *Looking for the wolf hiding in their herd.*

Jin’s fingers tighten and he hears the phone case crackle ominously.

“Single one of them out,” Sensei says. “Become their friend. Show you’re willing to create connections.”

That won’t be hard. Jin’s already pretty sure either Spinner or Toga would be open to company if he plays his cards right.

Because they’re weak.

“Keep me informed as soon as you know their next planned moves.”

“Kiddo’s going to be down for a couple weeks, probably.” *Because he was saving a little girl, like heroes do.* “I don’t know if there will be anything like a couple days ago again until then.”

His head throbs and Jin shuts his eyes tightly as he tries to hold back.

“Get in touch with Kurogiri if anything interesting *does* get planned, then.”

“Yes, sir.”

The call ends and Jin drops the phone onto the window sill, grabbing his mask to drag it on before he can split again. The relief is instant and he leans hard against the tile wall as he pants for breath with his heartbeat ringing loudly in his ears.

No matter what happens, Jin’s here to do a job and he won’t let anything get in his way. Kiddo’s not kind to his enemies. If Kiddo catches wind of Jin’s intentions…Well. Jin can still smell Mr. Compress’s roasting flesh from Kiddo making good on his promises just that morning.

No. He won’t let anything get in his way. His life depends on it.

Chapter 14

October

Quiet from the underworld looks like more and more criminals changing sides, dwindling funds as more resources get funneled to specific coffers, and fewer warm bodies willing to fill the ranks of certain organizations. It looks like supply chains suddenly going dry for some and plentiful for others, familiar phone lines to powerful friends being disconnected, and the consolidation of power to a far less numerous few.

There is nothing about these recent developments that Toshinori likes. There's less open crime, fewer civilian casualties, sure, but he knows that just means something *big* is building up. The nervous energy pooling and strengthening in the criminal world only needs one tiny spark to blow.

Kiddo has proven himself completely willing to turn things on their head and Toshinori is entirely sure that's exactly what he means to do. With Kiddo out in the wind again, it's up to the heroes to try and figure out what he'll do next.

Which is why that morning as Toshinori steps into the teachers' office at UA, he's surprised to find a note waiting for him.

Stop looking for me and go to I-Island for a while. Go see David. He's doing something stupid you might be able to prevent. Tell Melissa hi from a stranger.

- Kiddo

What? Toshinori squints at the note and wonders how much of it he can take seriously. Kiddo has a habit of finding reasons to get him out of the way, all in the name of preserving his life. Is this another instance or is there something actually wrong with his friend?

If there's nothing wrong, Toshinori might miss something he could help with. If there is, he might lose a dear friend.

He calls. There's a time difference but David still picks up and they talk for a bit about this and that. Melissa's doing exceptionally well in her studies, David's making breakthroughs in quirk enhancement, it's all lovely.

There is a strain in David's voice that Toshinori can't get past. It could just be gearing up for that big event that's coming soon, but… No. Something is wrong. Something is *very* wrong.

Toshinori's sure this is a way of getting him out of Japan. He's just as sure that he can't let David down. So far, Kiddo's information has always been accurate and spot on. He never gives much, but Toshinori can't stop thinking about the recordings of conversations with Kiddo, of how many times he'd been sure no one would listen, and the way his fellow heroes were turning themselves backward to *continue* not listening…

Nedzu seems only mildly surprised when Toshinori puts in a request for a few days of absence. He can at least check in on David and see if there's something going on.

For some reason, Manami hadn't expected to hear from Kiddo again so soon. He left a post-it note again, this time on her front door - on the inside. Her cameras show him breaking in, slapping the post-it on the door, and then immediately leaving. She's not sure why he prefers it that way when he could just email her. Maybe he's trying to pull a power move, but while it annoys her, the fact that he doesn't take the chance to actually do anything to her setup is just… silly. She thinks she likes that about him.

Wanna commit a high profile robbery?

- Kiddo

Well. Of course she does. The hits they got from the All Might videos are *insane* and Gentle's been on cloud nine for weeks. They got hundreds of new subscribers in the first hour alone. Is this another chance for a mega hit? She's chomping at the bit and is sure Gentle will be too!

Manami calls up the number from last time and patiently sits through it transferring through at least ten different switch boards that she hears, probably more for real.

"You didn't take long to think about it," Kiddo says the moment it picks up and Manami has to wonder if anyone else has this number if he already knew it was her.

"I'd like some details," she says, "but we're probably in."

Kiddo emails over information about the location, including blueprints, guard schedules, and even ideas on getting into their network. He's so blasé about it that it takes her a minute to realize exactly where he's wanting them to break in.

"Are… Are you *actually crazy?*" she asks, clutching the phone tight.

"Probably."

"If we get caught-"

"I don't want this to be quiet. That's why I'm asking *you*."

There's causing a scene and then there's *suicide*. Manami suddenly wishes she'd never gotten Kiddo's attention in the first place.

"Don't worry, if we play our hands right, they'll be looking for me, not you."

That doesn't help! "This… might be too big for us."

"Maybe you should ask Gentle if he agrees. Just consider the footage you could get and how many new viewers watching his daring escape."

That… that does sound good.

“We’d need backup,” she says.

“Of course. My team will take care of any heroes that show up, but we’ll make sure to keep it from being flashier than Gentle Criminal.”

In the end, Manami leaves it up to Gentle and Gentle accepts the challenge just like Kiddo knew he would.

The resulting break in at the HPSC goes a lot more smoothly than she was afraid of. Kiddo’s team keep out of shot and let Gentle take the glory as Manami films some of the best shots of her life, the fire guy even giving a few pyrotechnic effects to make them look even cooler.

By the time she’s home and starting the video editing, Manami’s back to feeling pretty good about that Kiddo guy. Whatever he wanted with the top secret files Gentle nabbed for him alongside his own trophies isn’t anything she really cares about knowing.

It’s not exactly easy, getting everything the police have on Kiddo’s identity, but it is simple. All he had to do is threaten someone with high enough clearance to access the case file and make a copy. It’s a low level of theft, something no one had to know about. A little threat, a little payoff, and his currently most annoying enemy’s weaknesses are laid out bare.

He pours over the information the police have gathered to try and get to know this young fool. There’s nothing all that notable about Midoriya Izuku. He got good grades but there’s no spectacular standout subject. No extracurriculars, no sports, no teams. No particular reason to think he could be as effective a leader as he’s shown himself. That he’s quirkless is a surprise but… Well. If anyone knew better than to underestimate a weaponless man…

Is that what Kiddo hates about him? Jealousy seems a bit petty a motive for the sort of things Kiddo’s done so far. Too petty by half.

With the police file, it’s also simple to track down Midoriya’s only living relative. She’s in protective custody but another bribe to just the right person gets him the address. He’s there an hour later and quietly murders the officers watching the property. Entering the house, he takes out the officer inside with little fanfare.

And then Midoriya Inko is at his feet, pitiful as she stares up at him. Helpless. There’s something familiar about her face and the soft, quick intakes of breath as tears roll down her cheeks. Perhaps just the resemblance to her son. He wonders if Kiddo will have as pathetic an expression when he finally breaks the boy.

“Yes, I think you’ll do just fine,” All For One says, his smile widening as her shaking intensifies.

Living with Eri is… not easy but something Shouta finds is getting comfortable. Her gentle voice, soft expressions, tiny hints of inner joy… He wouldn’t mind if this placement becomes

permanent.

As long as Hizashi stops teasing him about his “little duckling”, anyway. If Shouta didn’t l- Nope. That is not a thought process Shouta’s willing to go down right now. It might be different if Hizashi was into guys but-

Shouta rubs at his sore eyes and allows himself a few seconds of feeling pathetic before pushing all that back under the rug with the rest of his emotional repression. He’s got a kid to look after. A kid who is supposed to be eating her breakfast.

“Eri!” he calls, careful not to let his voice get too sharp, and she comes running to hop up in a chair, ready to be fed. Part of that is a fear of retaliation if she doesn’t mind, but Shouta likes to think part of it is a genuine assurance that she *will* be fed. It’s the little things when you’re getting an abused kid to trust you.

As Eri works on her breakfast, Shouta sips coffee and checks the news and resolutely doesn’t look at her. He’s noticed Eri gets nervous when she’s watched, sometimes to the point where she can’t even move. It’s understandable, even if it hurts his heart a little every time he sees it.

“Sensei?” Eri asks, using the title she’s heard the other kids call him. He hasn’t seen a reason to change that.

“Yes?”

“Will Izuku come visit me today?”

It’s the same question she’s asked since the rescue, everyday.

“Not yet,” Shouta says, just like yesterday and the day before. He’s not sure what else to say. They haven’t told her Izuku is a villain, nor that he hasn’t asked after her. Shouta has no intention of taking that hope from her. Sometimes, it’s all that keeps someone going.

As always, Eri nods, looks down at her meal, and starts eating again. Just when Shouta thinks he might have a calm morning for once, his phone rings.

“Aizawa.”

“It’s Tsukauchi. We have a problem.”

Shouta doesn’t let himself stiffen or show any outward signs of distress. Eri’s scarily good at picking out changes in body language. Another problem? And so soon after the HPSC was attacked…

“Midoriya Inko was kidnapped last night,” Tsukauchi says and Shouta’s blood runs cold. “The officers guarding her were all murdered. The security cameras were compromised, there’s no footage. We don’t know who has her.”

And somehow, Shouta very much doubts Kiddo is behind this considering he’d asked for her to go into protective custody in the first place.

“Does he know?”

“Not sure. My guess is no, considering there haven’t been any big upsets.”

Makes sense. Shouta grounds his thumb between his eyes to ward off the headache he knows is coming. Kiddo’s chaotic enough on a normal day. If his mother’s life is on the line, who knows what he’ll do?

“If this is something by the League…” Tsukauchi sounds as grim as Shouta feels.

“Do what you can and keep me informed.”

“Look after yourself, Eraserhead.”

As Shouta slides his phone back in his pocket, he looks over at Eri and sees her jerk her gaze back down to her plate. Damn it, she saw something. Shouta gets up with a soft sigh and starts gathering the breakfast dishes.

“Go get ready. We’re going to UA today.”

As Eri scampers off to get cleaned up, Shouta handles the dishes and tries to decide how he’s going to deal with the mess that’s surely coming their way.

This isn’t the first time the HPSC has asked Takami Keigo to follow someone. He’s uniquely qualified for spy work. The interesting part is that this time he’s not just tailing one person.

The gang that follows Kiddo hasn’t ever announced a name, but Keigo thinks of them as Kiddo’s Crew because why not enjoy some alliteration? They’re fiercely loyal to him, even on the outskirts with people only minorly connected. Keigo spends his time working his way through the lower level goons (but are they really goons when they seem to be civilians with legitimate jobs who just happen to supply the gang with things or information?) and slowly moving up the chain. There doesn’t seem to be much of a strict hierarchy until you get to the inner circle, but Keigo does find a few well placed “bosses” with specific specializations.

He hasn’t seen any sign that the information Kiddo had stolen from the HPSC is in circulation, but Keigo keeps his eyes peeled anyway. Not that he actually knows what all was taken but he’s pretty sure there’d be some kind of shift in the criminal world if Kiddo was acting on it yet. With nothing there, he concentrates on his current mission.

There’s not much of a break until he comes across Spinner by accident. And then things change drastically. Keigo keeps back as he watches Spinner check with several smaller bosses, suppliers, and the like. He’s got Kiddo’s favor so none of them dare give him any trouble. It’s kind of funny how much control that sixteen year old kid has over this part of the underworld.

Then again, Keigo had his own agency at eighteen, so who’s he to talk?

Of the known top names in Kiddo’s organization, Spinner’s supposed to be the most approachable. He’s got the fewest murders to his name and seems less likely to maim out of

hand, anyway. A relatively good head on his shoulders. Keigo follows him around for nearly three days and notices a pattern.

Every time they get into a specific part of the city, suddenly Keigo has a rough time keeping his attention on Spinner. There's always something else intensely more interesting and more noteworthy. He starts thinking it's a quirk of some kind, something location based to keep people from noticing things? Directed to everyone but the specific people allowed to notice, he guesses. It's an interesting trick. He's sure he's heard of similar quirks.

Now that he knows the trick, though, he's able to notice when his attention wanders and refocus, which means he successfully figures out where Kiddo's home base is. If this were a normal mission, this would be the point when he radios in for backup and they take the place down. Rumor has it, Kiddo's got a core group of five and no one else would be present here. But this isn't a normal mission so Keigo just settles in and waits.

It takes three days before he finally sees Kiddo and… wow, he's even tinier than the pictures. The oversized hoodie he's wearing practically swallows him and his cap just barely contains his curls. Kiddo looks around like he's trying to make sure he's not being tailed, which. Valid. Is he going out on his own? That hasn't happened before. Maybe the older gang members don't like him being alone. *Precious*.

Kiddo makes his way out and past Keigo's position, so Keigo takes the opportunity to slip a feather into his back pocket. Then Keigo actually gets a look at the design on his hoodie and nearly blows his cover laughing. The audacity of this villain, wearing an All Might design on his outing. But it does kind of make sense. Who'd figure someone like Kiddo might wear hero merch?

The kid makes his way to the subway and Keigo tracks him through his feather rather than following him in. That's a little too much to hope to stay off anyone's radar. They travel into the mall and then Kiddo just starts wandering. With his hero hoodie and bright red sneakers, Kiddo looks like any other teenager out on a shopping day, but Keigo knows better. He finds a perch nearby to keep watch and realizes Kiddo's looking for something. The wandering isn't random, it's systematic. Is he supposed to be meeting someone here? They must be high profile if Kiddo's going himself-

Bingo, Kiddo zeroes in on someone and walks up to them. Taller, another guy in a hoodie with the hood up, is that just the casual day villain outfit now? He hones in on the vibrations his feather is picking up just in time to make out the newcomer asking, "You? Why the hell are you here?"

"I could ask you the same, but I already know," Kiddo says without any concern. He throws an arm over the second man's shoulders and grins widely. "Come on. Let's sit down somewhere and pretend we don't want to kill each other."

So not a friend. Keigo scratches along his jaw as he watches them settle on a bench, noticing a tiny flicker of light off the blade he hadn't even noticed Kiddo had in his hand when he'd grabbed the other guy.

"I want you to know," Kiddo says, "that I don't give a shit about your past."

The other guy twitches.

“I don’t care about the sob story. I don’t care that you were mistreated and traumatized and that your caretaker is an abusive piece of shit.”

“You-” The other guy stops as Kiddo presses the edge of his concealed blade right against his jugular.

“*I don’t care*.” It comes out like a hiss. “Maybe All Might or one of the other heroes might try to save you, but I know it’s not possible. If I thought you could be rehabilitated, maybe I might feel guilty about what I’m going to do to you.”

Keigo’s muscles coil, just waiting to see if he needs to step in before there’s a bloodbath.

“I told you what happens to people who touch my things. I told you what I’m going to do to *you*. Mr. Compress already knows how good I am about keeping my promises.”

“I’m going to turn you to *dust*,” the other guy growls out but Kiddo just gives him a wide, savage grin.

“Just try it, you crusty asshole,” Kiddo says like they’re at all playing around. “I’m taking one of your fingers for every bruise on her body. How do you expect to be useful to your precious Sensei if you can’t activate your quirk, Shigaraki?”

Abruptly, everything is a *lot* more serious. Keigo’s almost vibrating with energy now that he knows who this second guy is. And seeing the two high profile villains having a low grade pissing contest in the middle of a populated mall should be funny but Keigo has no urge to laugh. Who is Kiddo talking about?

“Are you trying to scare me into letting her go?” Shigaraki asks and Kiddo snorts.

“No. I know that won’t work, but I believe in fair play. This is a warning.” Kiddo leans in closer and if Keigo wasn’t hearing them, he might think they were dating and whispering sweet nothings to one another. “I know where that bastard is. I know where his Nomus are being stored. I know where his scientist is.”

There’s a pause, absolute quiet and stillness, and then Shigaraki says, “What do I care if you know?”

“You don’t,” Kiddo agrees. “But *he* will.”

It happens quickly. One moment, they’re still pretending to be normal mall goers. The next, Shigaraki’s hand is shooting out towards Kiddo’s face while Kiddo stabs at his chest with his off hand. Keigo’s on the move immediately, feathers shooting out to move civilians out of the way of what could end up being a pretty intense villain fight…

Except even after Shigaraki’s fingers curl over Kiddo’s entire face, his quirk doesn’t activate. Kiddo knocks him off the bench and slams Shigaraki head first into the tile floor.

“Not so tough when you can’t decay everything you hate, huh?” Kiddo says as Shigaraki lets out a horrified noise that almost sounds like he’s dying. “Don’t worry, I’m sure your sensei won’t turn you into a Nomu over this.”

Shigaraki manages to get his legs under him and knocks the smaller Kiddo away, stumbling off to disappear into the crowd, but Keigo gets a feather on him in passing. Might as well use the opportunity to track where he’s going. Kiddo doesn’t pursue him. He just gets up and dusts himself off like there isn’t panic around him or a pro hero nearby.

“So was that enough to show you my intentions or are you going to keep stalking my people?” Kiddo says to no one, if by no one it’s obviously Keigo.

Busted.

“If you’re not going to arrest me, then meet up with me in an hour. I’ll keep your feather on me.”

That sneaky little brat! Keigo might be delighted if he hadn’t just seen him effortlessly take down another high ranked villain. Kiddo fades into the crowd and Keigo has to pretend it was a false alarm to calm everyone down. It takes a while before he’s standing next to the bench and notices some odd fragments on the floor. Picking up the red bits of metal and glass, he carefully tucks them away in a baggie and then leaves the scene. He’ll report it later once he has a better idea of just what happened.

Kiddo makes it easy to find him, sitting at the edge of a rooftop with his legs dangling over the side. He doesn’t tense when Keigo shows up, just leans back on his arms and stares out over the city.

“So, did they tell you to just stalk us or to try and get in as a spy?” he asks. “It’s always a fifty/fifty shot either way.”

“Why not both?” Keigo drops down beside him. This isn’t how he pictured his first encounter with the villain to go. It’s so… casual.

“I don’t think you’ll get along with my crew, being an Endeavor fanboy.”

Keigo snorts. “Maybe I can keep my mouth shut?”

“Have you ever, in your life, been able to do that?”

Point.

“Guess my cover’s already blown,” Keigo says and Kiddo glances his way.

“Oh, that’s not your fault,” he says, easy going as ever. “I’m just stuck in a time loop, so we’ve had this conversation a couple times already.”

Keigo looks over his face but there’s no sign of a joke, no sign of falsehood. It’s just like the reports said. Kiddo truly believes that.

“I guess you know what I’m gonna say, huh?”

“I know a lot of possibilities, but there’s always the chance one of my earlier changes will affect what you decide to do in ways I haven’t experienced yet.”

It doesn’t sound like he’s expecting to be surprised, though. He just seems *tired*.

“So this Bakugou kid, is he your boyfriend?” Keigo asks to give himself time to figure out just what he wants to do now. “Seems like this whole mess is about him.”

“He’d kill you for implying it,” Kiddo says with a smile just dripping in fond remembrance. “And I know better than to let him get close anymore. It never ends well.”

Which means they probably *had* been close, at least at some point. Rough. Keigo chews at the side of his mouth a bit because romance has never been his strong point and it’s actually kind of uncomfortable hearing the longing in Kiddo’s voice for a thing he won’t allow himself to have.

“Kind of far to go for someone you’re not even boning.”

Kiddo laughs, quiet and soft. “He’s worth saving.”

It feels like some kind of out of control teen romance tv show on its undeserved tenth season and Keigo’s not sure how to feel about that. He considers the situation, what he knows and doesn’t know about Kiddo, what might happen, and figures even if Kiddo knows his intentions, he might as well go for it.

“So are you going to let me join your gang?” he asks and Kiddo laughs again, almost sounding his age.

“You know, usually you go in with a little more finesse.”

“Yeah, but I figure that’s a waste of time because of the time loop thing.”

“You’re not wrong.” Kiddo grins widely like they’re just friends joking around and maybe in one of the other loops, they had been. Maybe Keigo isn’t entirely sold on the time loop thing, but he’s willing to give Kiddo the benefit of the doubt for now. “Sure. I’ll let you in the club. Try not to get Dabi mad or he might roast all your feathers.”

“Great. I’ll let my superiors know that I’ve *finessed* my way in.”

As playful as they’re being, Keigo is sure Kiddo thinks he can use him for his own ends but the best way to find what those ends are is to be part of the in group. He’s sure Kiddo will bar him from anything he might threaten… but Keigo is a *good* spy. He’ll get what he needs. He just has to find the cracks first.

Chapter 15

Chapter Notes

So this one just flowed and ended up way different than i was expecting lol

He doesn't know why he keeps coming here. It's stupid. He *knows* Auntie and Deku aren't going to be there, but Katsuki keeps finding his feet taking him to their apartment building. He stares up towards their door, hands tightly fisted in his jacket pockets, and can't understand what the hell he's feeling.

The last time he saw Deku, he was bleeding out in an alleyway and looking at Katsuki like he was a ghost. He didn't manage to get into Deku's room before the asshole broke out of custody and he hasn't gotten a single hint of him since then. No matter how closely Katsuki scours the news, things are weirdly quiet after that run in between two gangs of villains. It feels wrong. Like things that are supposed to have happened keep getting circumvented and the whole world is doing its level best to cut him out of the equation.

The only reason he'd even known the nerd got hurt again was overhearing Aizawa talking to someone on the phone because who would think to tell him in the first place. Which makes sense because it's not like Katsuki gives two shits about him. He's just confused as hell by him and about the only way that might change is if he pins that quirkless asshole down and beats some answers out of him.

Standing here in front of Deku's apartment building certainly isn't going to further that goal but Katsuki finds himself reluctant to leave. He keeps remembering the alley. He keeps seeing the look on Deku's face and hearing the anguished sound he'd made. He keeps thinking about what *I'm not leaving you* must have meant to him.

It's obvious there's something really wrong with the idiot that spent so long chasing after him, so long taking any tiny thing Katsuki threw at him no matter how cruel, and Katsuki had taken for granted that it would continue forever. And then the last year of middle school, Deku one day just… stopped. Stopped following him, stopped reaching for every scrap of attention, stopped even looking at him. He faded so far into the background that Katsuki barely even realized they still went to the same school anymore. And then high school happened and… There hadn't been much reason to think about Deku anymore. Katsuki had his studies and training, new extras to whip into shape.

He might be willing to call some of them friends but Katsuki knows his definition of friendship is a lot different than theirs. His friendship is a constant struggle of pushing each other forward, of accepting nothing less than the best, of constantly challenging limits, and the closest he's gotten to that is Kirishima, but Kirishima is also just so… He doesn't push others. He doesn't let himself *be* pushed, not the way Katsuki needs to do. Kirishima pushes

himself and accepts everyone else right where they are without demanding anything more and it's so *frustrating* that he's fine if they're just half of what they could be. Katsuki has plenty of sycophants and it's fine, they're entertaining, but he doesn't…

Deku could never fill that role and yet Katsuki is so *angry* at him for not managing it anyway.

His reverie is cut short when he hears someone shuffling around behind him but Katsuki doesn't let on that he's noticed them at first. It might just be a neighbor, a passerby… or they could just make it easy on him and walk up to stand at his side.

"You miss him!" says the blond freak from the training camp, her hands clasped behind her back as she sways in place like an over caffeinated ferret.

"The fuck are you on about?" Katsuki growls at her but this is probably his best chance of figuring out where the hell Deku is.

"Why else would you come to his house so much?"

What, is she *stalking him?!* "I was just in the area!"

The freak grins so wide he's surprised her head doesn't split in two. Worse than Sero.

"You miss him," she repeats with obvious glee. "He misses you, too!"

The look on Deku's face, the sound-

"What's he even doing right now?" Katsuki mutters, staring back up at the apartment. "Playing the villain, getting himself hurt, killing people-"

"We're making a better world," the freak says and her sing-song tone is grating on his nerves. "But I think, mostly, he wants to save you."

Katsuki sees red and his palms explode as he snarls out, "I don't need saving by that weak, shitty nerd!"

"Maybe you should tell him that so he stops taking so many risks!" she half laughs, bouncing back out of range but not reaching for her own weapons. "Wanna go to our base?"

"For the last time, I'm not joining a fucking villain organization!"

The freak laughs harder, bending in two with the force of it. Nearly a minute goes by before she can straighten and wipe tears from her eyes.

"Oh wow, no no no. You're on the no-go list. I'm not trying to subvert you!" *The fuck is the no-go list?!* "I just don't want my bestie to be miserable all the time so I figured maybe if you visited, he'd be happy!"

The tactical part of Katsuki's mind muses that this is a good opportunity to get some intel on what's going on, pass it on to pro heroes, get some points to counteract the stupid bullshit

people keep thinking about him, but Katsuki's never been good at listening to that outside of battle.

"Why would I trust your crazy ass?" he asks, giving her the in he's sure she was looking for.

"Because it's the only way you get to go see your boyfriend."

His *what*.

Katsuki thought he'd been angry before. It's nothing in the face of the sudden whiplash of rage that rolls through his body at the very idea that he'd *ever* see Deku as that much of an equal. Dating that nerd?! Is she *insane?!* Clearly, if she believes that!

"You're fucking *delusional!*" he snarls out as heat flashes bright in his hands, but she doesn't have the decency to do anything but giggle. "I don't know why I'm even bothering to talk to you!"

"Well, you *could* be talking to Izuku," she says and he gets hit with more whiplash at the lack of honorific, why the hell is this crazy bitch calling Deku by his *name*- "I can take you to him!"

Katsuki has half a mind to beat her bloody and broken, but this might be his only chance. Damn what she thinks, he's got a fucking nerd to drag home already.

"If you try anything, I'll kill you," he says and then just glares at the creepy grin that crosses her face. It takes a moment before he realizes that his 'kill' and hers are entirely different and his belly drops at the implication but he doesn't let that show on his face.

"Right this way."

There is a hole inside Tomura, carved out and left bleeding. It's been there for a long time, but now the edges are even more raw than normal and he can barely breathe as his body throbs and aches.

He hasn't been able to call decay since the mall. Since he got home and Kurogiri dug a needle out of his chest that Kiddo had pierced into him. Since Kiddo had *ruined him*. It doesn't matter how hard he holds onto things with all five fingers on both hands, it won't crumble under them. He screamed and raged and threw things, but the truth hasn't changed.

His quirk is gone and it's all that fucking *bastard's* fault.

"Is he finished?" Sensei asks and Tomura can't quite hear Kurogiri's response before Sensei gives a loud sigh. "This does certainly put a wrench in my schedule."

Hate and shame burn through Tomura like acid. He was useful to Sensei when he had power, but without it… His fingers dig in harder against his neck and he feels wetness under his nails.

“I suppose I can give him something else,” Sensei says with disappointment dripping from every word. “Maybe that woman’s quirk, just to dig in the knife.”

That woman has only stopped crying when she’s passed out from the pain but Tomura hates everything about her. He hates her face, her voice, her sniveling. He wants to tear her apart and render her so much dust in the wind. Her quirk is nearly useless, watered down and barely there, it would only be punishment if Sensei foists it on him.

“Give me the best you have,” Tomura snarls out as his hatred gives him the strength to get up off the floor, to finally look Sensei in the face. “Give me the power to *destroy him*.”

Sensei hums thoughtfully, arms crossed and tapping his fingers along his bicep. “And who’s to say you won’t just lose that one, too?”

“I’ll tear him apart with my bare hands!” Tomura yells back and he can almost feel bones break in his hands, skin split under his teeth. “I’ll take him on again and again and *again* until he’s nothing but broken and lifeless at my feet!”

Kurogiri whispers his name but Sensei’s mouth twists into a wide smile that both elates Tomura and sends chills down his spine.

“Will you, now?” he says in his most smooth, amused tone. “And what if I want him alive?”

“He’s a quirkless piece of *filth*.”

“Mm. And yet…”

Tomura opens his mouth to scream at him and demand everything he has when that woman chokes on her next breath. HIs gaze jerks over to her body in the cage, broken and weak and *pathetic*.

“Izuku,” she whispers, shaking and clinging to herself, but her eyes lift to his. She’s terrified and yet she *dares* meet his gaze?! “Izuku will… my baby will… beat you.”

And Tomura hates *everything* about her but when he steps forward to tear out her huge, stupid eyes, Sensei grabs his hand.

“Now, now, Tomura. Let her have her hope for now. It makes it so much sweeter when she loses it later.”

Tomura doesn’t give a damn about later but he’s so angry he can’t speak, his chest tight and spasming around his lungs like there’s something alive trying to eat him from the inside. He hates so goddamn much and then he freezes as he feels something warm and slimy and *wrong* filter into him. Jerking his head up, Tomura stares at Sensei’s mutilated face as the man just continues to grin at him.

“The best I have,” Sensei says as the new quirk settles into Tomura’s blood, liquid mercury filtering into every cell of his body. “Don’t say I never gave you anything, my dear boy.”

“What makes you think you’re doing this alone?

“Because it’s personal.”

“Didn’t we go over why that excuse won’t work anymore? When you nearly *died twice?*”

“That doesn’t change the fact that I’m not putting anyone else in danger for-”

“What’s the point of being in a group if you’re just going to-”

“I’m not putting your lives on the line for me!”

Spinner resists the groan he feels welling up in his chest. Kiddo and Dabi have been going in circles for a while now and while Spinner understands both sides of the conversation, he has to admit he’s got one he’s rooting for. That self destructive tendency that seems baked into Kiddo really, *really* pisses him off. It’s like Kiddo can’t conceptualize the idea that he might be important enough to other people for them to not want him to die for them. As if dying for someone is the ultimate way to care for them, ugh. If any of them are going to get it through Kiddo’s thick skull, it’s Dabi, and even then Spinner doesn’t really have that much hope.

“Just what are we supposed to do after you get yourself killed-”

“Why do you assume I can’t beat him-”

“*Because he’s the king of the underworld, you demented little brain dead chihuahua.*”

Oh damn, Dabi’s actually pissed if he’s pulling out the really stupid insults.

As the two of them continue snarling at each other, Spinner thinks maybe his decision to hang back in the hall and listen might have been ill advised. He’s not going to learn anything new, after all. Kiddo’s ridiculous plan to rescue his mother with that pro hero he’d inexplicably gotten to join up is simple enough that there’s no way Spinner could have forgotten it already. He scratches back through his hair but it’s not very soothing.

Then he gets nearly scared out of his skin when Toga drops a hand on his shoulder out of nowhere and asks, “What are they fighting about?”

“*Shit!* Don’t sneak up on me!” Spinner turns to start in on her and then freezes. “Oh no. Why is he here?”

The spikey blond student just glares at him from behind Toga. “What stupid stunt is Deku trying to pull now?”

Spinner looks between him and Toga before dropping his face into his hands to let out the groan he’d been holding in.

“-gotten pretty good at killing villains-”

“Not this again. I don’t care about how you defanged Shigaraki-”

“-so if anyone is qualified to do it-”

Spinner peeks up between his fingers but Toga is still there and so is the top name on the no-go list, the one Kiddo had written boldly in red sharpie and underlined three times.

“He’s going to murder you,” Spinner says and Toga just giggles, but Bakugou isn’t paying attention to either of them anymore. His eyes are on the two arguing villains, narrow and calculating.

“And what if he takes your quirk? What then?”

“Then I learn to fight quirkless like you, what’s the harm?”

“The harm is he uses it on you after!”

“Did you forget where I got these scars?”

Toga leans in and asks in a whisper that isn’t actually all that quiet, “How long have they been at this?”

“I don’t know, maybe half an hour?” Spinner says, feeling helplessly caught. “Kiddo said he was going with Hawks later to save his mom and-”

“Wait.” Bakugou’s attention snaps to him and Spinner did not think anyone could be as overwhelmingly intense as Kiddo but he was *wrong*. “What happened to Auntie?”

Toga is absolutely no help when Spinner sends a panicked look at her because he’s entirely sure that telling Bakugou anything will violate the no-go, but she’s the idiot that brought him here in the first place!

“It’s-” Ah hell, just how is he supposed to navigate this.

Turns out he doesn’t have to because right after, in the calmest, coldest tone he’s ever heard, Kiddo asks, “What the hell is he doing here?”

Spinner slowly turns his head, eyes wide and- oh. Oh shit. Kiddo isn’t just pissed, he’s utterly *enraged*.

“What do I have to do to make you all understand no-go? *IT MEANS DON’T FUCK WITH THE PEOPLE ON THE LIST!*”

“It’s not my fault this time,” Dabi says from behind him, entirely unhelpful and also unconcerned. “I respect the list.”

“Take him home!”

Bakugou shoves past Spinner and walks right up to Kiddo like it’s his universe given right, only to grab Kiddo by the front of his shirt and jerk him in close. “What happened to Auntie?”

Kiddo glares at him but doesn't try to shake himself loose. "None of your business."

"Like hell it's not my business, shit nerd!"

Spinner spares a glance at Toga to see if she's regretting this decision, but instead she's starry eyed as if she's watching some kind of romantic confession.

"You're not getting involved," Kiddo says, stubborn as ever, but while the rest of them tend to cave to him pretty quickly, Bakugou just bares his teeth at him like an animal.

"You don't get to tell me what I can and can't do!"

"I do when it'll get you killed!"

"If it would kill me, then it'll get you obliterated off the face of the planet!"

It feels like a fight between an old married couple and Spinner hates himself for even thinking that. Maybe it's a good thing that Hawks and Twice are off doing recon so that as few people as possible witness this ridiculousness.

"You're a hero student," Kiddo says, his hands lifting to wrap around Bakugou's wrists. "If you get caught doing vigilante work, you could be barred from getting your license."

"What do you care about my license, you shit nerd? Aren't you a villain? I'll make my way exactly as I want to and there's *nothing* that will hold me back!"

"Which is why you're going *straight home right now!*"

"The hell I am! What's going on with Auntie?!"

Kiddo finally shifts his hold on Bakugou's hands, twists abruptly in some way that apparently hurts a *lot* from the cussing, and breaks out of Bakugou's grip.

"Get him restrained and then take him home," Kiddo snarls as he finally looks away from Bakugou to glare at his three teammates. "If anyone spots you, make it look like a kidnapping gone wrong and then bail."

"The fuck-"

Kiddo rounds on Bakugou so fast, Spinner could swear he had a speed quirk. "And you! Stop associating with villains!"

The offended look on Bakugou's face should be funny but the entire situation is so surreal Spinner can't do anything but hop to his marching orders and go find something to tie the blond up with.

"Is that what you are?" Bakugou asks and the soft tone stops Spinner in his tracks. It's only soft in volume. Underneath it is a fury that feels like a physical weight crushing down on the entire room.

The only one of them that doesn't seem to feel it is Kiddo, staring back at Bakugou.

"Well, I murder people, so what do you think?" he asks and it should be flippant, it should be entirely without merit, but Spinner has heard Kiddo be that way and this isn't it. This is… He doesn't know what this is, but it feels like there's an entirely different conversation going on under the one he's hearing.

Bakugou seems as unsure of how to respond as the rest of them. After a few moments, Kiddo sighs and rakes a hand back through his head, turning his back on them to go look at their planning wall that's strewn with maps, pinned up reports, and hand written notes.

"Get him out of here and if any of you ever bring him back, I will kill you personally."

"*Deku!*"

Spinner hears the *thunk* before registering Kiddo whipping around and letting a knife fly. It's sunk over an inch into the wall and when Spinner's gaze slides back to Bakugou, he sees blood dripping down from a clean cut in the kid's cheek.

"You're not authorized to use your quirk right now," Kiddo says with a deadly sort of calm. "This is probably the only time in our lives that the two of us have ever been even close to being on a level playing ground."

For once, Bakugou doesn't respond. He just stares poleaxed towards Kiddo.

"So let me tell you how this is going to play out." Kiddo starts walking towards him, almost predatory in his movements. "You're going to turn around and walk your ass out of my base. You're going to let Spinner escort you back home. And after that? You're not coming after me again."

"Like you get to tell me-" Bakugou cuts off as Kiddo lets out an actual, honest to god snarl that makes even Spinner go still and on guard with every survival instinct inside him screaming.

"Don't fucking test me right now, Kacchan, or so help me-" Kiddo hisses through his teeth and then forces his anger back like it's a physical thing he's restraining. "Just- just *go*."

Spinner's not sure if it's the tone or the way Kiddo stalks back to the planning wall, but Bakugou finally stops fighting back. He stares at Kiddo hard for several seconds before turning to go back out the way he'd been led in. Spinner hurries after him because like hell is he going to be the one blamed if Mr. Asshole Explosives gets a bad case of dead on his way home.

Bakugou says nothing nearly the whole way but Spinner's sure there's plenty going on in his head. That's just how it works with guys like this. When they finally get to Bakugou's neighborhood, the kid stops and Spinner resists the urge to groan in frustration. *Just go home!*

"What's going on with his mom?" Bakugou asks without looking at him.

"It's really not your-"

“Shut the fuck up. What the hell is going on with his mom?”

How is he supposed to shut up and answer at the same time? Spinner’s irritated enough that if he didn’t know Kiddo would rip every inch of skin off his body bit by bit, he’d be knocking some sense into this damn kid.

“She got kidnapped out of police custody,” Spinner says and observes a ripple of tension forming in Bakugou’s shoulders.

“Who has her?”

“No. Not this time. I’m not going to be the one that puts *you* in danger.”

Bright, hot pops go off in both of Bakugou’s hands, hinting at something a lot stronger that Spinner is entirely aware he’s capable of.

“I’m not going after them! I’m going to tell the fucking pros!”

Which Spinner knows is exactly what Kiddo *doesn’t* want to have happen. If he wanted pro heroes in on this gig, he’d have contacted them himself or had Hawks do it.

“Go home,” Spinner says and jerks back at the rage filled glare that gets turned on him after, but he’s resolute. No-go means not giving information away to a volatile teenager that will *definitely* use it to justify really stupid ideas.

Spinner leaves Bakugou in his neighborhood and goes back to see if Kiddo’s calmed down. When he gets there, only Dabi is waiting for him.

“He’s with Toga,” is the only explanation Spinner gets but it’s all he needs. If any of them will be able to calm Kiddo down, it’ll be her. Too bad she can’t stem that self-sacrificial streak that annoys Spinner so much.

“Anything from Hawks?” And it is never going to stop being weird that they’ve got a pro hero in the top ten on their roster.

“Yeah. He’s verified the location is in use. He and Kiddo will be hitting it tonight.”

Great. Well, hopefully that little impromptu visit won’t have rattled Kiddo enough to risk living through his stupid stunt.

“You think they’re exes?” he asks and Dabi snorts.

Chapter 16

Chapter Notes

> So bit more of a wait this time. I got on a new work schedule and am closing on a house, so things have been screwy in my brain but finally got it running enough to finish this.
>
> Also I would be posting this tomorrow but tomorrow is going to be a metric shit ton of shit and I don't wanna wait until evening to get this up so here we go.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

This is probably the most insane thing Kamihara Shinya has been dragged into and of course, of *course*, it's because of Hawks. There's no way anyone else could bring about something so chaotic.

"Are you sure he won't double cross us?" Shinya asks.

"What? No, not really, but we're useful to him right now," Hawks replies without sounding at all worried. "This is his mom we're helping to rescue, after all."

Point. As long as Kiddo hasn't been lying to Hawks, anyway. Shinya still doesn't like this. Like most pros, Shinya has informants that aren't exactly on the straight and narrow, but Kiddo is a straight up villain with a body count filled by impressive names. It's not exactly on the same level. Whatever game Hawks thinks he's playing, Shinya's not sure he's actually winning.

"And the other team?" he asks only for Hawks to shrug.

"There's thirty over there with their sidekicks, why are you worried?"

Thirtyish heroes and several dozen sidekicks against who knew how many of those Nomu monsters that gave even All Might trouble? It's almost like Shinya has some survival instincts that Hawks entirely lacks. Then again, Hawks did have a keen enough insight to realize Shinya would be a good partner for this job. He's just not sure they'll all regret it or not after.

Shinya hears footsteps before seeing Kiddo arrive. The virulent green interspersed within the black of his costume should seem a lot more out of place than it does. His mask rests against his collar showing his youthful face, but there's nothing young about the look in his eyes. Shinya won't let himself underestimate him.

"Thank you for coming, Edgeshot," Kiddo says with politeness Shinya hadn't expected. "If you arrest me later, I won't hold it against you."

“I would be arresting you now if Hawks hadn’t spoken for you.”

“See, Kiddo? Friends in high places.”

Kiddo nods, but doesn’t seem amused. He launches immediately into the plan and it’s… It’s risky. It’s a lot riskier than Shinya likes. There’s so much that hinges on only hunches and Kiddo’s assurances that of *course* things will go this way, they did *last time*. It makes Shinya remember about the kid thinking he’s in a time loop and suddenly he’s even less sure about this entire thing. They’re trusting the intel of someone who may be psychologically impaired and Hawks doesn’t seem to have *any* issue with that.

“And if you’re wrong?” he asks because Hawks isn’t.

“Then we all die and I wake up again on what used to be the best day of my life.”

Which is… not a reassuring thing to hear. If Kiddo doesn’t care about dying due to his delusion about the time loop, he’s liable to take far greater risks than someone who has any respect for death, if not fear of it. Every second, Shinya’s regretting agreeing to this a little more.

“Oh, and I forgot, but I’m definitely killing Shigaraki Tomura tonight,” Kiddo says, looking at Shinya head on as if he’s expecting pushback. As if he knows Hawks won’t object (which he doesn’t) and he’s *testing* Shinya.

“You must know I cannot allow that to happen,” Shinya says and the villain smiles at him. Not even in a mean or cruel way, just… *fond*. Like they’re *friends* and he’s said something Kiddo would entirely expect from him.

“That’s why you need to concentrate on taking down Kurogiri quickly. Remember, only what the collar covers is his real body. You need to disrupt his brain long enough to knock him out and you’ll only have one or two shots at the most before he bails.”

Skimming right over Shinya’s objection, seamlessly sliding into his plan of action. He’s almost impressed by how smooth it is.

“Hey, if you get him on the first try, then you’ll have more time to curb his murdergobin tendencies,” Hawks points out in a cheerful tone that has Shinya’s teeth on edge.

Kiddo isn’t even offended by the moniker. “I mean, you can try if you want, but I’m definitely killing him.”

“I *was* kind of surprised you didn’t in the mall.”

“Letting him live after taking his quirk works out better in getting everything into position for this attack.”

Shinya stills. “After you *what?*”

“Oh, yeah, I forgot to tell you,” Hawks, the bastard, says in the most casual of casual tones. “Remember that Overhaul case? Turns out Kiddo swiped some of the product.”

Which of course sends Shinya's belly ten miles into the ground because no matter how casual Hawks is being and how amiable Kiddo is, this boy has the ability to utterly destroy heroes with a single move.

"Don't worry," Kiddo says and Shinya can only stare at him, "There're only two people I plan on using the rest on and you're not one of them."

That isn't nearly as comforting as Kiddo seems to think it is.

Still, they have a mission to complete and Hawks has already gotten all the permissions through the HPSC to move, so there's not much Shinya can do to protest. His jaw tightens as they get into position to start their covert assault on the villain hideout.

Keigo hasn't been sure what to expect from Kiddo. The young villain keeps his thoughts to himself for the most part, voicing them when it's necessary but otherwise turning his attention to observing the rest of the world around him. He's no different now, leading two pro heroes into enemy territory like he's done it a hundred times. It's one of those things that makes Keigo almost believe the time loop thing. Kiddo acts like a seasoned pro that's two days from retirement. It makes it easy for Keigo to follow him.

The lab is distressing to go through, far too large and dark with chemical smells that only barely cover up old blood. Keigo tries not to think about what's gone on here. Reminds him too much of things he really doesn't need to be remembering now or ever, if he had his way. Of the locations Kiddo revealed, this isn't the one he'd expect a hostage to be kept at but Kiddo had been adamant when he was going over the plan with Keigo. His mother will be here, as should Kurogiri and Shigaraki. The main unknown is whether or not Shigaraki will actually be a threat.

"*It's one in three, which quirk he'll have,*" Kiddo had said. "*Unless one of my changes makes All For One change his mind.*"

"*Why not all three?*" Hawks had asked since if the guy can give *one* quirk, why not more?

"*Because that would either kill Shigaraki or break his brain. Humans aren't meant to carry more than one.*"

Which makes Keigo wonder if he's seen that in action by anyone other than All For One, who's supposed to have dozens of them. The idea makes him shiver, feathers shifting into a tighter formation.

Focus.

Keigo's job is the rescue. While Edgeshot takes Kurogiri and Kiddo takes Shigaraki, he's the best option for finding Midoriya Inko quickly and getting her out unharmed. It seems simple but Keigo knows that the more confident they go into this, the more likely shit is going to hit the fan.

And it does. Quickly.

One minute, they're making their way around floor to ceiling shelves offset to force people to walk the full length of each one. The next, Keigo's feathers pick up foreign air movement half a second before he knocks Kiddo down to the floor to avoid getting skewered by a set of shiny red spikes that embed in the wall where his head had been. Edgeshot is gone, likely compacted and using the distraction to head off and find his own target while Keigo lets free a dozen feathers to seek out the air disturbance.

He recognizes mercury blood from Kiddo's off hand description and remembers it to be the quirk Kiddo had hoped wasn't their one in three. Just their luck.

"Go!" Kiddo orders, getting up to dodge another spike and then racing forward. Keigo almost goes after him but he's still got a civilian to rescue and her life is definitely a higher priority than a villain's. He hears more than sees spikes crash after Kiddo and instead concentrates on sending out his feathers into an open search pattern now that the gig is up. No sense in being stealthy when the enemy knows they're around.

The search means Keigo figures out this place is *way* bigger than he expected. The first level is mapped out pretty quickly but then he finds out the second level is four times the size and has to head down himself to keep in range. There's plenty more things he really doesn't want to pay attention to since this is apparently a place where they stash mutilated enemies or experiments, he's not sure which. Whatever they are, Keigo really hopes they aren't actually human. The twisted bodies are grotesque and had to have been in ridiculous levels of pain before they died.

Kiddo *had* said this place doubled as some kind of lab but hadn't said much about the League's doctor. From the look in his eyes when he talked about him, Keigo's pretty sure he doesn't want to know more either.

Prisoner cages, he expects. Bodies, he expects. The smell, he expects. It's the fact that Midoriya Inko is entirely whole that he doesn't. She's sitting in the back of her cage with her knees hugged to her chest, rocking with a far away look on her face that Keigo recognizes. She's filthy with blood and grime but when he does a quick examination, he finds no wounds. No wounds at all. As if they'd restored her after what had to be some intense torture over the last few days considering the look on her face. Healing quirks are rare but that doesn't mean a villain can't get their hands on one.

"Can you walk?" he asks even though she hadn't responded to him introducing himself and he isn't surprised when her only answer is more tears. Keigo gets up, using more feathers than he has to to lift and cradle her in the air. She lets herself hang in them like a worn out child, big eyes that look so much like Kiddo's staring at him with a vacancy his have never had.

Keigo doesn't bother telling her to stay quiet as he starts leading out to the stairs because she's barely making a sound anyway past the little hitches of her quiet sobs. He can hear thumps and rattling from a fight and is comforted to know that probably Kiddo is still alive. If Edgeshot did his job right, Kurogiri didn't even know what hit him. Would Edgeshot help Kiddo after that or just wait to see if Shigaraki takes him out for them? Though… Keigo's pretty sure Edgeshot isn't quite as willing to let that happen as he would be.

Just because Keigo is a hero doesn't mean he thinks every villain life is worth saving. He does it because there are rules and he doesn't *like* letting people die, but… There's a reason he's a good spy, that the HPSC trusts him to do what's necessary. He knows how to deal with the darker parts of the job. Kiddo is a highly intelligent villain with dangerous levels of personal knowledge of current heroes and villains and a willingness to do anything to accomplish his goals. Traits like that Keigo can respect, but if the HPSC decides he needs to be put down for the greater good? Keigo will do what he has to.

He probably won't sleep for months after, but he'll still do it.

The sounds of battle are farther off as Keigo works through the lab with Midoriya Inko in tow and he's honestly surprised not to find Edgeshot waiting for him once he gets outside the building. Instead, it's one of Kiddo's crew. The loud one, Twice.

"Oh! So she's still alive," Twice says cheerfully before immediately turning it around with, "Time to finish the job."

"Here," Keigo says, shoving the woman towards Twice who barely manages to catch her in an awkward hold. "Get her back to Kiddo's base. I don't have to tell you what he'd do to you if his mom doesn't get there safely."

Twice gives the half comatose woman an odd look. "Should we go kidnap Recovery Girl again?"

"You know, maybe just ask her nicely and kidnap her if she says no?" Keigo replies, mostly because he's hoping it'll give Recovery Girl the chance to kick Twice's ass first.

"What? No- That's a *great* idea!"

Rescue locked in, Keigo makes a quick call to the police and then turns back to the lab. He might as well make sure Edgeshot's okay and has Kurogiri in the bag. Moving through the shelves and weird architecture (seriously, what is it with villains and creating nigh unnavigable bases?), he keeps track of the crashes and thumps of Kiddo's fight with Shigaraki, sometimes catching a word here or there when Shigaraki gets upset, but his senses are tuned in for other things. His searching feathers finally pick up breath and Keigo jets that way.

Edgeshot looks up, Kurogiri's limp body on his back as he heads for the exit. He doesn't seem relieved to see Keigo but that's not a surprise in the least. "Midoriya?"

"She's out," Keigo assures him and then starts maneuvering Kurogiri off Edgeshot and to his feathers.

"Any sign of other villains?" Edgeshot asks.

"No."

"Does that not seem strange to you?"

It does, is the thing. This place has to have some kind of strategic value. Kurogiri certainly does, rare as teleportation quirks are. But no goons, no low level mooks, no one to do all the boring shit or be cannon fodder. It makes his shoulders itch.

“Maybe the League’s just that good about time off,” he says and Edgeshot doesn’t even glare at him for the joke.

“Get him into custody,” Edgeshot says instead as he breaks off to go and save a villain’s life.

Keigo only has a little trouble taking Kurogiri out of the lab. Whatever Edgeshot did to him knocked him out cold and Keigo can’t risk leaving him to go help Kiddo. Twice is already gone with Midoriya Inko-

Wait a second.

Something doesn’t feel right-

That’s as far as he gets before a blast of concussive air knocks him away from Kurogiri’s unresponsive form and into the thick brick of the lab’s exterior.

Sensei is a *genius*. Tomura knew of course, but this quirk singing in his body really shows just how true it is. The ease with which his new blood twists and moves at his direction, the way he can effortlessly go from offense to defense with barely a thought. He doesn’t need good control over it to win this fight. Of *course* Sensei would give him something powerful that’s useful right from the start, before he’s even had time to learn how to make the most of it.

Sure, he’s been throwing up everytime he uses it and his gums ache fiercely, but that’s a small price to pay.

And of course Sensei would give him a quirk so well suited to his needs because Tomura is his *heir*, his *favorite*, and there is nothing this stupid bastard can do about it. Who cares how many other players Kiddo takes out of the game when Tomura is the best piece in Sensei’s hand?

And yet… Even without a quirk to put them on an even playing ground, all Tomura has managed to do is wing Kiddo a few times. The idiot dodges past another spike of too shiny red, light glinting off the metallic surface to light up his serious face.

“Stay still and die!” Tomura snarls at him but Kiddo refuses to play along like always. Stupid *brat*.

“It’s a good thing I don’t give a shit about you,” Kiddo says before ducking behind a half destroyed shelf as Tomura goes after him again, “because you’ll be dead in the next ten minutes without my help at this rate.”

“Shut up, shut up, *shut up!*”

How could anything get to him now? Tomura's body is alive with this power, burning up with it like a fire lit in his belly. It doesn't matter if it hurts, he's never felt better than this. All he has to do is catch this bastard and his day will be complete.

Kiddo comes over a pile of debris with his knife but has to dodge around another bloody spike. Tomura only realizes he'd thrown another knife on his escape when it thuds into his shoulder and he snarls as he tears it free.

"You son of a bitch!" He hates Kiddo *so much*.

His new blood is spattered all over the place and Tomura calls it all back at once at high speed. From somewhere, he hears Kiddo grunt and grins because that means he probably got him, doesn't it? Sensei said eventually he'll be able to sense things using the droplets but right now, sending them out like bullets seems to work well enough. They can't go through everything but bodies? Bodies seem to hurt well enough.

Tomura almost misses Kiddo coming at him from behind but with a wide sweep of his arm he sends metallic red in a deadly arch that Kiddo only half dodges. The brat goes flying back into more shelving and Tomura pursues. He doesn't have the control to capture Kiddo with his new quirk but why use his quirk when his own hands are still functional?

Grabbing Kiddo's hand, he slams it back against the shelf hard enough to knock the knife free, other hand going to snatch his throat. And oh, that feels so *good*, squeezing hard enough to hear Kiddo wheeze.

"Nothing has been right since you showed up," Tomura growls out and wishes, oh he wishes he could still turn the things he hates into dust. What he wouldn't give to watch Kiddo fade away. "All you do is get in the way and buzz around like an annoying insect."

Kiddo has the gall to grin at him, weak as it is while he's trying to breathe around Tomura's hand, his own curling around Tomrua's wrist to dig his nails into it, but Tomura's not letting go. Not now that he finally caught his prey.

"You take my pieces, kill the rest, ruin my plans… well now it's time for me to ruin *yours*." Leaning in close, Tomura whispers, "Do you know how we *broke her?*"

There, *finally*, Tomura sees despair in Kiddo's gaze. His body stills, his struggling pauses, and he just stares at Tomura, showing how he's *won*. Tomura can only smile back at him.

"Sensei healed her over and over just so we could tear her apart," he purrs out. "She didn't even scream the last time. Your friends might save her body, but know this: the mother you knew is gone and she'll never come back-"

Kiddo tears his hand from Tomura's wrist and slaps him awkwardly across the face. Snarling, Tomura slams his head back into the shelf again hard.

"She tried to have faith in you at first," he says. "Can you imagine? Trying to convince yourself that your quirkless son might be able to save you? But she was lying to herself and

knew it. Amazing what some people will do. We broke her of that quickly. She even admitted to telling you you'd never be a hero."

Tomura slams him again into the tough, metal shelving. "How could she say that to you and then think you might be able to save her anyway? Some people-"

Sharp pain in his belly. Tomura shudders and for a moment wildly wonders just how many *fucking knives* Kiddo has on him before Kiddo uses his shock to break out of his hold. He barrels into Tomura, knocking him onto the ground. Around them, drops of Tomura's blood surge but Kiddo doesn't give him time to regroup. He half pins Tomura to the floor, one hand grabbing a handful of his hair to drag his head forward. Tomura sees a glint of metal and isn't fast enough to stop Kiddo from slitting his throat.

There's only one thing Tomura can do. His blood is flowing freely and he lets it act as it will. His last seconds of thought are filled with shiny red spikes and the hissed sound of his enemy's pain.

Shinya's been doing this for a while. That doesn't mean coming across a gruesome tableau like this is any easier. He can tell Shigaraki's nearly gone with just a glance, but there's still a shudder of life in him. Just not enough to endanger Shinya. As for Kiddo… He's not sure how long he'll last, either. Shinya doesn't move him from the multiple spikes wedged into his torso yet. Who knows what they might have pierced, what damage he might do trying to free him.

"Don't touch-" Kiddo chokes out. He can't quite lift his head but Shinya kneels down to meet his eyes. "Don't touch… his blood. Wash your clothes… thoroughly. Mercury…"

Mercury? Shinja frowns, noticing the metallic sheen of the spikes he'd taken for some kind of blood quirk, much like Vlad King. Similar, it seemed, but with a wicked twist. What that must have felt like for a body not meant to have the quirk… And worrying about Shinya making skin contact with Shigaraki's laced blood instead of his own internal contamination? Another strange detail to the pile .

Shigaraki gurgles, opening his mouth like he means to speak, but then stills under Kiddo. The spikes start losing their form almost immediately and Shinya has to grab Kiddo's shoulders to keep him from toppling over. There's nothing he can use as a field wrap here and he probably wouldn't trust it if he found anything in the first place.

"I'll wash it later," Shinya says as he loops Kiddo's arm over his shoulders and gets him on his feet. Kiddo's short, the angle is awkward, but he lets Shinya half drag him towards the exit. Surely the police have arrived by now and have an ambulance waiting, maybe even someone with a healing quirk.

But even before they get to the outer doors, Shinya's honed senses are screaming at him that something is wrong. It's too quiet. Where are the sounds of officers waiting outside? He sets Kiddo down against the wall just to the side of the door- or at least he tries to.

“No,” Kiddo says, his eyes glassy and not quite tracking right. “Take me… take me with you.”

“I need to verify that it’s safe-”

“It’s not. He’s here.”

He?

Kiddo refuses to let go and even though his grip is weakening from blood loss and exhaustion and poisoning, he’s resolute.

“You need to… take me with you.” And then the boy has the audacity to smile at Shinya like there’s anything about this situation to smile about. “I want you to live… so you need me there. To distract him.”

The very idea burns hot and terrible in Shinya’s chest. “I’m not using you as bait.”

“He doesn’t care… about you. He wants *me.*”

“All the more reason for him not to get you.”

Kiddo laughs, wet and congested and Shinya doesn’t want to know how messed up his insides must be right now. If he doesn’t get this kid to the hospital quickly, chances are he won’t make it.

“Are you dumb? This is… this is what I’ve been working toward,” Kiddo says and tightens his grip when Shinya moves to try and leave him against the wall again, refusing to let go. “He needs… needs to see me like this.”

Kiddo had *planned* this?! Surely not getting himself injured to this degree. Surely the boy isn’t that insane, whoever this mysterious ‘he’ is. But there’s no wavering in Kiddo’s expression as he awkwardly goes for one of his pockets and pulls out a small red cylinder. He presses it into Shinya’s free hand.

“When he’s distracted… when he’s gloating,” Kiddo says. “Aim it right at the base… of his neck. Into his spinal cord. Smash it hard. That… that’ll give the quickest delivery.”

It takes a moment for Shinya to realize what this is and what Kiddo’s asking him to do. He stares at the quirk destroying bullet, the outer casing removed. The needle is small, the delivery mechanism smaller.

“Who is he?” Shinya asks. Just because a villain is doing wrong doesn’t mean he has the right to take their quirk forever.

“Don’t worry. It won’t… It’s just to make it easier for me.” Sagging against him, Kiddo closes his eyes, taking a few deeper, troubled breaths as he holds on through what can only be excruciating pain. “You’re not taking anything… that he hasn’t already stolen.”

Stolen- Shinya goes very, very still. Oh. To say he's not afraid would be a lie, but at the same time… If the enemy outside the lab is who Kiddo thinks it is, this might be a chance to rid the world of the king of the underground for good. How much safer would everyone be after?

But using a critically injured, quirkless sixteen year old boy as bait? Not even a hero student or intern but a civilian? Shinya knows his morals can't take that.

"No," he says. "I won't do it."

"Come on, Hero," Kiddo says with another smile. "I'm a *villain*. I've killed… so many more people than you can imagine. I'm… going to keep killing people. I'm even planning on… killing one of the top ten heroes later. I'm not someone… you need to be protecting."

The fact is, none of that matters nearly as much as it should in this moment. When Shinya was young, one of his teachers said that heroism is in the small moments where it would be so much easier to back down. This feels like one of those and he's not even sure it's *his* moment.

"I can threaten your family… if that's easier," Kiddo says and no. It doesn't make it easier at all because Shinya's suddenly entirely sure that Kiddo never would.

"You don't get to decide who I choose to protect."

And the boy stares at him, not quite surprised so much as just *moved*. His eyes go wet and his smile wavers. "See, this is why you're a hero and I'm not."

Using the wall as leverage, Kiddo shoves Shinya back from him and then half slumps against it as he pants for breath. He lifts his head and starts resolutely moving towards the door.

"You'll do anything to save anyone," Kiddo says, "and I'll do anything to save *one*."

He'd probably have to knock Kiddo unconscious to keep him there and while Shinya considers it, knows he could make it quick and not leave lasting damage, he doesn't. The resolute determination filling Kiddo's entire body stays his hand. When Kiddo reaches the doorway, he forces himself to stand as steady as he can and looks out without fear.

"Oh," says a deep voice from outside. "There you are."

Kiddo glares out and drops one hand down, tilted to let his thigh shield it from view as he runs through a few quick hero hand signs. Shinya gets the message immediately and silently moves into a better position. He will find his opening.

"I think there's enough left of Tomura to make a nomu out of," Kiddo says without moving from the doorway. His shaking grip on the doorframe is the only reason he's standing. "If you give a shit about that."

Higher up in the building, Shinya gets a good vantage point to see the scene beyond. No sign of Midoriya Inko but he sees Hawks in a crumpled pile against one of the other buildings, unmoving with feathers scattered around him. Shinya can't get a good enough look to tell if he's alive. Kurogiri's still unconscious near the entrance to the lab. And several paces out

from it is a man in a suit and helmet. Even having not seen him in years, there's no mistaking All For One from his sheer aura.

"I hope you've had fun meddling in my affairs," All For One says with a bit of a smile, "because I think I'm finished with you."

"Yeah, kind of hard to get the squishy emotional sort of revenge on All Might when you can't use Shimura Nana's grandson against him, huh?" Kiddo says. Shinya recognizes Shimura Nana's name vaguely but he'll have to look into it later. When he's not watching a villain standoff. "I mean, that's the kind of poetic justice any writer would cream over."

All For One starts walking towards the building and Kiddo stands as firm as he can. Shinya grips the bullet in his hand and *waits.*

Chapter End Notes

I refuse to confirm or deny Hawks' survival.

Also why do I keep having so many fight scenes. I hate writing fight scenes, I would MUCH rather just do squishy emotional things.

Chapter 17

Chapter Notes

There is vomiting in this chapter, btw.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Usually, it's quite gratifying to see his enemies pathetic and brought low before him. Izuku's body trembles with the effort to stay standing, running on fumes and sheer willpower. His breathing is harsh and loud, hitching as blood chokes his airway in turns. While it's a pity to lose such a useful piece as Tomura, at least he did a good amount of damage on the way down.

Looking at Izuku's face like this brings out every little familiar thing All For One would expect to find there. The coloring, the wide eyes, the curve of his jaw, Inko written in nearly every inch of him. What a shame Izuku didn't inherit her restraint and pliability.

"Did you really think I wouldn't recognize you?" All For One asks as he continues to approach the boy.

"No. I knew you wouldn't." Cheeky brat. "You recognized my mom… after a while."

"I admit, it took me a little longer than prudent to put the pieces together," he says in an absent tone. "To think one of my cast offs would come back to cause this much trouble…"

Izuku's lips twist into a grimace that almost manages to be a smile, despite how tight he's gritting his jaw. His hands are white knuckled on the door frame, face so pale and his freckles standing out in stark relief. In this moment, he looks so much like Yoichi that All For One almost wants to spare him.

It has been a futile experiment, family. All For One has tried it several times, charming some woman long enough to beget a child only for the inevitable disappointment when that child turns out to be useless to him. He's tried giving a few of them quirks, but they never amount to anything interesting. There were dozens of attempts. All For One thinks Izuku is his only living child currently. He might have missed others, forgotten once they lost his interest, but Izuku is different. Izuku has *power*.

"Well, one of us… had to. Statistically speaking." A shiver runs through the boy and he wavers as his gaze goes glassy for a moment. Then he's back and holding onto the door frame tighter. "Can you hurry up? I might as well… start this loop over again if you're just… gonna kill me anyway. Since you didn't… make the first mistake."

"Oh?" All For One *has* been wondering about that little detail in the police reports his mole got him. *Subject believes he's living in a time loop. Likely to be more reckless as he thinks he*

will have another chance. “And what mistake would that have been?”

“Giving Tomura anything other… than mercury blood,” Izuku says, his body starting to lean forward again before he catches himself. “He must have gotten caught on me… being his rival. Instead of All Might.”

Not untrue but the correlation Izuku makes is interesting. “Then if that was not a mistake on my part, I suppose that means this loop is a wash for you?”

“Not necessarily. There’s… still two more you can make.” And then Izuku loses the battle to stay standing and ends up on his knees, barely catching the ground with his hands before he’s wretching. Dark red twists within clear bile. Ah, this conversation won’t last nearly long enough at this rate. The boy doesn’t manage to lift his head after, shaking as he holds himself up.

“Three chances then? How lovely.” All For One stops well within grabbing distance, but he doubts Izuku has the strength to move at all, much less go for an attack. Kneeling, All For One reaches out to grab a handful of dark curls and pull his head up. “Let’s get a look at this fascinating quirk of yours-”

Except there isn’t one. Like all the others, there’s nothing for him to take. All For One stills in stunned disappointment.

“Why does no one believe me… when I say I’m quirkless?” Izuku says with a wet laugh. His arms give out and his body sags, only All For One’s tight hold on his hair keeping him upright in the least.

“Another failure then,” All For One says and wants to be angry that even this boy who has been such an effective nuisance is as useless as the rest but can’t quite pull himself from his disappointment yet.

“You will never have… a quirked child,” Izuku confirms and his eyes are growing more hazy as the blood loss gets to him. “Your genes are… damaged.”

Something All For One is well aware of, but he’d hoped that one or another regeneration quirk he’d managed to find over the years might have fixed that. That perhaps the slowly changing human genome over successive generations might be strong enough to overcome his genetic shortcomings. Might allow him to have a true heir. All for naught then, this breeding experiment of his. He’d gotten tired of the parenting game long before now anyway and hadn’t even considered starting another family after his near defeat six years ago ruined his face.

“Then you’re simply mad, I suppose,” he mutters to himself and there’s no answer. The boy still breathes but it’s shallow, barely audible. Time’s up.

All For One doesn’t think much of it, pulling at one of his lesser used quirks. He doesn’t heal Izuku entirely and instead merely patches up the damage enough to keep him alive a while longer. Not useful, not dangerous, just not actively dying. It takes little effort and then Izuku’s sucking in a full breath again as his eyes flutter.

“Cut it kind of close,” Izuku says after several breaths and All For One shouldn’t be surprised to hear sass after the boy nearly died in front of him.

“You can die on your own time when I’m finished with you.”

Izuku laughs and coughs up a wad of blood that he spits right into All For One’s chest. *Brat*. There will be no getting that out of his button up or the tie.

“Second mistake,” Izuku says with a grin. Which action? Healing him or continuing the conversation?

“Tell me, will I make the third?”

“I don’t know if you have yet.”

A decision he hasn’t made yet or a past action Izuku hasn’t confirmed, perhaps. All For One has always liked puzzles, but this one has gone on plenty long enough. He lets go and Izuku is able to keep himself sitting up, barely. Still weak, he hadn’t replenished much of the lost blood and his repair of internal organs was a hack job at best. All he’d done was buy Izuku a little more time.

“If you aren’t in possession of this time looping quirk, who used it on you?” he asks despite being sure he won’t get an answer that makes any sense. He’s not even positive it’s *real*.

“Her name is Kazuko,” Izuku says almost immediately, looking utterly guileless in a way All For One doesn’t trust. “But she hasn’t been born yet so you can’t steal her quirk.”

All For One wishes he could still roll his eyes as he gets up to his feet and tries to decide whether or not there’s any use in keeping Izuku any longer. He already has Twice to flush out those loyal to Kiddo, he doesn’t necessarily need the boy alive for that except perhaps as bait. Izuku isn’t likely to let himself be knowingly used in a way that furthers All For One’s goals.

A girl from the future putting Izuku into a time loop. Ridiculous. Perhaps the disappointment of quirklessness and an absent father was enough to convince Izuku he needed something else to make him feel special. At least he’d grown out of his ridiculous hero phase. The longer All For One looks at him, the more he remembers from the couple years he played a dutiful husband and father before news of Izuku’s quirklessness was confirmed. It hadn’t been all terrible, but he’s watched dozens of toddlers grow into children over his lifetime. What use is it to care more about *this* boy’s childhood than any of the rest?

Perhaps it’s fortunate he doesn’t have the face Inko was familiar with anymore. He doubts torturing her would have been any more satisfying if she’d known. Baiting Kiddo isn’t any more fun with Izuku knowing who he is, after all. Oh well. The boy could at least lend himself to be the base of a new nomu in return for the healing-

“Oh,” Izuku says abruptly and then laughs. “You *did* make the third mistake.”

What? He hasn’t sensed any sort of change in the area but Izuku seems sure. “What are you babbling about now?”

“See, if you don’t make any of the three mistakes, then I definitely die when we meet like this,” Izuku says with a dazzling smile on his face that makes Yoichi beam out from him so brightly All For One barely manages to hear the next words at first. “If you make all three, then you die here.”

“I’ve only made two, according to your cryptic count.”

“That means we both live through this and I have to kill you later.”

The utter *cheek*. It reminds him of Yoichi in the worst ways, in ways *none* of his other children ever did, and All For One almost obliterates the boy entirely for his utter gall right *then*-

The decision is taken out of his hands when he has to dodge out of the path of razor sharp feathers and realizes he hadn’t killed Hawks like he thought. A mistake indeed.

The thing is, Jin has a mission and a master to report to. He hadn’t had any doubts about this weeks ago when he was handed the undercover mission. He shouldn’t now, either.

Kiddo resembles his mother a lot. Enough that it’s hard to see anything on Kiddo that doesn’t come from her other than the curls and freckles. Right now, with her far away expression and teary eyes, all Jin can see is Kiddo and it’s…

He wouldn’t say they’re friends but Kiddo has been good to him. No real threats with actual substance to them, no jeering remarks past light teasing, not even any particular amount of suspicion. Sometimes Kiddo smiles at him when he’s including Jin in on a joke, when he’s welcoming Jin into the group conversations, when he’s letting Jin try to be *part of his crew.* Jin’s pretty sure Kiddo suspects he’s a spy but is equally sure Kiddo has decided it doesn’t matter and he’s not sure how to feel about that. Being trusted with his *mother*, who Jin *knows* is vitally important to him, feels… It’s…

He’s uncomfortable. This isn’t how being a spy is supposed to be (of course it is, this means he’s doing it right.)

If he follows the plan, Jin takes Midoriya Inko to the vault All For One set up to house her for a life of torture until he gets tired of it and makes her into a nomu. If he follows the plan, the Inko-nomu will be a crowning jewel of pain and misery to heap upon someone who’s been nothing but a nuisance to the man Jin pledged his loyalty to. It should be easy to just do the job. Jin doesn’t care about Midoriya Inko for real, it’s just a side effect of his affection for Kiddo that is totally not real, it’s just a con, and he is going to do this *right* for once-

He feels his phone buzz in his pocket and pauses in his pacing in the alley to check it. It’s a message from Himiko and he freezes as a video starts to play. The tiny kitchenette in the old employee break room is immediately recognizable, as is Dabi standing in front of the dented microwave someone had brought in a week ago. There’s smoke rising from the thing and Jin can’t understand what Dabi’s muttering but it sounds distinctly unhappy and just *done*. Then he’s lifting his blue filled hand, there’s screaming, and the camera shakes violently before the video clip ends.

She sent him a picture, too. The breakroom is a blackened mess with globs of white all over it, Spinner's holding a fire extinguisher and crying, Dabi looks satisfied. She sends a string of laughing-crying emojis last.

Jin stares at the picture and then looks at Midoriya Inko. If he hands her over, he'll lose this and probably Kiddo will torture and murder him. If he doesn't, All For One will track him down and definitely torture and murder him. He looks back to his phone.

It's been a long time since he felt like he had friends.

This isn't a fight Keigo expects to survive. He realizes this after losing his second volly of feathers as the king of the underworld unleashes some truly overwhelming quirks. Keigo can't identify them for more than their most obvious effects, doesn't have time to try. His thoughts are only about making it to the next minute, the next second, the next action he can take to save a teenage boy who's too stupid not to be afraid for his fucking life-

He hadn't expected to *like* Kiddo, is the thing. When the HPSC handed down his marching orders, he figured he'd tolerate the young villain at best. Keigo's always been good at getting along with just about anyone, especially people who don't want to, but Kiddo made it easy. Kiddo treated him well, didn't have a problem accepting some levity into his life, and smiled like a war veteran trying his best not to bring anyone else down. He makes it easy to be loyal to him.

Which brings Keigo to his current situation. There's no predicting what All For One will pull out of his ass with so many quirks on offer (fucking *unassisted flight*) so Keigo can't make any solid plans past trying to lead him away from the lab and holding his attention until the backup surely Edgeshot had sent for arrives. With the joint operation on the nomu storage facility also underway, he doesn't know how long it'll take.

Not trying to defeat him frees Keigo up to just work on staying alive as he annoys arguably the most dangerous man on the planet. He can't make too many big moves, can't waste too many feathers, and he can tell All For One is getting tired of the interruption of his reunion with his *son.*

Yeah. That's one Keigo's gonna have to think about later. You know, if he survives this.

Keigo barely manages to dodge past a blast of superheated water and hisses as he feels the singed edges of several feathers. He's losing maneuverability as he loses feathers but doesn't have time to think about it as a nearby building suddenly crumbles in a fast moving radial pattern where All For One touches, the top half of it starting to fall towards Keigo. Dodge, duck through a window, out another, send another few precise shots that miss or are deflected, dodge-

He'd forgotten Edgeshot entirely until something long and thin slams into the back of All For One's neck at speed, right under the lip of his mask. Abruptly, the villain drops out of the air like a stone and lands hard enough to crack the concrete. Edgeshot unfolds himself a good distance away from the villain and Keigo lands beside him.

“What the heck was that?” he asks.

“Quirk destroying bullet from Kiddo,” Edgeshot replies without taking his eyes off the still figure in the impact crater. Had the drop killed him after Edgeshot destroyed his quirk? That seems too easy.

“Think it actually worked?”

“Kiddo didn’t think it would put him down for good, just that it would ‘make it easier’ for him.”

Easier to *what,* is the question. Capture? Not likely. Kill? Definitely more Kiddo’s MO. But the kid isn’t in any condition to wage war against a foe like All For One. Or, frankly, anyone else. Keigo spots him struggling to catch up with them, stumbling along with what looks like a rod of rebar he’d fished out of some rubble from the fight so far. He’ll give the kid this: Kiddo doesn’t seem to know what the word quit means.

“Just what does it take to put that kid down?” Keigo mutters to himself but Edgeshot moves from his side to get a closer look at the downed villain. His body is intact and Keigo doesn’t see anything in the way of blood spatter which is honestly kind of creepy. That had to have been a three or four story fall, he should be at least a little splattered, but the fact that he isn’t makes him look like a really weird life sized doll instead of a corpse. Keigo creeps forward to watch Edgeshot’s back.

Lifting an arm, Edgeshot folds it thin and makes a strike to the still form of All For One only for one of the villain’s hands to shoot out and catch the end. Edgeshot jerks back but not fast enough to avoid a surge of electricity that travels up his arm, strong enough to spark brilliantly in the low evening light and make him begin to seize.

“He’s *mine!*” Kiddo snarls out and for some reason, that seems to give All For One pause. He lets go and Edgeshot collapses, barely giving enough time for Keigo to catch him and lower him to the ground so he doesn’t brain himself on the way down. Unconscious, still breathing but his heartbeat seems all wrong and there are trembles rolling through his whole body as his muscles contract at random. *Shit*.

All For One sits up, reaching back to dusk off the remains of the bullet Edgeshot had used. He gets to his feet easily for a guy who should at least have a couple broken bones, then says, “Do you have any idea how rare levitation quirks are? It took me ages to get that one.”

“Oh boohoo, I’m sure the person you stole it from is so broken up about it not existing anymore,” Kiddo says as he leans on his makeshift walking stick. “So how many quirks did that take out? I need to know for science.”

“Enough of them.” All For One apparently doesn’t see Kiddo as any kind of threat because he turns to regard Keigo standing protectively in front of Edgeshot, just waiting to see what might happen next. He’s tired, unsure how long he’ll last in an all out fight, but it sounds like at least the bastard would be *grounded* this time.

“He’s mine, too,” Kiddo says which… Huh.

“Why do I care who you’ve decided to get possessive about? That just makes them a better target to take out before you can regroup and bother me more.”

Kiddo snorts and looks past the other villain. “Hawks! Backup on the way?”

“Yep,” Keigo says even though he doesn’t actually know.

“See? So how about you just scram and I’ll come kill you later.”

All For One pauses as if thinking it over a moment. “Or, I could kill the three of you now and *then* leave.”

“You can *try*.” And Keigo doesn’t like the challenging undertone in Kiddo’s voice, nor the glimmer of actual heat in his gaze. He suddenly has no doubt Kiddo *would* try to make a last charge, no matter what state his body is in. Does he even *feel* pain?!

All for One takes a step towards the boy and Keigo reacts without thinking, a mass of feathers building up a wall of thorny defense in front of Kiddo that’s definitely more of a deterrent than an actual threat, but it still makes the villain stop. Even Kiddo seems surprised by it, blinking wide eyes before shooting Keigo a look he can’t quite read.

“What the hell are you doing?” Kiddo asks. “I’m a *villain*, you don’t have to protect me.”

That… Keigo doesn’t drop his guard and instead readies himself to fight for this brat. “Maybe I’m just trying to earn points with the villain organization I successfully infiltrated.”

“Now that *is* a useful quirk,” All For One says and Keigo’s entire body tightens as Kiddo leans more heavily on his rebar.

“Touch him and I’ll tear your fucking hands off.” Kiddo resolutely starts forward, pushing aside a few of Keigo’s feathers on his way. “You want a toy? I’m right here, old man.”

“You’ve got nothing useful-”

“I’ve got a quirkless body you can stuff whatever fucking quirks you want into. I know it’s easier making a powerful nomu when the canvas is blank.”

Hearing the kid offer himself up like some kind of sacrifice just doesn’t sit well with Keigo because he knows Kiddo would go through with it. That same self-sacrificial streak he’s heard the crew complain about. Keigo’s not sure if Kiddo thinks he’s got nothing else to offer or he just wants to die that much.

“I know it’s easier when the body’s willing, too,” Kiddo adds and that gets All For One’s attention.

“If this is a ruse to distract me-”

“What? No, never. You’re *much* too clever to fall for that.”

All For One snorts with amusement but the tension in the air isn't going down at all. It's like standing at the edge of a drop off, just waiting to be pushed. One second, everything is still. The next, All For One's got a hand tightly gripping Kiddo's shoulder as a mucky substance spreads out from it and the boy *screams*-

Fire erupts hot and sudden between them and it's just enough of a distraction that All For One lets go and Keigo's able to use the few feathers that survive the attack to wrench Kiddo back to safety. Or relative safety, that is. Dragging Edgeshot into his arms, Keigo books it out of the immediate radius as Endeavor swoops in to engage All For One. There are three other heroes but Keigo doesn't bother checking who. He touches down at Kiddo's side and drops Edgeshot beside him as he takes in the damage.

Whatever that quirk was, the ooze has already eaten through Kiddo's clothes and a good amount of skin and muscle to leave his shoulder a truly gruesome sight. How much of it might get healed later, Keigo has no idea. He might lose the arm. He might lose a *lung* at the rate that shit is spreading down his chest. Keigo drags off his jacket and sacrifices it to try and get some of the muck off the kid before it dissolves more of him. Kiddo screams and shudders under the onslaught until he finally passes out from the shock.

Oh. Or maybe he's just stopped breathing entirely.

The sounds of battle behind him are far away and negligible as Keigo feels for a heartbeat and can't find it.

Training kicks in and Keigo straightens Kiddo out on his back. No obstructions to the airways that he can find so he starts CPR, feels Kiddo's ribcage give under every push of his hands. The already weakened body refuses to respond but Keigo won't stop. He's not losing Kiddo, not here. Not after watching him time and time again put himself in harm's way to keep a supervillain's attention off others, determined enough to protect that he'd kill for it.

Someone calls his name but Keigo doesn't let them disrupt his rhythm. Twenty-eight, twenty-nine, thirty. Rescue breaths, back to compressions. He goes through another rotation before someone grabs him by the shoulders and jolts him partially out of focus.

"Medics," X-Less says, somehow knowing that Keigo won't leave the kid for less. He lets himself be pulled aside as the medical team descends. They'd already packed Edgeshot up on a stretcher and Keigo watches them wheel him away a moment before looking back to the group around Kiddo. He sees the shine of someone's quirk in use but can't see around the paramedics well enough to know if anything's helping.

"-and All For One got away-"

Keigo snaps out of it entirely and all sound around him swoops back in at once. He doesn't let himself startle, instead looks over to where a group of heroes are talking. Endeavor has his own set of paramedics trying to get him to sit down by the remaining ambulance as the other carts Edgeshot off for more care. From this distance, Keigo spots a good amount of damage to Endeavor's uniform, splashes of blood harder to make out. Seems he's got some kind of head wound, maybe got himself knocked out. Without his firepower, it would have been difficult to keep All For One corralled long.

So. They're back to square one on that front.

"Hawks! A word," says one of the police officers on the scene- oh, Tsukauchi. That'll make things easier. The man understands exactly how to work with heroes, especially ones that might still be in a battle high. Which… Keigo probably is, now that he thinks about it.

"Sure, go ahead."

He answers some questions then details everything that happened, admits to a several minutes long period of unconsciousness after removing Kurogiri from the building, recites as close to word for word the conversation he'd overheard-

"Wait," Tsukauchi says, eyes wider as he stares at Keigo. "Did you just say- Is All For One Kiddo's *father?*"

"Apparently. They don't get along."

Tsukauchi starts to say something and then closes his mouth, staring ahead for a few seconds before he shakes himself and mutters, "Later."

Keigo gives the rest of his statement and someone runs up to Tsukauchi to report on Shigaraki Tomura's positively ID'd body within the lab. Then the cops are distracted with other things and Keigo looks back to the clump of paramedics around Kiddo. They've gotten him on a stretcher and are getting ready to move him. Something in Keigo unclenches as he recognizes from the paramedics' focused body language that the kid has to still be alive. They're not gearing up to transport a body.

Well there's his single win for this disaster of a day.

Chapter End Notes

I'm on the fence over whether to add the Dad For One tag or keep it a secret for later readers...

Chapter 18

Chapter Notes

References to suicide in this chapter.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

This is the last time Toshinori leaves Japan until All For One is captured or dead. No more getting led around by the nose, no more prioritizing other things, no more letting his feelings get in the way of what he knows he needs to do. He swears that on the unconscious boy they have locked in an isolation suite right in the heart of UA because they can't trust he'd be secure anywhere else except *Tartarus*, and most of them don't want him there.

It's been two days since the encounter with All For One that Toshinori should have been here for. Toshinori got back to UA late last night.

"Will he wake?" Toshinori asks when the door opens, not looking away from the small window into the suite.

"I'm hopeful," Chiyo says as she closes the door behind her. "His brain activity has steadily risen over the last twenty-four hours and his body's responding well to treatment. Once he's strong enough for me to use my quirk, things will progress very quickly."

Maybe Toshinori should feel better that they'd already taken Midoriya off the ventilator by the time he got there. He still has a cannula in place for additional oxygen, but he's breathing on his own. Now, they just have to wait to see if there's any brain damage.

"His mother?"

"She's been settled into a short term care facility for observation."

From what he'd been told, Midoriya Inko was found sitting in front of UA a few hours after the lab raid. She'd been conscious but hadn't responded to any questions. They aren't sure if it's trauma or some kind of quirk effect.

Something sends an alert on the tablet Chiyo's holding and she looks over it quickly before some of the tension in her shoulders bleeds out. "Good news. It looks like he's slipped into actual sleep. I'm getting REM levels of activity."

Dreaming, that *is* encouraging, but it does little to help with the guilt that feels like it's going to overwhelm Toshinori. He should have known Midoriya was trying to get him out of the way for something big. He should have known it was something that demanded All Might's power. Instead, several heroes had been injured and Midoriya himself had nearly died.

Whatever good the boy thinks he's doing, All Might is finished letting himself be led so easily.

David's problem was legitimate. That doesn't let Toshinori off the hook.

It's nearly lunch before he can drag himself away from the window and go to the teacher's office. There's plenty of work that's built up in his absence. Toshinori spends the rest of the day on it. He won't be teaching any classes until Monday so he has time to go over reports from his substitute, get the right permissions for his planned lessons, ponder the repeated comments on the problem of just how little Todoroki Shoto and Bakugou Katsuki in class 1-A seem willing to bury the hatchet.

And of course, seeing Bakugou's name just makes him think about Midoriya again. Toshinori sighs and rubs at his tired eyes. He hasn't slept and it's weighing heavily on him along with everything else. All he can do is get through this day, crash for a few hours, and then get back into his routine.

When the end of the day comes and the students are off to their dorms or homes, Toshinori finds his feet taking him right back to the medical wing instead of his own home. He'd sigh at his own ridiculousness but that'd take too much effort.

Chiyo meets him at the door. "He's awake and aware. Aizawa just went in to talk with him."

Grateful for the warning, Toshinori psyches himself up for the worst and goes in. Aizawa glances up as he enters but turns his attention quickly back to the boy on the bed. Midoriya's pale but his eyes are bright and he recognizes them. All good signs against brain damage from his near death experience. A display screen on the wall shows his heart rate, blood oxygen levels, and other things, all stable. His body is definitely strained in the healing process, but over all he seems to be doing well for the circumstances.

"Lucky me," Midoriya says in a tired tone that does little to soothe Toshinori's guilt. "Interrogated by two pros? I must be important. Is Hawks coming next? I need him to pass a message to my crew."

"How about you slow the hell down and just let yourself heal before you start into your next scheme?" Aizawa grumbles back at him, hands stuffed in his pockets as he glares at the kid who has the gall to grin at him.

"I know our first priority should be getting some answers, but we must get one thing straight," Toshinori says to redirect the snark-off that's sure to start if he doesn't head it off now. "You must stop trying to protect me, Young Midoriya."

Something about that hits a lot deeper than he meant, Toshinori can see it in the tightening muscle of Midoriya's jaw.

"I can't just-"

"You can and you *will*." On this, Toshinori isn't willing to budge. "I won't let you distract me from my duty any longer even if you think it's for my own good. It is not your job to keep me

safe-"

"It is if I'm the only one who knows what's coming!" Midoriya snarls back with sudden fire, more than Toshinori's seen from him before. "If I'm the only one who *can!"*

"Then you will tell me where this danger is and *I* will decide how to handle it."

Midoriya glares at him harder. "You never choose the ways that will actually keep you safe."

"He has a point," Aizawa says blandly, which *isn't helping*.

"That is still my decision to make," Toshinori says without acknowledging Aizawa at all. "I am a pro hero, ranked number one. This comes with duties that I will not allow you to take from me, including the protection of my own life. You are not my keeper, Young Midoriya. You are not *responsible* for me."

The fracturing in Midoriya's gaze hurts to watch but Toshinori can't have this child putting himself and others in danger for his sake. What kind of hero could allow that?

"If you have information about future events, future dangers, please know I will listen," he says, his voice softening. "You've proven yourself credible time and time again. I have little doubt you will continue to do so."

Midoriya doesn't answer and Toshinori glances to Aizawa for any help. If they can just convince the boy to listen, to *trust* them…

"How far into the future is your information good for?" Aizawa asks, putting the matter to bed for now, and Midoriya sighs.

"About five months. Anything past April is a wash."

Oddly specific but something about it catches Aizawa's attention.

"Bakugou turns seventeen in April," he says and Toshinori doesn't understand. Aizawa steps closer to the bed and waits for Midoriya to actually look at him before asking, "What happens if you don't save him?"

"Why would that matter to me?"

At the deflection, Aizawa's eyes narrow. "What happens *to you* if you don't save him?"

Midoriya's face isn't blank, isn't cold, isn't empty. It's just tired, so deeply exhausted and heartsore that Toshinori hurts for him.

"Nothing," the boy says. "I just kill myself."

The words hang in the air, so simple and yet so horrific that Toshinori wishes he hadn't heard. Aizawa doesn't look surprised but Toshinori's sure he must be feeling a similar sense of helplessness in the face of that terrible admission.

“How many times-” Toshinori starts to ask before he can stop himself but no, it’s an awful thing to ask and he doesn’t actually want to know the answer. He can’t stand the idea of this boy being in such complete despair to end his life over and over. “Not again. You aren’t alone anymore.”

And finally Midoriya looks at him again. A soft, slow smile spreads over his face but it isn’t happy or relieved, there is no cheer, and it breaks Toshinori’s heart even worse. “You won’t be able to stop me. There’s no point in continuing a loop after Kacchan dies.”

“*Watch me*.”

Toshinori will do everything he has to to keep Bakugou alive. There has to be a way around the terrible future Midoriya believes is coming. Some way to save *both* of these boys. Surely, this is what heroes are for.

There is a wet sheen to Midoriya’s eyes, barely holding back tears, but the moment is passing. Soon enough, the boy’s determination returns.

“Call in Hawks,” he says. “I need him to pass on a message and get my notebooks.”

“If you think we’re going to let you scheme from your sick bed-” Aizawa starts with irritation.

“Only a little scheming. Dabi has permission to go kill his father if I’m laid up for too long and we’re going to need him if All Might’s determined to go after All For One again, so I need Hawks to tell him to stand down.”

The two pros share a glance. There’s so little information about the villain Dabi. Even his real name is a mystery. But Midoriya knows about his family, thinks his father will be helpful in the fight against All For One? Does that mean his father is a hero? Or simply a powerful villain with enough of a grudge against the king of the underworld to cooperate with them.

Whatever it turns out to be, they need to move. Toshinori steps away to make the call. It’s time to show their trust in Midoriya so that he can give them the same.

The moment All Might is out of sight, Midoriya stops trying to hide how much pain he’s in. He sinks back into the bed, closing his eyes a moment to just breathe through his clenched teeth. Some might think it’s kind, hiding that from All Might, but Shouta just rolls his eyes.

“Stop it,” he says. “You’re not supposed to protect him from his own guilt, either.”

“Reflex,” Midoriya replies quietly, none of the bratty undertone he’d had before. Amazing the difference it makes when he isn’t putting on a strong front.

“How long has it been since you bothered living past Bakugou’s death?” Shouta asks because he sees no point in sugar coating or hesitating. Not right now with so much on the line. He needs to know exactly how hard it’ll be to curb the kid’s actively suicidal tendencies.

Midoriya already has a distressing enough lack of concern about his own welfare without adding that on top, if this last stunt is anything to go by.

“I don’t know. I only do it when I have something to learn before starting the next loop, but turns out that doesn’t really matter so much after a while.”

“Because of your changes to the timeline?”

“Because it didn’t take that many loops to learn what I needed.”

Shouta moves to lean against the wall at the head of the bed, crossing his arms as he thinks about that. “How much do you remember from them all?”

“How much do you remember from being *five?*” Midoriya shoots back but after a moment of thought he answers honestly. “More from the most recent ones. Almost nothing from the first one. My brain’s still a normal human one, right? We’re not supposed to live this long.”

It makes sense. It makes Shouta wonder how much Midoriya remembers from before the age of fourteen, since the loops start then- and then he realizes just how seriously he’s taking all of this. How close he is to actually believing.

“There’s a few events I never forget, no matter how long it’s been,” Midorya goes on in a softer tone, his eyes locked on something across the room as horrors play behind them. “Trauma response, you know? Burns it into you. So there are things I can’t forget, no matter how much I want to. But the everyday stuff, it fades pretty quickly unless it’s reinforced. I mean, I’m pretty sure I can still recite whole sections of my history books since I spend so much time researching the rise of quirks, but I can’t tell you all the forms of the verb ‘to eat’ in English.”

It makes sense. More than having a perfect recall of all of them would. “How do you keep track of what you need to change, then?”

“My notebooks. I always wake up in the middle of the night and I write down everything I can remember from the last loop.” Closing his eyes, Midoriya sighs a little. “Then it’s just a matter of going over my mistakes and doing better. Building from what worked.”

Shouta frowns, taking it all in. The thing is, he’s fairly sure there’s more to that day than Midoriya is saying. More to what Midoriya experiences and feels.

“I don’t have to remember every action I’ve ever taken,” Midoriya continues, waving a hand idly. “I just have to build from the events I’ve found workable solutions for and go to the next. Work it until I know how to beat it and then the next.”

Why keep memories of timelines or events Midoriya gets in the habit of preventing? Shouta knows plenty of things he wishes he could have done differently, plenty of regrets he might have liked to prevent. But… The sheer monotony Midoriya must experience, forcing himself to go through the motions on each event…

“It sounds frustrating,” he says and Midoriya snorts. His mouth twists into a grimace that tries and fails to become a smile and Shouta knows abruptly that this is probably the thinnest Midoriya’s defenses have ever been around him. And then he sees it, the moment something in Midoriya just *snaps*.

“You want to know the worst part of all this?” the kid finally says, like it’s exploding out of him and he has no more control of the words. “It’s not having to teach myself how to fight again because my body doesn’t know how to do it yet. It’s not seeing my loved ones die over and over and *over* again no matter what I do. It’s not knowing intimately what it feels like to die in dozens of ways.”

Midoriya stops, his breathing unsteady and loud in Shouta’s ears, and then the kid’s face is awash with ugly, heavy tears.

“It’s that every time this starts, *I’m fourteen goddamn years old again!”* he almost screams out, his body trembling in the sheets as his hands curl into fists like he might be able to protect himself from all of this. “And it doesn’t matter how many times I go through it, it still takes for-fucking-*ever* before I can *stop crying!*”

Shouta’s not the type to fall for emotional displays like this. Especially not from a known manipulator, a villain who’s managed to talk his way into the hearts of some of the most dangerous people alive and will continue to. But even so…

“Because my mind, right?” Midoriya’s still saying, too worked up to cut himself off. “My mind is supposed to be hundreds of years old by now and yet, every time I wake up, it doesn’t matter what I remember. It doesn’t matter how many times this has happened. I’m still back in a body with raging hormones and poor emotional regulation and unrestrained impulsivity, and all I want to do is curl up in a ball and cry until my *mother* comes home to *hold me!*”

Suddenly, it doesn’t matter if this is a delusion. It doesn’t matter if it’s real to Shouta because it’s definitely real to *Midoriya*.

“I believe you,” he says and Midoriya lets out a wounded noise that thuds right into Shouta’s chest like a knife. Turning his head away from Shouta, he covers his face and starts to sob.

All Shouta can do is stand and bear witness to the breakdown. He won’t disrespect Midoriya’s pain by leaving but his eyes flicker to the doorway. Blessedly, the door remains shut even though he’s sure it’s been plenty long enough for All Might to have finished his phone call. Shouta will take the break for once.

It takes a while before the gut wrenching sobs slow and quiet down. As Midoriya calms, Shouta tries to decide where to go from here. They can’t let Midoriya go once he’s healed. He’s still a murderer, still responsible for a serious amount of crime and mayhem that he undertook entirely of his own volition. Left to his own devices, he’ll continue acting completely outside acceptable bounds in the name of his sacred goal.

And that makes Shouta wonder something. “Why are you trying so hard to protect All Might? Of anyone, he’s in the best position to protect himself.”

There's no movement from the bed beside him, nor any answer, but Shouta knows Midoriya's still awake. He waits and eventually is rewarded.

"He was the first person to ever believe in me," Midoriya says softly. "He said I could be a hero. I can't… even though I don't let it happen anymore, I won't forget that. What it felt like."

Shouta can't tell if that's a good thing or not by his tone, but he hopes it's something that has helped support Midoriya rather than tearing into him like most of his more solid memories no doubt do. Because he knows Midoriya is right; trauma etches deeper into memory than just about anything else.

"He's your mentor, isn't he?" Shouta asks before he can stop himself as another piece slips into place.

"Not anymore."

Bullshit. Shouta doesn't call him on it, though. Whatever Midoriya thinks, Shouta knows for sure he still sees All Might that way just as much as when it was actually true. All he has to do is notice the way Midoriya throws himself at problems without regard to his own safety to see the hallmarks of All Might's own attitude laid bare.

"That idiot was right about one thing," Shouta says as he glances at the boy from the corner of his eye. "You're not alone. Maybe it's time to let us adults do our damn jobs."

That gets a reaction, the corner of Midoriya's lips twitching up into something that isn't quite a smile but might get there some day.

"Maybe," he says and that'll just have to be good enough, Shouta guesses.

It's been a very long time since All For One held so few pieces. With Tomura gone, his plans for poetic revenge are in shambles. Losing Kurogiri is another blow but he cares less about it. Successful experiment he may have been but All For One can always make another. One thing he's never short on is time.

Still, if he wishes to move forward with any speed, he'll need to take the brat out first. Not even a holder of that damned quirk but Izuku seems primed to continue Yoichi's legacy anyway. Despite his delusions about time loops (and what a disappointment, not finding that quirk to be real), Izuku presents far more danger than a single quirkless boy should.

He's almost proud, seeing one of his get rising above mediocrity. Alas, he'll take little enjoyment in killing him.

"Your progress?" he asks as he enters the secondary lab they'd been forced into. With his nomu storage raided and pillaged, they'll have to build up his army once more and that'll take time he doesn't want to waste but can't hasten.

“Going well!” Dr. Garaki assures him but the man is old hat at this kind of genetic manipulation by now. His previous army had taken years. This one will be ready in only *months*. “I’d say this is my greatest work, but the next one will be even better.”

Behind his mask, All For One can only smile at the man’s assurance. “Excellent. I’ll be sure to gather more raw materials for you to work with.”

There’s always people no one will miss if they disappear from the streets, after all. All For One leaves Dr. Garaki to his work and then begins figuring out how best to remove the annoyance of his son from the world.

Something’s up. Katsuki’s been noticing a certain restlessness in the teachers for the last few days. It’s most obvious in Aizawa, but that may just be Katsuki’s familiarity with the man. Something happened. Something’s wrong. He just doesn’t know what.

No matter how closely he watches them, he doesn’t get any clues until the third day. Then he catches Aizawa talking to Yamada in quiet tones just outside the 1-A dorms. Katsuki isn’t a stealth based hero, but that doesn’t mean he can’t be quiet when he wants to be. He carefully makes his way closer, keeping to cover just as he’s been trained. He makes sure to only move when neither teacher will notice, trying to treat it like a training exercise.

“-doesn’t mean I’m getting attached,” Aizawa’s saying when Katsuki gets close enough to make out the words.

“I didn’t say that,” Yamada replies. “I said you’re *projecting*.”

“That makes even less sense. He’s nothing like me.”

Yamada sighs, but there’s not nearly as much drama to it as Katsuki is used to seeing. It’s… weird, seeing him so muted.

“You want to know what I think?”

“I’m sure you’ll tell me regardless.”

“I think you want to save him because you feel like it might make up for the people who failed him to begin with.”

What? Aizawa seems to share the sentiment because his expression goes entirely flat. “Are you kidding me right now?”

“I’m just saying!” Yamada says in his own defense, throwing out his hands. “You don’t go this far even for your current class and I know you *adore* those little troublemakers!”

Aizawa’s dead eyed stare gets even more blank and Katsuki barely keeps himself from jumping out to defend his teacher’s apathy towards them. Why the hell would Aizawa have a soft spot for any of them? He knows teachers call them a hellclass and wears that like a badge of *pride*.

“That’s it. We’re done,” Aizawa says as he turns to leave but Yamada grabs his arm.

“I’m worried about you, Shouta.” The soft tone in Yamada’s voice is so alien that Katsuki feels it’s something he should never have heard. “He’s getting under your skin.”

Lips pursed a moment, Aizawa pulls his arm free and then says, “I know what I’m doing with Midoriya.”

And Katsuki’s entire body locks down at that name, his vision tunneling down to just his teacher’s face.

“He may think he’s doing a good job playing at being a villain, but he’s shown too many cracks in the facade,” Aizaway continues. “He’s scared. Desperate because he doesn’t think he has anything left.”

“And you don’t think that’s dangerous?!”

“I *know* it is. But I also know what will happen if none of us reach him.”

Yamada hugs his arms across his chest, looking like someone had kicked his dog. “It doesn’t have to be *you*. He may not have killed any heroes yet, but that doesn’t mean he won’t.”

“Are you doubting my skills, then?” Aizawa throws out like a gauntlet and Yamada just sighs.

“Don’t do that. You know that isn’t what I mean.”

“Midoriya trusts me to an extent,” Aizawa says. “It’s the closest any of us have gotten to him. If we want a chance at curbing some of his more destructive tendencies, I need to get even closer to him.”

“I think you’re underestimating just how much trouble he’s bringing with him.”

“And I think it doesn’t matter. That boy needs *someone* in his court. At least before he ends up in *Tartarus*.”

Yamada reaches out, taking Aizawa’s shoulders as he leans in closer. “Okay. Okay, I get it. This is important to you.”

“I trained him in one of the loops,” Aizawa says and there’s an odd, almost helpless quality to it that Katsuki’s never heard from him before and a strange uneasiness knots in his belly. “There’s no way he could have learned my style so quickly just from watching me. I trained that boy. I was his mentor, once.”

He shouldn’t be listening to this but Katsuki can’t move. It’s enough of a surprise that he got this close without either noticing, he knows his luck won’t hold out if he tries to leave. He looks away from them and tries not to listen anymore as their voices grow quieter, more intimate,

So, something’s going on with Deku. Something having to do with loops? What the hell does that mean? Maybe his best chance of finding out is to keep tabs on his teacher, see if he can’t follow him to Deku. When he’d tried to go back to the hideout Toga took him to, all he’d gotten was ridiculously lost. For some reason, he simply couldn’t remember why he was wandering around there when he got close, his attention redirecting to anything else. That’d been the only lead he had on tracking Deku.

Well. Now he has a new one.

The teachers finally split and go their separate ways. Instead of following Aizawa now, Katsuki goes to work on his homework. He needs to think, to strategize, and also to get his homework out of the way. No matter his extracurricular activities, Katsuki’s still aiming at graduating top of his class and there’s no way he’ll let someone like Deku take that from him.

And, maybe, he thinks his teacher could use a little privacy after that confrontation.

Chapter End Notes

Just as an aside, i've had Izuku's rant about what sucks most about the time loops written for uh over a month, just wasn't sure when it would ever appear. and then the chance came so yay! Catharsis

Chapter 19

Chapter Notes

Suicide mention in this chapter.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Dabi's not sure when his goals in life changed but he knows they have. He knows because when Hawks brings word of Kiddo's injuries and being held at UA, he doesn't even remember that that means he's allowed to kill Endeavor until Hawks adds that Kiddo said to hold off on "removing his burden from the planet."

It's obvious Hawks wants to know what that means but Dabi just nods, accepting the order, and starts trying to think of a way to spring Kiddo free. Hawks gives a report on how Kiddo's injuries are doing and Dabi feels a colder lump of rage start to form inside him. This shouldn't have happened. Had Kiddo not gone off on his own, they could have helped keep his dumb ass safe. What's the point of having a gang if he won't fucking *use them?!*

"Dabi," Spinner hisses nearby and Dabi twitches, knowing without feeling it that there's heat building in his palms.

"When are they moving him to police custody?" he asks instead of acknowledging that.

"Not sure," Hawks replies with no more caution in his voice than ever despite Dabi's anger. "Last I was told, he's responding well to treatment but won't be up and around for another couple days. Pretty sure All Might and Eraserhead mean to try and rehabilitate him."

Spinner pulls a face at the idea and Toga, who's been pretty quiet since Kiddo left on his stupid suicide mission with only a corrupt hero and a fake one to watch his back, suddenly asks, "Do you think he'll turn on us?"

Looking at her face in surprise, Dabi scowls harder because of all of them, she's been the most relentless in her loyalty. "Don't be stupid."

"I'm not." She looks at her feet hanging over the filing cabinet she'd parked herself on and kicks then absently. "You know how he feels about certain heroes."

She's not wrong. No matter how ruthless and deadly Kiddo could be, there are certain people he's almost insanely protective of, to the point that Dabi is absolutely sure he'd throw away his own life for them without thinking. Both All Might and Eraserhead are on the no-go list. So if even one of those two had taken an interest in Kiddo…

"He's not turning on us," Spinner says decisively, folding his arms across his chest as he stands taller to glare at all of them. "Just because Kiddo acknowledged certain heroes as

being worthy of the title doesn't mean he's giving up the fight for a better future. Why are you so quick to doubt him just because someone like All Might acknowledges him right back? If they're trying to rehabilitate him, it means they see his worth and power just like he sees theirs."

It makes sense in the twisted sort of logic he's come to expect from Kiddo. Dabi feels his shoulders relax a little because Spinner's right. Kiddo won't just try to abandon them. They've come too far. They're still useful to him.

"Then maybe we need to clear the path for him while he's recovering."

The voice is quiet, hesitant, and Dabi glances towards Twice lingering in the doorway like he hadn't shown his loyalty to Kiddo already when he turned his mother over to the heroes for safe keeping instead of taking her right back to All For One. When he'd confessed to all of them about being a spy for the king of the underworld fully expecting them to kill him.

It's weird seeing him without his mask, but he'd made the point that he knew all of their faces, they might as well know his. And he's way less bombastic without it. Twice is stiff and awkward with all their attention on him, but he just takes a drag from his cigarette and looks away.

"We've got the list," he reminds them.

"If we divide it up between us, we can probably take out most of them by the time we can safely spring him," Spinner says, considering it.

Dabi looks straight at Hawks, sizing him up. "You're too flashy and we need the other heroes to keep thinking we don't know you're a spy."

Hawks snorts. "Pretty sure I'm technically a double agent at this point."

"Doesn't matter. You don't get to know who's on which targets. Go and only come back if something changes with Kiddo."

Without Kiddo around, Dabi's free to make the decisions and none of the others counter him. For a few seconds, it looks like Hawks might try but then he just nods and leaves. No doubt, he thinks he'll get the info later somehow. He's been weirdly resourceful like that.

Dabi steps up to the kill list posted on the wall. Scanning the various names, he picks out half a dozen for each of them without expecting they'll actually completely wipe out their targets. Anyone they can take out now will make later actions easier, so even managing half would still be useful. He eyes one that has the group mission mark next to it but decides to trust Kiddo's insistence that they can't take Re-Destro alone. Obliterating his support base will have to do.

The others take to their orders easily. Even Toga seems comforted by a concrete plan but Dabi makes a mental note to keep an eye on her. She can be unpredictable and he doesn't want that biting Kiddo's ass later. With his own list, Dabi heads out to start tracking his first target and figuring out the easiest way to end them.

Turns out, Dabi's comforted by a concrete plan, too.

"What we need to do is find a weak point we can use," Nedzu decides once Toshinori and Aizawa take their seats in front of his desk. "There's surely a way to get through to him."

"And what happens if we *do?*" Aizawa asks, arms crossed and expression guarded. "There is eye witness and forensic evidence for several murders perpetrated by him that he will absolutely admit to when questioned given past experience with him, plus several more he can be argued as an accomplice for. Once he's healed, he's going to be incarcerated pending trial and I don't see the courts *not* trying him as an adult. He'd probably make it easy on them and just plead guilty to all charges from day one. There's no way this ends well."

Which would normally be the case, Toshinori is entirely aware of this and knows that if justice can be trusted, it's exactly what *should* happen… But he also can't stop remembering the dead eyed look on Midoriya's face when he admitted to repeatedly killing himself, nor the distress he'd overheard as the boy finally opened up to Aizawa while he was out of the room. He keeps remembering how Midoriya takes ownership of his every act, refusing to defend himself or share blame with any other, refusing to lie about it.

"Yes, that does complicate matters." But Nedzu doesn't look worried in the least. "It will be very difficult for us to gain primary custody of Midoriya but not impossible."

What?

Toshinori doesn't realize he's said it aloud until the principal gives him a satisfied grin and says, "He *is* a minor, after all. His remaining legal guardian can't care for him currently and a juvenile detention center would be ill equipped to handle him, especially given his homicidal tendencies. He's quirkless, not harmless. Having UA take him in until trial might be the only viable option."

"If they don't just throw him into an adult prison, you mean," Aizawa says and Toshinori knows Midoriya is more than capable of protecting himself from most threats, but he's still a young boy. There are vulnerabilities he cannot deny.

"Precisely. I believe given his age and the assistance he's given unprompted to both us and the police, protecting dozens of lives, it would be far more appropriate for him to be confined to the campus rather than prison where he might benefit from a more nurturing environment."

"And what of the safety of the students?" Toshinori forces himself to ask. He may want to find a way to save Midoriya, but certainly not at the cost of innocent lives.

"What exactly makes you think he would be a danger to the students?" Nedzu counters. "We're aware of his past targets, our students do not match the profile. Every teacher here is a pro hero, quite capable of taking him down themselves. I don't believe that will be necessary-"

"Not unless he decides he's been backed into a corner and the only way out is to kill," Aizawa says. His fingers are tight on his arms, white knuckled, but his face is utterly calm.

“Midoriya will do *anything* to further his goals.”

“Then perhaps we need to help him find another way to accomplish them.” Maybe Toshinori already has his hands full raising his successor but he can’t stand the idea of failing to save Midoriya. His struggles and determination, something about them speaks to parts of Toshinori he’s ignored for years. Had he only met the boy earlier, perhaps he might have even chosen him over Togata.

The satisfaction on Nedzu’s face makes it clear that that’s exactly what he’d hoped one of them would say.

“Midoriya’s primary concern is the safety of Bakugou Katsuki,” he says, back to his pitch. “Perhaps we can leverage this to keep him under some amount of control.”

Aizawa immediately tenses and his tone goes flat. “You’d better not be suggesting what I think you are.”

“We, of course, cannot take him on as a student,” Nedzu says, unaffected. “However, if he were to *audit* hero courses while under the supervision of pro hero teachers, perhaps acting as a teacher’s aid…”

“No.” Aizawa’s tone brooks no discussion. “You will *not* subject Midoriya to the heroics students.”

Toshinori blinks because shouldn’t that be the other way around? He almost wonders if Aizawa misspoke but he’s never known him to not be careful with his words.

“Midoriya is a fallen hero,” Aizawa says and it seems so clear and simple, but Toshinori knows that few would hold the same belief in the boy. “Subjecting him to the heroics students would only ground into him what he has lost in his trial to save Bakugou. He’s unstable enough as it is.”

“And there’s truly nothing that might be gained in reminding him that the path of a hero is an option?” The way Nedzu says that, it seems so easy. Like they simply need to teach Midoriya to trust again. Toshinori wants to believe there’s a way to redeem him.

“I doubt he’d believe that. He’s convinced that a hero can’t save Bakugou.”

Just what all had the boy seen that made him lose faith in heroes? Toshinori aches for him.

“Then maybe we can prove him wrong,” he says and Aizawa glares at him. “Part of a hero’s job is to inspire hope and I know few who need hope more than Midoriya.”

“This may cause him to spiral if we’re hamfisted about it,” Aizawa counters with venom in his voice.

“Then we’ll have to do this delicately,” Nedzu says, clapping his paws together. “Please consider which teachers would be most suitable to observe Midoriya-”

“I-” Toshinori starts but is cut off immediately.

“He’ll be under my supervision.” Aizawa doesn’t even look at Toshinori, gaze locked with Nedzu. “If you’re adamant about doing this, then during school hours he’ll accompany me. I will arrange for the watch schedule after that.”

“Fatherhood has made you demanding,” but Nedzu doesn’t sound displeased in the least.

“I’m not Eri’s father and I won’t be Midoriya’s either.”

The principal laughs, waving it off. “Yes, yes, go on then. Give me a copy of the evening watch schedule once you’ve finalized it. I will let you know when I’ve secured custody of Midoriya.”

Aizawa rises from his chair and leaves without a goodbye. It leaves Toshinori to scramble in his own farewell to hurry after him.

“Don’t,” Aizawa says before he can even open his mouth.

“Are you certain-”

“I said *don’t*.”

“Aizawa-”

Aizawa stops dead and whips around to face him with rage in his eyes. “Do you think I’m unqualified to supervise Midoriya?”

“What?! No!”

“Then what could you possibly have to say to me now?” He’s so angry he might as well be spitting the words and Toshinori doesn’t understand *why*. “I’ll consider you for the evening watch schedule. You’ll have your time to *inspire* him.”

“That’s not why I-”

“I’ve already been manipulated by Nedzu today,” Aizawa growls out. Even without his quirk active, Toshinori nearly steps back from him on sheer instinct. “I don’t need you fumbling at it, too. Especially since you barely even realize you’re doing it in the first place.”

Toshinori stiffens. “What-”

“Midoriya isn’t a *project*. He isn’t a cause for you to champion. What he needs more than anything is stability and barring that, he needs someone to trust. Someone to actually look after his interests. Nedzu isn’t doing this to protect him. He’s doing it because he’s bored and Midoriya is a *puzzle,* and he said all the right things to get you to agree with him.”

Maybe Toshinori hasn’t been in close contact with the principal for nearly as long as Aizawa, but he’d like to think Aizawa is misreading things in his normal, overly pessimistic way.

“It may not be that simple,” he tries, despite how much colder Aizawa’s expression gets. “He’s likely taking many factors into account.”

Aizawa snorts and then turns his back on Toshinori. “I’ll let you know when your turn comes up in the rotation for evenings.”

This time, Toshinori doesn’t pursue him when he leaves. There’s more than one way for him to help Midoriya. He’ll just have to wait for his opportunity.

“What a mess,” Naomasa mutters to himself, looking over his scattered notes from the laboratory event as he waits outside UA’s infirmary for them to let him see Midoriya. The file in his desk is brimming with witness statements, photographs, damage reports, coroner’s report, hospital admissions… The whole operation can only be called a success because two high ranked villains were successfully captured, but Shigaraki’s death and All For One’s subsequent escape overshadow anything good that might have come from it.

Kurogiri probably won’t talk. The Tartarus staff will try anyway.

“Detective?”

Naomasa startles out of his thoughts at Recovery Girl’s voice but settles quickly. “He’s ready?”

“Yes. Follow me.”

The infirmary is quiet enough as Naomasa follows her through to the isolation rooms. He nods to the pro hero standing guard outside of Midoriya’s room. When he goes in, the second one inside steps out to give them privacy. Midoriya’s room has only a single window, small and several inches thick, facing into the isolation ward’s hallway. The light above is too bright, washes out what little color there is on Midoriya’s face. The only things inside are the bed, a small cart near the door, and the pole for his I.V. lines. Who knows what Midoriya might use to escape otherwise?

He looks better than he did three days ago, but Naomasa knows he’ll need a while to heal up entirely. It doesn’t look like he’s going to take that rest time lightly, considering the notebooks piled up at his side.

“Busy on your next scheme?” Naomasa asks and Midoriya glances up with disgust.

“I am making *plans* to save the *world*,” he protests. “You act like I’m up to no good.”

“I *know* you’re up to no good.”

The kid huffs and then drops the notebook he’s holding onto the stack, relaxing back against his pillows. “Okay. Let’s get this over with.”

Glancing at his notes, Naomasa tries to decide what he should ask about first. He knows what he *wants* answers on first, but someone has to be professional around here.

“You assisted in a sanctioned Hero mission three days ago with pro heroes Hawks and Edgeshot…” he begins and goes through Hawks’ report, having Midoriya verify his participation even though they both know the sanctioned part of that is bullshit. Hawks hadn’t

elaborated much, just said the HPSC had signed off on both his and Edgeshot's participation, but getting answers out of them is a bureaucratic nightmare Naomasa isn't quite ready to undertake.

Midoriya corroborates the reports given by both the heroes and gives his statement for what happened when they were separated. There's not even a flicker of unease in describing his kill, no regret or even satisfaction. Naomasa isn't sure how to feel about that.

"Were you given clearance to make the kill?" Naomasa asks because he has to, even though he knows the answer.

"Of course not. Heroes only kill by accident," Midoriya says without looking away from his eyes. Without trying at all to exonerate himself or downplay his culpability. "Edgeshot was hoping to stop me after I told him I'd do it."

"Why warn him?"

"It seemed polite to give him the heads up and it's not like he could have actually made a difference in the outcome."

The way that rings true in his quirk just makes Naomasa sigh. Hopefully, Edgeshot isn't taking that failure too hard. That whole mission is the type that can linger in the what ifs of someone's mind for a while. Shaking his head, he goes on to his next bit of questioning.

"Regarding something Hawks heard in your conversation with All For One outside the lab," Naomasa says, not allowing himself to get bogged down with his continual lack of understanding about this boy. "Can you confirm that All For One is your father?"

"Unfortunately." The disgust is clear in Midoriya's face. "Don't worry. I'd want him dead regardless, but maybe I want him *extra* dead for that one."

Makes sense. Having his father skip out on him had to have been difficult as a child even before he knew him to be a supervillain.

"How long have you known who he was to you?" Naomasa asks, more for himself than for the report.

"I don't know. It's been a lot of loops since I found out." He sighs, gaze growing a little farther away as he no doubt remembers the event. "He actually recognized me that time. I think I did something too much like my mom for him to ignore or maybe he just got lucky. He tried to use it to subvert me. That whole 'we're not so different', 'let's be a family with a shared purpose' song and dance. I was a hero that time."

Was a hero. Seeing the boy so fallen from those ideals now makes Naomasa wonder if it would have still happened had Midoriya not known. Probably so. Eventually, enough failures can break just about anyone. He shakes it from his mind and returns back to his notes.

"There seemed to be an implication that he has other children-"

"They're all dead." Entirely sure, not a shred of doubt.

“You’ve looked into them?”

“Yeah. The last one before me died when I was still a toddler. She was twelve, there was a villain related incident she and her mom got caught up in.”

Naomasa notes that down and then asks, “How many of them do you know about?”

“Twenty-six, not counting me.” Midoriya picks up his notebook again, flipping a few pages absently like he needs something to do with his hands. “He’d make a new identity, stick around until the kid was confirmed quirkless, then find some reason to fuck off.”

That matches up with what happened to the Midoriyas, anyway.

“Sometimes he’d come by to see if there was a late onset quirk, but that’s about it. He left my family when I was four but visited once when I was nine. Of course, that’s when All Might nearly killed him so maybe he’d have stuck around otherwise.” A slight shrug of Midoriya’s shoulder shows how little he believes that.

“The name ‘Midoriya Hisashi,” Naomasa says after noting that. “It looks like he took your mother’s surname?”

“Yeah. That’s how you can find records about him,” Midoriya confirms. “Just look for guys named Hisashi that take their wives’ names and disappear after their kid is five. Kind of amazing no one else ever put the pieces together. He probably owes *so* much in child support.”

While he’s definitely going to follow up on that, Naomasa takes a moment to study Midoriya’s expression. His tone has been even, almost dismissive, but that doesn’t mean this isn’t something he feels a certain way about. As if sensing eyes on him, Midoriya’s gaze flickers up from his notebook.

“I’m fine,” he says, almost exasperated. “I got over the parental abandonment a while ago.”

“Did you?” Naomasa asks because this is one of the few times he’s actually been alerted to intentional falsehood when speaking to the villain.

Midoriya snorts, looking off again. “Yeah. I mean, it’s not like even the couple loops I joined up with the League of Villains he paid any more attention to me.”

“You-” But it makes sense. Just another set of possibilities for him to try out in his quest to perfect the timeline. “Is that why you hated Shigaraki so much? Your time with the League?”

That shocks a harsh laugh out of the kid that has him wincing after from the stress on his ribs. “No, I hated him for being a pathetic manchild that blamed all his problems on a guy who he’d literally never met before the USJ incident and was too stupid to realize his precious *Sensei* only picked him up for some kind of bit part in his shakespearean tragedy played out in real life. Hell, look how easily he threw him away this loop?”

There’s pure venom dripping off every word as Kiddo stares at nothing, likely seeing the man in his mind.

“I mean, I get it. That crusty bastard was traumatized to hell and back, accidentally murdered his whole family, it’s so sad. Why not decide to become a hand fetishist and destroy society?” Midoriya pauses and then points a stern finger towards Naomasa. “Don’t think for a second that by the time my loops start that asshole can be saved. He can’t. There is *nothing* anyone can do to turn him into a decent person. That boat sailed *long* before I came onto the scene.”

“I believe you,” Naomasa says and Midoriya looks away, just this side of flinching. It’s a strange enough response that Naomasa has no idea what to think about it, especially when his quirk is nudging in his mind that that isn’t the *whole* story on why Midoriya hated Shigaraki. Lies by omission are still lies, after all, but he’s not sure how to get more from him. If he’s not careful, Midoriya will clam up entirely.

“He would have died anyway,” Midoriya says after a longer pause, quieter again. “That quirk All For One gave him is a death sentence. It literally changes blood cells into mercury when in use and then that builds up on the user’s organs if they aren’t actively changing the cells back after. Little self control as he had, he’d be dead within another week. He was already showing signs of poisoning.”

That doesn’t mean it had been a mercy kill, Naomasa is absolutely sure of that, but it’s good to know. It means All For One meant to throw Shigaraki away in the end. Does that mean he has a better placed piece elsewhere?

“What’s your next task?” Naomasa asks.

Midoriya snorts, eyeing him. “Depends on if Dabi decided to trust Hawks to help or not. I mean, he’s a hero, so we can’t trust him with *everything*.”

“But you do trust him to a certain extent?”

“I know how far he’s willing to go to infiltrate villain organizations,” Midoriya says, his amusement draining entirely. “But I also know how useful he can be if he thinks he’ll get what he’s looking for.”

Of course Midoriya would use Hawks for his purposes. The real wonder is that he’d been willing to allow Edgeshot in on their last mission when he hasn’t shown any sign he has something on the pro hero to assure his cooperation.

“What happens if Dabi does trust him?”

“Then half my team goes to jail in a sting operation and I have to break them out.”

“And if he doesn’t?”

Midoriya smiles and for a moment looks like a normal, cheerful teenager. “Then we make a *lot* of progress on our kill list.”

A shiver runs down Naomasa’s back and suddenly he has a lot more doubts about curbing the boy’s worse off intentions.

Chapter End Notes

So this was kind of a setup chapter but I still like it :D

Chapter 20

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

November

Yotsubashi Rikiya is not a superstitious man. He's been called a fanatic for his dedication to the ways of Destro but while he will do anything to defend those beliefs, he stays grounded within the real world.

A real world that is starting to chip away at its edges.

"I'm sorry, *what?*" he asks.

"Someone is targeting us," Curious repeats, looking like she wishes she was anywhere else. "We've lost ten supporters I've confirmed, another fifteen I haven't."

Rikiya stares at her.

"Low level ones, mostly suppliers," Trumpet adds, "but they're working up the chain. Someone's trying to cripple us and they know who we are."

Their group has barely gotten started moving and someone already has it out for them?

"Heroes?" Rikiya wonders and Curious shakes her head.

"Not if they're turning up dead."

Point. Which means either another villain group or a vigilante. A couple of vigilantes? Just what the hell did they think they were doing?! Rikiya's fingers curl tightly together, nails digging into his palms as he holds back the sudden swell of rage rolling through his body. Curious and Trumpet are just messengers and they're still useful. He can't kill them yet.

"Close ranks," he orders through gritted teeth. "The first person to bring me one of these idiots gets a raise."

Both Curious and Trumpet nod and leave to disperse his order to the rest. Maybe this is a sign that the Meta Liberation Army's time has come. If someone's already targeting them, that means their message is gaining attention…

Anyone else would probably feel accomplished for figuring out where Deku is after only a little while tailing Aizawa, but Katsuki isn't just anyone and it grates on him that it took so long. It grates on him that Deku's holed up in an isolation suite in the infirmary. It grates on him that Recovery Girl won't let him in to see the damn nerd.

The fact that he doesn't even know if Deku's *conscious* or *whole* pisses him off more than he can stand.

Katsuki takes it out on his classmates but they can deal. They aren't *that* weak. He'll never admit it but there's only a couple of them he wouldn't let back him up in the field as long as they stayed out of his way.

After classes are over for the day, he marches right back to the infirmary. This time, failure's not an option.

"I'm here to see Deku," he declares the moment he spots Recovery Girl, barely even noticing the man she's talking with.

She sighs, giving him a long suffering look. "I've already told you no."

"Haaa? That was yesterday."

"The answer is *still no*."

"That's the wrong answer!"

Reaching up to pinch between her eyes, Recovery Girl turns back to her companion- Oh. Katsuki knows him. That's the detective that took his statement when all this with Deku started.

"Bakugou?" the detective asks with a blink. "Who told you Midoriya was here?"

Katsuki scoffs. As if someone had to tell him. "Aizawa and All Might made it fucking obvious. All I had to do was watch them. Now get out of my way! I've got a nerd to yell at."

The detective shares a glance with Recovery Girl, something almost calculating in his gaze, and then he shrugs. "They *are* childhood friends and Midoriya isn't armed…"

"I don't appreciate you challenging my authority in my own infirmary," she replies curtly, but gives a little wave and walks off like she's washing her hands of it all. Not that Katsuki gives a shit about that. This means he *won*.

He didn't expect the detective to follow him in, though. Katsuki grits his teeth but at least with the detective, the pro guarding Deku's door just waves them through and the one inside the room leaves as they enter. And it's so weird, how careful the adults are being with security for fucking *Deku* of all people. Like they fully expect him to just up and start a murder spree or something.

Katsuki's at least somewhat mollified by the bewildered surprise on Deku's face when he realizes who's visiting him.

"What are you doing here?" the nerd asks and one corner of Katsuki's mouth curls back.

"What the hell are *you* doing here?" he counters, glaring down his nose. "This is my turf, shithead."

And Deku has the audacity to roll his eyes. “Wasn’t exactly my choice. I was unconscious at the time.”

Katsuki does a quick glance over, but Deku’s alert, has all his limbs, probably even all his fingers and toes. There are still a few bandages here and there, healing bruises and such, but nothing that won’t be fine with a little time. That’s all he’d meant to verify in the first place, but now that he’s here it seems like a waste to just march back out again.

“So what did you even do to yourself this time?” he asks, crossing his arms.

“I didn’t. It was the overdramatic crimelord’s fault.”

What.

The detective snorts behind his hand and Katsuki had almost forgotten he was there.

“What, were you trying to invade his turf, too?” he asks, honestly curious about what Deku’s involving himself with. Deku grins and there is a faint glimmer of the boy Katsuki remembers there, under the weird confidence and sharper edges.

“Yeah. I’m gonna take everything from him.”

It doesn’t sound like a bluff and something about that is utterly maddening. Katsuki barely notices he’s moved before his open palm smacks upside Deku’s stupid head, earning him a whining cry from Deku and a disapproving shout from the detective.

“This isn’t a comic book and you’re not a fucking supervillain, you stupid nerd!” Katsuki snarls at him, feeling heat in his palms. “What the hell is Auntie gonna think if you get your stupid ass killed?!”

Deku glares at him, rubbing his head. “Well, it’s not like I’d be around to find out, is it?”

Katsuki just barely keeps from hitting him again.

“Is this just your newest bid to be a hero?” he asks instead, keeping his hands tightly clenched so he’s not letting off sparks. “Are you trying to be some kind of fucking vigilante or-”

“Oh, no. No, I tried that, it doesn’t work,” Deku says, looking at him like there’s nothing wrong with what he’s just said. “I’m definitely a villain this time.”

“How can your quirkless ass be a *villain?!*”

“Hey Detective, did I count as a villain after Stain? Or was it Muscular?”

The fuck is he talking about? But Katsuki follows Deku’s gaze back to the detective, who seems a little uncomfortable with where this conversation is going.

“Neither, actually,” he says, scratching at his cheek.

“Wow, how many times do you gotta kill someone on purpose in front of a pro hero before they call you a villain?”

“You’re definitely a criminal but being quirkless means you can’t actually be classified legally as a vigilante *or* villain, since both require unlawful use of a quirk.”

“Well *that’s* quirkist.”

“That doesn’t mean most of the heroes who know anything about you aren’t calling you a villain anyway.”

Which seems to soothe Deku, the weirdo.

Also, what. The. *Fuck*.

Katsuki turns to stare at him as something uncomfortable and cold rolls down his back. It’s like the boy in front of him is someone he doesn’t know. He looks like Deku, those big stupid eyes and freckles, but the way he carries himself, the way he talks, everything else is so wrong Katsuki wonders if he’s wandered into some alternate world.

“You should go,” Deku says and Katsuki can’t quite get words out to answer him. “You really need to stop coming after me, Kacchan.”

“Where the fuck do you get off thinking you can order me around?” Katsuki asks, but he doesn’t really feel the bluster. He’s confused, so off base that he wants to be angry about it but isn’t sure how. Because worthless Deku is supposed to be an unchanging staple in his life. A stepping stone, a pebble to walk past.

“Go back to your dorm and your classmates,” Deku says, then shrugs. “You probably have homework.”

He does and normally Katsuki is all about keeping up with his studies first, dealing with bullshit second, but his feet are stuck solid.

“Who the hell are you?” The words burst out of him like one of his explosions, like they have a life of their own and he would never be able to hold them back.

And Deku doesn’t answer. He stares up at Katsuki with an expression he doesn’t recognize, with a stillness that is alien and so very wrong and Katsuki feels his world rock awkwardly off axis.

“Nobody you ever should care about,” he says finally and he means it, Katsuki doesn’t need a mindreading quirk to know that. Deku smiles, soft and watery as he finally does something even remotely like himself. The amount of times Katsuki has seen Deku cry is countless but this feels different. This feels…

“Why are you looking at me like that?”

“So I can remember,” Deku says, smile twisting into something more painful, “when you’re gone.”

And then Katsuki finds it hard to breathe. He stares at Deku, at his stupid smile and his stupid wet eyes and his stupid *everything*, and he doesn't understand what this is making him feel. There is a weight pressing down on his shoulders, an expectation he doesn't want and could never carry. Without another word, Katsuki leaves the room only to freeze as he hears a sob through the mostly closed door.

"Midoriya?" the detective asks softly.

"I just- I just need a minute. I wasn't expecting him to come here. I wasn't ready."

His voice is as wrecked as Katsuki's chest. The pro standing guard outside gives him an uncomfortable look but Katsuki's full attention is back inside the room he'd just left.

"Maybe it would be good if he visited you again later, once you've had time to calm down."

"No. No, he needs to stay far away from me. He can't… He needs to stay away or- Or I need to stay away from *him*. It's not safe for him."

"Mido-"

"Don't let him come back here and I'll give you my notebooks when you transfer me to prison."

Something tight winds up in his chest at hearing the desperation in Deku's words. It's painful and confusing and Katsuki hates it *so much.* Why the hell is Deku, of all people, trying to… what, protect him? *Him?!* Did becoming a bigshot in the crime world suddenly make Deku forget he's *powerless?!*

He can't listen to this anymore. Katsuki resolutely makes his way back to the dorm where things make sense.

Naomasa gives Midoriya a few minutes to compose himself, checking his phone to see if Aizawa's on his way. He hadn't come here to reunite childhood friends after all, and Midoriya's comment about prison just reminds him of that.

It occurs to Naomasa that for once, Midoriya doesn't seem to know what's planned for him. Had they actually managed to break out of the expected timeline that far? He glances towards the bed where Midoriya's laying back on his pillows, staring up at the ceiling with pink rimmed eyes.

They're off script and Naomasa isn't sure if that's a good thing or not.

"Better?" he asks and Midoriya makes a noncommittal noise that nonetheless comes across as a lie.

"Can we speed up the transfer?" Midoriya asks without looking at him. "Just… put me in solitary for a few days to finish recovering before I go to gen pop."

“You’re not going to prison.” He’d meant to wait to let the cat out of the bag until Aizawa got there but oh well. Midoriya pauses, then lifts his head.

“Tartarus?” he asks and there’s surprise but none of the fear or horror Naomasa has seen with others facing that fate. “Usually, I have to kill Endeavor before that happens.”

Endeavor? He’s one of Kiddo’s targets?!

“You-”

“Well not *yet*. All Might’s going to need his help taking down All For One since he’s decided to do that despite my efforts.”

That doesn’t actually comfort him. Naomasa makes a quick note to warn the number two pro that there’s apparently a conspiracy on his life in the future, even if he’s not sure Endeavor would ever take that seriously.

“Why would you even target him? Is he a danger to Bakugou?”

Midoriya glances off, shrugging his shoulder. “I made a promise to someone.”

Which skirts the line between truth and lie so carefully Naomasa’s not actually sure which it is. Not that it really matters because just like his notions he could take down All For One, Midoriya seems certain he’d be able to take out Endeavor as well, and that’s… mildly terrifying. Naomasa doesn’t let it shake him though.

“You’re not going to Tartarus either.”

The narrow look Midoriya shoots his way, like he’s trying to read Naomasa’s mind, makes him more sure that they’re off script. Is that a good thing?

“You’re not adopting me, are you? Because you only do that when my mom dies and she’s alive in this loop.” There’s a moment before the boy’s face starts to drain of color. “She’s still alive, right?”

“She is.” Severely psychologically damaged but alive. The last update Naomasa got from the treatment facility is that she’s starting to respond a little. Definitely not enough to take a parental role yet but the doctors are hopeful she’ll come though. The idea of adopting the embodiment of chaos that is this child certainly has Naomasa a little off base, if he’s honest, so he’s glad that hasn’t come up. He thinks he would, if it came to that though.

Midoriya relaxes just a little at the confirmation but is still on guard. “So, what’s happening to me then? You’re not letting me go.”

Before Naomasa has to do this alone, he spots Aizawa moving across the hallway window and feels tension bleed out of him. The pro lifts a brow at something he reads in Naomasa’s body language.

“Did you tell him?” he asks.

“No, was about to.”

Aizawa nods and looks at Midoriya, who’s eyeing both of them.

“Am I getting the death penalty already?”

“You’re a *minor!*” Naomasa protests and Midoriya shrugs.

“So you wait a year and a half and *then* kill me.”

“Stop being dramatic. *No*,” Aizawa says with a roll of his eyes before shooting Naomasa a look. “Did the order come through?”

Naomasa reaches into his jacket pocket to pull out the reason for his visit in the first place, handing over the court order paperwork. Aizawa glances over it as Midoriya gets more and more antsy on the bed.

“Congratulations, Midoriya,” Aizawa says. “You are now a ward of UA.”

For once, the person blindsided is Midoriya. He stares at Aizawa with wide eyes, then Naomasa, and then back again. Which just clinches it, right? They’re off script.

“No,” Midoriya says abruptly, horror in his voice.

“You’ll be in my custody through the school day and other teachers will be watching you in the evenings,” Aizawa goes on like he didn’t even hear him. “At night, you’ll be remanded to a locked dorm room.”

“*No*,” Midoriya repeats a little louder.

“You are required to attend therapy sessions and also speak with one of our career counselors to start planning for a future outside of crime. I expect your full cooperation and best behavior-”

“*Send me to fucking prison!”*

Both adults stiffen and stare at him because that wasn’t the sound of a brat refusing to face consequences. That was *fearful*. Midoriya’s eyes are still wide but there’s a faint trembling in his hands where he clenches them on the sheets. He’s breathing a little too shallow, his face draining of color.

“Breathe, Midoriya,” Aizawa says and the kid’s attention refocuses exclusively on him.

“I can’t stay here,” he says with urgency. “It’s not safe.”

“All For One can’t get to you here,” Naomasa tries and the kid laughs, harsh and stressed.

“Only because he’s not interested in doing that and the worst he’ll do is kill me so why the *fuck* would I be afraid of him?”

“Then what are you-” Aizawa stops, eyes narrowing, and says, “It’s something to do with Bakugou, isn’t it?”

Midoriya’s lips press into a hard line, his gaze turning inward. Remembering? Stepping around the bed, Aizawa reaches out and grabs Midoriya’s shoulder, causing the boy to jerk back to attention.

“It’s time for you to start trusting us,” Aizawa says, steady and even.

Naomasa sees the struggle in Midoriya’s gaze. It’s one of the few times the boy’s seemed unsure and something about that is so very *wrong*. Kiddo has been a force of nature since the moment he appeared on the scene, but Midoriya is just a teenage boy in way, *way* over his head.

“I’m going to escape the moment you let your guard down,” Midoriya warns.

“That’s what the ankle monitor you’re required to wear is for.” Aizawa drags the compact anklet out of his pocket and then waits until Midoriya moves his leg out from under the blanket so he can secure it on the boy. “If you move within ten feet of the outer walls of the campus, the alarm will sound.”

“Great.”

“Your communications with outsiders, including heroes, will be monitored by at least two teachers,” Aizawa goes on. “You are forbidden from using any electronic communication methods including social media.”

Midoriya narrows his eyes. “Really isolating me from my support system, huh.”

“Your gang will have to get on without you for a while.”

“Oh yeah, it’s not like they’re a bunch of overdramatic criminals with short fuses or anything.”

“You’re starting to make me wonder how good you are at long term strategy if you didn’t leave them things to do in your absence.”

“Touché.”

There’s something almost comforting in hearing the banter. Naomasa can see Midoriya starting to unwind a bit, not quite standing down so much as settling in. He’s sure there will be trouble but this gives him a little hope things might end up alright. Midoriya still needs time to heal and in the meantime, this is the best chance they’re going to have to get through to him.

“I expect you to be awake and ready to go when I get to your room in the morning,” Aizawa says, crossing his arms “You don’t leave that room without an escort. Understand?”

“Sure.”

“Escorts *only* include current teachers at UA. Hawks and Detective Tsukauchi don’t count.”

Midoriya makes a face and Naomasa is fairly sure it’s due to the former name rather than the later. Hawks is a pro hero but he’s also been neck deep in Kiddo’s crew for weeks. Who knows what he might decide is a good enough reason to break Midoriya out?

“Why are you doing this?” Midoriya asks, pinning Aizawa with an uneasy look. “I’m a villain and unless there’s been a major breakdown with my crew, they’re out killing people on *my* order.”

“Maybe we think we can give you an alternative option.”

The boy narrows his eyes, calculating odds and who knows what else. If Naomasa’s right, if this really is a new event for him, then either Midoriya embraces the possibility or will fight tooth and nail to get back on track to what he knows. They’ll have to watch out either way.

“This isn’t going to work out well for you,” Midoirya warns but it means he’s giving in, at least a little. Willing to try or maybe just willing to wait and see.

“That’s the benefit of being an adult,” Aizawa says. “I’m allowed to make leaps of faith that might be mistakes.”

He leaves the room, catching Naomasa’s eye on the way out with a slight nod towards the door.

“Rest well, Midoriya,” Naomasa says as he goes to follow only to pause when the boy calls out to him. Midoriya grabs one of his notebooks, flipping through the first several pages and then tearing out three from the back of it to stuff into a different notebook. He looks up as he holds it out.

“Here. Maybe you’ll see something I don’t.”

It’s not exactly trust Midoriya’s showing when Naomasa takes the notebook. Midoriya doesn’t *have* to trust him when he thinks any mistake can be countered just by dying and trying again. But it’s still something and Naomasa will respect that gift.

“Thank you. I’ll be sure to check in when I can.”

“Sure.”

Naomasa leaves, passing the pro that will guard inside the room on his way to meet with Aizawa further down the hall. Aizawa glances at the notebook in his hands but doesn’t comment on it just yet.

“We need to get a handle on what his crew is up to,” Aizawa says, “and I don’t know how far we can trust Hawks’ information.”

Naomasa feels the same. The whole mess with the latest ‘sanctioned’ mission from the HPSC rankles him terribly, but he’s not sure if it was driven by Hawks or the organization itself. They’ve always been just annoying enough in the background, but Naomasa had so many

other things to concentrate on. Corporate crime isn't usually in his wheelhouse, but heroes most certainly *are*. Maybe it's time he takes a closer look at the HPSC and their foremost star.

"I'll handle Hawks. You concentrate on Midoriya," Naomasa says.

"Watch yourself," is the only answer before Aizawa leaves. It's not until he's in his car that Naomasa opens the notebook. He frowns at first, not sure what he's looking at, before he realizes it's a timeline of events dating back a year and a half. Back to before Kiddo's activities began in the underworld.

April - Sludge monster attack, saved by All Might, don't follow him, don't be chosen

Naomasa narrows his eyes as he reads through activities and notes that only make half sense to him. Flipping several pages ahead, he sees the events he does know of, sees notes about possibilities, things in the margins that had to have been added later like *get Twice around Himiko, I never turn him* and *new strat on muscular worked, add to main timeline.*

The amount of work here is staggering. The timeline goes out several years but gets hazier and less detailed after the first two. Like Kiddo didn't care enough to document past the ominous note in April of the second year: *Kacchan dies*.

There's nothing to describe how, it's just there and then a few vague events after that seem more like speculative fiction than reality spanning out after. The fall of society, a series of crippling events, and then the final note of *Game over*.

Even warned, Naomasa wonders if they'll be able to prevent any of this, but they'll just have to try, won't they?

Chapter End Notes

I need to get way more comfortable writing Bakugou lol

Chapter 21

Chapter Notes

Uuuhhh quasi suicide mention in this chapter.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

The bad news that morning is that Shouta has to endure the worst case of "I'm not mad, just disappointed" from Eri that he's ever seen when he can't enjoy a leisurely breakfast with her and instead has to hurry her off to her minders for the day. She'll forgive him, of that he has no doubt, but he *hates* not living up to what meager expectations she's started tentatively having when she isn't being exceedingly, depressingly accommodating. Maybe he'll try to arrange for Midoriya to come visit her as an apology.

Speaking of Midoriya, the good news is that he's awake, dressed in the slacks and button up they provided him, and waiting when Shouta arrives to unlock his room. The room itself is kitted out like any of the dorms but Midoriya had arrived with nothing and hasn't said anything about retrieving his things from his apartment so they haven't. Maybe Shouta will bring it up later.

He hands over the suitcase he'd brought with him. "The support department remade your costume while you were in the infirmary. Let me know if adjustments need to be made."

"Why would they bother?" Midoriya asks with a frown as he takes the case. "I'm not a hero student."

"Think of it as a bribe."

"...Was Hatsume Mei involved?" Shouta guesses she's memorable enough from the hero loops to never forget.

"I'd imagine so."

Midoriya hums but says nothing more as he follows Shouta out to the school. He's moving well, not showing signs of the muscle strain and bruises Shouta knows are still there. It had been deemed unnecessary to heal them through a quirk when there'd be no complication leaving them to do it naturally, considering how much of a strain quirk healing could be on the body. Besides, anything that will slow Midoriya down for a bit is probably a good thing.

The walk to the 1-A classroom is silent. Shouta's not sure if Midoriya's anxious or just had nothing to say, but he doesn't initiate either. This first day is going to set a tone and what that tone will be is entirely Midoriya's choice. It'll be telling, whatever that choice ends up being.

The door to the classroom is open when they get to their hallway and Shouta stops hearing Midoriya's steps. He pauses, glancing back, and isn't sure how to read the look on Midoriya's face. Not afraid, not resigned, just…

"What are you going to tell them?" he asks and Shouta can't read his tone, either.

"I'm not. You are."

Midoriya's gaze slides away, brows furrowing in thought. "...The truth will come out eventually, since Kacchan is here. He's good at keeping secrets if he knows they're secret but this version hasn't had to protect All Might or…"

The muttering goes on for a few minutes, getting quieter and less understandable as Shouta observes him. Not quite worried, just used to thinking obsessively, it seems. While he'd love to give Midoriya time to work through his concerns, he has a class to wrangle.

"Midoriya," he calls and the boy goes silent immediately, refocusing. "Let's go."

Shouta enters first, his class immediately in their seats and ready to go the way Iida has trained them. Then Midoriya follows after and the whispers begin. He spares a glance at Bakugou and finds another expression he can't quite read.

"We've got a guest for the next… however long," Shouta announces, sweeping his gaze over the whole class. "He'll be joining you for home room and certain training sessions under my supervision."

Midoriya makes an exaggeratedly low bow and when he straightens, Shouta zeroes in on the changes to his posture immediately. His shoulders are hunched, head not quite raised fully, feet turned slightly inward, and he starts tugging at his fingers nervously. It makes him look suddenly so much smaller than he already did, harmless even. What on earth is he-

"H-hello!" Midoriya says in a tone that's both cheerful and nervous, his smile wobbly and eyes unable to settle on any one student for more than a few seconds. "My name is Midoriya Izuku. Thank you for having me!"

Shouta's speechless. Where the hell is the criminal mastermind that's been manipulating heroes and police alike for over a year? Is this another con he's trying to pull? Something to get the students to trust him? It's *bizarre*.

"AH!" Kirishima jerks up to his feet, hands slamming on his desk before he points at Midoriya excitedly. "I know you! From that raid a couple months ago. I'm glad you're okay!"

Midoriya blinks with surprise and gives another uneasy smile. "Oh. Yeah, hi. Um. Thanks? You, too?"

"Does that mean he's a hero?" Ashida pipes up as excitement sweeps through the class. "He looks our age!"

"Maybe an intern from another school?" Kaminari asks. "What's your story, man?"

For a moment, Shouta almost starts believing the nervous routine as Midoriya hangs a hand on the back of his neck, looking away from the students entirely. It comes across so naturally, makes him wonder if this is what Midoriya had been like before the loops started. There are a few uneasy looking students who seem on edge, ones that interacted with Kiddo during the training camp, but he's not sure they actually fully recognize him. The only one that definitely hasn't bought in to the act is Bakugou, who's watching the proceedings through narrowed eyes.

"Oh, I'm, uh." Midoriya hesitates as the students' attention sharpens with anticipation. Deciding how he wants to play this. Then he draws in a deep breath and says, "I'm a villain?"

The resulting surprise is fit to burst Shouta's eardrums but thankfully Iida immediately takes charge in his role as class president to try and calm the class. Not that Iida seems happy with the pronouncement and the looks on several faces have gone harder, more on edge despite Midoriya's act.

"Settle down," Shouta says, tired of the noise. "Midoriya's here for a rehabilitation program and to assist in future hero actions. I expect *all* of you to act accordingly."

"Sensei!" Iida pipes up with his hand in the air. "Perhaps we would be best served with a better understanding of his capabilities in case of an emergency!"

Makes sense. Shouta leans against his podium as he gives Midoriya a glance. Still a little crumpled, still giving the pathetic act. "Well?"

"Oh. Uh…" Midoriya straightens but his shoulders are still hunched up and every inch of him screams of awkwardness. "Please don't worry! I have no intention of hurting any of you. None of you are on my list!"

Shouta narrows his eyes because *what the hell*. Is he *trying* to ostracize himself from the students?

"You have a *list?!*" Sero asks incredulously and Midoriya winces.

"Yes, so I can be organized."

"...Just how many people are on your list?" Uraraka asks as she eyes him. She looks confused and off base. Maybe this is a good lesson in not trusting appearances…

Midoriya hesitates, then looks at his hands, counting out on his fingers and muttering to himself. The longer this goes on, the more on edge the students get.

"Fifty-eight," he says finally, sounding only partially sure. "We're waiting on one, but I'm not sure how many of the rest of them might have already been eliminated by my crew while I was in traction."

"That's more than enough already!" the class declares as one, barring Bakugou who's still just watching in silence.

“Stop it, all of you,” Shouta orders irritably, his ears ringing. Damn, and he still hasn’t replaced his bottle of aspirin… “That’s enough, Midoriya. Don’t think I haven’t figured out what you’re trying to do. Sit down over there.”

Midoriya doesn’t let up the act, just glancing up at him with a contrite expression he doesn’t trust at all before heading to the extra desk Shouta had brought in last night.

“Oh, so he was just trying to wind us up?” Sato asks hopefully.

“No. He was being honest,” Shouta says to stop some of the relief that had been starting to seep into his hellions. “He was just going on about unnecessary things. Look, it’s true that Midoriya is a villain but also true that the school has decided to attempt rehabilitation- for reasons we will *not* be going into right now.”

Iida slowly lowers his hand.

“Any complaints can be brought to Principal Nedzu on your own time. In the meantime, I don’t expect any of you to be stupid enough to get involved in his business, nor does he have interest in any of you.”

Several pairs of eyes shoot over to Midoriya but he keeps his attention on Shouta, inadvertently proving his point.

“While he’s here, we’ll be taking advantage by using him as a sparring partner for you during special trainings-”

“You want us to fight him?!” Kaminari protests immediately, horrified.

Shouta rubs the growing headache at his temple. “*Yes*. You’ll all benefit from sparring with an unusual opponent like Midoriya who uses unfamiliar tactics. It will better prepare you for duty for those of you who haven’t faced a villain in an offensive capacity.”

Several students shift uncomfortably in their seats.

“Does this mean you’re giving me back my knives?” Midoriya asks at entirely the wrong moment, cheerful and friendly and sending shivers down the spines of most of the students.

“No. You’ll be given dummies of the correct weight.”

“Sensei! When will we start these new training sessions?” Iida asks with his hand held high. He could at least wait to be called on…

“In about ten minutes,” Shouta answers. “Go change and meet me at Gym Gamma.”

The class is utter chaos after that but they file out to do his bidding with plenty of backward glances to the only person who *didn’t* get up. Midoriya doesn’t even try to hide that he’s waiting for a moment. He waits until the last student is gone and then the act drops immediately as if it hadn’t been there at all.

“This isn’t going to work,” Midoriya says, staring at Shouta head on.

“Like your innocent act?”

“No, that worked. None of them trust me and they’ll continue being on guard like they should be.”

Shouta narrows his eyes. “I figured you were pulling something like that.”

“Only because it’s necessary.” Midoriya gets out of his seat and picks up his case to set it up on his desk. “I’m not dragging them down with me when I know how promising they all are as heroes. If I had my way, they’d *never* have to meet me.”

“Maybe you’re underestimating them.”

“Maybe you’re underestimating *me*.”

It’s a valid enough point. Shouta crosses his arms and considers it, but… The best way to save Midoriya is to give him something else to lose. He’d been a student once. Surely, he’d had friends. Surely he could have them again.

Giving Midoriya privacy to change, Shouta goes to the door and frowns as he catches the tail of someone’s jacket disappearing around the corner. He frowns but doubts whoever was lagging behind heard anything that might cause problems. He’ll just have to deal with it when they come to that.

Gym Gamma has been built up into a series of uneven columns and walls, not quite mimicking the city scape of Ground Beta but similar in the amount of cover provided. It’ll be good for the more acrobatic hero students, giving them access to several levels to work off, and for the ones who need cover to set up their strikes.

Among the group of 1-A students in their gym uniforms, Aoyama Yuga hopes no one can see how badly he’s sweating. He hadn’t thought this day would come. Things have been quiet for a while, nothing worth reporting, and now the villain *Kiddo* is at his school for some reason. He hasn’t had his hunch actually confirmed, but Yuga knows he’s right. Kiddo is the only teenage villain anyone’s talking about these days and Midoriya matches the description he was told to look out for. It’s him. He knows it’s him.

That means this time, Yuga has to do more than feed information. He tastes bile in the back of his throat and he hasn’t even started using his quirk yet.

When Aizawa walks into the gym, the person trailing behind him is in full costume. The nearly full black is a dead giveaway for an underground hero or villain, all sleek lines and practicality. The virulent green accents emphasize parts that have to be more armored and break up the black to disguise some of his figure. Light glints off the mask hanging around Kiddo’s neck, his hood hanging down his back, and he’s still tugging one of his gloves a little tighter over his fingers.

Yuga wishes he hadn’t seen this costume. His belly clenches so hard he could die.

There's a quiet rumble of mutters as the two of them walk up to stand in front of the class. Midoriya isn't bothering to act nervous anymore, like the costume itself has made him a different person. His steely gaze makes Yuga shiver.

"Here's how this is going to go. You'll all be facing Midoriya until either the matches are finished or Midoriya taps out," Aizawa explains, sending ripples of surprise through the class. "A win is determined when one person is unconscious, unable to move, or has received a confirmed kill shot."

Midoriya lifts a knife to show them. The edge is bright red, too bright for blood but easy to see.

"Midoriya's weapons have been coated in chalk that will immediately show if he's made contact. As you are heroes, it's expected you will *not* go for kills."

Yuga wants to laugh or maybe cry.

And then Aizawa looks at him and Yuga *doubly* wants to cry. "We'll go by seat number. Aoyama, you're up."

Reluctantly, Yuga steps forward and goes to stand before Midoriya. There's something about the way Midoriya looks at him that burns right through his body, making it hard to even consider moving. He barely hears Aizawa call start before Midoriya's right up in his face and there's a dull pain digging into his chest. Yuga's eyes widen as he feels soft curls against his cheek.

"Don't worry," Midoriya whispers in his ear, barely audible over Aizawa calling the match, "I know you'll do the right thing."

The moment is broken when Midoriya backs off and Yuga looks down at the bright mark right over his heart. It's like a *brand*.

"Match," Aizawa announces in an almost bored tone. "Midoriya wins."

Yuga stumbles back to his classmates, barely even noticing the way they eye the mark. Right thing? What does Midoriya even mean? What does he *know?!* As Ashido makes her way up, Yuga covers his mouth and prays he can keep from throwing up at the sheer weight of what he's had to do to protect his life so far and the task that has presented itself in front of him. The right thing…

He hasn't done the right thing in a long time.

Ashido goes down within a minute. Asui takes nearly seven. Iida's down in two. On and on, the hero students go down with little fight. The red marks on them make the point of this exercise clear, at least to Yaoyorozu Momo.

After Sato is defeated with a double hit to both kidneys, Aizawa calls a pause and throws a bottle of water to Midoriya, who sinks down to sit and rest a bit. A projector screen rolls

down from the ceiling and Aizawa puts up images of every defeat.

“What do all of these have in common?” he asks, glancing over the class that has just gotten more morose after every fight.

“They’re all cheap shots!” Kirishima grouses bitterly, his own mark shining from the back of his neck when Midoriya had taken advantage of his tendency to bullrush forward to get behind him. He’d lasted not quite a minute.

“They’re all potentially *lethal*,” Aizawa corrects in a harsher tone that has all of them standing straighter. “Most of you are going to be limelight heroes. The kinds of villains you face are not generally going to be like Midoriya. He values efficiency, which means he looks for the fastest way to remove his obstacles permanently. He’s not looking for a fight or to show off. He’s not going to monologue about his dreams or complain about the world. He’s not looking to distract you from whatever he’s doing. He’s trying to kill you because you might trouble him again later if he doesn’t.”

Momo shivers, looking over the images and wondering how she’ll stack up against those who have already lost to Midoriya.

“If he has an ideology, he won’t be telling you about it,” Aizawa goes on. “Trying to convert you to his way of thinking will take too long. Trying to convert him to *yours* is even more worthless. It’s easier to take you out quickly and move on to his next objective. *You* are handicapped in that you will do everything you can to take him down without killing or permanently injuring him, but he has no reason to offer you the same courtesy if you get in his way.”

Without her permission, Momo’s gaze slides to the boy sitting on the floor. Midoriya is small but he’d taken a hit full to the chest of Kirishima’s hardened fist just to get into position for his own strike and seemed no worse for wear. There’s a sturdiness to him that’s easier to see in costume than in his uniform. And… That makes her realize. She hasn’t seen him use his quirk yet. Not unless it’s something too subtle for her to notice it out right.

“This kind of villain isn’t common,” Aizawa says, bringing her out of her head. “You’ll see them more in underground capacities. Getting flashy *usually* isn’t their style-”

“Hey, all of your students are *alive* because I got flashy,” Midoriya protests and Aizawa shoots him a dirty look.

“Your participation cost the lives of *four people*,” he growls out and Momo feels her insides clench up, remembering the aftermath of the training camp event.

“Four *villains*,” Midoriya says, like that makes it any better. “I’m allowed to take out the trash in my own community when they’ll just cause problems again.”

Glaring for a moment, Aizawa turns back to them with hardened resolve at the detached way Midoriya spoke. “That’s what I mean. Midoriya is a type of villain you will only sometimes come across, but you need to know how to recognize them and how to act accordingly, or they *will* kill you because it’s easier than fighting you.”

They begin the matches again. Shoji holds out for a while before he's taken out with a gut shot that would have left his intestines in pieces. Jiro goes down nearly as quickly as Aoyama did. Sero manages two minutes. Tokoyami lasts longer, but only because Midoriya leads him on a chase through the pillars before it turns out he has small flash grenades hidden in his costume that he uses to distract long enough to get the kill.

"He's got other weapons?" Kaminari asks in what was probably supposed to be a whisper to Ashido.

She grimaces. "Should we feel more pathetic that he didn't bother using them on us?"

As Todoroki goes up to take his turn, Midoriya suddenly relaxes and holds up his hand. "Forfeit."

It's the first time he's refused and Todoroki looks as taken aback as the rest of them. He blinks, glances at their teacher, and then just nods. But as Todoroki turns to head back to the group, Momo barely catches the slight shift of Midoriya's weight before he's launched himself into the air. His hand comes down on Todoroki's shoulder, using him as a stool to flip over Todorki's body and twist. The knife comes down and slams into Todoroki's chest before he can react. Ice creeps up Todoroki's arm for a second before he gets control of his surprise and by then Midoriya's landed.

"Match," Aizawa says. "Midoriya wins."

"Cheap shot! He called forfeit!" Kirishima yells with several others giving their own angry agreements. Todoroki looks down at his shirt, staring at the red mark over his heart like it might be able to explain to him what just happened.

"It's called lying," Midoriya says, sounding cheerful and light as he straightens. Almost like the boy he'd been pretending to be in the classroom.

"It's called subterfuge," Aizawa corrects and then starts into a short lecture on choosing your battles, turning things in your favor, not turning your back on opponents… It's all very important things that Momo should be paying attention to, but her eyes are stuck on Midoriya as he sips more water. He's their age. Just what had turned him into such a cold, calculating person? What made him think this was his only option? Or… had it not been? What if he'd just *wanted* to be this way?

He lifts his head and meets her gaze, and her entire body locks in place at the intensity in his eyes. She can't even take a breath until he looks away again.

"Oi, *Deku!*" Bakugou calls out as Aizawa hits a stopping point. "Time for you to lose."

He saunters past all of them, eyes narrow and tight with anger Momo doesn't quite understand. He can't be that offended by the dirty trick, can he? Bakugou hates Todoroki. But Midoriya looks more attentive as he rises to his feet again.

"No," he says and his face is almost blank, his earlier mirth entirely absent. "I'm not fighting you, Kacchan."

“Haaa? You running away from me, nerd?!”

“Forfeit-”

“*Like hell I’m letting you forfeit!*”

Even as Aizawa starts to open his mouth to call Bakugou off, Midoriya lifts his knife up to his own throat and slashes a chalk line across it with a quick, practiced jerk. Like he’s done it before. Like he’s done it *a lot* of times before. Momo clenches her hands in her shirt because even though she’s never seen that happen before, the bright red of the chalk suddenly goes dark and wet to her mind’s eye.

“*Forfeit*,” Midoriya snarls, throwing down his knife.

The clatter shocks Bakugou out of his sudden stupor at the move and he starts yelling as explosions light up his palms. Aizawa’s on him immediately to stand down as several of their classmates try to calm Bakugou, but Momo’s attention is entirely on Midoriya. The way his body only seems held up by his skeleton locked in place, his muscles too weak to offer assistance. The way his expression is so very *tired* with hundreds of years in his half lidded eyes. He’s not proud of pulling a trick like with Todoroki. That wasn’t a trick. It was a *promise*.

Momo’s feet move forward before she can stop herself. She gets within three feet of him before Midoriya’s attention jerks onto her like a physical thing and she freezes. Anything she might have been half planning to say to him disappears from her mind. Then he sighs and the tension drains away again.

“Don’t,” he says quietly, keeping it just between them.

“Are… are you okay?”

“*Don’t*. I won’t be here long. You don’t have to try to look after me, Yaomomo.”

The nickname coming so naturally from a stranger feels like a shot as her eyes widen and then he curses under his breath, reaching up to rub between his eyes.

“Sorry,” he says without looking at her. Angry with himself? “Slipped. I won’t be so familiar with you.”

Momo would never exactly call herself brave. She’s trying to be a hero, sure, but that’s because she has the right makeup of talents and resources to be able to do it and that means she’s got an obligation to, right? That’s what it means to be a hero, being called to help because you *can*.

“It’s okay,” she says. “You can… You can call me Yaomomo. You’re here for rehabilitation, right? So… Maybe making friends is part of that.”

He gives a quiet, bitter laugh and for a moment, it’s like she *hit* him. He rubs his hand down his face and turns back to her. His eyes seem so dark, a shine of moisture over them growing.

“No matter how friendly you are, I would tear every one of you down to reach my goals,” he says with not even a hint of falsehood or overstatement and despite the gentle tone, ice goes down her spine. “You’re a stepping stone for me. I’ll throw you to the wolves at the *first hint* that it will further my goals.”

It feels as if a wall of force pushes on her, making her take a step back as he continues to stare at her.

“The moment you start trying to *save* me, I’ll turn on you.”

A lump clogs Momo’s throat and it doesn’t go away when she swallows. She takes another step back. If she looks away, Momo wonders if Midoriya will make good on his threat. But… She’s going to be a hero because she can be. Sometimes heroes have to make the first move towards trust. Momo turns her back on him, walks back to her friends, and is only a little surprised when Midoriya doesn’t stab her to complete his set.

Chapter End Notes

Woot for Aizawa's mixed signals and Midoriya being a BAMF for the sole purpose of proving a point.

So I decided I'm gonna do a sorta nanowrimo using this fic. So either I finish it before the next 50k or there's gonna be another 50k of it, I don't know which. We'll see! But it does mean that updates will probably be a smidge faster since I should be hitting the word count for one in like three days at a pop.

Why do I do this to myself.

Chapter 22

Chapter Notes

> ...should I keep mentioning when there's a suicide mention in these chapters or can it be kind of assumed there's a chance of it? It seems like i'm doing the double warning nearly every chapter now because the adult characters continue to be reasonably concerned about it.
>
> Anyway. Suicide mention in this chapter.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

"You did *what?!*"

"He passed the test, no one was injured, I don't know why you're so upset."

Toshinori stares at Aizawa harder and the man absolutely refuses to back down or even look sorry for his actions.

"I suppose it was as good a way as any to let the students know how outclassed they might be by a villain in the future and to prove Midoriya is willing to work within our confines," Nedzu says in a surprisingly understanding tone, "but I do wonder how well it will serve our greater purpose."

Leaning back a bit more in his chair, Aizawa crosses his arms and says, "You're thinking too narrowly. The truth about Midoriya would have come out eventually anyway. Starting off with it, making it clear to the students how dangerous he is from the beginning, was the safer option."

"I feel just talking with them might have left less resentment," Toshinori says.

"Telling them wouldn't have ground in the point. I know my students, they would have underestimated him. That's why I didn't tell them he's quirkless."

"I fear this will *definitely* sow seeds of resentment." Nedzu steeples his paws, considering things. "Setting them up as antagonists…"

"It won't be a problem," Aizawa says with a shrug. "From the conversations as we left the gym, all I've done is light a fire under several of them to get better."

Toshinori can almost picture that, knowing class 1-A. If they didn't know Midoriya's quirkless, then it probably looked like he was holding back and still defeated them. It would almost come across as mockery.

“Besides, even after watching him utterly destroy sixteen students, Yaoyorozu still approached him in a friendly manner.”

“She was a recommendation student, correct?” Toshinori asks.

“One that’s been doing very well in class,” Nedzu confirms, a considering expression on his face.

“She has good instincts when she isn’t overthinking herself into a corner,” Aizawa says. “If she’s willing to try and make friends, there are several others who will follow in her wake. Frankly, I suspect most of the class will try to adopt him within a week.”

Toshinori’s not so sure. Pride can be a heavy thing and the way Midoriya almost effortlessly put down the entire class one after another… “You said he refused to fight Bakugou?”

“I had put 50/50 odds on whether he’d be willing or not. It seems he’s not going to put himself against Bakugou even for training. That may bite him in the ass later, considering Bakugou’s personality.”

“Please monitor the situation,” Nedzu says and then reaches out for a packet of papers, flipping through a few. “Now. I’d like to discuss the Detective’s hypothesis.”

“That we’re treading on unmarked ground?” Toshinori asks, getting a nod in response. “If we take Midoriya’s word on the time loops, isn’t that a good thing? We know his end goal. We know that his previous actions have not accomplished it. Maybe this time with our support-”

“Maybe this time Midoriya gets desperate and kills himself to get back on track if things go too far off the rails,” Aizawa interrupts, his voice cold as Toshinori stills at the very notion. “Midoriya is calculating and methodical. If we’re that far off from the story he knows, he may decide resetting is a safer bet.”

“I had considered the possibility,” Nedzu says. “His room is being monitored, since I doubt he would attempt in front of an escort.”

Toshinori’s belly tightens with unease. Both of them are so sure, have already set up safeguards he hadn’t considered might be needed and he doesn’t understand. Isn’t this a better outcome than Midoriya’s other choices?

“Are you so certain he would…?”

Aizawa shoots Toshinori a harder look. “You’ve seen the aftermath of his battles. Midoriya has *zero* concern for his own life because he knows he’ll just come back. Why would this be any different?”

“But if this current environment is so new to him, wouldn’t he wish to explore it?”

“Sure. By figuring out how he got here in the first place through trial and error, however many times it takes, and then seeing how many possibilities open up for him.”

The ice in Aizawa's voice is like a slap, but Toshinori deserves it. He covers his face a moment, then slides his fingers back through his hair. A new avenue of opportunity should have been a good thing but seen this way… The unpredictability would be terrifying for someone who has spent so long on known paths.

"He's even more of a danger to himself than anything else," Nedzu says, setting down the packet. It's a copy of the notebook Midoriya had given up to Tsukauchi. Toshinori has read through it, chilled by the hints of future troubles Midoriya has apparently witnessed. How much of that has changed since he stopped bothering to outlive Bakugou, Toshinori has no idea.

What he keeps being reminded of, though, is the very first note: *April - Sludge monster attack, saved by All Might, don't follow him, don't be chosen.*

Toshinori doesn't remember it. He's vaguely aware of a sludge based villain he'd put away at some point, but this moment in Midoriya's life he has no memory of. Don't follow him, don't be chosen - chosen for *what?* Because Toshinori's been spinning through possibilities and he keeps coming back to one: chosen as his successor.

It seems insane considering how much havoc someone like Midoriya could wreck with One For All in his hands, but at the same time… At the same time, he remembers listening to a boy say that All Might was the first person to believe in him. A boy willing to put everything on the line. A boy who picks himself up after every failure and tries again and again and *again.*

In another life, Midoriya would be exactly what Toshinori was looking for.

"Not again," Toshinori vows softly to himself, lifting his head to pin both of them down with a hard look. "I will not let that boy die again."

"That may not be your call," Aizawa says but Toshinori isn't having it.

"It is if I make it be."

Aizawa's eyes narrow and Nedzu makes a quiet noise of interest.

"And Togata?" he asks, sounding curious rather than needling.

"I'll train them together."

"That may not be wise," Aizawa says in a more tense tone.

Toshinori knows there's plenty of reasons why it wouldn't be, but he has to do something. He has to save this boy, even if it's from himself. He needs to give Midoriya a reason to save himself.

"I don't see why it can't be tried," Nedzu decides after a moment and Aizawa glares at him. "We're in new territory, gentlemen. Giving Midoriya more anchors can't hurt. Maybe Togata can help get through to him."

Sighing with frustration, Aizawa gets up from his chair and heads to the door. “Figure out a training schedule around your time limit and let me know-”

“Oh,” Toshinori says and flinches when Aizawa twists around to glare at him. “He uh. Midoriya- He already knows about it.”

“What?!”

“He approached me before all this when I wasn’t transformed. He knew exactly who I was.”

Aizawa’s lips press tight a moment and then he turns back to the door. “One less thing to worry about then.”

The door slams after him and Toshinori feels kind of bad for upsetting him, but he’s sure this is the right course of action. Midoriya needs support, needs anchoring presences, needs *friends* and *mentors*. If Toshinori can give him that… wouldn’t it be wrong for him to refuse?

“I’m willing to support you,” Nedzu says in the quiet left behind by Aizawa. “Just be sure you know what you’re doing.”

The smile Toshinori gives him isn’t as confident as he wishes it was. All he can do is try.

This isn’t really going to be helpful, is it?

Yamada Hizashi looks at the boy next to him from the corner of his eye but Midoriya hasn’t looked up from the paperwork he’s been diligently filling out since they got to this classroom. It seems almost mean to make him go through general knowledge assessment tests when he has no hope of being a student but Hizashi guesses Nedzu is just trying to keep him busy.

Better to be bored by assessments than out doing… all *that*.

Looking at him right now, it’s hard for Hizashi to believe all the stories, even though he has no real reason to doubt them. Reports from the police, testimonies from pro heroes, from *Shouta* even, but looking at Midoriya all he sees is a very focused teenage boy. In the hour since school ended and Shouta passed the kid over to him, Midoirya’s barely said a word. Hizashi finished grading papers for most of his classes and-

Oh, that’s an idea, isn’t it?

“-Ready for a break?-” Hizashi asks in English.

Midoriya lifts his head but his gaze goes inward, picking through the words. “-I am not finish.-”

Broken, but trying! Hizashi’s always been the type to appreciate the effort more than perfection and he’s thrilled the kid responded at all.

“-Come on, maybe something more practical? Put it down for a second, let’s have a chat.-”

He can tell Midoriya has a harder time muddling through all of that but he still gamely tries. Still, Midoriya puts down his pencil and sits up straighter.

"-In English?-" he asks and Hizashi doesn't see why not use this as a learning opportunity. Who knows how much time this kid villain has gotten in a real classroom?

What follows is nearly two hours of silted but slowly smoothing conversation, a lot of repetition, and several tangents on grammar and word choice. It's probably the most intellectually stimulated Hizashi has been in a long time, not the least in part due to Midoriya's sincere interest in learning. If he were any other boy, Hisashi would be over the moon to have such an attentive pupil.

They're still in the thick of it when Shouta comes by to fetch Midoriya and Hizashi abruptly remembers who it is he's been talking to. *What* this boy is. Hizashi covers the sudden shift in his mood well enough that Midoriya doesn't notice but Shouta gives him a narrowed, penetrating look that means he'll be back for answers and Hizashi's not sure what to say to him.

For a little while, Midoriya had just been another student, one who was attentively trying to learn and doing well at it. The escort is a cold reminder that he's far more. It almost doesn't seem fair.

By the time Shouta comes back after dropping Midoriya off in his locked dorm room, Hizashi mostly has himself set back to rights. Seeing the kid as just a kid is part of the rehabilitation process, right? It's what Hizashi is supposed to be doing. Giving Midoriya a chance to *be* a kid, giving him glimpses of normality, making him *want* it.

There's an annoyed tilt to Shouta's mouth when Hizashi looks up but before he can ask, Shouta says, "Don't."

Hizashi's gotten pretty good at figuring out when that means he can pester and when he can't.

"Did he say something to you?" Shouta asks and Hizashi blinks.

"What?"

"You're off base. I can speak with him about whatever it was."

And it's stupid, reading more into that protective care Shouta's always shown him when Hizashi *knows* it's just friendly, it'll always just be friendly, he's not even sure Shouta *can* fall in love with someone because he's never seen him date, but…

It still makes him want to respond to it anyway. "It's nothing he said. I just…For a little while, I forgot what he was."

"Yeah." Shouta rakes a hand back through his hair as his shoulders sag. "I get that."

It's comforting that Hizashi's not the only one. "I feel kinda bad for when I warned you off trying this, now."

Which gets him a snort and a rakish smile and Hizashi falls for him all over again.

“Don’t let your guard down too much. He’s still dangerous. He’s just fine with playing nice right now.”

“Yeah…”

Shouta clasps his shoulder a moment and then turns to go. As he watches Shouta’s retreating back, Hizashi almost calls out to him but… It doesn’t feel right. They’ve both had a long day. Shouta doesn’t need him dropping more on him.

There’s nothing like Oboro in Midoriya but Hizashi thinks about him anyway on his way back home, wondering what he would have been like grown, what Shouta would have been like without losing him, and figures this is just the kind of day when you can indulge in the what ifs.

It’s never a good week when there’s a rush of bodies being found. Naomasa doubts they’ll identify this one. The corpse was burned at such high heat that the bones crumble to dust when disturbed. No clothes or personal effects survived the blaze.

They’ve found over a dozen bodies in the last few weeks, several of them burned like this. Others eviscerated, some even exsanguinated…

Naomasa didn’t want to believe Midoriya left orders like these, but they have to be related to the kill list he’d mentioned. They’re too on track for the MO of his most known crew members. He just wishes he knew what connected them all.

The victims are civil servants, ordinary citizens, a few low level criminals who know how to keep their noses clean. They’re people with no record at all, ones with a single speeding ticket, ones with a misdemeanor here and there. These aren’t people Midoriya seems the type to target and Naomasa is sure he’s missing something. They have to be connected. There has to be a *reason*. Everything Midoriya and his crew do has a reason.

He’s poured over Midoriya’s notebook and there’s mention of someone called Re-Destro but no civilian information. The entries are vague.

November - kill the underlings, flush out the generals. Corner Re-Destro alone and take him down

Simple, concise. Worked just fine for someone who already knew what it was referencing but for Naomasa it’s nothing but frustration. He needs names. He needs to find these people before Kiddo’s crew can. He needs to stop this boy who thinks he’s working for good before he gets any further in his insane plans.

“Detective?”

Naomasa looks up as one of the officers walks up with something in his gloved hands. A book? He takes it, frowning over the lurid red cover. *Meta Liberation War?* Naomasa flips it

open and… Oh. Oh, he knows this book. Some crazy villain's autobiography that keeps getting reprinted every decade or so as the rights are bought and sold over and over again. A manifesto for people who balk at the safety concerns with uncontrolled quirk usage. He's come across it a few times, but what it has to do with the current murder spree, he's not sure.

Wait.

The author. Could this Re-Destro have something to do with the original Destro? It would make sense in the twisted way criminals often did if Destro's propaganda had infected a new generation.

"Bag it," Naomasa orders, "and then I want you to see if you can track where it was sold from and who's publishing this again."

"Got it."

It might be a dead end but it might give him some insight into how Kiddo's crew are choosing their victims. The sooner he sees the pattern, the sooner he can prevent any more unnecessary death.

This is definitely the same boy. The clothes are different, an actual costume versus the blank hoodie from before, and he's not wearing a mask, but Mirio recognizes him anyway. There's something about the way he stands, the way he takes everything in. This is definitely Kiddo, the same one who warned him about the USJ attack and pushed All Might to choose him as his successor.

Which means Midoriya Izuku *knows*, right? About One For All. About the quirk Mirio was given so he could carry on All Might's legacy.

"Don't hold back just because I'm quirkless," Midoriya says - and it's strange to call him that but Mirio's trying to see him as more of the person in front of him and not the villain from all the rumors. "Underestimating your opponent can be a fatal mistake."

"Yeah, but you wouldn't really hurt me," Mirio replies cheerfully. "Otherwise, you wouldn't have worked so hard to get me where I am."

Midoriya looks at him like he's seeing something for the first time in a long time, but then the moment is gone and he just smiles.

"Sure, as long as you take me seriously."

He'd been a little unsure when All Might announced this joint training session, especially when the first words out of Midoriya's mouth was to tell him of his quirklessness, but Midoriya's complete lack of concern helps soothe him. He wouldn't have survived as long as he has in the criminal underworld if he weren't highly capable.

When All Might calls for them to begin, Mirio isn't surprised by the way Midoriya immediately closes the distance, but he *is* by how well Midoriya deals with his Permeation. It

never phases him when his fists move into and through Mirio, not like even some of his classmates who have been sparring with him for years still do. He just bides his time, pushes Mirio through his paces and takes his shots when Mirio's least expecting it.

They go at it a while and it's a nice workout before suddenly Midoriya touches Mirio's chest and a shock of debilitating electricity shoots through him. Mirio topples, muscles twitching even without the attack continuing.

"You're holding back," Midoriya says like he's disappointed as he pulls a tiny, blackened disk off his palm and stuffs it into his pocket.

"What?"

"I told you to take me seriously. Why aren't you using One For All?"

The question shouldn't catch him as off guard as it does but… To be honest, even with how long he's had All Might's quirk, it still doesn't quite feel like *his*. It's like he's just holding it for someone else. He only pulls on it when he needs to and he's nowhere near comfortable doing so.

"I-"

"You should *at least* have access to the physical enhancements," Midoriya goes on, though he seems like he's looking through Mirio instead of at him. "The other abilities are hit or miss, but that one's always active in wielders, might as well be considered the baseline of the quirk, so you should be able to get it down to where using it is as natural as Permeation…"

Mirio stares at him as Midoriya continues to mumble, a hand at his mouth as his eyes twitch from one side to another like he's reading words from a screen or checking through a book. It's bizarre. Does Midoriya go on muttered tangents like this often?

"Uh, Midoriya…?"

"-have figured by now that at least Blackwhip would be unlocked but Banjo can be testy about users," Midoriya's still going on, completely focused on what's going on in his head. "Though you probably *do* have Danger Sense by now, Shinomori's not as stingy-"

Blinking, Mirio looks over to All Might, who's started walking over to them to find out what's wrong. Mirio shrugs at his questioning expression.

"-of course, if *that* comes out, it just means Shimura probably likes you-"

All Might freezes a moment as his eyes widen and then he reaches out to grab Midoriya's shoulder. Before his hand makes contact, Midoriya snaps into action, grabbing hold of All Might's arm and flipping the larger man over his shoulder. Even before All Might hits the ground, Midoriya twists to slide his hand around All Might's throat to slam his head down harder into the dirt of the training field, other hand moving to claw out his eyes.

Mirio barely notices he's pulled at One For All until he's already got hold of Midoriya's arm and sees the near white electric arcs over his own body. The speed boost is the only reason he

got there in time and he starts dragging Midoriya back off All Might.

“Finally,” Midoriya says, lips pulling back into something approaching a grimacing smile. Then he twists his body like a gymnast and next thing Mirio knows, there are thighs wrapped tight around his neck and head and his own feet leave the ground. Mirio hits the ground with a grunt and wishes he’d already figured out how to use Permeation at the same time as One For All.

Lifting his head, Mirio looks over to where Midoriya’s already righted himself and is reaching out a hand to All Might.

“Sorry. I don’t react well to getting crowded,” Midoriya says in a cheerful, friendly tone.

“No, I should have guessed it would startle you,” All Might replies and there’s something in his tone that’s a little far away. Did his head get knocked too much? Mirio scrambles over to make sure he’s all right.

“Young Midoriya, what you were muttering about-” All Might says but Midoriya interrupts him almost immediately.

“Doesn’t matter, you don’t have to worry about anything.”

“But-”

“Look, you only unlocked the parts of One For All that you needed and Mirio will probably be the same,” Midoriya says, looking between them and seeming almost like he was *their* senior instead of the other way around. “He already has a pretty strong quirk of his own-”

“How do you know so much about One For All?” All Might asks and Midoriya cuts himself off, his lips pressing in a tight line. “It can’t just be from your loops. It can’t just be things you’ve witnessed. You *know* One For All.”

Which is really weird because even the few people who know *of* One For All don’t have a great working knowledge of how it works. Even Mirio is still getting his head around it and that’s nothing on the practical side. At least he’s not breaking his own limbs like he did for the first couple months.

“Young Midoriya.” All Might’s voice goes lower, softer between the three of them. “You were a wielder.”

Mirio startles at that, jerking his gaze back over to Midoriya who’s gone still and silent. His hands are tightly fisted at his sides, his gaze is on the ground between them. The idea of a villain having the power of One For All is terrifying, but…

“Mid-”

“Not for a long time,” he says through gritted teeth. “You made a mistake with me, I fixed it for you-”

“I *chose* you,” All Might says, like he’s confirming something he had already known for a while.

And that… hurts? Mirio thinks maybe it hurts. He looks up at All Might and wonders if this is real. If Midoriya was meant to be chosen as All Might’s successor and not him. If he’s even *worthy* of this quirk.

“I can’t be the symbol of peace the way Lemillion will be,” Midoriya says as if every word is taking a chunk of him with it. “Maybe I could have before, maybe it was possible, but the me I am now? I can’t. I can’t put everyone else first, I can’t smile in the face of destruction, I can’t save-”

“Hey, Midoriya, it’s okay,” Mirio tries, reaching out to him because his eyes are filling with tears. Then Midoriya’s head jerks up like he forgot where he was for a minute and just realized it.

“I-I’m sorry, I can’t- right now-” Midoriya stares at them wide eyed with tears rolling down his cheeks. He takes a shaky step back and then another one. “I need-”

When he turns and starts running back to the school, Mirio calls out and starts after him only for All Might to stop him.

“I’ll handle this,” he says. “Go get cleaned up.”

As Mirio watches All Might run after Midoriya, watches Midoriya’s small figure disappear from his sight, he says to himself, “Even if I’m not the true successor, I won’t let either of you down.”

The oath settles deep in his chest.

Chapter End Notes

> Mirio I love you and wish I was better at your narration <3<3<3 squeeze your goddamn cheeks

Chapter 23

Chapter Notes

I'm just gonna keep doing the heads up, just in chase.

Suicide references in this chapter.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Katsuki's restless. He's been restless since that practical lesson when fucking Deku refused to fight him. Everything about that was wrong, wrong, wrong, and he hasn't been able to figure out if his irritation is at the loss of an opportunity to show those extras his skills or having Deku look down on him *again.*

It's definitely the latter.

He'd spent the rest of the day biting off the heads of anyone too stupid to leave him alone, considered doing it *literally* in a few cases. How *dare* someone like Deku make him feel this way, How dare Deku pretend like he's so much better, like Katsuki wouldn't even have a chance against him.

How dare Deku pretend that death is better than the risk of hurting him.

Katsuki stops walking as the memory of Deku slitting his own throat flashes in front of his eyes. It shouldn't still be affecting him. It was a joke, it was mocking him, but he can't stop seeing it. He can't stop thinking *what if he did it for real*. The very idea sours his stomach.

Stupid goddamn Deku, ruining everything even when he's not in front of him.

Katsuki goes for a walk to clear his head. It's going to be dark soon and he should be doing finishing up that report for History, but he can't make himself sit still. The restless energy is still surging through his body in a mix of anger and confusion, which just makes him angrier. He can't believe that useless idiot can still get to him like this.

There was always something annoying about Deku, even when they were little. Every once in a while, an iron core of will would come up out of nowhere, giving him the strength to stand up for someone else or say the things that scared him or try to help even when his help wasn't needed. And then it would disappear behind tears and flinching and Katsuki can't pinpoint when his annoyance of that lost potential started to fester but things got worse as they aged. That inner strength just got weaker, showed itself less often, no matter how much Katsuki pushed and prodded at him. His frustration with listening to Deku's big dreams of heroism when he couldn't even protect *himself* only grew with every passing day, every time he heard the call of *Kacchan, Kacchan.*

Even seeing Deku's deadly confidence now still frustrates him. The skill with which Deku took down his classmates one by one looked effortless. He's not the Deku Katsuki used to know but there's still pieces of him there, Katsuki knows there are, even if Deku's finally stopped living in the delusion that he can be a hero.

Something moves in Katsuki's peripheral and he looks up only to spot the damn nerd himself racing across the campus towards Ground Beta. He's in his costume, had he been in another session with another class? Some one on one training? Wait, *where the hell is his escort?* The teachers have been so careful about tailing him every single minute!

And then Katsuki's tearing after him at top speed. He doesn't think about it, doesn't question himself, just races behind the black and green figure before him. As Deku nears Ground Beta, the gigantic doors are shut but that doesn't even slow him down. He jumps, gets a handhold and throws himself up higher, scrambles over the wall in seconds. It might have been impressive if Katsuki was really thinking about it, but instead he's propelling himself up after him with his explosions. Katsuki's feet hit the top of the wall as Deku lands inside and he watches Deku immediately start running again. He drops down and keeps his pursuit but it doesn't look like Deku's trying to *get* anywhere, so much as trying to run *from* something. Which is so typical that disappointment goes sour in Katsuki's mouth.

What the hell is that asshole trying to escape now?

Ahead of him, Deku trips over a curb and goes rolling, but recovers easily. It's just enough for Katsuki to catch up. He throws out a hand and catches Deku's forearm, jerking him around and nearly getting a fist in the face for it except Deku's wide eyes lock on his and he redirects the strike at the last split second to sail harmlessly past Katsuki's head.

"Don't you fucking hold back on me now!" Katsuki snarls at him and then it's *on*. Deku wouldn't give him the satisfaction of a fight before but Katsuki's not letting him out of it *now.* He presses the attack as naturally as breathing, entirely in his element as he forces Deku to make the decision of either getting his ass kicked or meeting Katsuki head on.

It takes a while, Katsuki gets in some good hits that don't *feel* good at all, but then Deku lets out a noise that doesn't even sound human and *finally* starts fighting back. He's fast and imaginative, his movements showing no rhythm or pattern Katsuki can pick up which means he can't think, it's pure instinct. He dodges past a fist, kicks a weak point, uses a strike that could have disabled him to give him the opportunity for some distance only to drive Deku back with well aimed blasts.

Even without his weapons, without a quirk, Deku's keeping up and it's *exhilarating*. The closest Katsuki has come to this was at the sports festival when Uraraka showed just how much power and drive she actually fucking had inside her, coming at him again and again until her body simply gave out on her her and solidifying herself as Katsuki's number two in the class. There are others with more sheer power, more specialized abilities, but Katsuki would rather have her at his back than even Kirishima. That was a fight he'd had to put his all into winning and it had been *glorious*.

And somehow this one is getting to him just like that and Katsuki doesn't know whether to be angry or pleased.

Deku dodges under his hands, knocks them aside or trips up Katsuki's footwork to bump him off his rhythm, uses his terrain like he's got a floating or rebound quirk. Every time Katsuki manages to land a hit, Deku's turning it back against him to push Katsuki the way he's always wanted him to. For once, this is a Deku that isn't afraid to meet him at full strength.

As Katsuki twists around a punch, he grabs Deku's shoulder to propel him further, trying to get at his back, only for Deku to roll with the push and dip forward. Katsuki narrowly dodges a boot to the face and lets out a growling laugh as Deku flips from his hands back onto his feet only to shoot back at him. It's exhilarating, all the action and none of the danger, with Deku finally, finally, *finally* pushing *back*.

Katsuki doesn't know how long they're at it before Deku's knocked back against one of the buildings and Katsuki pins him there with his body. They both pant for breath, wordless in the sudden lull from their fight. Green eyes lift to meet his own and Katsuki's not sure what he sees there but it catches him up, has his belly twisting up in ways that just piss him off all over again.

"The hell were you running from?" Katsuki asks and Deku just stares at him. "We could have done this before if you hadn't fucking forfeited."

Deku lets out a shaky laugh that hurts to listen to, sounds more like a sob. "*Kacchan,* you…"

"Haaa? What, you going back to being a coward-"

Then Deku surges forward and at first Katsuki thinks they're going to fight again but gloved hands seize his face and his vision is suddenly filled with freckles and dark eyelashes. He barely realizes there's a mouth on his at first in his shock but the battle high is still singing strong in his blood and as Deku works his mouth open, there's no way in *hell* Katsuki's going to back down. Deku's fingers slide back to grip his hair tight as Katsuki shoves him harder into the wall, biting at his lips and chasing his tongue back into his mouth.

This isn't something Katsuki does. He's been vaguely aware of sex and romance and all that stupidity, but it's never interested him as much as a good fight or training his quirk. His single minded obsession with becoming the number one hero is all he's ever needed. Maybe once he's a pro he'll think about getting a girlfriend, but the thought hadn't crossed his mind to be interested in anyone *now.*

He's never thought of Deku like this either and yet here he is, pressing his full body against Deku like he's trying to crawl into him and Deku's clutching at him with just as much force. Deku is solid and warm and so much stronger than his skinny frame lets on when Katsuki's fingers slide hard down his chest. It makes Katsuki want to tear off his costume and see how much of that is actual muscle versus armor woven into the cloth. It makes him want to bite down on Deku's thin shoulder and leave a mark that won't ever go away.

Deku's thigh shifts up between Katsuki's and there's sudden stimulation he hadn't expected and abruptly everything is too much. Katsuki slams both hands against Deku's chest to propel himself backward. He stumbles a few steps, his breathing uneven and loud as he stares at that fucking nerd who dared-

“You-” he manages and his voice sounds wrecked, Katsuki is going to *murder* that son of a bitch for doing this to him! His face is flushed, heart beating so fast that it almost hurts, and his body thrums with an unfamiliar want that’s so close to a good fight and yet so foreign Katsuki has no idea what the hell to do with it.

Deku stares at him with his stupid watery eyes, his lips bruised red and trembling. The dichotomy of lost passion and devastation gives Katsuki no solid ground to react to.

“I’m sorry,” Deku says and the dam *breaks*.

“Don’t you fucking apologize to me!” Katsuki screams back with explosions in his hands. “Don’t you dare think for a *second* that you can do anything bad enough to me for that! Stop looking down on me, you fucking bastard!”

“*I’m so sorry*.”

“Fuck your sorry!”

Deku’s sobbing and Katsuki hates the sight of it, the sound of it so much because Deku could be so much more than this *mess* and he just keeps sliding back every time he almost gets there. He keeps showing Katsuki these little glimpses of the competent hero he could be and then yanks them back like it’s just a joke. Like he’s just waving it in front of Katsuki’s face to fuck with him.

As Deku opens his mouth to give him another useless apology, Katsuki silences him with a roar of pure rage. Deku sinks down to his knees and Katsuki turns his back on him because he’s more than done with this. He walks away and doesn’t look back at the wretched way Deku calls his name.

There are times when Toshinori just feels… *old*. When he spotted Bakugou in pursuit of Midoriya, he’d thought perhaps this might be a good opportunity for the two of them to reconcile, for Midoriya to take comfort in a friend, someone Toshinori knows is vitally important to him. But he hadn’t thought things would turn out this way.

Young men often work through their emotions with their fists. Even Toshinori was that way, before One For All gave him the power to actually make a difference in the world. For heroes in training, it’s doubly sure that fights will break out as passions overwhelm. He just… hadn’t really expected them to twist in the opposite direction as well for these two.

Toshinori waits until Bakugou has climbed over the wall to show himself. No sense in embarrassing the already agitated boy further by letting him know his interlude had been witnessed. Bakugou will handle himself. Toshinori is more concerned with the other one.

Midoriya hasn’t moved from where Bakugou left him, head in his hands and body bent over itself. It makes him look small, so very young, and Toshinori aches for the turbulent mix of loneliness and grief that must be rolling through him.

“Young Midoriya,” he murmurs as he kneels before the boy, reaching out to rest a hand on his shoulder. Midoriya flinches but doesn’t rise. “It’s all right.”

“I shouldn’t be here,” Midoriya says, sounding like his chest is being crushed by the weight of his own feelings. “I can’t- He was right there and I just-”

“It’s all right,” Toshinori tries but Midoriya only gives a wretched sounding sob.

“For a second, I forgot. He was *mine* again,” the boy whispers as he curls in tighter on himself, forehead nearly on the ground as his hands slide into his hair to tug at it hard. “He was mine and he was- I should never have let you keep me here.”

Most heroes develop a sense of when things will go bad and Toshinori’s is blaring at full volume.

“None of this is right, none of this should have happened, I can’t *be here*…”

“Young Midoriya,” Toshinori tries again, his grip tightening on the boy’s shoulder as he shudders with his tears. It breaks his heart to see it, but he needs to shake Midoriya out of this state. This isn’t the healing sort of crying, he’s liable to spiral. “Stop. It won’t help you to think this way. Come with me back to my office. We can talk-”

“I promised myself I wouldn’t interfere in his life more than I had to,” Midoriya mutters as if he hasn’t even noticed Toshinori there at all. “I’d let him be *happy*, fall for Uraraka or Kirishima. I’d-”

Toshinori grabs his other shoulder and forces Midoriya to sit up. He carefully eases tight fingers out of short curls, meets wet, unseeing eyes that are still caught so far inward that he doubts Midoriya even knows who it is in front of him. His cheeks are drenched with tears that are still falling, his body shivering with every unsteady breath.

Only when Toshinori takes Midoriya’s face in his hands does the boy seem to snap out of it at all, focusing on Toshinori’s face finally.

“You’ve done nothing wrong today,” Toshinori tells him and shushes gently when Midoriya tries to argue with him. “You didn’t force young Bakugou to fight you or respond to your advances. He did so of his own will. You’ve done *nothing* wrong here.”

“He’s dead by New Year’s when he loves me,” Midoriya says, heartbroken, his lips pulling back as his upset only grows. Lifting his shaking hands to cover over Toshinori’s, his voice raises in pitch and breaks as he sobs. “I can’t keep him alive. I need to *leave*-”

“No. Listen to me, Midoriya. You’re not alone this time. All of us are watching and ready to defend Bakugou’s life.” *And yours*, but Toshinori is sure that that argument means nothing to him. He wonders how any of them expect to make Midoriya care about his own life again. “We’re with you, this time.”

Midoriya crumbles before him and all Toshinori can do is gather him into his arms and hold him tightly to his body. He feels thin fingers curl tight in the front of his jacket, feels the

shuddering of Midoriya's body as he cries.

It's that every time this starts, I'm fourteen goddamn years old again! Midoriya's overheard words echo in his ears and Toshinori sees it, right now, right here. He sees the boy for what he is, a terribly traumatized child who'd given up everything to save the most important person in his life from what seemed to be a fated end.

But Toshinori doesn't believe in fate and he'll prove Midoriya wrong if it's the last thing he does. They'll save Bakugou and they'll save Midoriya and he *pities* any force that tries to stop him.

"Midoriya, I'm here," he says to the top of the boy's head, hugs him tighter when it only brings more choking sobs. "*I am here*."

Because when All Might arrives at a scene, all will be well.

His phone goes off while Shouta's trying to get dinner into his foster child. She's had a hard day, she's tired, she's fussy. If Shouta isn't careful, she'll clam up and he won't get a single bite into her, but right now she's staring at her plate as if she's a million miles away and so close to crying it makes him physically ache inside. He doesn't know what set her off today but he kind of wants to stab it a billion times.

And then there's a phone call and Eri flinches and huddles further in on herself as Shouta curses under his breath. He moves away from the table to answer, hissing through his teeth, "*What?*"

"I'm on my way to your room," All Might says, as if it's a normal thing for teachers to visit each other in the staff boarding wing. Though, for all Shouta knows it *is* normal, it's just that he's one of the few that takes advantage of the free rooms in the first place because it's just too convenient not to.

"Now isn't a good time," Shouta says without looking at Eri because he doesn't at all want her to think he's upset she's there, which he is *not*, he just wants her to *eat*.

And then there's a muffled knock at the door, like someone's using their shoe to do it. "I'm already here."

When Shouta looks up, Eri's frozen stiff with her eyes wide and wet as she stares at the door. He might have to murder All Might for this. Taking a deep breath that doesn't calm him at all, Shouta pats Eri's stiff shoulder and says, "It's fine. I know who it is."

He goes to the door expecting to lay it into All Might (quietly), but when he opens it he's caught short. Midoriya looks even smaller held by the bulk of All Might's muscle form, like a tiny child rather than an undersized teenager. There's dust and dirt on his clothes, on his wet face, and the way he's clutching at All Might's suit jacket as he sleeps in his arms looks more childlike than just about anything Shouta's ever seen from him. Shouta jerks his eyes up to All Might's face to demand an explanation.

“He had a run in with Bakugou,” All Might says quietly and before Shouta can tense up, he adds, “They’re both uninjured. Physically, at least. There was a fight and then…”

Shouta’s never seen All Might get embarrassed, but he thinks this is fairly close as the man tries to gather himself up a bit more.

“A romantic interlude that ended badly,” is what All Might decides to say, which tells Shouta *nothing*.

“Badly?”

“They had a short argument and then Bakugou left. Midoriya was… distraught.”

Shouta looks back down at the boy and studies his slack, tear streaked face. “Why did you bring him here?”

“I don’t think he should be alone,” which had to be hard to say considering how difficult it had been for All Might to understand that a kid with suicidal tendencies doesn’t just get magically better when his circumstances improve. “And he trusts you.”

“Me?”

“He’ll talk to you sooner than he will me.”

Which is… probably true. Shouta thinks about the traumatized little girl at the table, likely straining to hear what they’re saying so she knows if she should be (more) scared or not. She’d been asking after Midoriya a little less each day, but it’s still clear to him that she wants to see him again. Maybe she’d even be a comfort to Midoriya, or at least a deterrent for any self harming behaviors tonight.

“Couch,” Shouta says as he turns to walk back to the dining table and his other responsibility. “Eri? Mid- Izuku is going to spend the night with us.”

She finally looks away from All Might’s hulking figure as he settles Midoriya on the couch to stare at Shouta. “...Izuku?”

“That’s right. He’s had a hard day, too.”

Immediately, Eri climbs off her seat and scampers towards the living area. She stops part way as she remembers to be scared of All Might, but he just smiles at her and moves toward the door with a glance Shouta’s way. With him out of the couch’s vicinity, Eri gathers herself up and walks resolutely over to it so she can see Midoriya for herself. It’s almost sad how quickly she switches gears and picks up a tissue to start cleaning Midoriya’s face, but she’s almost instantly more lively than she’s been all day.

Shouta figures maybe this will be good for both of them. He steps over close to All Might and lowers his voice to keep it between the two of them. “How badly did that ‘interlude’ end?”

“The way Midoriya was speaking…” All Might sighed a little, almost looking his age for once. “I think Bakugou was only shocked by his own behavior and reactions to Midoriya, not angry with Midoriya himself, but Midoriya seemed to take it as a personal failing that it happened at all. He thinks his proximity to Bakugou and any possible feelings Bakugou may develop for him will only put Bakugou in further danger.”

“You made the right call, bringing him here,” Shouta says, scratching back through his hair. “I know what to watch for and he’s always been full of glaring red flags.”

“I was more remembering how he’s opened up to you more than anyone else,” All Might says and his smile goes a little sheepish but Shouta supposes he can’t fault the man for forgetting which of the teachers is fully trauma certified and which only have the minimum legally regulated training.

“Not sure he’ll want to talk when he wakes up, but I’ll make sure he survives the night.”

Looking back over the couch as Eri works on cleaning Midoriya’s hands, All Might gives a grave nod and then slips out the door far more quietly than a man of his size has any business doing. Shouta shuts and locks it, sets the quiet alarm that will alert his phone if it opens again, then turns back to the couch.

“I’ve got this,” he tells Eri. “Go finish your dinner.”

“…But…”

“Finish your dinner and then you can help me look after him.”

If anything, Midoriya proves to be a good bargaining chip because after only a moment of shifting between one foot and the other, Eri rushes back to the table to finish her plate. Which gives Shouta time to get a better look at Midoriya. His costume is filthy but undamaged other than a few singed areas from Bakugou’s explosions. Shouta finds the beginnings of bruises on what little skin is visible, but no cuts, no serious injuries. The way Midoriya’s breathing, his ribs and lungs are fine. The fight must have been more at the level of a normal sparring match, then, good. He’ll have to remember to compliment Bakugou’s self control when he reprimands him later for the unauthorized fight.

After fetching a t-shirt and some sweatpants he’s not sure won’t fall off the kid even with the lacing at its tightest, Shouta sits at the edge of his coffee table and just observes the sleeping boy.

So, that’s the nature of his relationship with Bakugou. He’d had his suspicions but wasn’t sure if it was romantic or more brotherly. Both could have inspired the obsession Midoriya shows. And it’s apparent that Bakugou might similarly end up focusing on Midoriya. Ugh, this is more complicated than Shouta likes.

Midoriya’s body language shifts just barely enough for Shouta to notice, but he doesn’t say anything until the kid opens his eyes to look back at him.

“Welcome back to the land of the living,” he says but he knows Midoriya’s still not in the right headspace for jokes.

“...Where…”

“My apartment.”

Midoriya pushes himself up to sit. He doesn’t look around, isn’t curious at all what a teacher’s living space might look like. Because he’s already seen it before? Because he doesn’t *care?* Shouta’s pretty sure it’s the latter, looking at his face. He hands over the clothes and isn’t surprised when Midoriya just stares dully at them.

“You’re staying here tonight,” Shouta says.

“Sure.”

“Possibly tomorrow as well.”

“Okay.”

“That depends on Eri.”

Tired green eyes flicker from him towards the dining room table and back again. “...You think that’s wise?”

Maybe he should rethink it, but Shouta’s sure Midoriya means Eri no harm. He wouldn’t have tried so hard to save her otherwise, gotten himself nearly killed. Sure, it might just have been the danger to Bakugou if the quirk destroying drug went widespread, but Shouta doubts that. He knows he’s right.

“I think she’d be more upset if you didn’t stay.”

Midoriya hums and then there’s a clatter as Eri half throws her plate and cutlery into the sink so she can race back over to the living area. Her wide eyes lock onto Midoriya and when he only smiles weakly in her direction, Eri marches herself over to throw her arms around his neck. The boy stiffens - so unused to physical affection that he can’t predict it? - and then slowly gathers Eri up into his lap.

Watching the way Midoriya clutches her to him like a precious thing, the way he presses his face against her shoulder while she pets his hair, Shouta knows he made the right call. This will be good for both of them. He goes to clean off the table and wash up from dinner to give them a little while. Over the din of water, he can hear them talking quietly together. Two lonely children with unimaginable pain, surviving after unspeakable suffering.

Shouta sends a text to Nedzu: *How quickly can we remodel my rooms to add a bedroom?*

The response is almost immediate: *He can move in the day after tomorrow*.

Most days, it annoys the hell out of him how well Nedzu reads what he means under the surface. Today, Shouta’s just grateful he doesn’t have to explain the whole situation. Nedzu

no doubt has plenty of surveillance to check against whatever report All Might will submit to him, if All Might remembers this kind of thing requires an incident report, anyway.

Midoriya's smiling when Shouta looks back at them and it looks real. Quiet, small, a little wobbly, but still real. Alright, that seals it. They don't have to wait to move his few possessions in when Shouta's couch is plenty comfortable for a night or two.

Chapter End Notes

It only took me 95k but I finally got to the KISS. Aaaaahhhh

Chapter 24

Chapter Notes

As has become usual, suicide mention in this chapter.

Kirishima Eijirou has no idea what crawled up Bakugou's ass and died, but he's about ready to dig it out himself if it'll get Bakugou to calm the heck down already. In a totally platonic bro sort of way, of course.

The problem is that every time Eijirou manages to get any sort of privacy with Bakugou, he just gets blown off as Bakugou finds somewhere else to be and someone else to get pissed at. He even snarls at Uraraka like he actually means it, which hasn't happened since before the sports festival.

Eijirou's not the only one confused but he's probably the only one that might be able to get down to the bottom of this terrible mood. He can see that in the way his classmates eye Bakugou and then pointedly notice Eijirou right after. Yeah, he gets it, he's the best friend, it's kind of his job to keep Bakugou from being a *complete* jackass.

"What's up with you?" he tries for the fifth time today, just after Bakugou nearly sent Ashido flying. She'd noticed his near breaking point and backed off, but it was still close.

"Fuck off."

Normally Eijirou would but this mood is affecting *everyone*. "Dude, you know you can talk to me."

"I don't need to talk."

"You kind of do, though."

Bakugou turns and gets right in Eijirou's face, opens his mouth to snarl something, and then goes still. Like he's noticing something for the first time. And then a pink flush that most of the time would mean rage forms over his cheeks before Bakugou immediately backs off like he's been struck. It's the weirdest thing Eijirou's ever seen.

"Bakubro?" he asks but Bakugou just turns away from him and moodily goes to get his food. Eijirou stares after him.

Wait, *what?* Because suddenly Eijirou's reminded of some of the mushy shoujo manga and that mental image compared to Bakugou just… hurts his brain. A lot. A *lot* a lot. He blames Ashido for every thought that springs through his brain for the next few minutes as he goes to get food and then finds where Bakugou's stomped off to. Still in the cafeteria, but the aura

he's giving off has successfully warded away anyone that might have wanted to sit with him. Which is good for Eijirou! He'll totally withstand the brunt of what seems like embarrassed rage.

Bakugou glares at him when Eijirou promptly sits down across from him.

"Okay, but seriously. What pissed you off?"

Stubbornly, Bakugou shoves food into his face and pretends he didn't hear him. It's almost endearing how childish it is, but they're sixteen now and they're almost done with their first year of hero training and Bakugou's gonna have to stop this if he wants to go up in the ranks.

"Are you still mad about the training with Midoriya?" Eijirou asks and Bakugou drops his chopsticks. It startles Eijirou enough that he almost misses the look on Bakugou's face before it flashes back to rage as Bakugou starts cussing out his food.

That… Okay, why would anything having to do with Midoriya make Bakugou look like one of the sullied maidens in that one fantasy manga Ashido made him read a while back? Did Midoriya do something to him?

"Bakubro, are you-" Eijirou cuts off, unsure how to actually even ask when Bakugou won't look at him and his face is so *red*. "Did something happen with Midoriya?"

"Nothing happened with that fucking nerd and next time I see him, I'll kill him!"

Oh. Well, that settles it. Something *definitely* happened with Midoriya. Should he tell a teacher? Bakugou's busy stuffing his face like his life depends on it, but Eijirou can't take a single bite as worry floods over him because sure, Midoriya had been nice enough, but he's still a *villain*. And a villain with a body count, if the news reports Eijirou looked up are accurate. A villain that absolutely creamed all of them in what felt like seconds.

If Midoriya wanted to hurt Bakugou, he probably could. Easily.

Bakugou freezes when Eijirou reaches over the table to grab his shoulder, then stares at him as he gets ready to rage but Eijirou doesn't give him the chance.

"I'm worried about you, man," he says honestly. "Are you okay?"

"I'm *fine*."

"No, you're not. If Midoriya did something to you-"

"*Nothing fucking happened!* So back off already!*"*

Eijirou backs off. He looks at his forgotten meal and grimly makes a decision. Once he finishes his lunch, he walks to the teacher's lounge to find Aizawa. His homeroom teacher had just been on his way out when he spots Eijirou and waits for the approach.

"I think Midoriya did something Bakugou," Eijirou says in a rush and Aizawa doesn't look surprised. "Bakugou's been off all day and had some weird reactions and I think something

bad happened but he won't talk to me."

Aizawa sighs a little. "I'm aware. It's being handled."

Abruptly, an enormous weight comes off Eijirou's shoulders, so quickly he almost feels dizzy. This kind of thing, it's not what he's built to carry. Eijirou's a pretty simple person in his opinion. If it's not a problem he can't punch into submission… Well. That's what allies are for, right? To fill in the gaps left in your own skills.

"Go on, class will be starting soon."

Eijirou nods and feels a lot more able to deal with Bakugou's anger for the rest of the day.

This is the first time Inui Ryou has actually met Midoriya Izuku. He's seen the villain in passing, was briefed on the principal's plans for him, but a chance to speak with him hadn't presented itself. And now Midoriya is lowering himself into a chair across from Ryou in his office and is showing every subtle sign of trauma Ryou's ever been trained to spot like someone's checking off the list one by one. The hyper vigilance is the least of his problems.

"Thank you for coming," he says even though he knows Midoriya is only here because he had to be. "It's nice to meet you formally."

"Sure." Short, even, neutral, utterly cut off. Nothing Ryou wasn't expecting.

"How are you feeling today?"

Midoriya's gaze is focused and unwavering but it doesn't come across as a powerplay or an attempt to dominate the room the way Ryou half expected him to. It's the flipside of that, waiting for something he sees as inevitable. Something he can't fight. This is a boy who knows how to endure terrible things and expects them from Ryou. Is it because of how much larger Ryou is? Or just the general social power discrepancy between them?

"Fine," the kid says. No invitation for more, no indication he'll start making this easy.

Ryou starts with some softball questions, things meant to get his patient more comfortable, get a feel for what the root of their issues is. He might as well be talking to a robot or brick wall for how little Midoriya gives up, but that itself is still a clue. It's still something to go by.

"I want to talk about what your plans for the future are," Ryou says as he flips open his notepad.

"What future?" Midoriya asks before Ryou can elaborate and that brings him pause. When he looks back up at Midoriya, the boy is just as calm and controlled. What future. Meaning he doesn't have one because the loops mean he'll relive a few years over and over? Or doesn't think he has one other than prison after his crimes. Or just that he doesn't *want* one.

"The immediate future is fine for today."

"My immediate plans are to escape the campus and murder a lot of people."

The way he says it isn't quite casual, closer to matter-of-fact. Hearing that from a sixteen year old boy is chilling and Ryou barely catches himself before he can start growling. Midoriya keeps pinging him as an apex predator in turns so quickly Ryou can't get used to it.

"Why?" he asks to head off his instincts.

"Because if the Meta Liberation Army isn't gelded from the start, they'll overrun the school in January since the League of Villains isn't around to put them under their thumb and redirect their attention. UA is a good political target that'll get world wide attention to their cause from the media."

Ryou doesn't even write that down. He just sets the notepad on his knees and tries to figure out if Midoriya is really telling the truth about… well. *Any* of this. The time loops, the possible futures, the fate of Bakugou Katsuki. Ryou's been given the relevant details but just because Midoriya's been helpful with some things doesn't mean he's necessarily telling the whole truth about *everything*. The calm Midoriya exudes right now could be trauma or it could be a front made to look like trauma. The boy is extremely intelligent from what the assessment tests have told them.

"They kill at least forty students and a dozen or so staff in the initial attack," Midoriya continues. "Then they start killing top twenty heroes and blow up the HPSC. But Kacchan's already dead by then, so I don't really care."

"You're being more open than before. Why are you telling me this?"

"Because you asked about something that matters."

Maybe he's going about this the wrong way. He scratches back through his hair, considers the boy in front of him. Defenses this strong are tough to crack and this is their first session. Ryou can't expect to be trusted, but he can maybe see where cracks might form. He just has to keep asking about things Midoriya finds meaningful.

"Then let me ask this," he decides on. "What happens after you save Bakugou?"

And there, suddenly Ryou sees a crack form as Midoriya goes very still. His stare doesn't waver so much as twist inward instead and Ryou can't let him run when he has an in. He might not have meant for that but he'll take it.

"What happens when Bakugou is safe? When April ends and he's still alive?"

Midoriya's fingers tighten in his lap.

"What do you do after that?"

"I finally fucking die and *stay dead.*"

Chilling but Ryou had almost expected something like this. After so long, so many attempts and failures, running through the same couple years over and over, it makes sense that Midoriya would just want things to end for good. They're all already aware of his suicidal tendencies.

“You wouldn’t want to keep going and make sure he lives out a full life? Prevent anything else that might happen to him after?” *Be* with him? Because Ryou was briefed on what happened at Ground Beta.

Midoriya focuses on him again and suddenly Ryou feels like he’s been *stabbed*. The force of Midoriya’s presence feels like a physical, cutting thing that tears into his chest, and he’s genuinely surprised not to feel the heat of blood soaking into his shirt. His claws dig into the arms of his chair as his entire body goes into high alert at the pro level threat rolling effortlessly off Midoriya’s body.

This is the kind of intensity he’d expect from someone like *Endeavor*, not a quirkless child.

“He’ll be fine after that. The loops stop when I save him in April,” Midoriya says in a tone that is just as intense as his gaze. “It stops when I save him. I just have to save him and it’s *over*-”

“How are you so sure?”

“I just have to- I have to save him. That has to be when this ends-”

Shit, that sounds like potential spiraling. “Midoriya-”

His door opens and Ryou loses his battle with growling, jerking to his feet to snarl at Sekijiro standing in the doorway. Thankfully, he’s probably the one person on campus that won’t take it personally.

“Sorry,” Sekijiro says like he understands what a mess he’s just walked in on - and he probably does, he usually understands Ryou scarily well. “The police are here to speak with Midoriya. They say it can’t wait.”

Ryou huffs out a breath and looks back at Midoriya. He’s not surprised to see the boy’s back in the present and has composed himself in the seconds Ryou’s eyes left him. That fits the profile way too well.

“Go on, we’ll talk again later,” Ryou manages to grit out despite being angry at the missed opportunity. He hadn’t expected to get this far into Midoriya’s walls and now the kid will be doubly on guard next time.

Midoriya gets up and follows after Sekijiro. As the door shuts, Ryou lets himself be as pissed off as he wants with no traumatized child to witness it.

He can’t go into this seeing Midoriya as a child. Naomasa tells himself that over and over as he waits in the meeting room UA graciously gave him and Tamakawa to use for this. Heck, part of why he chose Tamakawa to accompany him is his hope that Tamakawa’s professionalism will keep Naomasa in check, too.

He’s gotten too close to this kid villain and he knows it.

Midoriya's escorted in by Eraserhead and Vlad King, who take seats on either side of the boy once he's sat down. It's not entirely clear if they're here for Midoriya's protection or the police's, but it might be a little of both.

"Thank you for seeing us," Naomasa starts, gathering the stuffed full folder he'd brought with him. "I'm sure you have some idea of why we're meeting, Midoriya-"

"Either you want more information about All For One or my crew are doing their jobs well enough for you to notice."

Naomasa opens the folder and starts laying down a series of photographs from the crime scenes of the last few weeks.

"Both," he confirms and is glad at least Eraserhead and Vlad King looked bothered by the dead when Midoriya barely glances at them. "What's the connection? You never do anything without a reason."

"Meta Liberation Army members," Midoriya says without even attempting to hide or deny his involvement, but that's been his MO the entire time. Midoriya *never* shirks his own responsibility for the things his people do. And at least that confirms what Naomasa had already figured out. "Looks like they're moving through the list at a good pace. That should prevent the attack on UA."

Of *course* it somehow went towards keeping Bakugou Katsuki out of danger. Why didn't Naomasa think of that? Still, it's only cold comfort that there is a method to his madness.

"Why didn't you just provide a list of individuals of interest to the police or a hero? We may not be able to arrest them all without cause, but we could at least look into things."

"Tried that, doesn't work," Midoriya says and next to Naomasa, Tamakawa looks up from the notes he'd been taking.

"What happened when you tried?" he asks.

Midoriya shrugs his shoulders. "You don't have enough evidence to hold any of them, expend too much effort tailing the wrong ones, and mostly just let them know someone's on to them. They move sooner, more people die."

Tamakawa's whiskers twitch before he turns back to his notes to jot that down.

"Why kill them?" Naomasa asks, spreading the photos out.

"If you put them in prison, the Army's lawyers have them out in hours. They're a lot better settled and funded than the League of Villains ever manages. There's no point in wasting the time or effort." No matter how gruesome the photos are, how awful the deaths Midoriya's unaffected. Because he's already decided this is necessary? "And trying to hold them unlawfully somewhere is a *lot* more effort than it's worth, even when I stole enough quirk suppressant cuffs and drugs."

Eraserhead reaches out and takes one of the photos, staring at the violent death like he can make some sense of it past the obvious.

“You said there were fifty-eight on your list,” he says, glancing sideways towards Midoriya from the corner of his eye. “Are they all MLA members?”

“No.”

“We know at least one of them is Endeavor,” Naomasa reminds him and is gratified to see shock flicker over Vlad King’s face. “So there may be other heroes.”

Midoriya, suspiciously, doesn’t confirm or deny that.

“Why do you even want to kill Endeavor?” Vlad King asks like he can’t keep the question inside now that the intention has been made clear. “You don’t care about status or prestige.”

For a moment, Midoriya just looks at his hands resting on the table in front of them. Considering his words, considering what lies Naomasa will suss out.

“Aizawa. Todoroki Shoto is in your class,” he says finally, sounding… oddly *diplomatic*.

“He is,” Eraserhead confirms.

“His quirk is half fire and half ice.”

“Correct.” Eraserhead’s eyes narrow as he, like the rest of them, try to figure out just where he’s going with this.

“You’re one of four teachers in UA with full trauma certification. You’ve been watching him for most of a year. Why does he *only* use *ice?*”

There’s quiet for several seconds as that sudden observation settles ominously between them. An ugly piece of a puzzle most of them hadn’t realized was waiting to be solved. Naomasa stiffens as Midoriya lifts his head and sets his steady, intense gaze on him.

“What really happened to Endeavor’s oldest son?” he asks like it’s nothing, like it’s *innocent*. “What’s happening to his youngest *now?”*

No one speaks. Naomasa manages to break off his stare with Midoriya only to watch as a cold rage tightens in Eraserhead’s jaw.

“Are you accusing-” Vlad King starts and then notices Eraserhead’s stillness.

“I’ll look into it,” Eraserhead says like a vow, effectively ending the speculation.

“I’m still helping Dabi kill him after All For One is defeated,” Midoriya replies as calmly as ever. “I promised.”

Naomasa looks down at the photos and spots the last few words of Namakawa’s notes: *The villain Dabi has a fire quirk.* It may not be an actual connection, but Naomasa’s gut tells him

differently. Except for keeping certain information to himself, Midoriya has never lied to them when it counted.

“Speaking of All For One,” Naomasa says as he refocuses on what he’d needed to accomplish with this conversation. “How would you flush him out of hiding?”

“I wouldn’t. I’d go to him.”

“Then you know where he is now?”

“Roughly. I know where all his bases and labs are and the ones he’s most likely to be using while he rebuilds his nomu army.”

“He’s making more of them?” Namakawa immediately catches onto.

“He’s kind of a one trick pony, for a guy with dozens of quirks.” Midoriya doesn’t even sound amused by that, just tired. “I took out the entire League of Villains, so pretty much all of All For One’s usual plans are in the gutter. He’ll be switching over to being even more of a dramatic asshole than usual and with him, that just means a lot more nomus. He’s really not as clever as he thinks he is and he’s a million times more predictable.”

“Where do you think he’s storing them?” Naomasa asks. “If we attack it first like you arranged the last raid on his warehouse-”

“Yeah, no.” Midoriya doesn’t react to the others’ surprise at his refusal. “I’m not sending you all half cocked to get your asses handed to you when I know it won’t work. Sure, there are a few heroes on my kill list, but most of them are doing good work. There’s no sense in leading them to a slaughter.”

“You’re implying this new batch of nomu are on a higher level than the ones from before,” Vlad King says in a more uncomfortable tone.

“I’m not implying jack shit. I’m *telling* you, sending a bunch of heroes after the second batch just ends up with a lot of dead heroes. That’s why I’ll handle them myself.”

No matter how many times Naomasa has seen Midoriya’s confident honesty, no matter how capable he knows the boy is, he isn’t sure he’ll ever get used to how easily Midoriya takes on challenges like that.

“Don’t think for a second I’m letting you out of my sight,” Eraserhead growls and Midoriya just shrugs.

“I do have to escape UA first,” he says like that’s just a technicality.

“That’s enough,” Naomasa says to get them corralled again. “Midoriya, how would you approach defeating All For One?”

Midoriya’s expression sobers. “I usually kill him.”

“What?”

“If you want to capture him, it’s just a matter of beating him until he’s too broken to run away,” the boy says, quiet and intense. “But then he escapes later and the whole thing starts again. So I don’t bother with that.”

“You’ve-”

“I’ve gotten pretty good at patricide.”

The cold reminder of Midoriya’s connection to the king of the criminal underworld catches Vlad King off guard and Eraserhead just looks more angry than before.

“Was that in one of the loops where you had a quirk?” Naomasa asks.

“It’s easier when I have a quirk, but I’ve done it quirkless, too.” Midoriya’s gaze never wavers and his words never signal falsehood. It makes ice sink into the pit of Naomasa’s stomach. “Like I said, he’s not as clever as he thinks he is.”

From anyone else the whole idea would be utter madness, but Naomasa knows Midoriya. He knows at least some of what he’s capable of and he knows a real truth when he hears it.

“Okay,” Namakawa says, then pauses as he figures out his words. “How do you think we should approach defeating him?”

“All Might just needs to beat the shit out of him,” Midoriya says simply. “With Endeavor and Hawks backing him up, he’ll manage it.”

“Then it’s happened before?” Eraserhead asks more urgently. “This battle-”

Midoriya’s eyes fall to his hands as he his brows furrow, unease filtering into his body language. “Yeah. If I don’t take All For One out myself, All Might takes him on.”

“And what’s the most common outcome?” It’s not a question Naomasa wants to ask, but now he’s remembering Sir Nighteye’s prediction so many years ago.

“He…” Midoriya hesitates, his hands tensing before he manages to lift his gaze back up to Naomasa’s face again. “He wins.”

He wins… but something in the soft way Midoriya says it, in the deadened look of his eyes, tells Naomasa how pyrrhic that victory is.

“Does he survive?” Naomasa asks, barely above a whisper.

Midoriya’s silence tells him everything he needs to know.

Chapter 25

Chapter Notes

> Blink and miss it self harm mention in this chapter. Not quite enough for a tag but I just wanted to be cautious.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Stupid mistake. *Stupid* mistake and Spinner knew it before he even decided to make it. He doesn't need to look at Dabi's cold expression to know how fucked he'd have been if Dabi hadn't been taking down a target nearby enough to back him up.

"I expect this shit from Kiddo," Dabi says with barely contained fury. "The insane teenager we're following. Not *you*."

Which, okay. It's probably kind of fucked up when it's said like that. Spinner never quite lets himself see Kiddo as anything other than his highly skilled and motivated leader. He certainly tries not to think about the way Kiddo throws himself on the sword like it's the most natural thing in the world, something that is definitely going to get him killed some day. But that's not really the important part right now.

"Kiddo is a chaotic force of nature pretending to be a boy," Dabi continues, glaring at the wound he's cleaning on Spinner's side like it owes him money. "*You* are an adult that's supposed to have a working brain."

"I-"

"Toga has more sense than you!"

Well that's uncalled for, but Spinner keeps his mouth shut because maybe he doesn't want Dabi to be any more pissed off than he already is. It's been difficult, not being sure what's going on with Kiddo. If the heroes are being successful at trying to turn him. Even Hawks hasn't gotten to see him yet.

It makes Spinner wonder how Kiddo is healing up. Giran managed to get them the police report from the event that put Kiddo in this position and Spinner's not sure he'll stop seeing the words *respiratory and cardiac arrest* for the rest of his life. What if Kiddo didn't come back from that? What if he's already *gone?*

"Are you listening to me?" Dabi growls through his clenched teeth and Spinner flinches, forcing himself back into the present.

"Sorry, I was…" Mentioning Kiddo is just going to make this worse so Spinner holds it back. "Sorry. I should have gone in with backup."

Dabi doesn't even bother grunting in response. He just finishes taping up the bandage on his side and starts on another gash on Spinner's arm.

"I can get that one-" Spinner starts and then shuts his mouth with a snap at the look Dabi shoots him for his trouble. Okay, fine, he'll let Dabi keep patching him up. The silence stretches uncomfortably between them. Sure, Spinner likes Dabi fine but they aren't *close*. Not like Toga and Twice. Frankly, Spinner's not sure he belongs here or if the others really want him to stay. Toga's friendly, Twice is awkwardly enthusiastic, but sometimes Dabi looks at him and Spinner just *knows* he's being judged. He just doesn't know what that judgment is for or what the decision has been.

"Who's next on your list?" Dabi asks without looking up.

"Uh- Curious."

One of the few names on the list Kiddo had added a note to: *keep Himiko away from her.* Spinner never asked why but he'd kind of wondered what the story was. In any case, Dabi seems primed to follow the advice because she'd been stuck on Spinner's list.

"I'm going with you," Dabi says.

Spinner opens his mouth to protest and then thinks better of it. Maybe once Kiddo's back with them, Dabi will stand down from whatever this weird protectiveness has been about, but right now it's just easier to let him. Even if Spinner is a grown ass man who can look after himself (mostly) and it's not like Dabi is that much older than him.

At least, he's pretty sure it's probably only a couple years. With all the facial damage, it's hard to tell.

"How old are you?" Spinner asks and Dabi pauses, looking at him with confusion.

"Twenty-four." Only three years and he's acting like Spinner's a kid that can't take care of himself. "Almost twenty-five."

"So where do you get off pretending you're *that* much more mature than me?" It comes out despite himself and Spinner knows he'll regret it but he can't stop himself. He's been twenty one for all of three months and is still disgusted by how much of a kid the others see him. "I don't have any older siblings and I certainly didn't ask you-"

Spinner stops because there's something in Dabi's expression that… hurts? He's pretty sure that's what the sudden uncomfortable tightness in his chest is. Dabi just stares at him, his eyes wide like he's made some kind of huge discovery.

"I do," Dabi says and sounds a little surprised at that fact. "Have siblings."

This isn't something they do in this gang. Spinner hasn't even told any of them his name, not that it means as much to him as his current identity does. They're not the type to talk about their lives before villainy. The only one who might is probably Toga and she mostly only gets like that with Kiddo or Twice.

“Oh,” Spinner says. He shifts a little, uneasy under that stare. “Well. Good for you.”

“Three of them.”

“Y-yeah?”

Dabi is still and silent for several seconds before he finally stops staring at Spinner and looks down at the gash he’d only half tended to. After another far too long, awkward pause, he starts working on it again.

What the hell was that? Spinner doesn’t let himself stare at Dabi for fear that it might encourage another weirdly intimate moment. He waits for Dabi to finish, then quickly escapes on the guise of getting ready for his next target.

Kiddo can’t get back to us soon enough, Spinner thinks and then decides that repressing the entire damn thing is the better part of valor.

It’s not that Midoriya is necessarily more *gentle* with Shinsou, but as Shouta watches the two of them spar, it seems like he’s more attentive than he’d been in the 1-A or 1-B training matches or the sessions since then. This one would have been over in a minute flat if Midoriya wanted. Instead, he’s letting Shinsou make a certain amount of mistakes just to keep it going.

Shouta crosses his arms and keeps a close eye as he makes mental notes on how Shinsou can improve. His technique is getting better by leaps and bounds, far faster than Shouta had at his age, but Shouta also hadn’t had a teacher or a well suited training partner. Midoriya never lets himself get caught by Brainwashing, the match is pure martial arts which is exactly what Shinsou needs right now. His body needs conditioning, his mind needs honing, and Midoriya’s a tireless opponent.

When the current match ends, more because Midoriya’s aware of Shinsou hitting the end of his endurance than because of a decisive win, Shouta hands both of them water bottles.

“Your speed is improving,” he praises, not missing the way that affects his student. Shinsou eats up compliments and positive reinforcement like he’s starving and it’s been a powerful motivator Shouta has no issue putting into use. “It looks like you’re taking the self study exercises seriously as well.”

“Of course,” Shinsou says, ducking his head to rub at the back of his neck. “I’m not going to waste this opportunity, sir.”

He sounds almost sheepish, but he’s already proven to Shouta over the last several months that he has the spirit for heroics and the drive to get there. Shouta hadn’t thought he’d pass his specific skillset down to a student, not when the heroics track tends to go for flash over substance when allowed (the entire class he’d expelled day one is a prime example and the two students he’d expelled from this year’s cadre as well), but there’s something supremely satisfying in watching Shinsou’s careful mastering of his style.

Watching Midoriya exhibit the same style is more… vexing. The fact that at some point he had mentored this boy and yet Midoriya had gotten to his current state anyway feels like a failure. Like he'd let Midoriya down in ways he can never rectify. He knows the nature of the time loops means he likely had no idea through most of them, but he still feels it anyway. Whatever happened in the previous loops though, he's not failing the boy this time. He will save Midoriya Izuku if it's the last thing he does.

If Hizashi heard that vow, Shouta wonders if he'd join him at it. He hasn't missed the way Hizashi looks at the boy.

"Good job. I'd like you to add these exercises to your self study. They'll help with your endurance and overall strength," Shouta says, handing over the info packet he'd prepared. Shinsou glances through the pages with grave seriousness before nodding. "I'd like to continue having you train against Midoriya. He'll be able to help spot weaknesses in your technique and help you improve."

Something softer flickers over Midoriya's face before being shuttered back behind his eyes. "You'll be able to take me down soon enough."

"Uh…" Shinsou blinks with surprise at the vote of confidence, but Midoriya doesn't look at him, just takes another sip of water.

"I'm a miniboss version of the type of villain you'll be going after as an underground hero," Midoriya says absently, like it doesn't really matter, "but you've got a good foundation and I know you'll take it to the limit."

Shinsou's speechless and looks at Shouta as he silently flounders for some way to react to that. The reminder of Midoirya's status does seem to settle back into Shinsou's mind after a few seconds and Shouta doesn't miss the way his expression changes as he draws himself back in.

"Are you just biding your time?" Shinsou asks, eyes narrowing as he takes in the smile that forms on Midoriya's lips.

"I've got a mission to complete. Just have to wait for someone to slip up so I can get back to it." No attempt to hide his intentions. No guile or dishonesty.

"You're so sure one of us will," Shouta observes with slight annoyance.

Green eyes lift up to meet his and Midoriya looks almost apologetic. "No offense."

"I don't see how that isn't offensive," Shinsou says.

Midoirya laughs, soft and bright, and for a moment Shouta sees the child he should be. Then it's gone and Shouta can't stop himself from feeling bereft. He gives Shinsou an overview of his observations and has Midoriya do the same, which Shinsou soaks up just like usual. He'll be a great hero someday, Shouta's sure of it.

“Shinsou, get cleaned up and go to dinner,” he says to distract himself from it. “Midoriya, with me.”

Both boys nod and Shinsou grabs his bag before going back towards the campus. Midoriya gets up and follows behind Shouta as they head to the teachers’ dorms. It’s a quiet walk, one that Shouta spends getting his thoughts back in line. No matter what he feels for this boy, he can’t give Midoriya the chance to escape. He’s entirely sure that the moment Midoirya leaves UA’s custody, the chance to save him will be gone.

How on earth are they supposed to convince this boy to let them help him? It’s the question that keeps coming back to Shouta over and over again. Even Midoriya agreeing to help All Might take on All For One (with the assistance of the number 2 and 3 heroes) had seemed to be more of a concession than any real trust in their ability to assist in his plans.

“What comes after preventing the attack on UA?” Shouta asks without looking at him.

“Depends on whether the HPSC tells Hawks to kill me or not,” Midoriya replies and that stills Shouta immediately.

“What?”

Midoriya pauses a few steps ahead, looking back at him. “Oh. Sorry, you still don’t know how fucked up the HPSC is yet. I never remember when you find out.”

“What are you talking about?”

“I’m not ready to release the records yet,” Midoriya says with a shrug, which is even more concerning. ‘Records’ indicates this to be a *long term* thing. Shouta’s been aware of a certain level of corruption in the HPSC because any large organization develops it after a time, but actual state sanctioned assassination? And for Midoriya to be so blase about it-

“It’s happened before. To you.”

“Yeah. If Hawks doesn’t get attached to me, he takes me out when they ask. Even makes sure it’s quick and painless because he really doesn’t like doing it.” Midoriya’s voice is even, unbothered. Like that is just a minor inconvenience. “If he does get attached, he sanitizes his reports so that the order doesn’t come down in the first place. They decide I’m benign since I only target other villains most of the time.”

“And now?”

Midoriya thinks about it for a moment. “Inconclusive. He hasn’t visited me here though, so that points to him not being attached.”

No fear, no discomfort at the possibility. How many times has Midoriya already faced the knowledge of this particular betrayal? Maybe Shouta will need to confront Hawks himself.

“He’s asked to visit,” he says, as if correcting Midoriya’s conclusion might also prevent the worst from happening. “It’s under review.”

“Ah. Maybe he likes me after all.”

It doesn’t sound like Midoriya would be particularly broken up if that weren’t true. Shouta narrows his eyes, considering that as they start walking again. “What do *you* feel about Hawks?”

“He’s useful. His quirk is expertly trained and he’s got the creativity to back it up. As long as he sees it as useful to his mission, he tends to be easy to lead.”

“And personally?”

Midoriya looks up towards the darkening sky. “I guess… I guess I wish I’d been there to save him when it counted.”

The words are ominous and solemn, but Midoriya doesn’t elaborate further. They get to the teachers’ dorm and Shouta leads the way to his rooms. His mind is alive with thoughts and theories, things he tries so hard not to bring home with him, but it’s impossible not to when Midoriya’s there. Just looking at Midoriya makes Shouta start to spiral into what ifs and worries.

Eri welcomes them with quiet cheer, Midoriya dropping to one knee immediately to offer a hug that she eats right up. Today’s minder gives Shouta a polite smile before filing out, and then it’s just the three of them. Midoriya gets up with Eri propped against his chest, listening as she eagerly talks about her day. It’s easier for her to talk to him than Shouta and he supposes it’s because of how much closer in age Midoriya is to her. Shouta doesn’t mind it. Anything that makes Eri more comfortable is a good thing in his book and maybe Midoriya benefits from that connection as well.

It feels very domestic, listening to the kids talk while Shouta works on putting together a meal. He doesn’t mean to listen to them, to intrude, but it’s not like he has a lot of choice about it in the small space. His eyes keep sliding back over to watch them despite himself.

“And then my teacher, she told me all about big balloons you can *ride in*,” Eri says as Midoriya settles on the couch with her perched on his lap. The touching between them had been a surprise. Eri’s careful about touch, tries so hard to keep from showing if or when she wants it, but the moment Midoriya started staying with them, she’d blossomed. When they’re together, Eri is either sitting on his lap or his hip or clinging to his hands, and Midoriya seems as comforted by it as she is. It makes sense that the child villain would be as touch starved as Eri had been.

As Eri chatters about hot air balloons, she takes one of Midoriya’s hands and traces over the scars on his fingers. Shouta’s fairly sure they’re from Midoriya teaching himself how to use his knives again, training his hands to respond the way he remembered from previous loops. Either that or some kind of self-inflicted harm, but Shouta hopes not.

Eri’s words slow and stop. She looks up at Midoriya, chewing on her lip.

“What is it?” he asks her quietly, so much more gentle with her than anyone else.

“I wish you weren’t hurt,” she says and there’s only a choked sort of silence after that before Shouta hears Midoriya’s clothing ruffle. Glancing over, he watches as Midoriya hugs her close, burying his face against her shoulder.

“It’s okay,” Midoriya murmurs almost too quietly for Shouta to hear. “They don’t hurt. They’re just reminders.”

“Reminders of when things hurt?”

“Y… yeah, some of them.”

Eri’s quiet for a few moments before she says, “I wish I could keep you safe.”

There’s a quiet noise that’s close enough to a sob for Shouta to look again but he can’t quite tell if Midoriya’s crying. He’s still clutching Eri to him, still hiding his face as Eri pets through his hair. She seems to be taking his emotional state well, concentrating on trying to help because despite everything, despite what she’d been through, Eri is a genuinely good person.

“Izuku,” she says after a while, when Shouta’s nearly finished dinner. “Can I try to make the marks go away?”

And that… might not be a good idea. Shouta considers giving up the guise that he’s not listening in, considers stopping Eri from using her quirk even though she’s been doing well in the exercises he runs her through daily. Her control isn’t great but that’s to be expected at her age and she’s already leaps and bounds better than she’d been after she was rescued. Her abilities are going to help a lot of people some day but maybe tonight, maybe they can help a single boy. Something small like this might be all right.

“You wanna-” Midoriya lets Eri ease him to sit up again. His eyes are wet and a little red but he’s not quite crying. “I… Okay. If you wanna try that-”

“After dinner,” Shouta interrupts and both kids jump at the interruption before Midoriya laughs a bit. He gets up, carrying Eri over to the table as if her legs weren’t perfectly capable. Shouta serves their plates and then sits down. Dinner is a quiet affair, heavy with promises and intent. They say little and Eri finishes her plate quickly for once, obviously eager to get started. It takes a bit longer for Midoriya and Shouta to be ready and Shouta insists on cleaning up from dinner first before the three of them settle into the living area.

“If I tell you to stop, I want you to do your best to pull back,” Shouta says, a familiar enough instruction that Eri only nods with determination in her face, then turns to the other child. “If you feel any pain or discomfort, speak up immediately.”

Midoriya nods and then lets Eri take his hand in hers again. She furrows her brows, staring hard at the little white and tan lines. Triggering her quirk on command has been nearly as hard as controlling it, but Shouta’s proud to see when she manages it. Her bright eyes are utterly focused on watching the scars grow pink and then fade away, thankfully without actually reopening the wounds in the middle.

Abruptly, Midoriya sucks in a harsh breath and Shouta cancels Eri's quirk immediately as Midoriya tears his hand free to press over his side.

"Are you-" Shouta starts as Eri's eyes go wide and watery.

"I'm fine," Midoriya says quickly, "just… surprised."

He pulls his shirt up and- It looks like something had torn a chunk out of Kiddo at some point but the scars are angry red like it had happened days ago.

"I didn't expect it to go past my hands," Midoriya says, not quite bemused but close to it.

"When was that?" Shouta asks because it doesn't match up with injuries he remembers Kiddo getting.

"Oh. Uh… Shigaraki. When I rescued Kacchan. He got me with decay."

The pattern makes sense now and Shouta's uncomfortable with how easily that could have been a death blow. How many times is this kid going to skirt death in one loop? Midoriya drops his shirt again and Eri grabs his hand again.

"I can keep going," she declares but Midoriya pats her hand.

"It's okay. That's enough for now. My hands look so nice now, thank you."

If Midoriya hadn't stopped her, Shouta would. It's easy to see minute shaking in her fingers. While Eri's capable of ridiculously powerful waves of Rewind, the finer control he encourages her to use takes up a lot more effort and energy.

"Promise I can do more later," Eri says, looking up at Midoriya with determination. He smiles at her weakly and then reaches up to pet over her hair.

"Yeah. When I'm up for it again," he says.

The rest of the evening is less exciting. Shouta helps Eri finish up a worksheet for her lessons while Midoriya gets washed up for bed. The room that's now Midoriya's had technically been part of the apartment space next door, the same way Eri's had been, but there's still plenty of others for any teachers who decide to live on campus the way Shouta does.

Eri insists on giving Midoriya a hug before she's willing to be taken to bed but Shouta's only half way through the bedtime story when she falls asleep. He slips out of her room and checks in on Midoriya. His nearly empty room reminds Shouta that he'd meant to ask what he might need.

"Should we retrieve anything from your mother's home?" he asks and Midoriya blinks at him from his seat at the edge of his bed before smiling softly.

"No. I won't be here long enough for it to matter," he says like it's a foregone conclusion. "I kind of feel bad about the remodel."

Shouta crosses his arms, leaning against the door frame.”You’re pretty sure you’ll be leaving.”

“I can’t get the things I need done while I’m here. And…” Midoriya looks at the featureless wall, his expression growing more somber. “It’s dangerous for me to be here.”

“If you think I’m letting anything happen to you-”

“Not for me. For you, for Eri. For Kacchan and the students. It’s… I’ve got a lot of enemies that are still alive.”

Enemies he hadn’t yet eliminated the way he preferred. Shouta’s fingers tighten against his arms.

“It can’t be a secret where I’m being held,” Midoriya adds, glancing towards Shouta from the corner of his eye. “The sooner I get out of here, the sooner the school is safe.”

“I don’t know what it’s going to take to convince you that your life has value,” Shouta says with more venom in his voice than he expects. “I don’t give a damn if you’ll just loop again when you die, I’m going to do everything in my power to prevent you from having to.”

Midoriya shivers, turning to look at him head on with wide, impossibly young eyes.

“You’re here for *your* protection. Not anyone else’s. The information you can give us for current or future events is a bonus, not the primary reason we care about keeping you alive.”

“Don’t,” Midoriya whispers. It sounds painful. It sounds broken.

“I am well aware of the trouble you’ve stirred up for yourself and I get why you think you had to. I’m not sure I wouldn’t make the same decisions in your shoes.” And Midoriya’s still just staring at him with a desperate, starving hunger in his eyes. How long has it been since this child had someone refuse to be protected? Someone who didn’t allow Midoriya to put himself last every goddamn time? “That doesn’t mean I’m just going to stand by and leave you in the pit you’ve been digging.”

He moves away from the door and walks over to stand in front of Midoriya, reaching out to rest a hand on his shoulder. Midoriya just stares up at him in stunned silence.

“You’re under my protection, problem child, and I’m not letting you escape it,” Shouta says and doesn’t let himself waver as Midoriya’s eyes fill with tears. “You’re better off just giving in and pretending for ten seconds like you have anything approaching common sense.”

Midoriya gives a little, shaky laugh, reaching up to rub at his wet eyes. “Yeah, okay.”

It’s not necessarily an agreement that Midoriya won’t try to escape, but it’s enough for now. It’s enough that Shouta nods and leaves the bedroom to give Midoriya at least physical privacy, even if they both know his room has a camera that Nedzu monitors.

With the children settled, Shouta sits at the tiny desk space in his own bedroom and goes over his notes on Todoroki Shoto. Midoriya’s accusations can’t be entirely baseless. Shouta *has*

been watching the boy throughout the year and noticing little things that don't add up, tiny signs that something wrong could be happening. He'd seen signs of fire when Todoroki was particularly worked up or surprised but had figured perhaps his fire was simply a weaker part of his quirk or that it perhaps caused him pain to use. Not something he consciously avoided. This completely reframes most of how Shouta has approached him.

If the accusations are true, they need to move carefully. Endeavor is the number two hero in the country, well connected and respected world wide. Something like this becoming public could ruin him… so they'll have to make sure the case is air tight before making it public.

Shouta will do anything for his students and he's not about to leave Todoroki Shoto unprotected.

Chapter End Notes

Is Eri cemented as best girl? You bet your ass she is.

Chapter 26

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

It's kind of hard to enjoy a kill when Himiko has spent so much of the last couple weeks feeling lonely. She's tried to hide it and is pretty sure Spinner and Dabi have no idea, but Twice keeps giving her worried glances when he thinks she's not looking. Other than Kiddo, Twice is her best friend and he's wonderful and she's very glad to have him, but he's not… enough.

He doesn't understand her the way Kiddo does. His acceptance is a gift and he's very good for a cuddle even when he takes his mask off and gets all weird about holding himself back. She has spent a lot of time sprawled over his chest while they talk about anything and everything that comes to mind and she thinks he's been comforted by the closeness, too. It's nice. The problem is that that's all it is. He looks at her and accepts her exactly as she is and asks for nothing else.

When Kiddo looks at her, Himiko finds herself wanting to be more. More powerful, more skilled, just *more.* He looks at her like he can see her full potential just waiting to be unlocked and trusts her with the key, trusts her to let him help her turn it. It's hard to explain. It's easier just to love him than handle the weight of his expectations. So in that light, maybe being away from him for a little while has been a bit of a relief.

But the longer he's away, the longer he's with people she knows he desperately cherishes, the easier it is for the little voices in her mind to pick apart that bond.

He'll turn, they say. *He'll abandon you.*

"No," she whispers over her newest corpse, but she doubts he'll tell on her.

He'll leave you alone just like everyone else has.

Himiko presses her lips hard and smacks the side of her head a few times, shaking her thoughts away. *No*. Kiddo is her bestie, he'll definitely come back. Besides, he's got a *dream* and she pledged to help him.

What if he's just using you?

She shakes her head hard. That's fine. That's fine because if he's using her, it means he trusts her. It means he sees her and what she can do. She has a place in the world he wants to build and he wants her there with him.

He'll abandon you, the traitorous voices continue to whisper so sweetly in her ears no matter how hard she tries to ignore it. So, Himiko desperately clings to her list of targets and tries to drown it out with blood. It mostly works. Or, at least a little.

Things have been awkward since the training session Midoriya ran from. Mirio's done his best to keep it light, keep from probing wounds he hadn't realized were so deep and still bleeding, and he thinks Midoriya probably knows that. Whether he's grateful or just accepting it doesn't matter so much as just not upsetting him like that again. Midoriya's smiles never seem real but he makes an effort to give them and that has to count for something.

The things is… The thing is, Mirio keeps wondering what it must have been like. He knows Midoriya has been quirkless since birth, but to get a power like One For All, to feel that burn through your blood and muscles and heart only to lose it all…? He can't imagine that. He'd at least had Permeation from the start. A very different sort of quirk, but a quirk nonetheless. Midoriya had nothing and then everything and then nothing again.

It's hard to imagine anything except a deep hole in his chest, the idea of losing One For All now. Mirio would go on, of course. Some day, he's expected to pass it on to another and he hopefully has a long time to come to terms with that. He wonders if All Might feels that as the embers of One For All cool and fade in him. He's down to barely an hour of time in his muscle form and doesn't bother using it during these training sessions anymore unless he's going head to head with Mirio. Not that that happens often.

As they pause for a rest, Mirio sits next to Midoriya and they sip water while All Might goes over things he'd noticed in their last match. It's all important information and Mirio soaks it all in like a sponge, but he's almost relieved when All Might gets a phone call and steps aside for privacy.

"Oh thank goodness, a longer break," Mirio says, leaning back on his arms to look up at the sky. His heart is still beating pretty fast because Midoriya didn't bother to hold back at all. "You really know how to push a guy."

"Someone needs to and All Might only knows how to go all in when lives are on the line," Midoriya says with just a hint of a joke in it.

"I think he's afraid of hurting me but it's useful seeing him in action, you know?"

Midoriya hums, looking down at his water bottle. "You should watch him but having different experiences, forcing yourself to the limit, is the only way you're going to prove to the vestiges that you're ready for their power."

See, when Midoriya says things like that, it's really hard to hold back from asking him more. Mirio chews at the inside of his mouth a moment and then figures maybe it would be okay to ask a little, if he's careful.

"So, the vestiges…"

"Everyone who's had One For All leaves a little of themselves in it. If you're well suited, they'll open those pathways to you."

Which means Midoriya had been well suited. Had to have been. Mirio's entirely sure he must have unlocked everything about One For All when he was the wielder. If he'd been so well

suited, why doesn't Midoriya have it *now?*

It's only when Midoriya freezes, his entire body stiff and eyes staring out at nothing, that Mirio realizes he said that aloud. He immediately sits up.

"Sorry- I didn't mean-"

"It's okay." Midoriya says immediately like it's a reflex and that makes Mirio feel ten billion times worse. He's still trying to figure out what to say to smooth that over when Midoriya turns to look at him. "It's because you were supposed to be the ninth."

And if Mirio were kinder, if he were better, he'd leave it at that. The problem is he can't stand the resignation he doesn't hear but can sense under Midorya's words.

"How long did it take you to decide that? To give this up?" he asks and Midoriya's fake smile drops away like it had never been there in the first place. "How long has it been since you stopped being a wielder?"

Midoriya's eyes are so big. Most of the time, Mirio forgets that physically Midoriya is a few years younger than him because he has such an enormous presence that it's hard to think of him as anything but an adult. It's hard to remember that he's a villain, that he's anything other than just a boy. But right now, right here, Mirio can see the person he thinks Midoriya started as.

"It's okay to miss it," Mirio tells him with as good a smile as he can manage. "You don't have to pretend it was never yours."

Midoriya opens his mouth to speak and then seems like he can't quite manage to. He looks forward again instead, fingers rubbing over the condensation of his water bottle.

"I don't remember. How long, I don't remember," he says finally and something about that guts Mirio to the core. "I was… I kept trying to be a hero for so long. I kept trying to make it work."

Mirio swallows the growing lump in his throat and resists the urge to reach out and hug Midoriya because right now nothing else seems right to do.

"You'd think it would be easier, right? Having that kind of power. It should have been easier to do anything with it. But… He kept dying." Midoriya draws in a shaky breath as the water bottle crinkles in his tightening hand. "I had all this power and Kacchan still kept dying."

"So… you gave it up," Mirio says and Midoriya nods once, sharp and small.

"I figured… I figured if I couldn't save him with One For All, it might as well go to someone who's not as selfish as I am," he says, closing his eyes tightly. "Sir Nighteye was right. You're so much better suited for that quirk than I could ever be."

Except Mirio doesn't believe that. He doesn't believe for one second that he's the one fate truly wanted in this role. Maybe it *is* selfish, using a situation like this to only care about one person… but that's not what Midoriya's been doing, is it? Otherwise why warn them about so

many other, unrelated things? Even if the nature of the butterfly effect might mean they eventually still threaten Bakugou Katsuki somehow, that doesn't mean the warnings had been meaningless. Midoriya's saved countless people already and he's done it nonstop for who knows how long?

That solidifies something in Mirio and he scoots himself close enough to Midoriya to throw an arm around his shoulders. Midoriya stiffens but doesn't shake him off. Doesn't look at him either. After a little while, he relaxes and slumps against Mirio's side. They stay that way until All Might comes back and maybe that takes longer than the phone call necessarily should have, considering the look Mirio catches on All Might's face.

The training match after is brutal in all the best ways, but Mirio just grins and gratefully takes every bit of feedback Midoriya has for him afterward. Midoriya seems determined for him to be the ninth wielder and to help him be the best at it, so Mirio will accept that assistance with every fiber of his being.

The operation will be small. They can't risk it getting out before they're ready to spring the trap. The problem is they don't yet know where to spring it because Kiddo refused to say anything without seeing them all face to face.

Keigo idly waits in the meeting room, tapping his fingers on his knee as he side-eyes Endeavor only a few seats away. The number two hero is busy sitting crossly and not at all hiding how annoyed he is to be there. Which is about par for the course, as far as Keigo has observed in the past. Maybe he doesn't quite get why Kiddo is so a-ok with killing him, but… eh.

He'd be lying if he said he wasn't looking forward to seeing Kiddo alive and well though. His requests to visit have all been delayed or denied outright and that kind of thing makes it easy to think the worst.

The police get there next, there's greetings all around, and then All Might walks in with Kiddo and another guy trailing behind. It takes Keigo a second to recognize Eraserhead in the light of day, but he's a lot more occupied with getting a good look over Kiddo. He's walking on his own power, there's no visible sign in his posture or movements of lingering injuries, and Keigo doesn't even spot any bruises. Something in his chest unclenches at the confirmation.

"We're all here," Endeavor says, glaring at them above his fiery facial hair. "*Now* can we get the location?"

"How about go fuck yourself," Kiddo says with utterly no concern. "I think go fuck yourself is an excellent location for you to get lost in."

Endeavor stares at him in shock at the blatant disrespect, as do several others, but Keigo can't help the ugly laugh that escapes before he covers his mouth.

"Excuse me?" Endeavor snarls when he recovers, his fire burning brighter, but Kiddo just stares back at him with an unimpressed expression.

“How about you excuse yourself into a fucking *grave?”*

“Ah, young Midoriya, you-” All Might tries, clearly not having expected this meeting to go off the rails so quickly.

“I know. He’s useful for this mission and keeping you alive a little longer,” Kiddo says. “That doesn’t mean I have to be nice about it.”

“Sit down and make yourself useful, you little brat-”

“*Bite* me, old man.”

Keigo hasn’t laughed like this in a while. Did Kiddo require the face to face meeting just so he could have the opportunity to piss Endeavor off where he couldn’t hit him? *This is the best day ever*.

Eraserhead’s hand lands hard on Kiddo’s shoulder, forcing him into a seat well away from the hotheaded hero and taking the one next to him as if he can really keep him under control. It’s enough that Kiddo at least goes quiet and the rest of them settle around the table.

“Ahem.” Detective Tsukauchi waits until everyone looks towards him to continue. “Now then. We’re here to discuss the proposed raid on All For One with the intent to capture and imprison him. Midoriya, I would appreciate it if you'd hold off on verbally abusing Endeavor for now.”

Kiddo smiles like there’s a knife behind his teeth but only nods.

“Now then, I think it would be a good idea to get a few facts straight.” Tsukauchi spread out a few maps and then handed over a marker to Kiddo. “Where will this happen?”

“Depends on if one of his spies figures out what you’re planning.” But Kiddo still gets up and checks over the maps before marking four locations with thick red circles. “This is where it usually happens, probably the best bet. This one if he catches wind. These two it’s only happened at once. This one was probably because I’d already blown up the primary, this one only happened after I crippled him once and he still had Shigaraki-”

Endeavor scoffs and Kiddo’s eyes slowly lift to him, a dangerous spark to them. It almost makes Keigo want to get in the middle of them, but this is too goddamn funny to even dream of it.

“Can you give us an overview of the previous versions of this fight?” Tsukauchi says, steering Kiddo’s attention back to him.

“Sure. If All Might goes alone, he and All For One beat the shit out of each other for a while, All Might runs out of time permanently, and either he wins in a last ditch effort or All For One kills him. Either way, All Might’s hero legacy ends,” Kiddo says as he sets down the marker and sits back in his chair again. “It’s about fifty/fifty whether All For One gets captured. All Might never kills him.”

In his seat, the number one hero grows more pensive, probably doing the same thing Keigo is and considering the shit Kiddo must have seen.

“If Endeavor’s there, All For One doesn’t survive it.” The way Endeavor smirks at that seems to annoy Kiddo because he’s quick to add, “Because Endeavor pulls some stupid bullshit out of his ass and All For One blows himself up like an atom bomb. Half the country becomes uninhabitable no man’s land.”

The smirk drops immediately and Endeavor’s eyes narrow as Kiddo grins at him.

“And All Might?”

“Oh, All Might doesn’t survive those. He’s already dead by the time Endeavor gets his ass there. Maybe that’s half of why Endeavor loses his shit.”

Keigo is going to buy this kid so much ice cream if only for the uncomfortable way Endeavor shifts at that implication. Sure, he doesn’t hate Endeavor like so many people, quite the contrary, but Keigo’s also the kind of asshole who loves seeing his friends squirm.

“And Hawks?” Tsukauchi prompts.

“Hawks doesn’t usually get involved. That’s a new change I’ve only made since the last couple loops. I haven’t figured out all the odds on his actions yet. So far, he’s mostly kept Endeavor from blowing up the country.”

“Young Midoriya,” All Might murmurs, drawing the kid’s attention immediately. “What has been the most successful way to defeat him?”

Kiddo’s suddenly quiet, his expression shuttered back behind something that’s trying to be blank but can’t quite manage to hide the upset. Whatever the answer is, it’s not one he likes.

“If you let me out of here, I’ll go kill him myself,” he says after a pause.

“*Midoriya*.”

“It’s going so well this time, why can’t you just let me-” Eraserhead touches his shoulder and Kiddo jerks his gaze down into his lap. Keigo watches the muscles of his jaw work and then he says, “It doesn’t matter. If you go against him now, you’re going to die. I took the Kamino option away.”

“Kamino?”

“I don’t remember it all that much anymore. It’s been a while since I started changing that one. Back when Kacchan gets kidnapped, you were supposed to face him.”

All Might’s expression grows more thoughtful and Keigo says, “What was the result?”

“All For One gets captured, All Might dies, and then a couple months later All For One breaks out of Tartarus and ends the world.”

Tsukauchi frowns and rests his hand on the table, leaning over it into Kiddo's space. "What part of that are you lying about?"

Kiddo's stone faced as he stares back at Tsukauchi, neither of them willing to back down.

"It's not All For One that kills the world," Kiddo says after a time. "It's Shigaraki using All For One's quirk.

"But Shigaraki is dead-" Eraserhead starts only for Kiddo to interrupt him without looking away from Tsukauchi.

"Is his body in the police morgue?"

Tsukauchi blinks and then his eyes slowly widen.

"The nomu are created from dead bodies," Endeavor says, catching on faster than some of them to the horror of it.

"Has Tartarus run a DNA screening on Kurogiri yet?" Kiddo asks and it seems random but Keigo knows there's nothing about Kiddo that could be described that way. Tsukauchi seems to get the hint because he straightens and pulls out his phone, sending out a series of messages.

"Are you saying that All For One-" The horror is clear in All Might's voice.

"Will make another super soldier out of his failed protégé? Yeah. That's what I'm saying." Kiddo looks down at his hands, clearly working through his options, then says, "Except he'll be like Kurogiri. He'll be able to think. The process will destroy most of his current personality, but that just means it'll be easier to point him in the direction All For One wants."

And isn't that horrifying enough. Keigo glances between the gathered heroes and police, then pins his stare on the young villain alone. Kiddo looks so small in this setting. Even with his old eyes and harsh truths, Keigo suddenly can't stop seeing the child that has had to face these things over and over.

"If we take out One For All now, does it prevent Shigaraki's resurrection?" Keigo asks because someone has to and no one else either realizes that or wants to. Kiddo glances at him and even before he answers, Keigo already knows what he's going to say.

"He's already done his part. Garaki will finish Shigaraki's new body in February."

The rest of the meeting is solemn and spent ironing out a concrete plan of attack. Tsukauchi gets an alert and grimly reveals that Shigaraki's body is missing from the morgue, just as Kiddo suspected. Just one more thing they'll have to look out for later on.

Keigo stays quiet for most of the meeting. He's flexible enough to handle whatever strategy they come up with and his attention keeps sliding back to the child villain. Kiddo's helpful, giving tactical input on the plan and advice about specific outcomes, possibilities he's seen.

By the time they finish, Keigo's feeling pretty good about the mission but a lot worse about Kiddo's state of mind. He's seen the quick personality switch before, that doesn't surprise him, but there's something else. There's something in the way Kiddo moves, the words he uses, that screams in Keigo's mind something is wrong.

He's planning something and Keigo feels with every fiber of his being that it'll get him killed.

The meeting concludes after a few hours. Everyone's tired and Keigo gets to be amused by the way Endeavor and Kiddo snipe at each other before the pro files out of the meeting room. Keigo's about to follow when Kiddo catches his eye, so he waits until it's just the two of them, Eraserhead, and All Might. Eraserhead gives him a narrow look but Keigo just shrugs.

"Okay, Kiddo. Lay it on me," he says.

"How much progress have the crew made?" And isn't it cute that Kiddo's accepted the moniker Keigo gave them? At least he's made it clear he expects Keigo's figured out what the guys are up to even if they've tried to keep him out of the picture.

"I'd say about 75% of the MLA is either dead or has left the country," Keigo replies, ignoring the shock on both All Might and Eraserhead's faces.

"So they've started going after the main players?"

"Probably. They aren't sharing specifics with me. It's like they don't trust me or something."

"Tell them to go in pairs. And to wait on Re-Destro until I get there."

"You got it, Boss."

All Might reaches out, taking Kiddo's shoulder. "Now wait just a minute, you aren't-"

"If you think I'm going to just sit around UA while there's work to be done-"

"I'm not letting you out of my sight," Eraserhead growls out and Kiddo grits his teeth a moment.

"Even you have to sleep at some point."

For some reason, it seems like a surprise to both men that Kiddo would want to escape, or maybe be so adamant about it. Keigo is more surprised he hasn't already.

"Okay, okay, simmer down you guys," he says cheerfully, then reaches out and drags Kiddo into a one armed hug. "We're all friends here. Maybe cool your heels a bit longer while we take out All For One, okay Kiddo?"

Kiddo shoots him a dirty look but then just rolls his eyes. "Sure, whatever."

Keigo lets go and then watches Eraserhead lead Kiddo away, speaking quietly enough that he can't hear him. Or couldn't if it wasn't for the feather he'd slipped into Kiddo's shirt just

now. Still, it's nothing important just yet.

Keigo gives All Might a friendly smile and then moves to leave, only for the older hero to stop him with a quiet, "How much do you know about his plans?"

"Oh, considerably less than I'd like to," Keigo says. "Mostly I know he's utterly ruthless about getting the result he's looking for regardless of the means he has to use to get there."

All Might pales. It's like the guy hasn't figured out what kind of person Kiddo is. Maybe he just can't see through the youthful face, but Keigo doesn't have that trouble.

"Look, I get what you're trying to do for him, but Kiddo isn't someone you can protect."

"He's a *child*-"

"He's a villain." Keigo's voice is sharp and strong, refusing to yield. "He's a villain that doesn't live under the delusion that his actions are right or moral. He's not doing this for some kind of defining principle, it's just his own selfish refusal to let go. The only thing Kiddo cares about is saving a few very specific people and guess what, big guy? *You're one of them*."

All Might flinches.

"He may only admit to trying to save Bakugou, but he's also done everything he can to keep you away from the person he thinks is most likely to kill you. And now that you're going headlong towards him anyway? What the hell do you think Kiddo's going to do?"

Keigo hadn't realized he was getting mad but now he takes a breath to push it back down. It's ridiculous to get annoyed by the way everyone underestimates Kiddo, the way they seem so determined to ignore huge parts of the boy in favor of babying him. Hell, even Keigo has to fight against the urge sometimes, but at least he *does* fight it.

"Thank you," All Might says finally. "I appreciate your input."

"Sure."

Keigo leaves him and exits the school after handing over his visitor pass. He'll be able to let the crew know Kiddo's intact and still thinking about them, which he's sure will comfort them and probably also galvanize their resolve. The loyalty Kiddo manages to inspire in people is something Keigo wishes he had, but Keigo knows he could never be so genuine.

His phone rings just before taking off outside the gates of UA. Keigo answers it without thinking.

"Hawks."

"How quickly can you get to the Pussycats Agency headquarters?" his HPSC handler asks without bothering with their usual pleasantries.

Keigo blinks. "A few hours. Why?"

“There’s been some kind of attack. All four members of the team are unaccounted for and the last credible sighting was almost a week ago.”

Chapter End Notes

I admit it. I enjoy being mean to Endeavor.

Chapter 27

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Taking out Curious is a task and a half. She laughs at their offer of changing alliances and then nearly blinds Spinner with a sneak attack. Dabi's glad he insisted on coming along and he insists on accompanying Twice on his mission to take out Trumpet after. That one ends up being a dead end. They get to his apartment just as the police are leading him out. Dabi finds out from Giran that he'd turned himself in offering information for a reduced sentence, but it's not difficult to find someone to take care of him from within the prison if he won't join up with Kiddo. No loose ends. He's learned that from Kiddo. Dabi takes both Spinner and Toga with him when he goes after Skeptic but it turns out to be overkill. Not *easy*, just not something that required that much firepower.

After Skeptic, it's just mopping up a few stragglers and then they're left with Re-Destro, who's losing his ever loving mind. Dabi can't help but grin at the reports Giren supplies of just how off the rails the man has gotten.

"Little birdie told me the boss should be out soon," Giren says in a casual tone, lighting his cigarette.

Something like relief flares up in Dabi's chest, but he just glances up at the man through his lashes.

"Anything we can do to facilitate that?" he asks.

"Pretty sure he'd murder you for going near the school," Giran says with a wider grin. Which makes sense. UA as a whole is on the no-go list.

"Did your little birdie tell you anything else?"

"Just to be patient."

Suspicious, but Dabi supposes a little time to rest and get ready for the next operation is in order. Besides, Giren didn't just come with information today. Dabi picks through the boxes of support equipment he'd brought along, knowing immediately who each piece is for. When he extracts a set of long, insulated gloves, he glances back towards Giren who just shrugs.

"The kid was insistent when he put in the order before all this started. Something about discouraging self harming behaviors."

Dabi snorts, but he recognizes the quality of the fabric. Sliding one on, he ignites the air over his palm. He never feels the heat, hasn't for years now, but the slight edge of pain further up his arm is absent as well. Clever. He'll have to thank Kiddo later.

"I'll pass the rest out once everyone gets back from the supply run," he says.

“Good because I’ve got a client to meet up with.” Giren waves as he heads out, but pauses part way through the door. “Oh. Almost forgot.”

Something gets thrown his way and Dabi grabs it before actually looking to see what it is. And then he just frowns. A keychain, some hero- Dabi blinks and then laughs. It’s an Endeavor figure but the head and half an harm are melted off.

“Found that and thought you might get a kick out of it,” Giren says as he leaves and Dabi just looks back down at the keychain. His mirth cools and fades the longer he stares at it. Then the plastic figure starts to shift and bubble in his hand, the air swaying around it as Dabi’s fire ripples over the surface. Within seconds, it’s unrecognizable and Dabi lets the melted plastic drip from his fingers onto the floor.

It’s been a while since Dabi even thought of Endeavor. He’s been so busy with leading the crew, getting the list handled, worrying about Kiddo… It almost feels like a sign.

Maybe when Kiddo gets back, it’ll be time to cash in that first promise he’d made.

Katsuki has been thinking about Ground Beta for days. Every time Deku walks into his classroom behind Aizawa, every training session he observes or participates in, every time he refuses to even look at Katsuki, he thinks about it.

If this is some kind of sexual awakening, Katsuki swears he’ll kill that fucking nerd. Except he doesn’t think it’s that. He’s as uninterested in other people as ever, it’s just that goddamn *Deku* he can’t get off his mind. Frankly, Kaminari and some of the others’ obsession with sex and dating has always kind of disgusted him. They’re supposed to be some of the best in the world at UA, you’d think they’d be more focused on their future rather than fleeting physical gratification.

Then he looks at Deku and he remembers what that mouth felt like on his and no, he still doesn’t get it, but the memory lingers. It’s… distracting and Katsuki hates that so much. He’s on the path to greatness and he’ll be damned if he lets Deku of all people distract him from that.

This needs to be nipped in the bud and quickly.

Once the morning classes finish, Katsuki waves off the extras heading to lunch and instead makes his way to the teacher’s lounge. Just as he thought, Deku walks out of it trailing Aizawa and both pause to look at him.

“Need something?” Aizawa asks, sounding a lot more bored than he actually is considering the focus Katsuki can feel.

“Need to talk to Deku,” he says. “Privately.”

Aizawa frowns then glances at Deku who suddenly looks grim like a death row inmate. The fuck does he have to worry about? He’s not the one who’s been biting off people’s heads for a

week. With a sharp nod of his head, Aizawa leads both of them right back to the abandoned 1-A classroom.

“I’ll be waiting outside,” he says like a warning and then closes the door behind him.

Katsuki turns back to Deku and is struck with annoyance when the idiot won’t look at him. “*Oi*.”

“What do you want, Kacchan?”

What *does* he want? Which just annoys him even more. Now that Deku’s standing before him, Katsuki doesn’t know what to say to him. And the nerd won’t look at him, like something sordid and dirty happened between them. His belly twists at the idea and then he’s moving, barging into Deku’s space. Deku backs up against one of the desks and Katsuki cages him in, resting a hand on either side of him. *That* gets his fucking eyes on the right thing.

“Kacchan,” he says, barely above a whisper.

“What the *fuck* was that in Ground Beta?” Katsuki asks because it’s the only thing he can think about. “Why did you-”

“I shouldn’t have. I’m sorry, I just-” Deku cuts himself off as the twisting in Katsuki’s belly moves to his chest instead. “I’m sorry. It won’t happen again.”

Which should be a good thing, he won’t have to feel this confusion again, but it’s not good enough. Katsuki needs to understand.

“*Why?*”

And Deku looks like he’s in pain, holding back the things Katsuki wants to know, *needs* to know.

“I-I shouldn’t even be here,” Deku says. There’s a flash of the Deku Katsuki remembers, the one that took all his abuse and still babbled about being a hero some day, like he could ever be on Katsuki’s level. It pisses him off to see it when Deku’s been so irritatingly competent even without a quirk to back him up.

“Tough shit,” he growls. “You’re here, it happened, and you’re going to fucking tell me *why* or I’ll-”

“Because I’m weak. Because you’re… Because I couldn’t…”

“Bull*shit*-”

“Because I love you.”

Katsuki freezes, staring as Deku’s face crumbles and he lifts a hand to cover his mouth. That isn’t what he expected. He watches Deku’s stupid eyes go wet, watches his shoulders begin to tremble, and it doesn’t feel good at all. It makes the tightness in his chest even worse.

“The fuck would you go and do that for?” he finds himself muttering and Deku makes a sound like he’s been struck.

“How- how could I not?” he says helplessly from behind his hand. “How could *anyone* not?”

Now Katsuki knows for sure that Deku is fucking insane. He’s not at all unaware of his less than favorable qualities, at least according to other people who are too stupid to keep from wasting his time. Having been on the other end of his more violent tendencies, Deku should know better.

“You’re going to be an *amazing* hero, a symbol of victory, how can anyone look away from you?”

All of this is so fucking wrong but Katsuki can’t move. He’s pinned in place by watery green eyes and a wavering voice and this time it’s Katsuki that closes the distance. Deku’s lips are a little chapped but the way he shudders on contact does something to Katsuki he doesn’t quite understand. It’s nothing like the roar of need he’d felt in Ground Beta, something softer and a lot more… Just more.

Deku’s body is so warm where Katsuki presses into him and then Deku’s hands slide around his waist, clenching into the back of his jacket to pull him closer. When Deku eases his lips apart, Katsuki lets him. Lets him lick into his mouth, chases him back to his own, something hotter stoked in his belly. This isn’t what Katsuki intended in the least but now it’s all he wants. He breaks for air, sees the flush in Deku’s cheeks, and then has to dive right back in for another kiss.

One of Deku’s hands slides up to curl in Katsuki’s hair like a lifeline as Katsuki explores his mouth and can’t help the little shiver down his spine at the way it feels when his tongue brushes Deku’s. He digs his fingers into Deku’s back and as Deku tilts his head, somehow the kiss feels *more*, feels deeper, feels…

Katsuki breaks off and Deku lets him, but they’re still pressed so close that he feels Deku’s panted breaths on his skin.

“I don’t love you,” Katsuki says because it needs to *be* said, but Deku just smiles at him with his stupid, wet eyes.

“I know,” he says.

“We’ve barely spoken in two years, I don’t even know if I *like* you at all, how could I-”

“It’s okay. It’s okay, I know.”

“Then why the fuck would you let me-?!”

“Shh, it’s okay.” And then Deku’s kissing him again, soft and gentle in ways that make Katsuki ache, confusing him even worse, but it feels like if this stops they’ll both break apart. They’re fully clothed but he feels almost *naked* in Deku’s embrace.

“I’m sorry,” Deku whispers against his lips when they settle again. “I can’t help it.”

“The fuck you can’t.”

Deku laughs like he wishes he were crying and Katsuki *hates it*.

“You don’t have to like me,” Deku says. Like he’s trying to make it easier. Like he’s not breaking to bits in Katsuki’s arms. “It’s better if you don’t.”

“What?”

“It’s better if you don’t think about me at all.”

Katsuki’s struck then by how stupid Deku must think he is if he thinks Katsuki will just accept all of this. He plants a hand on Deku’s chest and pushes himself back out of the idiot’s embrace, getting some breathing room.

“What the *fuck* are you talking about?”

The smile on Deku’s face is so very fake it can’t even stand on its own, wobbling at the corners. “Doesn’t matter. You don’t have to worry about it.”

“What, you don’t think I can fucking *handle* it?” Katsuki snarls at him as confusion wars with anger for control.

“That’s not-”

“Just because you can throw around those extras like ragdolls, suddenly you think you can underestimate me?!”

“Kacchan-”

“Don’t you *dare* look down on me! I’ll kill you!”

Deku reaches for him and Katsuki backs off before he can make contact. This is better, this is familiar. Katsuki finally feels like he’s got his feet under himself again.

“Don’t you start spouting shit about what I’m gonna be and then try to *protect* me! I don’t need protection from a worthless, quirkless *Deku* like you!”

As Deku’s hand falls, his expression fades as well. “Of course you don’t.”

The agreement isn’t as satisfying as it should be but Katsuki’s done with this. He got his answers, now he can go back to ignoring Deku’s existence. Fuck this, Katsuki is *done*. He jerks the door open and storms through it without looking at Aizawa or wondering what he might have heard. Lunch is probably half over but Katsuki has no appetite. He goes outside and he runs until classes start again and tries not to feel like he’s running away from Deku.

Something about this evening rings off to Shouta. It’s like an itch in his shoulders, right at the spot he can’t quite reach. He’s been in a low grade worry state for most of the day, since

Midoirya's conversation with Bakugou. Shouta could get the surveillance footage to find out what they'd talked about, but overhearing the end of it, it didn't seem to go well.

Midoriya didn't want to talk about it, but Shouta can't help thinking maybe letting it happen was a bad call. They've been trying to give him the opportunity to build ties here, to try and give him another view of the world and what his place in it could be, and Bakugou is one of their best chances to do that… but it's not like they can control what either boy will think or do, especially when faced with each other.

It was a miscalculation. Shouta had tried to draw Midoriya out after but nothing worked. Even Eri couldn't. Midoriya went to his room early and now Shouta's staring up at the ceiling from his bed, wishing he had a patrol to go on if only because he at least would know he was doing some good for the world. But he doesn't have patrols right now with Midoriya living with him. No easy distractions.

With a sigh, Shouta gets up and stalks around the apartment. He knows they're all safe but his senses are still on high alert. It's probably paranoia. Even heroes aren't safe from false positives when it comes to gut feelings. The news about the Wild Wild Pussycats disappearances probably isn't helping.

As far as they can tell, the Pussycats were taken quietly. No sign of struggle, no sign of even a gas or drug, but those could have dissipated before they knew to search their HQ. A group in service for that long had to have plenty of enemies, there's no reason to think All For One is involved, but Shouta keeps doing it anyway.

Maybe he's just tired.

He checks in on Eri and finds her sleeping peacefully with the stuffed rabbit plush he'd put in her room before she arrived. He hadn't known what she might find comfort in and there were a few other stuffed animals, but this one seems to have made the cut. He's just glad *something* did. If anyone deserves comfort and security, it's this little girl.

He checks in on Midoriya next and the kid's actually sleeping as well, bundled up in his blankets. Shouta nods, soothed, and almost closes the door again only to pause. Something's off. He's not sure what at first but it won't let him leave. Shouta narrows his eyes as he glances around the room, light from the hallway plenty to see by after how long he's spent as a night time, underground hero. Nothing seems out of place. Nothing seems new or missing. Shouta's about to chalk it up to paranoia when he finally centers on just how still the bed is.

Midoriya sleeps quietly and without fidgeting, but he still has to *breathe.*

Four steps to the bed and Shouta tears off the blankets. He's not surprised to find only clothes and pillows in the vague shape of a boy, but he curses all the same. Whipping out his phone, he immediately pulls up the app Nedzu had installed that's tracking the ankle monitor and stalls a moment when the app insists the monitor is right next to him, still active and doing its job. He finds it stuffed against the corner bedpost, intact. The monitor should have sounded the moment it was opened, dropped in temperature, or stopped reading a heartbeat, but the app seems to think it still has Midoriya under watch despite the evidence against. Hacked?

Really, he should have expected something like this.

Shouta's on the move immediately, even as he calls Nedzu so the Principal can wake the rest of the teachers. Midoriya can't have gone far. There aren't any windows in his room, the ventilation is too small for a person even Eri's size, so he could have only escaped when Shouta went into his own room. Shouta starts searching the grounds and gets alerts of other teachers on campus doing the same for the buildings.

Not quite ten minutes in, Nedzu alerts them: "Midoriya spotted, heading for the entrance."

Shouta jerks around and races there just as he feels the rumble of UA's defenses trigger and the barriers going up. He spots Midoriya in costume not even pausing in his dead run towards the covered gate. Sending the capture weapon flying, Shouta's only annoyed when Midoriya senses and dodges around it, not surprised.

"Stand down, Midoriya!" he orders as he chases the kid away from the high walls. There's no response except for Midoriya dodging attempts to capture him. Then he jackknifes around capture from another source as Kan joins the fight. Shouta had known Midoriya was good, but watching him evade the two of them makes it clear just *how* good he is. The acrobatic dodges and feints look effortless as he works towards the walls despite their attempts to drive him back from them. No matter how good Shouta and Kan's teamwork is, the kid runs circles around them both.

Even when Kayama gets there, it doesn't make much difference. Midoriya's mask was made to filter out toxins like hers and she's not as adept at the level of physical combat he's capable of. It's not her specialty. Shouta knows he and Kan are just barely keeping him occupied and they'll tire before he does if they can't catch a break.

"Midoriya!" he calls again as the kid continues to evade him. "Calm down and we can talk about this!"

"There's nothing to talk about!" He sounds so frustrated by the interruption of his escape, even as he doesn't pause in his attempt. "I'm done playing *house!* I have a job to do."

"Whatever happened with Bakugou-"

"*Kacchan has nothing to do with this!"*

Shouta doesn't need Tsukauchi's quirk to catch that lie in action. Fuck, he shouldn't have left them alone. But at least the burst of upset finally trips Midoriya up as a whip of blood wraps around his ankle. It only makes him stumble, not fall, and then he's launching at Kan but it's the break Shouta needs to capture him in his scarf securely. Without his knives, there's no way Midoriya's getting out. He manages not to fall but it's a near thing.

"Calm down," Shouta says as he slowly approaches like Midoriya's a feral animal. He looks it, his eyes wild and face twisted behind the mask into what has to be a snarl. Thankfully Kan and Kayama back off to let him handle it since he's closer to the kid. "I know you're upset and all you want to do is run away-"

“I’m not running away!”

“-but this isn’t the answer. I can still help you. *UA* can still help you-”

Midoriya laughs, harsh and bitter. “You don’t get it, do you? I have to go after him. I have a *responsibility* to take him out before he can hurt anyone else.”

“Not alone, you don’t,” Shouta says and he is only barely keeping his cool. Midoriya’s not even trying to fight his bindings anymore as the fight seeps out of him.

“All Might will *die* if he faces All For One-”

“That’s a risk he’s accepted. And he won’t be alone this time.” This isn’t actually about All Might anyway. Shouta is absolutely sure about that but he’ll stick within the fiction for now. As Midoriya sags in the capture weapon, head falling forward, Shouta reaches out to squeezes his shoulder. “Midoriya, even with your knowledge of other loops, this is a new day. This is a new chance. We’re taking every precaution we can. Maybe it’s time you try to *actually* trust us.”

“He’s gonna die again,” Midoriya whispers as Shouta carefully loosens his capture weapon so he can draw the boy into his arms. He feels fine trembling through Midoriya’s entire body. “He just dies faster when he loves me.”

When this is over and they have Midoriya back safely in his room, Shouta’s pulling up the surveillance footage from lunch. Fuck, that had been a huge mistake. Midoriya’s nowhere near stable enough.

“Come on. It’s late,” he says to the top of Midoriya’s head, but he can’t get another word out before there’s a sudden huge crash and then the kid’s shoving him back and his own senses scream to *dodge, dodge, dodge*-

A grotesquely enlarged fist slams into the ground between them as the nomu shrieks, bits of stone and metal from the demolished barrier settling around it as its wide eyes twist in two different directions to track both targets. Shouta yells for Midoriya to run and immediately engages. The nomu looks almost exactly like the one that had attacked the USJ, definitely armed with super strength and heightened speed, and something about that feels suspicious considering how sure Midoriya had been that the new batch of them would be stronger, more deadly, but he can’t think about that right now. It takes both him and Kan to keep its attention contained, and then he hears Kayama yell.

Shouta spares a moment of attention to jerk around and watch as Midoriya coughs up some kind of black ooze that quickly envelopes his entire body in barely two seconds, and then he’s just *gone*. There’s no time to mourn it because the nomu nearly takes off his head with his next swing and Shouta can’t save Midoriya if he’s dead.

He doesn’t know how long they keep it on the run before a familiar snarl of *SMASH* signals for his quick retreat and then the nomu is abruptly no more. All Might straightens, his expression so utterly unamused that it chills Shouta to the core.

“Young Midoriya?” All Might asks like he already knows the answer.

“Some kind of teleportation quirk. He wasn’t expecting it.” Shouta had caught his face as the ooze enveloped him, there was no way Midoriya planned for that.

All Might looks at the hole in the wall that the nomu had come through. “The timetable just moved up. We’re going after All For One *now*.”

Chapter End Notes

I don't usually headcanon demi or gray-ace Bakugou, but it just seemed right for this story for some reason

Chapter 28

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

It's the middle of the night and Keigo's normally a total day person, but being a hero means he's gotten used to answering the phone no matter what. Still, he's not actually sure anyone can understand the way he slurs out, "Hawks here, what is it?"

If there are any consonants in what actually comes out of his mouth, he'll give someone a raise. Not sure who, just someone. Maybe he'll just do that anyway.

"Does anyone in Kiddo's crew have a teleportation quirk?"

Keigo pulls away the phone and glares at it until the writing on the little screen starts making sense. What the hell is Eraserhead calling him for?

"Uh. No? Not unless it's recent. Why, do we need one?"

"*Damn it*. Then they're not the ones who have him."

The barely controlled frustration in those short words suddenly jumpstarts Keigo's brain and he sits up. "Wait, what? Did something happen to Kiddo?"

"Someone snatched him. We've got a few ideas, none of them good now that you've confirmed it isn't his own people."

Aw, *shit*.

"Description?"

"Black goo from the mouth that covers the body and then disappears with the target."

Keigo quickly thinks back but he doesn't remember seeing anything like that. "No dice."

"Didn't figure. Get suited up. We're hitting All For One right now."

What? It's like two in the morning. "Are you serious?"

"We're heading to the primary target location in lower Musutafu. Get there as soon as you can. All Might's not waiting."

Oh, that's just great. Keigo quickly suits up and hits the sky because the longer it takes him to get there, the better chance All Might goes down just as Kiddo predicted. Along the way, Keigo calls Dabi, half expecting to be ignored.

When the call actually picks up, he almost drops the phone. "The fuck do you want?"

“You guys haven’t added a teleporter to your crew, right?”

“What? No. Kiddo’s not back yet to talk anyone else into joining.”

“Damn.”

“Hawks. What’s going on?” Ooohhh, that’s not a good tone. That’s the kind of tone that gets people charbroiled. Keigo weighs his options and figures hanging up on Dabi now will just make things worse.

“Not sure yet. Kiddo’s been kidnapped from UA’s custody.”

Silence and then a weird static that probably means Dabi’s quirk is partially active and warping his phone.

“*What.*”

“I’ll let you know when I have more details. Byeeeee!”

There, now Dabi will only try to charbroil *half* of him when they meet up again. In the meantime, Keigo shifts into a more streamline position and hauls ass to meet up with the others. He just hopes he gets there before Kiddo’s prophecies come true.

Getting the boy into his hands is hopefully worth the sacrifice of one of the few first generation nomus he still has. He’d needed someone near the boy that he knew well enough for that quirk to work and what could he know better than a creature he’d had hand in creating? Not that that mattered much when it came to Izuku. He’d created him but there’d been no reason to *know* him before now.

The boy is, for the most part, meaningless. He could have just killed him but All For One has never been someone who could walk away from the opportunity to gain a captive audience.

Izuku glares up at him from the floor, his coughing from the transport finally subsiding. There’s barely any sign of their last meeting, though he’s sure his ooze left a good amount of scarring on his shoulder and arm. Pity that twit had worked so quickly or Izuku might have lost it entirely even if he survived.

“Are you just gonna stare at me or did you have a fucking point in this?” Izuku asks as he straightens. He kneels before All For One with his arms secured behind his back and yet, there’s a pride in his eyes that All For One wonders how quickly he can burn out of him.

“You should know by now that everything I do has a point.”

“Yeah, it’s about the only thing we have in common.”

All For One smiles because he knows there is *far* more. He’s seen the trail of bodies Kiddo’s people left for the police and heroes to muddle over. The MLA could have been a useful piece for him, but he hadn’t been quick enough to capture them for himself and now they’re, for the most part, dead. A pity. There’d been some useful quirks in the bunch so he had of

course taken several bodies for his nomus, but still. Sometimes one wants soldiers that think for themselves and not all people have the strength to survive the process well enough to do so.

His heir will. The work Garaki has done on Tomura is nothing short of brilliant and with All For One's greatest gift bestowed upon him, no one will be able to stand against him.

"Stop smiling like that," Izuku says. "It's gross."

All For One focuses back on the boy and only smiles wider in response. "Tell me, what sort of quirks should your nomu have?"

"Ugh, are we really doing this? Sadist."

"Come now, I'm feeling generous. The least I can do is give my *son* input on what sort of monster he'd rather to be."

Izuku sighs and just looks put upon instead of angry or frightened. Which fits, considering the time loop he thinks he's trapped in. All For One wonders, idly, if he's lived through a similar conversation before.

"How about the power to just bury myself," Izuku mutters as he looks away from All For One and starts taking in the office. It's quite put together, in All For One's opinion. Not quite as posh as some of his spaces have been but it'll do for now. He won't be staying here long, after all.

"I could stuff you full of enhancement quirks and send you after All Might once your mind breaks," he says and Izuku pulls a face.

"You're doing that on purpose."

"Nothing of the sort."

"Just kill me now instead of subjecting me to your overwhelming creep factor. Ugh, I feel dirty just being near you."

"Now, that's just rude."

All For One begins pacing a circle around the boy, considering his options. He has plenty of quirks to help him break Izuku and extract the information he wants, ones that will leave his body in great shape for the process of becoming a strong nomu, but there are some he favors over others simply because he *enjoys* them more.

Izuku looks so *small*. And yet, had he only power, he could be so much greater. It's tragic, really. All For One truly pities the boy.

Before they can really get started, there are things he wants first. All For One curls his fingers in Izuku's curly hair and jerks his head back. He ignores the hiss of annoyance and rests his other hand over Izuku's forehead.

“Show me the girl,” he says, smiling as Izuku’s eyes widen. “Show me Kazuko.”

And then the room around them melts away.

All For One stands somewhere entirely different. The room is quiet except for the constant background noise of medical instruments beeping steadily. The scent of chemicals and sickness permeate the air. He’d know he was in a hospital room without seeing more but he still casts his eyes around the room anyway. Pale green walls, a wide window with the curtains drawn to let in plenty of sunlight. The bed is settled against one wall with monitoring equipment sitting around it and laying in the sheets is a man All For One recognizes immediately.

Izuku doesn’t grow up to look like him. He looks like Yoichi and it takes All For One’s breath away. It’s not just his illness sunken cheeks, either. His white hair is cropped short and tidy, his face is lined with age, but the soft expression on his face is one All For One has desperately wanted to see again for so long. One he’s *never* seen on the boy’s face.

“You came,” Izuku says and for a moment All For One thinks maybe he’s being seen, but then a young woman that he assumes is Kazuko steps past him and goes to Izuku’s bedside, leaning over to kiss his forehead.

“Of course I came,” she says, smiling at him with the same gentle affection as Izuku. Her eyes are warm on her pretty face, her long hair held back with subtle little barrettes, but All For One can’t quite figure out what colors any of it is. He knows she’s pretty but when he looks away from her face, he can’t remember what she looks like. He wonders if Izuku’s forgotten after so long or if he’s struggling to hide at least something from All For One’s gaze.

“How are things at the agency?”

“Oh, same old. Uravity’s working me to the bone, but I’m getting excellent practice! She says hi.”

Izuku smiles wider as Kazuko drags over a chair and then sits down with one of his hands held in hers. They chat a little about work and All For One gathers that she is a fully fledged sidekick, but a young one. New to the work, newly graduated, perhaps.

As the conversation starts to lull, a certain melancholy passes over Kazuko’s face. “So… Did the tests come back?”

“Yeah.”

“And it’s not good, is it?”

Izuku smiles but it doesn’t reach his eyes. “No.”

“How… how long?” She swallows, squeezing his hand tighter in hers. “Until you…”

“Not long.” Her expression crumples in and Izuku only smiles more softly. “Shh, it’s all right, sweetheart. I’m not afraid anymore since I know you’re doing so well.”

“You’re- you’re *never* afraid when you should be.”

“I was terrified of *you*, when you came to live with me.”

She laughs, wet and rough, but manages to smile at him as her eyes grow wetter. “Yeah? You kind of sucked at the whole parenting thing at first. I remember that.”

“I *did* have to do it by myself. And you didn’t make it easy.”

“Yeah, well, if half the things you said hadn’t started with ‘*my mother always said’...*”

All For One finds his feet bringing him closer so he can get a better look at their faces, a better view of this family he doesn’t know and hasn’t really had since Yoichi first turned on him. He’d wanted it, once. He almost wants it now.

There are photographs on the bedside table but All For One only notices them when Kazuko’s eyes are drawn there. They look to be mostly candids, either of the two of them growing up or people they know. Grinning from one of the frames like a fiend is Bakugou Katsuki, looking no older than the last time All For One had seen him in the League’s custody. He’s in no other photo.

“Do you think he’s waiting for you?” Kazuko asks and that, finally, wipes the smile from Izuku’s face. He stares at her almost haunted and then looks up at the ceiling.

“No,” he says after a long pause. “At least, I hope not. It’s been a long time.”

Her brows bunch together and she squeezes his hand. “What if you could save him?”

“No,” Izuku says instantly, sternness twisting his mouth as he turns back to her without an inch of give. “Kazuko, *no*.”

“That’s your greatest regret, isn’t it?”

His eyes dim. “That doesn’t change right and wrong. Or what it does to-”

“It’s all right. Ouroborus doesn’t hurt me like it used to.”

“I’m still not letting you-”

“Maybe I won’t let you say no.”

Izuku’s jaw clenches and All For One sees how much he wants to take her up on that offer, wants to accept something he thinks is wrong.

“You could lose your license. You *know* special permission is required to use temporal quirks outside of work,” Izuku says and Kazuko just grows more stubborn.

“It’s worth it if you can clear your regrets. It might be the last thing I’m ever able to do for you after everything… everything you did for *me*.”

The need to protect her wars with his own wants in Izuku's eyes, but this version of him is much older and wiser than the boy All For One knows. His self control is ironclad. "No."

Kazuko presses her lips in a tight line and then nods a little, regretful. "I'm sorry."

There's something in her tone that Izuku seems to miss as he accepts her apology, but All For One isn't at all surprised when Kazuko gets up to her feet and presses her right hand flat on his chest, right over his heart. Only the deliberate action that appears to be familiar alerts Izuku and his eyes snap wide.

"*Kazuko-*"

She presses her lips to his forehead. "Go save him, Dad."

Izuku has only a moment more to stare at her in horror before everything fades away and then… Then they're in a bedroom that's covered in posters and merchandise of All Might, and All For One can't stand to stay there. He drags himself from the memory, barely noticing as he steps away from Izuku until he hears the boy slump forward to gulp down painful, heaving lungfuls of air.

"I see," All For One says, mildly disappointed. "She really *hasn't* been born yet."

"You son of a bitch," Izuku snarls, tears overflowing his enraged eyes. "You had no right!"

All For One ignores him, considering. Possibly twenty at the most, but as old as Izuku had seemed… No. It would be at least a few decades before that girl's quirk appeared for him to take.

"I'm going to tear you apart," Izuku's saying as All For One thinks to himself. "I'll burn you to ashes, destroy everything you've ever fucking *touched-*"

"I suppose it would be inconvenient if you were to interrupt me by restarting the loop," All For One says before pulling at one of his more specialized, less useful quirks. It'll do for now. A touch and Izuku's fierce eyes cloud and grow unseeing. "Why don't you dream quietly for a little while."

He leaves as the boy slumps down onto the floor and shuts the door, secure in the knowledge that at least one annoyance would be out of his hair for a while. All For One has plans to set in motion.

Toshinori hasn't been angry like this in years. He normally doesn't let it happen, not with the kind of power he has sunk into his very bones. The embers are dying out, but the power is still there and begging to be used. When he's angry, it's so much harder to hold himself back from the true level of destruction he's capable of. All For One is an opponent he *can't* hold back against. It's almost a relief if not for just how much he hates the man.

When they arrive near the old office building, it seems like nothing special. Just a business like dozens of others, only special for where it is located. But Toshinori chose to trust

Midoriya's word. If he said this is the most likely bolthole of All For One, Toshinori believes him. He watches it from a street away, barely able to stand waiting, but Midoriya had been adamant. If Toshinori goes in alone, he'll die. Even with Endeavor and Hawks backing him up, the boy hadn't been confident he'd survive.

If this is the end, so be it. Toshinori is ready. He'll take All For One down with him.

Hawks lands behind him but Toshinori doesn't look away from the building as he hands over an earpiece already tuned into the frequency they're using for the mission. His blood is singing in his ears, thinking about all those All For One has hurt, all those he's killed. He thinks of a green eyed boy that still doesn't know how to trust anyone and tries not to imagine what All For One might be doing to him, if it is him that took Midoriya. Who else would? Who else *could,* with a nomu to distract them.

"Endeavor?" Hawks asks and All Might shakes his head. He hadn't been able to get through on the number two hero's personal phone, but he'd called the agency. Someone is going directly to his home. Todoroki Enji is many things but there's no way he'll miss this chance at glory. And that's what it would be to him, Toshinori knows. He's a much different hero than him.

"He has half an hour," Toshinori says grimly. "Then we go in regardless."

Hawks steps up beside him, looking at him from the corner of his eye with his jaw tight. "We got a plan B for backup?"

"Eraserhead is scoping out the building to try and locate Midoriya. Vlad King and Midnight are on standby."

The way Hawks' lips twitch make it clear what he thinks about their chances. "Say I could call in some cavalry…"

Toshinori glances at him and waits until Hawks crosses his arms and rolls his head over to look back at him straight on.

"There's a reason Kiddo's gotten as far as he has," Hawks points out and this time Toshinori is the one to grind his teeth.

"Absolutely not."

"I'm just saying, they're not afraid to get their hands dirty and they've got the firepower to back it up."

"I'm not trusting a group of *villains* to assist in a rescue operation-"

"Is that what we're doing? Because I was pretty sure it was an assassination."

Toshinori stiffens, but doesn't deny it. Frankly, there's been blanket no-fault fatality permission on All For One for the last decade. Capture if possible but a kill is permitted otherwise. Toshinori knows better than to let All For One live. Not anymore.

“Kiddo chose them for a reason,” Hawks says, “and it’s not just because they’re skilled and powerful. They’ve killed for him and I’m pretty sure they’d die for him, too.”

“Are you telling me to use them as *cannon fodder?*” The cold rage in his voice has Hawks lifting his empty hands and taking a step back.

“Personally, I’d rather they lived. I’m just saying, those guys are loyal to a *fault* to Kiddo. If I let them know where he probably is? Nothing will stop them from tearing the place apart to extract him alive. Offload the rescue and we can concentrate on the more dangerous target.”

Toshinori understands what Hawks is trying to do, but the cold and clinical analysis leaves him at a loss. Just as Endeavor is a far different hero than All Might, so is Hawks. He’s known that since the young man debuted. Toshinori’s smile is meant to reassure. Hawks’ is meant to disarm and deceive.

Before he has to make a decision, Eraserhead’s voice carries over the ear piece from his subvocal mic.

“*Target confirmed. Third floor, east side, second window from the right.*”

“Package?” Toshinori asks after switching on his own mic.

“*Negative.*”

If Midoriya isn’t here, they’ll be back to square one. Toshinori’s fingers curl to tight fists, but the fact of the matter is that All For One needs to be taken down and the sooner he’s dead or captured, the sooner Toshinori can scour the city to find Midoriya.

“Additional threats?”

“*Negative.*”

He doesn’t like this. Something feels wrong and he can’t tell if it’s intuition or just his own anxiety regarding Midoriya’s safety.

“Keep looking,” he says and then looks at Hawks. “Call in his crew. Tell them to search the building for Midoriya or any clue to his whereabouts. Make it absolutely clear that if they touch any civilians or heroes, I will personally drag every one of them to Tartarus myself.”

“You got it.” Hawks pulls out his phone and steps aside to make a call and Toshinori checks the time. Fifteen minutes and they go in without Endeavor. Whatever happens, Toshinori has already accepted the consequences.

“What do you mean you can’t track him down?”

“I didn’t say I *couldn’t*. I said I *wouldn’t* track down a hero for you just because you yell at me about it!”

Dabi barely keeps his quirk in check. He can't lose this phone. He finally has the crew wide high score on that rhythm game Toga likes so much.

"What's your going rate?" he growls out and La Brava sighs heavily.

"How about some *respect* and *decency.*"

"How about you give me what I want and I don't burn your fucking building down with you in it?"

She hangs up. Dabi almost throws the phone at the wall and instead just punches in her number again. She hangs up on him after the first word from his mouth.

"Maybe I should try?" Spinner suggests and only flinches a little when Dabi turns his glare onto him. Stubbornly, Dabi dials her again.

"Take a hint!" La Brava says instead of answering like a normal person, only to hang up on him again.

"I'm going to burn her to *ashes*," Dabi growls, finally giving into the urge for violence. His phone smashes into pieces against the wall and it doesn't even make him feel any better. Someone has Kiddo, someone's taken the person Dabi dedicated himself to, someone is going to *pay*. He barely notices Spinner backing away from him as the heat grows around his body.

"Toga, say something to him!" he hears Spinner hiss out.

"Why would he listen to *me?"* she stage whispers back. Like he can't hear them scheming behind his back-

"Oh! Hello, there, do you have a minute to talk?"

The suddenness of Twice's cheerful tones cuts right through Dabi's awareness and he slowly turns and stares at the dark suited villain with his own phone to his ear.

"Right, right, no, I'm Twice! Of *course* I'm part of the same crew. *Who are they?*" Twice isn't looking at any of them, fully focused on the phone as he starts gabbing at that goddamn brat of a hacker who doesn't hang up on *him*, even though he's so much more annoying and taking so long to get to the fucking *point.*

It takes nearly twenty minutes to talk her into hacking the hero specific mobile network to track down that winged motherfucker by his cell signal. That gives Dabi just enough time to decide not to murder Twice for being annoying or La Brava since she finally comes through on the information he'd asked for in the first place-

It's going to feel so good to wring Hawks' fucking neck when they get to him. How dare he ignore Dabi's calls after dropping a bombshell like that.

Just as they've finished suiting up with the new support equipment Kiddo had arranged for them before his capture, Spinner's phone goes off. He blinks at it, lifting it to his ear. "Who is

this? You- Oh. Yeah, no, his phone is in pieces right now. Part of it's stuck in the drywall."

There's no goddamn time for this. Dabi's half tempted to leave all of them right here and go after Hawks himself, tear his wings off and *beat him with them*…

"Dabi?" Spinner calls, eyes wide. "Uh. It's him."

Dabi has no recollection of the two seconds it takes him to get to Spinner's side and tear the phone out of his hands. "*Where the fuck is Kiddo?*"

"Whoa, coming on a little strong there," Hawks says like there's nothing major going on because that stupid son of a bitch can't be serious for five seconds, can he? "Slow your roll, buttercup. You ready to get him back, then?"

"Give me a fucking address!"

Hawks whistles because he's absolutely allergic to not being a *prick*. "Wow, you're running a little hot there, buddy."

"I swear, if you don't tell me where he is *right now*, I'm going to piss on everything you own and then *burn you alive*."

"Ah, yeah, got it. You are so not thinking right now."

The sound that next escapes Dabi's mouth is not human.

Thankfully, Hawks rattles off an address, tells them not to hurt civilians or heroes without facing the wrath of the top three, and the crew finally, *finally* gets moving. Having a definite place to go even if the plan is basically to wing it starts calming down Dabi's fury. He doesn't give a shit about Hawks' rules, will gladly break them even if it ends up going against the no-go list, just as long as it means Kiddo's returned to them safe and sound. The weeks without him have made it clear that they can't continue on without his guidance.

That *Dabi* can't.

Blessedly, the others don't try to talk to him as they head towards their target.

Chapter End Notes

Dabi losing his ever loving shit was so much fun to write y'all.

Chapter 29

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Everything is still and quiet and calm until suddenly it isn't anymore.

One minute, Shouta's swinging back up to check if All For One has moved since he looked last. The next, he's being slammed into the next building by some unseen force and isn't entirely sure his back hasn't broken when he hits the floor of an empty office and slams into the corner of a bulky desk on the other side of the wall. It only occurs to him after several seconds that he might have also hit his head and by then he's already trying to push himself up again.

There are crashes behind him, something getting destroyed, but his head swims even getting onto his hands and knees. He barely keeps from throwing up as the world wavers before his eyes. *Damn it*, what even just happened?

Shouta gets to his feet and stumbles over rubble towards the gaping hole in the wall. His head is starting to clear a little bit as he grabs the edge of the wall to steady himself, but he still has to squint at moving figures to figure out what the hell is going on.

That… Okay. All Might has engaged, that must be All For One he's fighting, and that means All For One must have noticed Shouta and attacked. Makes sense but ugh, he really hates overpowered quirks like that. He's not even certain he could erase All For One with so many quirks under his skin.

A streak of red- Hawks. Shouta feels a little better knowing the number three is backing All Might up. There's already a good amount of collateral damage to the buildings, but at least it's all just offices and parking lots. This late at night, not even cleaning crews are around. It'll be hell for people to wake up to, but the alternative…

Shouta rubs his head and his fingers come back sticky with blood. No wonder his thoughts keep drifting. Still, he's awake and mobile, mostly. He doesn't expect to be any help in the fight, but that just frees him up to search for Midoriya. None of the windows revealed the kid, but there have to be plenty of internal spaces to search.

Testing out how his body's responding, Shouta weighs the odds of getting back over to the other building and decides they're good enough. He makes the jump right through the hole All For One left blasting him in the first place. It's not a great landing, he ends up on his ass, but it's good enough and thankfully there's no one to see him. Shouta climbs back to his feet and takes a second to mentally reorient himself in the space. The office is nondescript and not noteworthy in the least. No personal effects. The paperwork Shouta finds doesn't mean much to him. Orders, supply manifests. They'll be good for the police to figure out whatever the hell All For One has been up to. He finds a small text-to-speech document reader that throws him a bit but maybe behind the helmet, All For One is blind. It's not like they've seen his

face. He's able to navigate his environment easily enough, maybe due to any number of quirks he'd stolen over the years.

Fighting the nausea that any movement of his head brings, Shouta leaves the office and starts combing very slowly through the other rooms of the floor. Most of them haven't been touched in a while, covered in a thick layer of dust that would have made it easy to track steps if anyone had walked through them. Shouta leaves those be. More offices, meeting rooms, supply rooms… He's about ready to head down to the next floor when he hears something moving around nearby. Shouta narrows his eyes and ghosts towards it as quietly as he can manage.

"...every room," says a voice that picks at Shouta's memory but he doesn't quite recognize it. Then again, standing still is almost harder than moving, his awareness flickering for a few seconds.

"Stay on guard," says another, deeper and maybe older? With an undercurrent of barely focused rage.

"I'm with Dabi!" A girl this time-

Oh. These are Kiddo's people Hawks called in. Shouta debates showing himself to them, but then his head swims and when he gets back to himself, he's on his knees and there's a man standing in front of him. Shouta slowly manages to lift his head and take him in.

Tall, dressed mostly in black, horrific scarring on his face and what of his chest can be seen above the low collar of his shirt. Blue eyes that should be cold but are almost burning with anger. Shouta's first instinct is to capture and contain, but his body won't quite respond. *Shit*.

"Who the fuck are you?" the man says before a girl pokes her head out from behind him. Blond, young, dressed in a school uniform? That- Abruptly, Shouta recognizes the description from the training camp, some of the students had seen her. What the hell was her name?

"Oh! I know this one!" the girl says with hushed excitement. "The scarf, remember?"

"Eraserhead," the man confirms and Shouta's aware of heat rolling off his body. That… Didn't someone in Kiddo's crew have a fire quirk? It's really, *really* hard to think.

"He's on the no-go list, Dabi! We should make sure he's okay. He doesn't look like he's tracking well."

"We don't have time to baby a fucking hero-"

"*Kiddo won't ever forgive us if we let him die!*"

"The hell is the no-go list?" Shouta thinks but his mouth moves over the words without his permission.

"Sh, sh, sh, it's okay," the girl says and she's suddenly so close Shouta jerks back a bit, but he can't get far, there's a wall at his back. "We're not allowed to hurt you."

That seems important but Shouta's having a lot more trouble tracking anything in front of him. He thinks he hears the man move on but the girl is still so close and she reaches for his head.

"No," he says and she hesitates before getting a more stubborn look on her face, as much of it as he can see through her bulky mask anyway. What was her quirk…?

"If you bleed out and die, Kiddo will be so very upset," she says like that should persuade him to let a fucking villain - because she is one, if she's part of Kiddo's crew - touch him when he's vulnerable and can't remember what her quirk is. "Stop being so stubborn!"

"Don't you dare," he growls even though the rumble in his chest just has his head aching that much worse.

"How are you expected to do your hero thing if you can't see straight?"

He still tries to dodge away from her next grab but his vision blacks out for a few seconds and when it comes back, she's already examining the head wound with careful fingers and the light of her cell phone. Shouta hates to admit it, but this is probably a losing battle.

"Why… why am I on the no-go list?" he asks instead because it's better than trying to track what she's doing by feel. His senses are off. *Fuck*, his head hurts.

"Kiddo says you're a true hero," the girl says absently, like it's not important. "So you need to stick around for a better world."

True hero…? The hell does that even mean? Maybe Midoriya's talked to the heroes about the time loops and his main focus, but this is more about his crew's goals than any of them have been able to suss out. A better world? Is that just to get his crew on board or is Midoriya actually looking at the bigger picture as well? Has he been playing them with all his grief and focus on Bakugou?

There's not much the girl can do for him, but she eases him up to lean against the wall. "You should stay here while we search the floor. We'll come back and take you with us when we go up to the next one."

"...Why?"

"If the fight comes crashing this way and you're alone, you might get hurt worse! And then Kiddo will be sad. Or pissed off we left you. Or both? It's a toss up."

Shouta eyes her, trying to decide how much he actually trusts this, but Kiddo's crew are fanatically loyal to him according to Hawks. Knowing he's apparently on some kind of safe list is uncomfortable, but it might be a boon to him later if Midoriya's people go too far.

Without waiting for his approval, the girl gets up and leaves, presumably to follow after her companion. If Shouta's honest with himself, he's not in great shape here. The blow to his head rattled him badly and he's starting to recognize the feel of a few cracked if not outright

broken ribs. There is no universe where he's a good match for the raw power getting thrown around outside so he might as well stick around the crew for now.

Resting his head back against the wall, Shouta sighs and closes his eyes as he tries to listen and track what's going on around him by sound. Distantly, he can make out crashes and destruction outside, footsteps shuffling around inside. He thinks there's more than the two he saw just now, but he can't quite tell. Not that it's all that important to him right now.

Taken out of the fight in the first round, what a joke.

This is not an encounter he wanted yet but All For One supposes it doesn't matter. He'd hoped to get more information about the future, about his actions in the past loops, about plans the heroes thwart and how, but this is fine. His greatest creation is ready and waiting to take up the mantle of king of the underworld once the new body has been perfected and All For One is, perhaps, ready to let him.

To a point.

In any case, at least with the added interference of that winged punk, it's turning out to be an entertaining fight. All Might's tactics don't change much, but that's more due to how effective they can be. Hawks has his own habits and it's not hard to figure through anything All For One hasn't seen before. Most of the difficulty in fighting them is their familiarity with the idea of *teamwork*.

The most All For One has tacitly agreed to in this fight is to try to shield his office from damage as much as possible. If the boy dies, the loop begins anew and All For One will have lost the advantage of knowing they're in a time loop in the first place. His glorious plans mean nothing if he's forced back to that unknowing beginning, so he takes care to keep Izuku alive as he beats these two foolish heroes who should never have come against him in the first place.

"Getting tired over there, old man?" the impertinent younger hero calls out before All For One swats him away and then All Might's back in his face and it's all All For One can do to keep both of them at bay. He's holding his own for now. A stalemate just waiting to see who gives out faster and despite Hawks' taunt, All For One feels *fine*.

He shows just that when he pulls at one of his newest quirks and a wave of earth tears out from under the street to bury both heroes. He misses Hawks but All Might goes under with a satisfying snarl of anger that All For One will savor for the rest of his life. Hawks seems to think he's distracted because he makes a stupidly open attack that All For One twists right around as his body becomes wonderfully pliable and bendy. The shocked look on Hawks' face is almost too good. All For One wraps around him before taking both of them to the ground. It's nothing to make sure the bulk of the impact is on Hawks and then the hero is motionless so All For One lets go of him. He doesn't have time to verify a kill as All Might erupts from the ground and heads right for him.

Trading blows with All Might has a certain nostalgia to it. All For One will certainly tear him limb from limb when he sees the opening to do so, but for now he just pulls at destructive

quirks that All Might takes full on with little visible effect or dodges around with that damnable speed of his. An air cannon finally hits true, flinging the aggravating hero away so All For One can get a moment to breathe.

He realizes something, in those few seconds. He's taken hits, sure, but none of them have been as devastating as those he remembers. All Might isn't as fast or strong as he used to be. Behind his mask, All For One feels his lips pull back into a wide grin.

"You've gotten outdated, All Might," he says and isn't surprised to be answered by a punch after All Might gets his feet under him again. Outdated, slowing down, body giving out. All Might might have grown comfortable with his brother's quirk but he hadn't been made for it and the embers of it have gotten so very weak. Just as he's taken out every wielder before him, All For One will enjoy watching the life drain out of All Might's eyes before going after the successor he knows must be out there. He can feel them at the edges of his senses.

As All Might tries to gear up for one of his larger attacks, All For One presses on the offensive to keep from giving him the time. Then a wall of razor sharp feathers breaks the two apart before Hawks comes right at All For one with one wielded like a sword. He's not terrible, All For One will grant him that, but his body isn't nearly resilient enough to face someone like All For One as an equal. That is a *lovely* quirk though…

All For One manages to fling the bird away and then hears the telltale announcement of a *smash* before he gets knocked into and *through* the next building. Before he can even notice he's come to a stop, he's being pummeled enough that even his several shock absorption quirks are being strained.

Strained, not voided.

Even All Might can't keep up this kind of pace and the moment he pauses, the moment he lets up even a bit, All For One activates rivet stab and aims for the old wound he'd left on the hero years ago. All Might startles back with a gasp, blood trickling between his teeth.

"Oh, I thought you might feel that one," All For One with a soft laugh. He tugs at a recoil quirk as All Might punches at him again, flinging the hero back with the force of his own attack. All For One pulls himself out of the rubble and straightens just in time to catch both of All Might's fists at once and hold him as All Might strains against him. "Isn't this just like old times?"

"This ends today," All Might vows as if this is some sort of play where the good guys are bound to win. If All For One had any pity left in him, he'd kill All Might before he could realize differently.

"I wonder," All For One says absently, "if your successor will cry harder over your body than my son will. That is, if he could still cry."

"Where is Midoriya?!"

"Oh, quite close. Most of him, anyway."

Horror floods All Might's face. "What did you do to him?"

"Ah, come now. Don't you know about *spoilers?*"

Another opening and All Might's blasted back. Too slow, too *weak*. It's an embarrassment, what his brother's quirk has been trapped in. No more.

All For One makes his way after All Might with a vicious sort of joy in his heart. It looks like he'll live through this day after all. He catches Hawks' next attack in his quirk enhanced hand and then tears the feather from him only to stab it back into the hero's chest. Hawks jerks back from him but All For one makes liberal use of rivet stab to take him out of the fight for good. Then it's just him and All Might, who's faltering visibly. The way his form seems only half familiar has All For One laughing.

"Oh, if only the world could see you brought so low, you pathetic *Symbol of Peace!*"

The emaciated half of him looks to be barely standing as his muscular half tries to compensate. All For One won't give him the chance. He gears up for another air cannon and then his vision whites out as flames erupt around him, temporarily blinding his infrared quirk. He throws himself back on instinct and senses the air movement as another hero enters the fray. They're like *termites*.

"Endeavor!" he hears All Might call and oh, *of course* it would turn out like this.

"I'll handle this," the current number two hero says before heat builds up anew.

Oh well. All For One will just have to make due with what the world has given him, he guesses.

Had Spinner been thinking a little more clearly, they'd have started going down rather than up from the start. It just makes sense, the way you know things are supposed to happen with a story in a genre you're familiar with. So it doesn't surprise him when they get to the sixth floor and still haven't found Kiddo. Dabi looks ready to burn the place down, Toga's getting worryingly quiet, and Twice, who knows Kiddo the least, has about three brain cells centered on the search while the others try to comfort Toga. Which, sure, Spinner's fine with that. Means he doesn't have to.

They should have started down first. When he mentions a basement level, Dabi just stares at him for a few seconds and then resolutely heads back to the stairs. Which is great, there's no way any of them are using the elevator with that crazy fight going on outside, his legs are getting one hell of an exercise, but Dabi's not the one carting around Eraserhead's dead fucking weight!

Spinner waves the others ahead as he starts levering the concussed hero onto his back again. The asshole's wavering in and out of consciousness, but at least when he threw up on floor five, it only hit Twice's shoes.

“If you weren’t on the list, I would just leave you to rot,” Spinner growls at him but Eraserhead doesn’t answer. He’s been real quiet since throwing up, but he’s still breathing so Kiddo has *zero* to get pissed about. In Spinner’s opinion, they’ve gone above and beyond the call of duty.

Once Eraserhead’s settled, he hits the stairs and treks down until they get to the first basement level, and then has to stop because Dabi’s standing in the open doorway like an asshole. There’s light in the basement, but it’s weird and wavering. Maybe a server room? Offices have server rooms, right?

“Hey, this guy’s not exactly light!” Spinner says to spur them on. Dabi makes a grumbling noise, hasn’t really talked in the last half hour, but he gets moving. Once they’re inside, Spinner settles Eraserhead against the door because he might as well make himself marginally useful and then starts spreading out with the others.

And… okay. It’s fucking creepy. This isn’t a server room but it’s full of equipment. A lab, maybe? The light is low even after one of them flips a light switch, half the bulbs burned out- scratch that, half of them *removed* so it looks like twilight with a bunch of multicolored flashes from the machines. Spinner doesn’t really try to identify anything. It all looks like something out of an old, pre-quirk Frankenstein movie (so sue him, sometimes he gets a kick out of the old horror shit and maybe Frankenstein is one that always speaks to him in ways he will never tell anyone else about.)

Twice is the first one to find a body. At least, the first one to shriek like a fainting maiden about it. Toga doesn’t even shoosh him and when Spinner gets there to crane his neck around the two, well, maybe he doesn’t hold it against Twice for reacting that way. The thing is mutilated or mutated or… or something. More a pile of flesh with things stuck to it than something Spinner could actually see being ambulatory. It’s hard to tell if the thing’s skin is mottled or if it’s just the weird lighting, but it isn’t moving and Spinner really hopes Dabi torches this fucking place when they’re done.

It’s just creepy, okay?

They find a couple more whatever-the-fucks but no Kiddo, so the group heads down to the second and final basement level. And… What the ever loving shit. The others fan out pretty quickly but Spinner’s stuck at the door in a state of whiplash. The second basement is set up like a normal house, but there’s something disturbing about the sheer level of normality to every inch of it. Less like a living space, more like a stage. Like he should expect a camera in his face and a studio laugh track.

He doesn’t set Eraserhead down this time as a thread of paranoia sinks into him and just starts through the floor, trying to ignore the feeling of someone watching him with every step. The main rooms are empty of anything but expensive furniture and general creep factor. Spinner isn’t the one to search the bedroom, but Twice acts like there’s nothing notable and he takes his word for it. Soon, there’s only one more door left and it’s decidedly different than anything else.

It’s a goddamn bank vault.

“What the fuck,” Spinner whispers under his breath but Dabi doesn’t hesitate to try pulling at the thick wheel. They’re in luck. It’s not locked. It is, however, pitch fucking dark. Toga drags out her phone and switches on the flashlight, which finally lands upon their missing leader crumpled on the floor.

Kiddo doesn’t respond when Dabi unties his hands and turns him onto his back. Shaking him and calling his name does nothing. His pupils are fucking *blown* when Twice checks under one of his eyelids. Drugs? Nah, that’s not All For One’s style, as much as Spinner has figured out about him over the last while. Got to be a quirk.

“Let’s get him out of here,” Spinner says, adjusting Eraserhead to be a bit more comfortable on his back for the trek up. “We’ll figure it out later.”

Twice gets to carry Kiddo’s dead weight back up the stairs. They’re all quiet, unnerved by Kiddo’s mystery state as much as glad to see him. If Spinner has his way, they’ll drop his burden off outside and then fucking bolt. The heroes are all distracted fighting All For One, it’s a good chance.

It’s a great plan. Wonderful. 10 out of 10, Spinner’s a fucking genius. That is, of course, not what happens.

The moment they get outside, Dabi freezes like his quirk is ice based instead of fire. His eyes snap wide, almost haunted. When Twice stumbles into him, he doesn’t even budge.

“Dabi?” Toga calls, reaching for his hand, and then jerks back her own with a cry of alarm as Dabi’s fire flares up in his palms. Spinner checks over to where he’s looking but it’s just the fight. Just “good” and “evil” duking it out. Just-

Oh. Oh *shit*.

It’s just goddamn *Endeavor*.

Maybe Spinner doesn’t know exactly why Dabi has such a thing about Endeavor, why the rage courses through him at mention of the guy’s name to a frankly worrying level, but he doesn’t have to get it to understand what the fuck is about to happen.

“Dabi, don’t-” he says and it’s already too late because Dabi’s running before his name has left Spiner’s mouth. “*Shit*.”

He offloads Eraserhead onto Toga and Twice, who grimly switch their burdens for what’s gonna be a longer haul. They can’t leave Eraserhead here when he’s not even conscious. No one should ever trust Endeavor to notice someone around just waiting to be collateral damage because they can’t run away and Spinner is *not* going to be the one to tell Kiddo they let the guy die.

“Take them back to base, make sure the damn hero is secured, then one of you go kidnap Recovery Girl,” he orders. “Don’t let her or Eraserhead make any decisions about what to do about Kiddo until I get there unless he’s gonna die, got it?”

If they don't hurt her, all Kiddo will do is yell at them for grabbing Recovery Girl again which Spinner figures is worth the risk.

"Got it," Twice says and they start their escape. They'll figure out what the fuck to do with Eraserhead later, right now Spinner can't give a single fuck about that. Not when Dabi's going to get himself killed jumping into an all out war that's already leveled several of the buildings around them. Spinner does not want to be the voice of fucking reason here because that's not supposed to be his role but no one else is gonna do it.

He's lucky he's a more physical guy in general than Dabi because catching up to him otherwise would be a bitch and a half. Spinner barely manages to close the nearly half minute of lead time to tackle Dabi to the ground before he can start an attack. They're so close to the heroes and All For One that he can hear them trading quips even if he can't make out the words, but then Dabi's snarling at him and blue lights up the area from his quirk and Spinner is going to be *so fucking mad* if he has to let Recovery Girl heal him after this, too.

"Would you calm down and think already?!" he screams in Dabi's ear as he squeezes his arms tighter around Dabi's chest, resolutely holding on even as pain streaks through him from burning hands.

"He's right there!" Dabi yells and Spinner almost loses him, has to wrap his legs around the guy as well to keep him still. "He's right *there* and I-"

"There will be other chances, you can't go into this half cocked!"

"*Fuck your other chances!*"

Spinner grits his teeth and tightens his hold. The only reason this is working is because Dabi's not a martial fighter at all, relies on his finesse with his quirk instead of his relatively weak body. Spinner probably has forty pounds on him, easy. Not that it does anything for the *burning!*

"Get your quirk under control, asshole!" he yelps. "How are you supposed to help Kiddo build the better world if you get murdered by the hero statistically most likely to murder someone during a villain encounter?!"

It doesn't do much for Dabi's rage. Spinner considers bashing his head with a rock. They've already got Recovery Girl on her way, surely they can threaten her into healing him?

"What was the point of bitching about unnecessary risks and patching me up if you're just gonna burn me all over?" he complains and that, for some reason, finally seems to land. Dabi stops struggling and just lays there panting in Spinner's grip, trembling like it's some herculean effort not to act like a jackass. His fires burn out, the heat radiating off his body starting to lessen.

When they get back to base, Spinner's going to let himself be mad and spit vitriol and do all the things he wants to do right now but for some reason has the self control not to. Right now, he just keeps holding onto Dabi in case he changes his mind about the whole thing and tries

not to think about the heroes who have no idea they're here within easy range of becoming so much paste on the street.

"Are you done?" he asks because these burns are already starting to smart something fierce. He'd like to at least get some burn cream and see if he can avoid letting the healer hero touch him.

"Let me go."

"You gonna go get yourself killed if I do?"

Dabi sighs. Spinner waits. The heroes probably nearly accidentally murder them a couple times.

"No," Dabi finally says and Spinner maybe shouldn't believe it but he lets go anyway. He gets up, wincing as every new burn makes itself known. Fuck, he hates getting burned. Dabi accepts the hand Spinner offers to drag him up to his feet, pale eyes flickering over Spinner like he's… what, guilty? Sulking? Who the fuck knows what goes on in that guy's head.

Dabi looks back up as Endeavor builds up a thick cloud of fire around him, gearing up for some big attack Spinner does not want to stick around for. After another few seconds, Dabi clenches his teeth and then turns away. Spinner says nothing as he trails behind him.

Chapter End Notes

Everyone is having a terrible day except All For One, who's having a blast mostly.

Chapter 30

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Toshinori has been hanging onto One For All by a thread for longer than just since giving the quirk over to Togata. He knew his time was severely limited already and he hasn't let himself consider when that thread will break and the barely alive embers inside him will cool for good. As long as he's alive, he's going to push himself as far as he has to. Save one more person, force one more miracle.

He has the uncomfortable certainty that it's all been leading up to this moment and he is, on his own, not enough despite his convictions.

Hawks didn't recover from the stab enough to fully join the fray, but he's been offering support with his feathers, straining himself as he slowly bleeds out on chunks of rubble and glass. Endeavor's doing a good job keeping All For One distracted while Toshinori works on a field dressing to keep him alive long enough for paramedics to arrive. His own phone is in pieces somewhere but surely Eraserhead called in the fight by now. Or if not him, Midnight or Vlad King did when they headed off to All For One's stronghold.

"You should escape," Hawks says suddenly, looking up at Toshinori with a rare seriousness. "Endeavor probably has this. I can still run support. You're at your limit, aren't you?"

There's no hiding how badly Toshinori is doing. He hasn't been able to totally regain his muscle form and his hands shake with the effort of tending Hawks.

"It doesn't matter," Toshinori says and Hawks snorts.

"You're more than just a symbol, All Might," he says as he smiles. The smile reminds him of Midoriya and all his well meaning attempts to keep All Might away from this very sort of moment. "You're the kind of guy we hope gets to retire."

Frankly, Toshinori has never considered what might happen when he isn't able to be a hero anymore. The careers of One For All holders end in messy deaths. That's how it'd been for his master, for hers. It's how it seemed to be for Midoriya, how it would probably be for Togata.

"I'll always do what's necessary," Toshinori says as he finishes the field dressing. It's not great, but the pressure should help keep Hawks from bleeding out as long as he stays *still*. "When help arrives, have them take you to the hospital immediately."

Toshinori gets up only to stop as Hawks grabs his wrist. The younger man's steely gaze pins him in place far better than his grip ever could.

"I can buy you time. You're not expendable, old man."

“Neither are you.”

Hawks flinches, just a little, but he lets go and Toshinori turns to face the battle still raging. He can see signs of Endeavor slowing down, starting to succumb to the great heat being generated between him and the villain as All For One reflects and magnifies his own fires. He’s always been skilled at turning quirks against others. It’s part of what’s made him so dangerous, that versatility.

Toshinori draws for every bit of strength still in his body and leaps in as Endeavor tries to withdraw. It’s enough of a surprise to get All For One’s attention on him and then they’re back into the vicious dance of traded blows and powerful quirks. After Endeavor’s gotten a few seconds to breathe, he joins back in and it’s only Toshinori’s familiarity with the man that makes it possible for them to work together because Endeavor certainly doesn’t put much effort into it. He’s never been a team player.

The chance comes unexpectedly, but then Toshinori’s fist connects and he drives the villain down several feet into the broken pavement. The heavy metal mask shatters as Toshinori draws back to hit him again and sees for the first time the ghoulish mess he’d left behind in their last encounter. This time, Toshinori doesn’t hesitate. The dregs of his power are so cold but he still throws the next punch and the next one. He ignores the way All For One’s fingers shoot out and stab into him. He ignores the sound of Endeavor yelling at him to move and let him incinerate the bastard. The only thing that matters right now is making sure that All For One ends here and now.

“Yagi,” the villain manages through broken teeth and Toshinori pauses, panting for breath. He’s shaking with exhaustion, less of his muscle form still managing to hold on. “Isn’t this familiar?”

“Wait until I tear your arms off this time and beat you with them, then tell me how familiar it is,” Toshinori growls back, reaching to do just that, but the villain only begins to laugh. The heat behind him rises as Endeavor readies himself for the death blow if Toshinori is unable to land it. Both of them know this can’t go on, can’t happen again.

Maybe Endeavor has gone into a fight knowing it would end in death before, but Toshinori never has. Even as he tore All For One apart the last time, the intention had been capture, but now is different. Now, the only way to reduce harm is to make sure he will never be a problem again. Midoriya’s face flashes in Toshinori’s mind, his insistence on taking the kill to prevent future harm, but while Midoriya was indiscriminate with who he decided deserved that finality, Toshinori knows this is probably one of the most justified kills any hero has had to make.

“I think instead,” All For One says as he grins, drawing Toshinori out of his thoughts, “I’d rather go out with a *bang*.”

And then Toshinori realizes the heat he’s feeling isn’t from behind him but underneath as All For One’s body begins to rapidly extend upward. He stumbles off him and… There’s no time. Toshinori doesn’t think as he grabs Endeavor’s arm and then flings the man away with every bit of strength he still has. The last he sees is Endeavor’s bewildered expression and a second later he’s already too far away to see.

The the bomb that was All For One explodes and Toshinori's world fades into white.

Chiyo is awakened at oh-dark-thirty to a request coming in for medical support. This isn't the first time, it's just been a while. She's technically retired from active service but depending on those involved she might be called out anyway. The HPSC has kind of a sketchy idea of what retired means. There's no details given in the request, no warning for what she might be walking into. Is it an active battle? Is it concluded? Who knows.

She looks up the address they sent and figures she's awake enough to assist. Getting dressed takes no time and then she's got her front door open only to freeze. There is a tall man in a skintight black and white suit on her doorstep, one she recognizes. She looks up and says very clearly, "I don't have time for this. Please step aside."

"Sorry, but we need medical assistance. Please come quietly," Twice says. "You're coming whether you like it or not!"

This kidnapping thing is getting stale. Chiyo wacks her cane against his leg, surprising him enough to step around him. It's not like any of Midoriya's crew are going to actually hurt her, they've made that clear. "Young man, go bother someone else. I've got an emergency to get to-"

"That's where *we* came from!" Twice whines, following behind her.

"Your buddies can *wait* then," she says.

"But Eraserhead won't wake up-"

Chiyo stops dead and then slowly turns her head up to stare at him. "What happened to Eraserhead?"

"Probably a concussion?" Twice shifts from one foot to the other. "Lost the fight with a building!"

Her teeth clench. Aizawa is one of *hers*. "Other injuries?"

"Yes? Probably? He went unconscious and hasn't woken up so we took him with us when we left the fight so he wouldn't get squished. Kiddo's not waking either, but we don't know what happened to him."

Damn. Chiyo knows there will be plenty of other arriving at the scene she'd been requested to. There will be other healers, paramedics, support personnel. The HPSC tended to go overboard when they bothered to get involved. Her quirk is strong but not absolutely necessary. If she doesn't go with Twice, who knows who they might get to look after Aizawa and Midoriya.

"Fine. Take me to them."

Twice nods with exaggerated formality, almost enough to be a bow, and leads her to a ridiculously nondescript black van with tinted windows and she swears, she's going to let

them have it about discretion. It's not like they're a damn Yakuza group!

It doesn't take long to get to the headquarters of his group. Twice fills her in on the general gist of the fight they'd left, at least what little he knows about it. They exit the car a ways off from the building and Chiyo never sees the driver before he leaves. The structures around them seem to shift and draw her attention, but Twice keeps her focused through it until they're finally inside and the effect abruptly ends. Some kind of quirk, then.

The others of Midoriya's crew are solemn and one looks to be covered in burns that another's tending to, barely looking up to notice her in the least, but Chiyo's quickly ushered into one of the converted offices where two cots have been set up. One of them holds Aizawa, bloodied and quiet with makeshift straps holding him down and quirk erasing cuffs on his hands, the other is Midoriya.

Chiyo checks over Midoriya first. Breathing well, strong heartbeat, good color. He looks like he's just sleeping. Comforted that the child is stable, Chiyo moves over to Aizawa a lot more grimly. The head wound is bad as she moves the towel someone had stuffed against it to get a better look. A lot of blood, not surprising, but when she feels over the area carefully, she's sure there's significant skull fracturing. Whether any of it has chipped into his *brain* or not, she can't tell.

His breathing is too quick and shallow, sounds labored, and his skin is clammy to the touch. She examines his chest and is sure at least three of those ribs are broken. Whether they'd been fully broken from the initial impact or from him moving around after and being moved after is debatable. It doesn't sound like anything pierced his lungs but she'll need x-rays to be sure.There might be spinal damage, she doesn't ask any of them to flip him over to check. He's been moved enough already with uncertain injuries. She worries about internal bleeding, ruptured organs, but without any of her equipment here it's all even odds. Right now, she just needs to make sure he survives long enough to be hospitalized.

Chiyo makes use of her quirk, careful not to overstress his already battered body, and hopes his body will prioritize the head wound rather than everything else. The draw to her core is familiar and within minutes, Aizawa's eyes flutter open. He's still confused, she can tell he didn't expect her to be hovering over him, but he struggles to be aware anyway.

"Shu-"

"Tell me what happened," she says and he blinks before looking past her to the worried villain in the doorway. Twice hasn't said a word since Chiyo got there and he doesn't now, either.

"All For One," Aizawa says, brows furrowing as he works through his memory. "He detected me. Took me out quickly."

"I heard about a building?"

"I went through it."

Ah, that would do it. Without any kind of enhancement quirks to cushion the blow, Aizawa is lucky to only be *this* bad off.

“And after?”

“All Might engaged. So I went to look for Midoriya.”

“That’s where we come into the story!” Twice says and Chiyo gives him a withering look that makes him wilt. “Well, we *did* make sure not to leave him there to die.”

Aizawa doesn’t thank him for it and Chiyo looks back. “What happened while you were looking for Midoriya?”

“I collapsed. They found me and dragged me along while they searched. And… I passed out, at some point.”

“Did any of you drop him?” Chiyo asks over her shoulder and Twice immediately answers.

“No! We were very careful because he’s on the no-go list!”

“I want a copy of that list,” Aizawa says, as if that’s the most important thing here. Chiyo resists the urge to roll her eyes.

“You, stay still and just heal. Go to sleep again if you can,” she says, then turns to the excitable villain. “You, I need an ambulance to take him to a hospital.”

Twice snaps into a mocking salute. “Yes, ma’am! Right-”

“I’m not going anywhere,” Aizawa growls out and Chiyo just barely keeps from strangling him.

“Don’t you even start,” she says as she matches his glare with her own. “What I just did is a stop gap. You need medical attention *in a hospital*. You need x-rays, probably surgery, and if you’re not down for a few weeks after this, I’ll eat my cane!”

“I’m not leaving without Midoriya.”

Stubborn ass.

“We’re not letting you take him again!”

Stupid ass.

Chiyo rubs her temples against the headache she’s developing. She steps back over to Midoriya’s side, frowning at his peaceful face. “What happened to him?”

“We don’t know.” It’s hard to tell with the mask but she thinks he looks anxious. “We just found him in this vault and he was already asleep.”

Checking under his eyelids, Midoriya's pupils have almost fully dilated and don't react to light, twitching at random as if dreaming. She doesn't smell anything on his breath but there are plenty of ingestable drugs that wouldn't leave that sign. Twice helps her change him out of his costume and into a too large shirt and loose shorts so she can do a more thorough examination. As far as she can tell, he doesn't seem to have been injected with anything nor does she find any residue from a skin contact poison. All she finds are regular training bruises and scars that make her want to hit something.

Her gut says it's not poison or drugs. Her gut says it's a quirk.

"Do you guys have anyone with a good analysis quirk you can call on? Someone who might be able to identify quirk usage and effects?" she asks and Twice tilts his head as he thinks about it.

"I have no idea," he says after a minute. "I know just who to call!"

He steps away from the doorway as he drags out his phone and starts chatting at someone. Chiyo looks back at Midoriya. He looks so young like this, like one of her normal first year students, and it crushes her to know the peace of his sleep is an absolute lie. She eases a blanket back over him and glances back to Aizawa, unsurprised to see his eyes boring into her.

"Don't you even start," she says, tapping her cane, but Aizawa hadn't been afraid of her as a student, why would he be now?

"I'm not leaving him again. Someone has to put that kid first," Aizawa says with the same conviction as before. Her heart aches for him. She is also just barely keeping herself from knocking him upside the head. If he were injured *anywhere else*…

Twice pokes his head back through the door. "We're bringing someone! Giran says they're the best. Also the most *expensive.*"

Oh lovely. The best of the black market is coming to look at a comatose teenager she has no way to extract yet. Chiyo will have to deal with that because frankly, she's not ready to leave Midoriya here, either. His crew seems loyal enough and even with him out of commission, they're still following his orders, but who knows how long that will last.

Glancing past Twice, Chiyo's eyes land upon another kid, the young girl she's seen before. The girl stiffens, then smiles in a wavering manner before turning away to bother the others. The heteromorph could probably use more help than just burn cream, but the look on his face when she catches his eye isn't even neutral, much less positive, and good, at least one of these idiots seems to understand that she is a reluctant and temporary ally *at best*. If they'd stop kidnapping her, maybe even less than that.

She doesn't know what she did to get on Midoriya's fabled no-go list, but she almost wishes she hadn't.

Todoroki Enji comes to abruptly. He doesn't move at first, listens to the world around him but hears little movement. When he opens his eyes, the sky is still dark and cloudless but the stars are mostly drowned out by light pollution. The air smells dusty and when he sneezes, he becomes entirely aware of just how much he *hurts*.

The battle comes back in an instant and Enji seethes at the way All Might took him out of the line of fire like he was just another civilian, like All Might had *any right*. Enji climbs up to his feet and doesn't let himself wheeze as that puts pressure on injuries he hasn't decided to acknowledge yet. There will be time later once he's made sure that All For One bastard is down for the count and he's torn All Might a new one for the indignity.

All around him are the echoes of their battle. No building has been spared as far as he can tell and in one larger area, they were leveled entirely. Enji heads that way with certainty that if there's a fight to be found, it'll be there. He doesn't let himself think about the deathly stillness, not until he spots bright red and hurries over to find the number three hero.

Hawks is alive, barely. Unconscious, half buried by rubble. Enji drags him out from under it, but there's little he can do and it looks like either All Might or Hawks managed to get a field dressing in place for the stab wound he'd gotten before. Heaving Hawks over his shoulder, Enji continues on. The stillness makes him sure he shouldn't leave Hawks there alone.

He doesn't quite realize he's entering a crater until he's part way in already. Then the curved walls of debris become more obvious. Half a mile by his eye, he's sure of it. Not nearly as big as that brat had warned, but big enough that the whole area will have a great amount of rebuilding to go through. Another bit of good luck that this happened while the district was empty before the start of a workday.

Ground zero for the blast isn't too difficult to find, but Enji doesn't find any sign of either the villain or All Might. Had they moved to a different area while Enji was out? He'd been flung out a while but not *that* far. Surely he hadn't been unconscious for that long. But the quiet, the strange finality in the air… His senses are alive with unease.

Enji still hasn't found All Might or anything of All For One when emergency services begin pouring in. Someone takes Hawks from him, several someones start badgering Enji to sit down and let them tend to him, as if he's so weak he can't continue on like this. It burns through his chest that, for the second time, All For One has evaded his grasp. And this time it's goddamn All Might's fault for stealing the chance from him. Enji's never hated him more.

What it would do for his image if *he* were the one to finally take down All For One when even the Symbol of Peace failed to do so.

Enji gives one of the police officers a rundown of the event. He watches as several more comb through the area along with a few search and rescue heroes for All Might, All For One, and the boy who'd kicked off this battle in the first place. Enji's part in this matter is done for now unless All For One pops out of the ground like a spring daisy but he stays anyway. He watches. He waits.

When a few panicked yells for medical assistance come in from afar, Enji knows who must have been found; no one's carrying quirk suppressant cuffs. Despite the protests of the

paramedic tending him, Enji gets up and follows them grimly.

Though he's never seen this side of All Might, Enji still recognizes him in the thin, emaciated form that the rescue workers unearth. His ripped and torn costume sags badly around his body, his hair singed and limp. There's barely any movement past the unsteady rise and fall of his chest. Without that overpowered quirk of his, he likely wouldn't have made it even this long. Enji rakes his eyes over the rival he's been chasing for his entire career and knows with cold certainty that this is the end. Whether All Might survives or not, this is the end of him.

Enji stands in silent vigil as All Might is loaded up on a stretcher for transport and only then does he realize what the number one hero has lost. Yes. Even if he survives, this is most definitely the end of his career.

With Hawks and All Might in medical custody and Enji's own injuries quick healed and ready to manage the rest of the way on their own, Enji moves to assist the search teams in finding any sign of All For One. Either of an escape or a death, he doesn't care.

The sun is already warming the eastern sky when someone discovers the first piece of the villain's body. Then another and another. By the fifth, all from radically different parts rather than one limb or area, it's clear that All For One won't be coming back from this one. Enji finally leaves the scene and tries to ignore the sour certainty of a true victory snatched out of his fingers.

He's not sure if he should blame All Might or All For One more. Whether it matters.

The house is well on the way to waking up when he gets home. Fuyumi greets him warmly with an invitation to breakfast only for her smile to fade into worry that Enji doesn't acknowledge. Later, once he's had time to think. Fuyumi will understand. She always does. Of all his children, she is the one who's always accepted him exactly as he is.

His office feels stiflingly small after he closes the door behind him and sits down at his desk. The call will come in later but Enji already knows what he'll be told. He needs to get a statement ready, needs to galvanize his sidekicks against the press storm that is sure to descend upon them. They'll have to manage that mostly on their own. Enji wouldn't have accepted them if he thought he'd have to protect them every tiny step of the way. He stares down at an empty page of stationary and thinks *damn you, All Might*.

This isn't how he wanted to win. This isn't how he was supposed to solidify his legacy. Enji covers his face with his hands and then rakes them back through his hair as smoke escapes his fingertips. Closing his eyes, he gives himself a moment and then picks up his pen and starts to write.

The call comes in an hour later. Enji listens without feeling, accepts the HPSC's decision without gratitude, and then hangs up without waiting for the caller to finish his congratulations. The page on Enji's desk is full but half the words are scratched out. He grabs a fresh sheet and copies what little he's come up with. The PR department of his agency will turn it into something announcement worthy but Enji's always made sure to have some kind of input in the beginning.

He shouldn't be making this announcement at all. Tomorrow, he'll be plenty mad about it. Today, he's just… handling it. When he goes into his agency, the PR department takes his measly few lines and has a full speech penned out in what feels like minutes. Enji goes on camera along with an HPSC official to explain what happened.

"So, I present to you now: the number one hero, Endeavor!"

Suddenly everything comes rushing at Enji at once, like he'd been half asleep and just snapped wide awake. He doesn't let it show on his face, doesn't let anyone know he'd been in a fog before now. Enji grimly lets the press record and photograph him until they're satisfied. When they finally let him go, he excuses himself to the car that's standing by for him.

The hospital is bustling and energetic until he gets to the hero ward. There is a very telling silence over everything. No one questions Enji when he asks for All Might's room number. Then he's standing in front of the observation window and staring in at the former number one. What's left of him.

The nurses say he'll live. The look in their eyes says they don't know for how long. Enji ignores them either way because he already knows.

Had All Might not seen fit to save him, it would be Enji on that bed or worse. He's always been a man that prided himself on his skills… but the only reason All Might is alive is a strong enough enhancement quirk to withstand the blast. Looking at him now, Enji wouldn't have survived that. Knowing doesn't make the burn of shame any easier to accept.

He leaves before All Might can wake or take his last breath.

Chapter End Notes

Well, you could say All For One is still having a blast?

Chapter 31

Chapter Notes

This chapter kicked my ass. I rewrote so much of it lol.

It has to have been half a day since he woke up here. Shouta's starting to think maybe Recovery Girl was right that he might need to go to a hospital, considering how awful he's feeling despite a few applications of her quirk. She's had to be careful, not knowing if something might heal wrong simply because she didn't know the full extent of his injuries. Twice agreed to unstrap him from the bed, but they've left the cuffs in place to keep his quirk in check. They know he probably can't take any of them on right now.

But he's far more sure he can't leave Midoriya alone and doesn't have the strength to take him away yet. The members of his crew flit in and out to give Midoriya's sleeping body worrying glances but none of them seem to know what to do. They're like children missing a parent. Disciples missing a master. Followers missing a god.

None of them look at Midoriya and see a *boy*.

"We can't leave him here," Shouta says again quietly when it's just the two of them and Shuzenji nods, her expression just as serious. Plotting an escape with her lack of martial ability and his injuries will be difficult, but they keep watch. The chance has to come.

Twice has just finished taking away dishes from a second meal when newcomers arrive. Shouta recognizes one of them. Giran, underworld broker, known associate to Kiddo. He isn't smiling when he pokes his head through the sickroom door, but his eyes are as sharp and sly as ever as they flicker over Shouta and Shuzenji. Then he focuses on Midoriya and walks over to brush his fingertips along the kid's forehead.

"The hell did you get yourself into this time?" he mutters. Shaking his head, Giran waves his other hand vaguely at the door. "Come on, Haru, make yourself useful."

Watching the next person arrive is an exercise in ignoring Shouta's baser instincts. One would think living in the kind of society quirks have created would mean silly things like overly gangly body proportions and bone white skin would be easy to ignore, but there's just something so unsightly and *wrong* about the way this Haru person leans over Kiddo's body, kickstarting Shouta's adrenaline. Those spindly thin limbs and skeletal fingers harken back to every horror movie he's ever seen and it takes everything in him not to reach for his capture weapon that isn't even here in the first place.

The specialist, because that's who she must be, says nothing as she rests a hand on Kiddo's forehead and the other on his chest, long fingers nearly engulfing the whole of both. An eerie

sort of cold starts to permeate the room and then Shouta happens to look at the woman's face and ice trickles down his back as he watches her dark eyes go milky white and glow with an internal light.

It's only a slight consolation that beside him, Shuzenji's holding herself tight as a bow string just like he is.

"Well," Haru says once her eyes stop glowing. She takes her hands off Midoriya and straightens up to her full, ridiculous height, messy black hair nearly brushing the ceiling. "It's a good thing you called me and not Kurai because she'd be useless here."

Giran lifts a brow, leaning back against the wall at the head of Midoriya's cot. "Yeah, and? I'm not paying you to be cryptic."

"You're not the one paying her," Dabi growls from the doorway with the other members of the crew peeking around him.

Waving Dabi off, Giran puts his full attention to Haru. "Go on."

"It's a nasty one. I didn't realize anyone else could do this anymore." Haru tucks her hands into her too long sleeves, glancing Giran's way. "Shit's old school as hell. A dream of a world so real, the dreamer doesn't know they need to wake up. The user doesn't have to do anything except start the process then the effect's anchored to the victim."

"Sounds like something out of a movie," Twice says but no one's amused by the possibility. If Midoirya's stuck in a fake dream world, then…

"Oh yeah, some kind of romance movie for sure. He probably won't be able to wake up by himself," Haru says and that is exactly what Shouta didn't want to hear.

"Got a trick up your sleeve on how to fix that?" Giran asks. "This isn't some true love's kiss bullshit, is it?

"Pft. Nah, no, just trust." Haru shrugs one too slim shoulder. "Parent might be able to do it."

"Not an option," Shouta says through his teeth. From the last report, Midoriya Inko has only barely begun to speak again and is still lapsing into hours long staring fits. There's no way she's up for seeing her son like this and whatever horrors All For One saw fit to unleash on his mind.

"Maybe a mentor, then. Someone with authority."

They all look between one another and Shouta has the distinct feeling they're all thinking the same thing: who on earth holds enough sway over Midoriya to be considered authoritative? Shouta knows better than to think that's him. And even if it's clear All Might was Midoriya's mentor once, it's just as clear he isn't *now*.

"If we had someone like that," Shuzenji starts, cautious but unwilling to give up yet, "what would the proposed procedure be?"

“My quirk allows me to let people share dreams,” Haru says, tilting her head unnaturally far to one side until it looks uncomfortably like her neck’s been broken. “I’d let whoever you pick share Kiddo’s dream and try to convince him it isn’t real and to wake up.”

Shuzenji shares a glance with Shouta before he asks, “What are the risks?”

“Other than possibly getting *stuck* in his dream?” Haru shrugs. “It’s a dream. It’s not like getting hurt there will hurt the real body.”

But the risk of being stuck is certainly enough. Stuck and at the whims of the dreamer.

“Were you able to see what he’s dreaming of?” Spinner asks, peeking around Dabi. He’s covered in bandages slathered with burn cream but seems alert enough. Whatever the hell happened to him must have hurt like a bitch.

“It’s not really like that. I can’t watch them like a movie, but I get little images. Seems like he’s dreaming about heroes?”

Which doesn’t tell them much. Without context, heroes could be a nightmare of pursuit, of familiar faces hunting Midoriya down to the ends of the world and tearing him apart.

“Try sharing it with me,” Shouta says abruptly, ignoring Shuzenji’s sharp look. “You said there’s no risk to our physical bodies.”

Haru flickers too dark eyes over Shouta’s body before focusing on his face again. “You sure? Because you’re not looking too hot over there and this’ll take a lot out of you.”

“I’m against it,” Shuzenji agrees, lips pressed in an unamused line. “As the only physician here-”

“Your complaint is noted.” Noted and ignored because Shouta’s not leaving that kid alone any longer than he has to. “If I’m not enough of an authority figure for him to listen to me, we’ll at least know what kind of nightmare he’s in.”

They stare at him and then Midoriya and then each other. One by one, all eyes move to Dabi, who stoically takes on the burden of that decision.

“If you hurt him,” Dabi begins, sliding a look so cold onto Shouta that he almost shivers. He doesn’t have to finish. Shouta nods. “Do it.”

They move Shouta’s cot closer to Midoriya’s and Haru has him take the kid’s hand. It’s limp but warm and alive, settling Shouta just a little. Then he goes rigid as a skeletal hand reaches for his face and settles over his eyes.

“As long as you remember it’s not real, you should be able to wake yourself up,” Haru says and that’s the only warning Shouta gets before he’s suddenly standing clean and whole in the middle of a busy crosswalk.

The sky is clear and cloudless, the people seem content to walk around him without bumping into him, there is not a cross word to be heard. Buildings rise tall into the sky like he’s in

somewhere like Tokyo and the cars passing by are courteously quiet. A sense of peace settles strangely on Shouta's shoulders as he finally moves out of the street and only after he's reached the other side does the indicator light switch from *walk* to *caution.* Like it was waiting on him. There's no sign of Midoriya no matter where he looks. Just people living their lives, making their way, and-

A loud crash and then smoke billows out from what looks like a bank further down the street. Shouta's on the move immediately as people yell and panic but before he can get there, a man in a familiar costume runs past Shouta like he's standing still.

"Oi! Don't you bastards have anything better to do today?!"

That is not Bakugou Katsuki, the man is taller, broader, but no one quite talks the way Bakugou Katsuki does. Before Shouta is not a gangly teenager but a full grown man in the prime of his hero years. Muscles tensing and shifting under tanned skin, Bakugou lets loose a flurry of explosions as he meets the villains streaming out of the bank head on. His arrogant laughter and taunts follow their pathetic resistance and all Shouta can do is watch.

This doesn't make sense. The dream is supposed to be a cage for Midoriya, so where is he? Shouta looks around for any sign of him as Bakugou takes down the villains with ease and the police take them into custody. It's bizarre seeing this strange apparition of his student, like he's seeing the double image of familiar superimposed on the strange.

Several civilians shout out for Bakugou's attention, screaming out *Dynamight! Dynamight!* but Bakugou just waves them off with annoyance as he seems to be searching for someone. A shout catches their attention and then Shouta looks up to watch another hero leap down from the bank roof with another villain thrown over his shoulder only to land hard enough that the pavement cracks under his feet.

The hero is dressed in a green jump suit with black markings, padded heavily at the knees and ankles above his bright red sneakers. Pale gloves with additional wrist support, a metal mask, and a hood with… rabbit ears? For a landing like that, has to have some kind of strength enhancement quirk.

"Don't worry!" the hero says as he straightens up, green electricity arching up his arms for a moment before disappearing. He turns to wave at a few people with his free hand. "I am here!"

The *hell?* All Might's tagline?

"You dramatic fuck," Bakugou grumbles, apparently agreeing with Shouta's sentiment as the green hero hands off his villain to the police. The second hero laughs like he thinks Bakugou's just joking and then both of them stiffen and reach for their ear pieces in a move Shouta knows well. He's an underground hero but that doesn't mean he's unfamiliar with limelight procedures.

"On our way," the green hero says and then he and Bakugou race off together. Before Shouta can think to follow them, everything around him just… *shifts*. The entire scene changes, different place and different feel and suddenly he's watching the middle of a vicious fight

between the two heroes and a villain with some kind of earth or matter manipulation quick that's destroying the ground around them. It happens so quickly and yet somehow his mind wants to just accept it.

Dream. I'm in a dream, this is normal here.

Shouta watches the beatdown without fear as he remembers that and Haru's comment about no harm transferring to the main body. The unknown hero has a strength enhancement quirk with a mixed speed element? It's effective, works well with Bakugou's power like the two of them were *made* to pair up. Still no sign of the kid he's actually here for but Shouta keeps watching the green hero, sure that he's the key to this.

Bakugou and the green hero take down the villain after a lengthy fight that seems to push them rather far, roughing them up and tearing at their costumes. The green hero's hood is torn down the middle and he laughs when Bakugou complains about it until he pushes it down and-

It's Midoriya. Larger, *older*, looking so light and cheerful that he might as well be an alien for how little he is like the boy Shouta knows. It's an adult Midoirya with a useful quirk and working as a hero, getting yelled at by an adult Bakugou and-

It hits Shouta like a truck. He understands. He knows what this is. Even before he notices how close Bakugou's letting Midoriya get, how he lets Midoriya worry over a wound on his arm, how amusement simmers under the performative anger in his voice, he knows what he's looking at.

When Shouta blinks, he's staring at Haru's palm again as she tugs her hand back.

"I didn't think you'd tap out *that* fast," she says but Shouta doesn't have time to correct her before Dabi's right in his face, hand gripping the front of his shirt tight.

"What did you see? What kind of nightmare-"

"It's not," Shouta says. His voice comes out tight, hoarse, and he senses more than sees Shuzenji approach his side. "It's not a nightmare."

Dabi lets go of him but doesn't look relieved. Whatever Shouta's face is doing, it can't be good.

"If it's not a nightmare…" Shuzenji says, trailing off uncertainly.

"It's not." Shouta lifts a hand and covers his eyes."It's not a nightmare. It's a perfect dream."

Bakugou alive and allowed to grow up, Midoriya allowed to cling to his old dreams of being a hero with a quirk, a world that is whole and stable around them to flourish… What Midoriya has already fought and died for countless times and that *bastard*…

"It's everything he's ever wanted. There's no way any of *us* will be able to get him to reject it."

It's a very long silence that follows his words. None of them are important enough to Midoriya's core mission to sway him, but Shouta knows who might be.

The day had been normal except for the absence of their teacher. Katsuki doesn't know the story there but they don't see hide nor hair of Deku either. The other teachers all seem to be on edge and don't hide it well in the least. Katsuki still hasn't figured out what's going on by the time school's over and he's in the dorm, and that's when he catches the breaking news of All Might's abrupt retirement and Endeavor's rise to the number one hero.

The news stops Katsuki dead and he stares at the big TV in the dorm common room with several of the others. No one speaks. No one knows how to react. Katsuki feels like the entire world has just fallen away from under his feet. Retirement? *All Might?*

All Katsuki's life, All Might has been a hero who wins time and time again. Powerful, tireless, *perfect*. If All Might is stepping down, it should be because Katsuki is ready to step *up* and not before.

The internet is a wild mess of speculation when Katsuki drags out his phone to try and find more information. There'd been some kind of incident in an office district of Musutafu that leveled quite a few buildings but the official story behind the event hasn't been released yet, nor has All Might's involvement been confirmed. Theories about All Might's retirement raged through his death being covered up, a debilitating injury, even leaving heroism to raise a suddenly found love child. It all seems like utter bunk but the announcement had come directly from the HPSC, they wouldn't do so without good reason, right?

"End of an era," Kaminari says, collapsing onto the couch. He sounds as in shock as Katsuki feels. Like the world is crumbling around him, too.

"Do you think they'll tell us what happened?" Sero asks, glancing around at his fellow classmates but no one's got an answer for him.

"I mean, he's a teacher here, right?" Ashido's hand lifts to her mouth, but doesn't quite cover it. "They'll tell us *something*, right?"

As Katsuki stares at the TV and listens to his classmates, he's never felt more out of the loop. Everything going on with Deku seemed like another world overlapping his own temporarily and the idea of All Might retiring without warning or explanation is like some kind of spill over that shouldn't have happened. He can't help thinking Deku has to be involved somehow and then he's angry all over again at that bastard taking up even more of mental real estate at a time like this.

Katsuki moodily leaves the common room to lock himself in his dorm for the rest of the day. He whiles the hours away trying not to think about it by getting ahead on his homework and working out, but his mind never quite manages to settle.

Later in the evening, his phone sounds off with the ring tone he'd given to his parents. There's no way in hell Katsuki wants to talk to them but it'll be worse if he ignores the call. He grabs his phone and then snarls into it, "*What?!*"

“Katsuki,” Dad says, quiet and solemn and Katsuki’s rage drains in a second the way it always does when his father gets this way. “I won’t ask how you’re doing.”

“Pretty fucking *terribly*.”

“Yes, I’d expect so.” Dad sighs a little and Katsuki can just imagine him rubbing at his sore eyes. “Listen, something’s come up. Your help has been requested in a hero mission.”

Katsuki sits up taller. “What? Why didn’t they come ask me?”

“There’s significant risk and you’re still a minor. They needed permission from Mitsuki and I before they could ask you.”

What? Shouldn’t the school’s limited guardianship cover that kind of shit? “The hell kind of mission is this?”

“There’s someone trapped in a mental quirk that they think you can help with,” Dad says, like that tells him fuck all. “Your teacher is the one that called to ask. Aizawa?”

So Aizawa’s alive. Something unclenches inside Katsuki that he didn’t even realize he’d been feeling in the first place. Alive and caught up in something that involved a mental quirk. Wait,is this what was up with All Might? Was the retirement announcement somehow trying to throw villains off the scent? Had All Might been taken down and trapped where his strength can’t help him?

“What do they want me to do?” he asks because there’s no universe where Katsuki doesn’t get involved here.

“I don’t know. He said they were moving the victim to a medical facility and that you’d be getting a call once they’ve arrived. I gave my permission but this is your decision, son. If you want to help.”

“Like fuck am I not helping. I’m a hero in training, remember?”

“Katsuki, this is serious. I don’t know if they’ll be able to give you full informed consent with how little he could tell me, but if you feel like you’re in danger at any point I want you to back down. Say no, get out of there, and then come to me. I’ll handle whatever the fallout is.”

He’s never heard his father talk like this before. Usually, Dad is so go with the flow that it’s annoying, but there’s a steel under his voice now that almost makes him sound like Katsuki.

“Promise me,” Dad stresses and Katsuki curses under his breath.

“Fine. Whatever. Now get off the fucking phone so I’m here when he calls.”

“Let me know when you get called in. Let me know what you can about what this is about. Let me know when it’s over.”

Katsuki's fingers clench tight on the phone. "Fuck off, old man. Like I want you in my affairs that much."

He hangs up without saying goodbye because it seems like a bad omen to. Barely five minutes later, Aizawa texts him a warning that Present Mic will be picking him up from the dorm to take him to the hospital to meet up with Recovery Girl. No request, no wishy-washy "if you want to", because Aizawa knows he's coming already. Bakugou changes into fresh clothes and grabs a jacket before storming out of the dorm to meet up with Present Mic and follow him out of the school.

Like fuck Katsuki's going to pass up the opportunity to be the hero he's always been meant to be.

It seems almost a given that the fucking hero decided to collapse again soon after his dream adventure. Then Recovery Girl yells at them all and Kiddo continues to be a fucking comatose potato and Dabi thinks he's well within his rights to murder all of them at this point but he doesn't because he has self control. Some, at least.

At least Eraserhead is only unconscious for about an hour but it's still an hour Dabi spends getting yelled at by Recovery Girl about proper medical care and not overstressing "stupid men who think they're invincible and if you *dare* grow up to be anything like him, I will murder you *myself*."

Like fuck is Dabi growing up to be like Eraserhead. Wait- *just how young does she think he is?!*

In any case, Dabi decides after that hour that if the medic is afraid for someone's safety, someone Dabi is not allowed to let die, maybe he should be worried too. There's no lost love between him and Eraserhead but Dabi *does* care about Kiddo and *Kiddo* loves the asshole. He hadn't been sure of it before when Kiddo first declared the no-go list, but Dabi's figured it out over the last year. The people on that list are the ones Kiddo respects and adores more than anything.

The dream specialist Giran dragged their way doesn't know how long it could take once they have someone in Kiddo's mind trying to wake him up. In the meantime, Kiddo's going to need supportive care to keep his body going. Care their HQ is not equipped to give. Dabi makes the decision that needs to be made and though the rest of the crew give him almost betrayed looks, he can see they understand.

Goddamn it, when this is over, Kiddo better not fucking leave them again because he *hates* having to be the leader *so much*.

Dabi forbids the others from coming. If any of them are going to get caught, it'll only be him. Someone needs to break him out later, right? They help get Eraserhead outside with him and away from HQ before calling an ambulance and scramming. The moment Recovery Girl identifies the "victim" as Eraserhead, he knows there will be a hero on scene. Maybe she didn't say it out right but Dabi knows heroes have code words and she's sure to have used

one. He keeps Kiddo held in his lap while they wait, one hand wrapped around his throat in obvious warning.

He doesn't think he'd kill Kiddo to prove a point but he's been really fucking stressed out these last few weeks.

The hero that arrives with the ambulance is familiar even if Dabi can't remember his name. He thinks *blood quirk* and then just sits quietly while the hero glares at him and the paramedics pack Eraserhead up. The fuck does Dabi care what that hero thinks of him.

Recover Girl does all the talking except for when Dabi casually reminds her that no, he and Kiddo will be riding in the same ambulance as Eraserhead and no, that's not negotiable. Kiddo isn't his only hostage despite what it looks like.

When a paramedic tries to come look at Kiddo, Dabi *growls*. She backs off quickly. He sees the hero have a quiet word with Recovery Girl but can't hear it. He doesn't care what they say as long as they do what he's ordered. Fire flickers in his free hand here and there, just to remind them what's at stake. Then they're finally on the move. Eraserhead needs a real hospital, not one of the hole in the wall clinics Dabi's always had to visit, and though he's loath to go Kiddo probably needs it too. They don't know how long this stupid fucking quirk is going to last.

The trip is quiet except for the paramedics muttering over Eraserhead's body. Dabi doesn't let go of Kiddo along the way, nor when they get to the hospital. The moment they arrive, there's a whole squad of cops waiting. Dabi holds Kiddo against his chest like a shield and glares as menacingly as he can while Recovery Girl takes over to direct things. He doesn't pay much attention to what she's saying, just follows her as the hospital staff rush Eraserhead away to be treated.

Dabi ends up in a hospital room with Kiddo and three cops, watching as Kiddo's hooked up to machines and IVs. He's not in cuffs but he's also threatened anyone that might get near enough to restrain him. The cops are smart enough not to push him, for now. Or maybe it's that Recovery Girl is adamant enough he not be fucked with that they're willing to listen. Who cares, the end result is that Dabi is here in Kiddo's room right where he wanted to be and he's not fucking leaving.

The cops leave him alone. They mutter to each other, glance his way, stare at Kiddo, but they leave him alone. Dabi's leaning up against the wall on the other side of Kiddo's bed, keeping the kid between him and them, but he doubts that's the real reason they're not fucking with him.

Recovery Girl leaves for a while and Dabi spends it glaring at the cops and making fire dance in his palms just to see them sweat. When she comes back, he closes his hands over it and straightens.

"Eraser?" he asks because where the fuck else would she have been.

"Undergoing surgery," she replies and then gives Kiddo a more measured look. "We're calling in Bakugou. He should be here within the next hour or two."

Shouty little brat, yeah. If anyone's going to drag Kiddo out of this dream world, the kid he's in love with is probably a good bet. Dabi's got no idea *why* Kiddo's so into him but that's not really his problem most of the time.

Dabi steps closer to the bed and glares down at his leader. He actually looks like a kid here, laying in a bed meant for an adult and overwhelmed by all the machines meant to keep his ass alive. There's both a peace to his face and a devastating sort of finality and Dabi looks away before his thoughts can go down that path.

When Haru arrives, Recovery Girl has to go sort out her presence and run interference with the cops, who do *not* want another underworld operative involved. Dabi's just glad he's not the one having to make it all work. He looks up when Haru arrives, watches the cops get creeped out like fucking chumps. At least there's *something* entertaining around here. Haru makes herself even more hilariously offputting by taking out *knitting* to work on while they wait for the last piece of this demented little puzzle.

Leaning back against the wall again, Dabi settles in and waits.

Chapter 32

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Recovery Girl meets them in the front lobby. She's looking even more grim than she had while keeping him out of Deku's room before but Katsuki has a feeling this is probably worse.

"Shou-?" Present Mic asks immediately, then corrects himself, "Eraserhead?"

It's enough to get Katsuki side eyeing him but he guesses the teachers know each other well enough to be on a first name basis? Weird, considering their personal lives. Teachers aren't supposed to have those.

"In surgery," Recovery Girl says, which has both Katsuki and Present Mic stiffening. "He'll be fine, it's the other one I'm more worried about."

Well. That's not fucking ominous in the least. She sends Present Mic off with vague instructions on where he can meet up with Aizawa, then turns and waves Katsuki to follow her.

"The patient is stable and will remain so, regardless of your assistance," she continues as they walk through the halls and onto an elevator. "He's stuck in a 'perfect dream' quirk that's apparently giving him all that he wants. We're hoping you'll be able to shock him out of it and convince him to wake up."

"Why me?"

"You're the one he seems to care about most in the world."

Who the fuck would care about him like that other than his parents? He's about to ask who it is when the elevator doors open and he spots a whole group of cops standing outside one of the hospital room doors. Somehow, it doesn't surprise him that Recovery Girl heads right that way. One of the cops spots them, looking more uneasy, and Katsuki recognises him. Is this guy just on every fucking job or something?

"There's been no change," Tsukauchi says, glancing towards the closed door. "The… dream specialist and the other villain are still inside."

"Thank you. I'll take it from here," Recovery Girl says and leads Katsuki into the hospital room. The moment he sees who's on the bed, Katsuki freezes. What the fuck. No fucking way, hadn't he already made it clear to goddamn Deku that they weren't a thing, that Katsuki had no feelings for him? Why would he still be so hung up on him that only *Katsuki* can save him from this mess?

And *then*, he sees the villain and… the creepiest horror movie chick he's ever seen. He stares at her longer than the scarred up guy. When she smiles, he almost blasts her on instinct. The *fuck* kind of quirk is that?

"You'll want to lay down," she says, gesturing to the second bed alongside Deku's, and even her voice is straight out of a gore flick. Katsuki, thankfully, is made of pretty fucking stern stuff, so he doesn't let her know just how creeped out he is by her.

"Haru's quirk will allow you to share the dream with Midoriya," Recovery Girl says entirely too calmly as she stands next to the empty bed. "Once inside, you'll need to make contact with him and try to convince him that he's in a dream and to wake up. I'll be monitoring your vitals from here."

Katsuki finally manages to look away from Horror Show and gamely climbs onto the empty bed. He'd already agreed to this shit before finding out who it's for, he isn't going to chicken out now. Without meaning to, his eyes trail back to Horror Show but he forces himself to stare at the other villain instead. Stitches doesn't even seem glad he's there, barely looking away from Deku's sleeping face.

"We should begin quickly. The longer he's in there, the more acclimated he'll become," Horror Show says, moving towards the beds as Katsuki lays down.

"Go ahead," Recovery Girl says.

Horror Show takes one of Deku's hands and then reaches for Katsuki's. He barely keeps from jerking it away, gritting his teeth. When she moves to put Deku's hand into his, that's when he growls out, "The fuck do I have to touch him for?"

She blinks way too slowly. "How else do you expect to share his dream?"

He almost yells at her but instead he grabs Deku's stupid fucking hand and tries not to feel like a little kid again. They put a small table between them so their hands can just rest on it and not risk breaking the connection. Then Katsuki's gritting his teeth again as her skeletal fingers reach for his *face*.

"Don't let yourself forget this is a dream," she says, palm resting on his forehead, "or you might get stuck, too."

And then he's not in the hospital anymore. He's not sure where the hell he is. An office of some kind, filled with heroes? Katsuki blinks as he looks around and finally catches sight of a familiar symbol on one of the walls. He's at Best Jeanist's agency. Why the hell would Deku be dreaming of that?

"Oh, Dynamight! There you are," someone calls out and it takes Katsuki a moment to figure out they mean him. Then he's pushed and crowded into a meeting room with several other heroes who seem to think he belongs there. Okay, weird. Also *why is he so tall?* Katsuki's used to looking up to these people and now he's at eye level with most of them. It's a good change, just a really *weird* one, and his mind keeps trying to just shrug it off but Katsuki doesn't let himself do that.

This is a dream, he reminds himself. *Dreams are weird, but remember that it's not right.*

They're going over some kind of mission. None of the details matter much to him but tags a few things in the back of his mind, the things that pertain to his role. It seems like he's working as a sidekick under Best Jeanist or he's an independent pro here for the mission, it's unclear. Fucking *Best Jeanist* isn't exactly who he'd choose as a mentor after that disastrous internship but fine. He'll play this game. Surely, it's going to bring him to Deku eventually and then he'll drag that fucking nerd out by his hair if he has to.

They finally get moving and just as Katsuki's about to call it a wash with no Deku in sight at the mission site, a hero in a green jumpsuit runs to him from the other end of the parking lot they're using to stage, crying out, "Kacchan!"

There's literally only one person who has *ever* called him that but the hero is too big to be Deku. He's fucking *stacked*, not nearly as muscular as someone like All Might but even through what has to be pretty thick kevlar, Katsuki can see muscle rippling over his body. He's taller, too, and then Deku drags down his hood and mask and something clicks. That's an adult in front of him. Mid-twenties, messy curls cut in a more mature and managed style, eyes no longer taking up most of the real estate of his face. Why the fuck is Deku this old in the dream?

"I'm so glad we get to work together!" the nerd gushes out as he smiles like he's bursting with sunshine and Katsuki… Katsuki doesn't know what to do with this because Deku doesn't look at him like this. Deku always had a level of melancholy and worry the last few times Katsuki saw him, like he's looking at ghosts all around him or waiting for them all to turn *into* ghosts. This guileless brightness is just *alien*.

"Uh, yeah," Katsuki's mouth says while his mind still tries to get over how fucking weird Deku looks.

Then the mission starts and even if it's a dream, Katsuki still gives his all in this raid. Fighting has always been so much more comfortable for him than anything else. He blasts and punches and fights to his heart's content as the other heroes do the same. As *Deku* does the same using some kind of power enhancement quirk that keeps reminding Katsuki of All Might every time he sees it. A spark of green lightning runs along Deku's body as he races through a crowd of enemies, effortlessly slinging them into walls or other heroes' attacks.

It pisses Katsuki off that Deku's pretending to be a fucking hero here in his head but he guesses it's the only place it could happen. No wonder the moron let himself get stuck here. And at least when Deku's like this, he can finally actually keep up.

A villain pops up in Deku's blind spot but goes down fast as Katsuki hammers him into the floor with an explosive fist. The grin Deku shoots him is less grateful and more cheeky, but soon enough he's making his own save and it keeps on like that. Turns out, he and Katsuki work well together. He finds it easy to guess what Deku's going to do and of course Deku knows him too well to get caught up in anything Katsuki decides. It's almost like they're the only heroes around with how efficiently they take mooks down.

When the last of the villains are in custody, Best Jeanist and a few of the other, older heroes congratulate him on his efforts and wish him luck in the next ranking. Then Deku's grabbing his hand and dragging him off.

"Oi, what the hell?!" he yells out but Deku doesn't let go.

"Patrol!" is the only explanation, which is stupid. After a big operation like that, he'd expect the rest of the day off but he's not tired and his body is still thrumming with the thrill of battle, so fine. They'll go on patrol.

Every time Katsuki tries to talk to Deku about the world they're in, about how it's not real, some villain or criminal pops up and they have to take them down. It's like clockwork and Katsuki's sure it's the quirk trying to sustain itself, but there's no way he can stop Deku from responding to a cry for help and Katsuki certainly can't leave things alone either, even if it's not real. The quick bursts of violence make his blood sing and Katsuki lets himself enjoy this glimpse of what his future holds once he's graduated. It's not even bad hanging out with Deku like this, especially when they finish another fight and then Katsuki finds himself dragged into an alley with Deku's tongue down his throat.

It feels like a natural progression, going from fighting to making out and Katsuki groans as he pushes Deku up against the brick wall. Deku's hands slid over his chest, just firm enough and not at all shy, like they've done this countless times and he knows just how to touch him. The adrenaline from the fight seems just as happy to get excited over the taste of Deku's mouth and the firm grip of Deku's hand on his hip sliding back to grab his ass. His breath catches as Deku's knee fits between his legs and Deku's dragging him in hard to chase that feeling that lights up every inch of Katsuki's body. *Fuck*, it feels so real-

Katsuki blinks back to awareness and shoves himself back from Deku. He opens his mouth to try to do what he came here for and like before, another cry for help that has Deku moving immediately. With a curse, Katsuki runs after him and they end up facing a huge villain with *way* too much stamina and an annoying shock absorption quirk.

The battle takes everything Katsuki has and Deku looks just as tired by the time they're handing the guy over to the police. As the two of them pant and recover, Deku glances Katsuki's way with a little grin and says, "Hungry?"

"Starving," because Katsuki could probably eat a whole cow suddenly. And then they're in a restaurant and it's the best meal he's ever had that he didn't cook himself. They spend the meal talking about the fights, poking fun at each other's mistakes, joking about other heroes, and it's *fun*. It's fun being with Deku like this, watching laughter get surprised out of him from something Katsuki's said, and he feels lighter than he has for a long time.

They end up at an apartment next and Katsuki knows it's his with a single glance at the kitchen, but he doesn't really care because Deku's mouth is hungry against his own and there's no way Katsuki is going to let him keep leading the way. He takes charge and the rest is a lot less distinct in his memory almost immediately. It's all bodies and naked skin, need and vague notions of what's going on. Like listening to something from another room and knowing what it is but not exactly.

He wakes and makes breakfast, laughs at Deku's bed head when the nerd follows him out, and then they get ready for another day. Patrolling the city Katsuki throws himself wholeheartedly into. There's cutpurses and purse snatchers, muggings and attempted kidnappings, larger villain attacks that take out whole city blocks. And all the while, Deku's right at his side and pushing him forward to be better, faster, stronger.

The next hero ranking comes out and Katsuki's number two with Deku just behind him at number three. They're so close, Katsuki can almost taste his victory and throws himself into work like a madman. He'll take that number one spot from All Might if it's the last thing he does!

There's more patrols, more raids, more everything Katsuki's been working for and he's never felt so alive. When they're not on the job, he's cooking meals and hanging out with Deku or other friends and not caring about anything else. His parents are so proud anytime a reporter gets them on the news and former teachers congratulate the work he's done. It's wonderful, it's perfect, Katsuki can't think of a single thing he doesn't have that he's ever wanted.

Katsuki bashes some low level mook into a telephone pole to take him out of the fight and somewhere nearby, he hears the distinctive *smash* of one of Deku's attacks. He rounds the corner quickly to watch Deku's take down because those are almost as satisfying as making his own. But there's an extra villain Katsuki spots and he's blasting himself into position for a strike before he can even think. Deku's smile after they hand the villains over is a million watts.

"I never want to partner with anyone else," he says as Katsuki sips from a water bottle.

"Not like I blame you, considering how awesome I am."

Deku laughs and bumps his shoulder into Katsuki's, staring up at the suddenly star filled sky. "I mean, make it an official hero duo."

And that's different, that's a lot more final than just teaming up because they're from the same agency- or just patrol the same area? Anyway.

"The hell would I want that with *you?*" Katsuki grumbles but it's a token denial because the next thing he knows, they've filed for official duo status and the news is going nuts with it and Katsuki cares a lot less about that than the celebratory makeout session he gets with Deku on some random rooftop.

Life is pretty good. Katsuki gets to fight countless villains whenever he pleases, either on normal patrols or otherwise, and Deku backs him up. They talk about opening their own agency just like they'd dreamed of when they were little and Katsuki declares that the moment he hits number one, they'll do it. They'll open the Dynamight Agency and Deku demands to be the first hero signed up under Katsuki's name.

Then right before the next ranking can be announced, All Might comes to them looking larger than life. He takes up all the light around him like some kind of other worldly presence of greatness and the weight of his hand that comes to rest on Katsuki's shoulder is like a world in itself.

“It’s time,” All Might says with his usual grin. “I’ve served for as long as I’m able and you’re finally ready to take up my mantle.”

Katsuki is declared number one as All Might retires and it’s everything he’s ever wanted. The fame, the accolades, the sheer satisfaction as he’s declared the Symbol of Victory and a force villains could never topple.

He starts the Dynamight Agency with Deku and most of his extras from school join up under his banner. It’s almost like being a teenager again but Katsuki runs his team to the ground to root out crime in the city and even on world wide missions. There’s no way anyone could say he doesn’t deserve his number one spot considering all the good he’s doing for the world.

After successfully taking out a crime syndicate, Katsuki walks beside Deku as they head for a quieter street and towards a daycare. And of course they’ve done this before, had to have, because there’s a little girl waiting on the steps that screams out, “*Daddy!”* the moment she sees them and Deku’s kneeling down to catch her as she throws herself into his arms with a gentle, “Kazuko!”

Of course, it’s Deku’s daughter, she’s been with them this whole time and even has a room in Katsuki’s apartment which is really both his and Deku’s. Deku straightens up with her in his arms as he asks about her day and Katsuki walks beside them with his hands in his pockets, content with listening to the babble, except something starts to nag at his mind. He glances towards the two of them and can’t figure out why it’s important that he doesn’t know where Kazuko’s mother is.

Then he looks away and can’t quite remember what Kazuko looks like. Even when he turns back to stare at her, he still can’t. Not what color her hair is, her eyes, not even her facial features. Nothing quite *sticks*. He knows she’s a cute little girl and there’s nothing outwardly notable, but-

Katsuki stops walking as his eyes widen. His breathing catches and everything crashes down all at once inside him. It’s a dream. He forgot it’s all a fucking *dream* and no wonder he can’t see the girl right, he can’t even imagine Deku having kids and-

“Kacchan?” Deku asks, a hand on his arm and the girl is gone because she’s not important for this scenario anymore, the way dreams shift and flow at random for whatever a dreamer’s mind is centering on in that moment.

“This isn’t real,” Katsuki says and fuck if any random villain shows up or some civilian yells for help, he’s getting this out *now*. “You’re stuck in a dream.”

Deku stares at him and his fingers tighten on Katsuki’s arm. “I know.”

What?!

“The fuck do you mean you know?!” Katsuki snarls out, tearing himself out of Deku’s grip. “If you know it’s a dream, then wake the hell up already!”

“Why?”

The word hangs there, heavy and quiet as Deku's eyes pierce into him like daggers. It catches Katsuki off guard because he hadn't expected to be questioned like this. He'd expected to fight about the *reality* of this situation, not the leaving once Deku understood. But Deku *does* understand. He knows.

"When the fuck did you start running away?" Katsuki asks and Deku jerks like he's been struck.

"I'm not- I didn't-"

"What do you call this then? Playing around in your little fantasy world when there's real people in the real world out there?"

Deku's breathing grows ragged. "You don't understand."

"Oh, I fucking understand. You're a loser in the real world, might as well make yourself *entirely* fucking useless by becoming a vegetable to play around here."

"You don't understand. I just- I'm *tired*." And he looks it, suddenly. Like he hasn't slept in years, like the weight of the world is crashing down on his shoulders. "I'm so tired, Kacchan, I just wanted- I just needed…"

"What, to pretend at having a quirk and being a hero?" Katsuki's lip curls in disgust. "All that shit you've been up to in the real world and you couldn't think of a way a quirkless nerd like you could be a hero?"

"That won't *save you!*" Deku screams out with all the air in him all at once. He pants for breath, hands curling tight in his hair as he crumbles before Katsuki's eyes. "You die *faster* when I'm a hero!"

"The fuck are you talking about?"

Deku lets out a laugh that hurts to listen to and takes a step back, swaying in place. "I've watched you die so many times, Kacchan. I just- I wanted to watch you *thrive*."

Bits and pieces from their previous conversations and things he's overheard from the adult heroes start settling into place. Katsuki doesn't have the whole picture but what little he's got…

"If I'm dying over and over, what's happening to *you?*" he asks even though he's not sure he wants to know the answer.

"What does that matter? I just have to find the right pattern," Deku says, fingers tightening in his hair. "I just have to figure out the right pattern of actions, who to kill and when, what to prevent, what to facilitate-"

"Deku-" That's sounding fucking *insane*.

"But for a little while, I just wanted to see you get everything you want," and Deku's voice gets so quiet Katsuki can barely hear him. "I just wanted to be with you."

Just what is he supposed to do with that?

“Deku, what the fuck is happening *to you?*” And he grabs Deku’s shoulders, forces him to straighten up and look at him again. “If I’m dying over and over, what are you-”

“I just repeat it,” Deku says, his gaze far away like he can’t even see Katsuki there. “I just repeat two years over and over and I’ll find the right pattern, Kacchan. I’ll find it and I’ll save you, I swear I will-”

It clicks and the ugly reality rolls over Katsuki as he suddenly understands. It sounds insane, like something out of a shitty tv show, but he’s absolutely sure that it’s real and this useless *nerd* is just…

“How long?” he asks, interrupting Deku’s fervent promises. “It’s- what, a time loop? For how long?”

“I don’t know- It doesn’t matter how long, it doesn’t matter. Nothing matters until I get it *right*-”

“Have you ever *told me* before?”

Deku goes silent. His gaze refocuses on Katsuki’s face, actually seeing him again. And really? This fucking moron hasn’t ever thought maybe he should let Katsuki in on this whole time loop thing before?

“Fucking seriously?”

“I didn’t think you’d believe me. And I can’t- if you didn’t…”

Which, okay. Valid. Without all the fucking lead up and this mess in the dream world that Katsuki is going to have to do a ridiculous amount of thinking about later, he probably wouldn’t have. He’s not sure he even wants to *now*.

Katsuki huffs out a breath. This is too fucking much but at least one thing is clear. They need to get the hell out of this dream world if only so Deku can be someone else’s problem for a little while.

“I think you’ve dreamed enough,” he says and Deku swallows but nods. “You gonna wake the fuck up or will I have to come back here and drag your ass out kicking and screaming?”

“I’ll wake up,” Deku says, quiet and defeated. “I’ll give this up.”

Fuck and now Katsuki feels like he’s taking something precious away from him and that’s not what this is about, it’s *not*, and fuck this goddamn nerd for making him feel this way! There’s something raw and painful inside Katsuki that he’s not ready to think about right now, not until he can be alone with his thoughts.

There’s no production number when Katsuki gets out. He just blinks and then he’s looking at Horror Show’s hand and it feels like it’s been weeks but he’s sure it hasn’t. She pulls back her hand and Katsuki pushes himself up immediately.

The cops have changed out and Recovery Girl is gone, but Stitches is still there and he straightens up to pin a hard look on Katsuki.

“Is he-”

“Yeah, he said he’d wake up,” Katsuki says and his mouth feels like it’s full of sand. Horror Show gives him a cup of water that he practically inhales half of in one go. On the other bed, Deku opens his eyes and stares up at the ceiling.

“Kiddo,” Stitches says, getting up from his chair to loom over the bed. When Deku looks at him, Stitches’s shoulders sag with something like relief.

“Sorry I’m late,” Deku says with a voice that sounds ragged and torn up. Stitches helps him sit up and Katsuki shoves the cup into Deku’s hands so he can drink the rest of the water, but that just gives Deku something to look at that isn’t any of the rest of them. One of the cops leaves to alert the ones outside that they’re awake, maybe to track Recovery Girl down to tell her too.

“How long?” Katsuki asks.

“Two days,” one of the cops says and before that can settle, the door opens. Tsukauchi nods to the other officers first before eyeing Stitches and Horror Show. Behind him is Aizawa being pushed in a wheelchair by a nurse who does *not* look happy to be carting his ass around.

“Good job,” is the first thing Aizawa says, seeing both Katsuki and Deku awake. “Now’s the hard part.”

“You’ll need to stay for questioning, Bakugou,” Tsukauchi says but his gaze is on Deku and Stitches. “I’m afraid I’ll be taking the two of you into custody.”

Neither look surprised by that. Near the door, Horror Show awkwardly shifts from one foot to the other and then asks, “Am I free to go? I’ve definitely not done anything wrong during this and had medical permission from a hero to use my quirk.”

Tsukauchi’s mouth twitches before he signals one of the other cops. “You can go once you’ve given him your statement.”

That seems to be fine with Horror Show as she steps outside with the cop. Tsukauchi signals another cop and then turns to Katsuki. “Are you able to walk? I’d prefer your questioning be done away from Midoriya.”

Of course he can. He’s only been sleeping for two days, not two weeks! Katsuki rolls his eyes and swings his legs off the bed, standing without trouble. He feels a little weak, sure, but he’s not a fucking invalid. As Katsuki marches out of the room with the cop, he can’t help but glance back to find Deku watching him leave. It doesn’t *stop* him, but Katsuki thinks to himself that maybe he kind of hates the broken thing he’s leaving behind.

The door closes and Katsuki follows the cop out to another hallway to give his overview of what happened in the dream world. There are maybe a few things he doesn't mention but he's honest about most of it. The cop writes everything down and then his parents are crashing onto the scene. Mom berates him for worrying them and Dad just says he's glad he's okay and then they both lead him out of the hospital.

The moment he can, Katsuki locks himself in his room and sits down on his bed. Memories of the dream world are already starting to fade the way most dreams do and he's not sure he would want to keep it. The way things were there, the easy way he fell into Deku's company, he doesn't know what to think of that.

Did he want Deku there because Deku wanted him or just because he already wanted Deku?

How much of what he'd experienced had been because the dream was tailored for Deku's needs, guiding Katsuki's thoughts and actions?

What does he actually *want* from Deku?

Thumping back flat onto the bed, Katsuki covers his eyes with his hands and cusses Deku out for putting him in this fucking position.

Chapter End Notes

Really hoping the dream transitions came across okay lol

Chapter 33

This isn't a conversation Naomasa wants to have. He's a little tired of just how much of his time is getting spent worrying about one kid who keeps trying to prove he can't be saved. Midoriya Izuku won't be swayed from his self appointed mission and he'll tear the world apart to finish it. That, Naomasa is sure of.

"I'm not leaving his side," Dabi says, leaning against the wall near the head of Midoriya's bed. His eyes are so very cold as they meet Naomasa's. "And I'll kill you if you try to make me."

A battle Naomasa can't afford to fight right this second, but there's no way Dabi is leaving without quirk suppression cuffs and a cell picked out in Tartarus.

He turns to Midoriya and tries not to take any meaning out of Eraserhead settling himself on the kid's other side with a similar determination as Dabi. When Midoriya meets his gaze, his own is deadened. Exhausted or heartsore, Naomasa isn't sure.

"Let's start with the night you were taken from UA," Naomasa says as Sansa gets ready to take notes on Midoriya's testimony. "How did you get out of the ankle monitor?"

"Hacker on the outside," Midoriya answers freely and without hesitation. "She disabled it the day it went online and kept feeding it false information so I could leave when I wanted."

Eraserhead's mouth twitches and settles into a grimace. Dabi smirks.

"I don't guess you'd give me a name?" No answer, not that Naomasa was expecting one. "Fine. After being confronted by the instructors, you were abducted by All For One. Was that part of your plans?"

Midoriya looks at his hands, still clutching an empty water cup. "No."

"So you didn't expect to be taken. You've been trying to get All For One's attention, correct?"

"Yes." Simple, quiet, and the lack of elaboration feels poignant.

"Why?"

The pause that follows his question is expected, but Naomasa waits it out. This is too important to let Midoriya get away with ignoring.

"...I need him distracted," he says finally, staring at the cup more like he's in a daze rather than actually focused. "It's less dangerous for everyone else if he's trying to head me off. As long as I'm annoying enough, he'll take longer to go up against All Might."

Truth. Every word and not even in the half honest way Midoriya often skirts the truth. There's a sincerity in his tone that's only a little underscored by how exhausted he is. Too tired to manipulate and hide? Naomasa lets that roll around his mind a moment, before continuing.

"You were found already stuck in the dream quirk. What happened between being abducted and that?"

"We talked about nothing important. He acted like a fucking creep. The usual."

Naomasa's eyes narrow as he catches a partial lie. Not quite the truth. "What else?"

Midoriya barely lifts his head, just enough to be able to look at him through his dark curls. Naomasa doesn't let himself back down.

"He has a quirk that lets him look at people's memories. I don't know if it's all memories or has to be directed towards specific things, but it seemed like he was able to seek out exactly what he wanted," Midoriya says and the truth is horrifying even before he adds, "He looked at one of mine."

"What was it?"

"The day the loops started."

There's a sudden sharp edge to the attention on Midoriya from nearly everyone in the room. It's been something they all wondered about. The only clue was something they hadn't been able to confirm the veracity of from Midoriya's first known run in with All For One.

"Tell us about that day."

Midoriya looks at the cup again. His fingers tighten on it as the seconds pass and Naomasa thinks he might refuse to answer when he finally draws in a deeper breath.

"I was dying in the hospital," he starts without looking back up. Like his hands held the script he needed to read to them. "Cancer. It was terminal. There wasn't anything else we could try. I was just waiting."

"How old were you?" Eraserhead asks.

"Sixty-four."

The longest I've made it is to my sixty-fourth birthday once.

That means it was his first life, before the loops even started. It makes a sad sort of sense. Why bother living that long when you'd already failed your one mission? Naomasa gathers his strength and pushes on. "What happened that day?"

Midoriya sighs, closing his eyes. "Kazuko visited. My daughter. She… used her quirk. Said she wanted me to be able to clear my regrets."

The name Hawks had given them. So she *is* real and not some kind of dead end taunt just to aggravate All For One. Then did that mean… "Did she have a temporal quirk?"

They're some of the rarest and so highly regimented that they seem more a curse than anything else in his opinion.

"Yes. Ouroboros. She's able to create a time jump back a little while or a loop to give other heroes the ability to walk back specific mistakes. Usually fifteen to twenty minutes worth. Before this started, we thought her hard limit was about a day and even that long was a strain."

Except Midoriya had been sent back *fifty years*. That's a significant jump in power scaling and makes Naomasa wonder if someone else had been involved to give Kazuko the boost she needed to start this loop. He wonders if she even *survived* pushing her quirk that hard.

"You're quirkless," Eraserhead says, breaking the shocked quiet. "Then her mother-"

"Oh. She isn't- I adopted her. She was… eleven? Twelve? It's hard to remember after so long. I always wished I found her sooner. But I was retiring about then anyway and… Well. She needed someone and… I probably did, too." Midoriya finally sets the empty cup aside and instead rakes a hand back through his hair, eyes flickering to stare at nothing as he tries to remember clearly. "Her parents both had temporal quirks, but they were pretty weak. It was… I guess you could call it a quirk marriage situation except it was government mandated. Same for their parents."

Oh *hell*. He shoots Eraserhead a look and sees the same grim understanding that he feels himself. That's getting into something that may be *way* over their heads because there's only one organization springing to mind. If the HPSC are involved, he's going to have to tread more carefully than ever. It sounds like a *breeding program* somehow skirting around human rights violations regarding willful manipulation of quirk genetics by government entities.

"If it starts at least three generations back, wouldn't those people be alive now?" Dabi asks and Naomasa twitches, having nearly forgotten the villain is still there. He looks almost thoughtful. How much has Midoriya even shared with his crew before now?

Midoriya shrugs. "Yeah. Her grandparents are in HPSC custody now. I already figured out that killing them won't stop the loops."

"So paradox doesn't come into play at all," Eraserhead mutters while Naomasa tries not to feel blindsided by Midoriya's nonchalant murder mentions. It happens often enough, he really should be over it by now.

"No. I figure the way her quirk works creates a separate temporary timeline until the loop objective is completed that then either condenses into the main timeline or replaces it, unless every loop creates its own parallel universe that continues on after failure." Horrifying either way. Naomasa's head hurts just trying to work through it. He's never been into fantastical science fiction and wants even less to do with it now that he has a real life example.

"What did you mean by 'clear your regrets'?" he asks, trying to get back to the original topic.

Midoriya sighs. “I was… She… She knew I regretted not saving Kacchan for my entire life. It’s part of how I know he’s the catch point of the loops. I’ve already eliminated any other options.”

I just want them all to live this time.

Maybe he didn’t have to save everyone he cared about, but Naomasa is pretty sure Midoriya always tried anyway every time.

“So she used her quirk and began the loop. What happened next?” he asks.

“I woke up in my bedroom at fourteen years old.” The words are quiet, almost *broken*, and Midoriya doesn’t look at any of them. “The memory stopped then. I don’t think he cared about anything after that.”

“What happened after the memory ended?”

“He put me in the dream to keep me out of the way. And then I woke up here.” That, finally, seems to bring a little bit of life back to him as he turns to Dabi. “How did you get me out?”

“The heroes distracted All For One. We just walked out with you.”

Midoriya nods and then looks at his hands again. He sighs and his shoulders sag. “So who’s dead? It’s too early. Someone won’t have made it.”

The question doesn’t surprise Naomasa but it does tighten up the bit of his heart that’s been on edge since being informed of All Might’s injuries. They still don’t know if All Might will regain consciousness or even survive the next week. It seems almost cruel to tell him now, but Naomasa knows he’ll find out sooner or later.

“All Might is in intensive care and it’s uncertain if he’ll make it,” he says with as much strength in his voice as he can manage. Midoriya’s head slumps further forward, hands curling into fists as his shoulders begin to shake.

“That stupid son of a bitch,” the kid murmurs just above a whisper. “I told you. *I told you*. He can’t-”

Dabi reaches out to grab his shoulder, but it doesn’t comfort him in the least.

“Why does it always- I’ve seen it so many times, why am I always-” His voice breaks as the first tears hit his hands and then he covers his face and sobs. “*He never listens.*”

“All Might was assisted by Endeavor and Hawks,” Naomasa explains as the boy cries. “As you suggested. *He listened.* It was just barely enough to keep All For One occupied until he self-destructed. His death was confirmed.”

That doesn’t make All Might’s loss worth it, but it’s at least something-

Midoriya lets out a wet little giggle. He lifts his head, his face wet and red but eyes blazing with rage as he spits out, “He’ll be back in April at the latest.”

The whole room goes entirely stiff with shock because how-

“He’d only blow that body up if he’d already transferred enough of himself into Shigaraki’s nomu to take over,” and then Midoriya’s laughing, harsh and painful and oh so bitter, like a part of himself is being torn out of his body with every shaking sound. “All Might died for *nothing*.”

The only sound in the room for a while after is Midoriya’s soul crushed laughter.

It takes a while for Kiddo to stop laughing and the gut wrenching noises only pause when he passes out into actual sleep, rather than the quirk driven dream he’d been stuck in. Dabi eases him to lay back down, carefully wiping the tears from his face with the edge of his sheet.

This boy means more to him than his revenge, Dabi realizes. And he has for a while. It almost feels like he’s been made a liar, but there’s a certain peace in knowing he *can* care about things other than murdering Endeavor. It’s been years. That makes him wonder if he can care about more things, too. The others’ faces cross his mind and he thinks, *Oh. I guess I can.*

But he’ll have to deal with those revelations later when he’s not stuck in a hospital room with a hero who can erase his quirk and two pigs that would gladly arrest him.

“We might as well take your statement now,” the detective says, sounding dubious at whether it’d be useful to them. Dabi side eyes him.

“You want me to believe what I have to say matters?” he asks with suspicion.

“He has a truth sensing quirk. He’ll know if you’re lying,” Eraserhead says and yeah, that makes sense. It also tells Dabi who the detective is and great, now he has to be at least somewhat cooperative because Tsukauchi’s also on the no-go list. *Fuck*.

Dabi looks back down at Kiddo, brushes a green curl away from his forehead. “Fine.”

“How did you get involved in the incident?” Tsukauchi asks.

“A contact called,” Dabi says, covering for Hawks without a thought. Doesn’t matter if Hawks is a spy, he’s still one of them. “Said Kiddo got kidnapped and then gave us where to go.”

“Your crew?”

“*His* crew,” Dabi corrects with a glare and vague wave towards Kiddo. Tsukauchi just nods and Dabi continues. “We got on scene and searched the building. Found Eraserhead and brought him along.”

“Why?”

“He’s on the no-go list. He has to stay alive.”

That seems to perk Eraserhead's interest. "Why the hell am I on a safe list, anyway?"

"Because you're an *actual* hero, I know one of us must have gone over that with you already." It's like these people are too stupid to figure out anything without having it fed to them in bite sized pieces. Dabi would burn them all to ash for the waste of time if he didn't know it would upset Kiddo. "Worthy of the title. It isn't *fame* or *fortune* or *esteem*, you're in it to help people, what a hero *should* be."

A complicated look passes over Eraserhead's face and Tsukauchi glances at the cat faced cop at his side.

"Who else is on this list?" he asks.

"Not enough people," Dabi says because despite having the list memorized, he doesn't feel like being *that* cooperative. Not when talking about real heroes makes him remember the *frauds*. Makes him remember his *revenge*. He has to tug his hand away from Kiddo as it heats up, ready to release his quirk. A slow, careful breath out helps him cool it again. The others in the room are tense, like they know what just happened, but no one comments.

"What happened after you picked up Eraserhead?" the detective says after a while.

"Kept searching. Found Kiddo in a fucking bank vault in the basement." That seems to surprise them but maybe the building got decimated as the fight continued so they haven't been able to search it. "We knew if we left Eraser there, he'd probably get killed accidentally, so we took him with us when we left. Fetched Recovery Girl again since he was unconscious."

Another complicated look from Eraserhead and Dabi doesn't have the energy or willpower to try and decipher it. He's been on edge and stressed for days, *weeks* even, and he needs some fucking sleep.

"Did you only protect Eraserhead because he was on this no-go list?" Tsukauchi asks.

"Did I- What? Why else would I help a hero without Kiddo telling me to?" Dabi finally looks at the detective full in the face to try and convey just how stupid a question that is. Something inside him starts to fray badly. "Even the good ones are still complicit in this fucked up hero system. You've never heard the phrase *all cops are bastards?* Glorified pop stars."

"Hey, calm down-"

"Like any of them would go out of their ways to protect the people who actually need it. Like any of them care about actual *justice.* You don't do a thing to get rid of those miserable pricks who use their power to cover up a murder or bury child abuse charges or-"

"Wait," Eraserhead says abruptly and Dabi almost stumbles without having taken a step as his tirade is interrupted. He stares at Eraserhead with something like offense, but Eraserhead's serious expression doesn't change and Dabi feels like everything's tilted. "This is personal. You have specific grievances."

Dabi stares at him harder and tries to ignore the way his pulse is starting to beat loudly in his ears. “Go to hell.”

“Who was it?” Eraserhead presses. “Who is your grievance against? I can look into the issue.”

Why does he even care?

“You-” It’s getting too cold suddenly. Dabi doesn’t feel temperature right in most of his body, but suddenly everything’s seeming too cold like he’s going to freeze up, maybe so cold it’s actually hot and he’ll burn the rest of his skin off. He thinks he might be laughing.“Why would- *No one can kill that man but me.*”

Eraserhead doesn’t look away, nor does he erase the heat Dabi can almost feel in his nerve-dead hands even though both of the cops have already reached toward their sidearms. And Dabi does not give a *fuck* about what they’re going to do right now. His world narrows down to Eraserhead’s face, to his eyes, and there’s nothing else at all.

“Breathe with me,” Eraserhead says and Dabi thinks he tells him to go fuck himself but there’s not enough air in his lungs and he is going to *burn this scumsucker to nothing*, he’s going to take all of them down with him this time.

“Dabi, focus. You’re losing control. Focus on my voice.”

Self-righteous boy scout *asshole* except he knows what heroes really are, he *knows* what they do, he knows it doesn’t matter at all that there are a couple worth leaving alive. Don’t let a few bad apples ruin the bunch, but what if no one throws out the rotten ones? What if *most* of the apples are rotten to the core?

“Dabi!”

Touya!

Something breaks in him as he hears his father’s voice overlapping Eraserhead’s and he lashes out but the fire doesn’t come. He stares at his scarred fingers, stares past them to Eraserhead and his upright hair. It happens all at once, the world exists again and suddenly he’s hearing all the noise at once and the room is too small and he hates it, he hates this so much, he’s-

He takes in a full, shuddering breath. Looks at the bed between him and Eraserhead and recognizes Kiddo again. If he loses it, Kiddo could die.

“Eraser?” one of the cops says and Dabi looks at them, takes in the two guns aimed for kill shots because he’s probably been on *that* list for a while now.

“I have him.” And what does that even fucking *mean*. “Dabi, are you hearing me again?”

It takes a lot of effort to look at Eraserhead’s face this time. His quirk is still active which means Dabi’s isn’t. He’s suddenly so, so very tired.

“I’ll listen,” Eraserhead says, “so please tell me who it was.”

“It won’t matter. It won’t change anything.”

“It might.”

“I’m going to kill him and then it’ll be *over*.”

Eraserhead just watches him with no outward reaction. Then his hair tumbles back down over his shoulders as he blinks. Despite how tense the cops get, Dabi doesn’t move.

“Does this have anything to do with why Midoriya’s admitted to having Endeavor on his kill list?”

The words get stuck in his throat at the mention of *that man’s name* but Eraserhead just nods as if he’d answered. There’s more that he’s reading from this situation but Dabi can’t find it in himself to give a shit right now. He wants to be angry, but he’s just so *tired*.

“Okay. Thank you for telling me.”

Dabi glances at the cops. The cat faced cop is still tense and focused on him but Tsukauchi’s starting to come off red alert. With deliberate slowness, Tsukauchi holsters his weapon and the cat faced cop follows his lead. Dabi doesn’t know if he should be offended by that. Then again, he’s not sure he’d be able to cremate them faster than they can draw again. In the wheelchair, Eraserhead shifts and Dabi’s attention snaps back to him and stays there.

There aren’t any more questions for a while after that. The cops move to the other side of the room to talk quietly with each other, then the cat faced cop switches out with the one that had gone with Haru. Kiddo only sleeps for about an hour but he’s not interested in talking after and just lays on his side staring at the wall. A meal is brought in for both him and Dabi, which surprises the hell out of him and he eats even though it’s legitimately terrible.

A doctor comes in and takes Kiddo’s vitals, tells the cops he should probably stay on the drip until the bags are empty before they transport him elsewhere. After Tsukauchi had gone during another cop switch, Eraserhead leaves for a while and comes back walking under his own power though he still seems worn. When Dabi looks up at him, Eraserhead meets his gaze without flinching.

“You’re going to be arrested. Both of you,” he says, and Dabi already knew that. He’s been ready for that fight. Kiddo doesn’t bother reacting to the news.

“You can try.” Dabi’s voice sounds hoarse and the tone is off. It’s a token resistance anyway.

Dragging a chair over to the foot of the bed, closer to where Dabi’s sitting, Eraserhead takes a seat and crosses his arms over his chest. He’s studying Dabi like a mystery to be solved, fucking *prick*.

“I had a few more questions first. Why did you throw in with Midoriya?” he asks.

“Kiddo’s got a way with words. We thought it was a quirk at first.” That’s the best he can do to describe the ease with which Kiddo could talk someone into doing the crazy shit they’ve been pulling for the last year and a half. As if he already knew the right words to sway them. With this loop business, he must have had plenty of time to figure out the right things to say through trial and error. “He promised me what I wanted most.”

Eraserhead studies him a moment, and then says, “He promised to help you kill Endeavor.”

Anger still rolls through Dabi at the mention, but he’s still exhausted from whatever the fuck happened before. He can’t quite get up to the same level of rage.

“What is your grievance against him?” Eraserhead continues as Dabi glares at him. “What’s been covered up?”

“It won’t do anything. He’s in the top ten, he’s *untouchable*. The only thing that will stop him is his death.”

“No one is above the law.” Dabi snorts but freezes as Eraserhead adds, “You mentioned murder and child abuse. Which one is it for you?”

And that’s a little too close to the truth but Dabi’s throat is tight over any words he could hope to get out.

“It’s child abuse,” Kiddo says as he pushes himself up and Dabi almost wants to strangle him for that because how does he know, how do *any* of them know- “You already know it’s child abuse.”

Eraserhead just nods. “That fits in with what the investigation into my student’s homelife has uncovered so far. Another witness would be useful in getting the HPSC to take the case seriously.”

Witness. As if Eraserhead knows who Dabi used to be, knows who died to give Dabi a body to exist in. It burns Dabi to his core and he can’t tell if it’s anger or embarrassment or shame.

“Todoroki Shoto has elected to spend the winter break on campus with a few others, but hasn’t agreed to speak to me about his family yet,” Eraserhead says and Dabi’s insides twist at the name. His replacement, his *better*. “I have an appointment to speak with Todoroki Fuyumi and Natsuo soon.”

More familiar names, more people Dabi has tried so hard to forget and leave behind.

“I’m hoping they can give me some insight into what happened to Shoto.” Eraserhead pauses then and Dabi feels his eyes on him without even looking at him. “I’m also looking into their older brother’s death.”

“I killed him,” Dabi says and his voice sounds… odd, in his own ears. Like it belongs to someone else. “I killed their older brother.”

Kiddo and Eraserhead are both silent as they wait.

“I burned Todoroki Touya alive,” Dabi says as his gaze drops to his hands and the ugly, scarred skin covering most of them, “and then decided to live in what was left over.”

It’s not a confession and he doesn’t ask if Eraserhead understands.

Abruptly, there’s a knock at the door before it opens and Hawks comes in with his arm in a sling and a tired face, but he’s whole and alive. His wings are mostly full and he’s back in a fresh uniform.

“Exit,” Kiddo says without giving him a moment to greet them. Then Eraserhead is knocked out of his chair and into the wall before he can reach for his scarf, bright red feathers pinning him in place as Kiddo jerks his sheet up off the bed. Four more feathers pin it over Eraserhead’s body to neutralize his quirk. It barely takes a second. Dabi realizes the cops are in the same position, restrained and unable to attack.

“Let’s go,” Hawks says without much of his usual cheer or humor. Dabi gets up and takes out the window without a word. There will be more cops and heroes if they dally but Hawks grabs onto Kiddo and jumps out first with Dabi right behind him. Feathers catch him before he’s dropped five feet and then the three of them are gone.

Chapter 34

Chapter Notes

> After consulting with reviewers on whether or not to tag for ableism, I am not tagging for it but warning there are some bits in the second to last section that might be upsetting and are there for narrative purpose. The man's got a couple old fashioned complexes, thinks some not nice things about his self worth, and it's something he'll be working through.

December

It's been two weeks since Kiddo came back. He'd spent the first week in his room, not getting out of bed. The rest of them fretted but weren't able to rouse him. Dabi told them what happened but none of them knew for sure how the dream world managed to break him like this. It couldn't be the news about All Might, Dabi said he'd already been out of it before that bombshell.

Then suddenly, Kiddo left his room and checked over their progress on the kill list, started making plans, and gave them missions. Spinner doesn't know if this means he's actually *okay*, but it's been a relief having some kind of direction.

His burns are mostly healed. Toga tracked down an underworld healer for him that was able to speed his recovery considerably, but the new skin is sensitive and delicate, so he's mostly been on missions with a low chance of violence for now. Courrier more than anything. He's on his way back from one when he stumbles into a meeting he hadn't known was coming.

Kiddo stands at one end of the big table somebody dragged in a week ago, a huge map of Musutafu spread out before him. At one side is Dabi, at the other is Hawks. Spinner's still not sure what to think of the ex-hero. When Hawks showed up with Dabi and Kiddo, Spinner thought it was just another way to ingratiate himself to the crew while he spied on them, but then Hawks didn't leave. The news made an announcement about Hawks disgracing himself and going villain, how could this happen, oh so sad. Kiddo didn't explain.

Kiddo isn't doing much talking that isn't mission related anymore.

"With the blast radius being what it was, these are the most viable options for Garaki's current lab," Kiddo says, marking out four locations with a thick black marker. "All For One wouldn't have endangered the Shigaraki nomu."

Because while the media has been crowing about All For One's demise and the underground tentatively agreeing, Kiddo's absolutely sure he's not actually dead. He hasn't explained that either.

“That one, it’s a *hospital*,” Hawks says with a frown. “It’d be hard to hide something there.”

“Underground lab, ten to one he’s been using it for something currently whether it’s nomus or not while he daylights as an actual doctor.” Kiddo grabs a blue marker and marks out a few more. “Storage facilities for the new nomu should be only mildly difficult targets. We’ll hit those first. All For One may have given Shigaraki’s nomu that slime teleportation quirk. No sense in leaving him foot soldiers to call in when he pleases.”

“What kind of resistance should we expect?” Dabi asks with a sideways glance.

“Probably human. Whoever I haven’t poached from him yet. I doubt Garaki has many first gen nomus left. He’ll keep them in the lab he’s currently using. Man’s a coward and should be an easy kill once they’re out of the way.”

Capping the marker with a loud *pop*, Kiddo hangs the map on the wall. The hideout is a little more put together now. They’ve got a lot of lists and diagrams on the walls, a computer with a couple hundred detailed hero analyses, actual chairs. Maybe it’s still kind of low key for what Spinner would think of as a hideout, but it’s something. They’ve all got a cleaned out office turned bedroom so he hasn’t had to sleep rough since they got the place. There’s something to be said for knowing you’ve got a roof over your head and a lock on the door.

He wonders how long that’ll last.

Kiddo turns around and pins his cold, detached gaze onto Spinner, acknowledging him for the first time since he’d walked in and freezing him in place. “What did Giran say?”

“He gave me a new list of people that will probably change alliances with the right incentive and one for those that won’t,” Spinner says as he pulls them out. “He’s pretty sure Garaki’s down to a skeleton crew of die hard sycophants, though.”

Kiddo takes the lists and reads over them in silence. He tacks one up on the wall and grabs a pen to start adding names to the much reduced kill list. It’s kind of like watching a robot go through the motions but Spinner keeps that thought to himself.

“What about supplies?” Kiddo asks without the writing stopping.

“Supply lines are solid, Giran’s keeping that going smoothly.”

“Good. Tell him to hurry up on my knives.”

Spinner texts that over. There’s a lot he wouldn’t want an electric record of, but this is innocent enough the way he words it.

“We’ll finish the kill list first,” Kiddo says once he’s finished adding to it. “Hawks, you may abstain if you prefer.”

“I’ve killed on purpose before,” Hawks says with a shrug. “And I’m already a villain now. It’s a good way to prove to you that I’m all in.”

Without really acknowledging that, Kiddo continues. “We’ll go after Re-Destro last. He’s still holed up being pathetic, right?”

“No change per Toga. She sends her regards,” Spinner says. There’s no acknowledgement of that, either.

“Once Re-Destro’s gone, we’ll try to recruit the ones Giran thinks might turn. If they refuse, kill them. No loose ends.” He glances Dabi’s way. “Call back Twice. You, he, and Hawks will work on finishing the kill list. Tell Spinner if you need anything. Tell me when you’ve completed it.”

“Understood,” Dabi says with a nod.

“We’ll leave Toga watching Re-Destro until then.”

Then Kiddo leaves to go to his bedroom, closing the door behind him. It’s an awkward ending to the meeting but is becoming a familiar one. Spinner’s not sure what he does in there, but he doubts it’s good to leave Kiddo to it. They just don’t know how else to handle him right now. Like any of them are the spitting image of emotional resilience.

“How long do you think…” Spinner trails off and sighs, looking back to Dabi and Hawks.

“He received a pretty big shock, coming out of that dream.” Hawks is right, considering Eraserhead had called it a *perfect dream* that gave him all he wanted. Having it ripped away… Well. Spinner gets it.

“He just needs time,” Dabi says.

Spinner nods, glances at the door one more time, and then moves to get started. All he can do is keep his faith in Kiddo strong. He hopes it’s enough.

“You’ve made out with someone before, right?” Bakugou says randomly one afternoon while he and Eijirou are sparring, trying to get as much in as they can before the winter break takes both of them home. It’s enough of a shock that he doesn’t even try to block or harden for Bakugou’s next punch and it lays him out flat.

Eijirou blinks up at him from the grass with a throbbing cheek. “Uh. Yeah?”

“What did that feel like?” Bakugou’s face is utterly serious as he offers a hand and then drags Eijirou up.

That has Eijirou blushing and wow, he hadn’t realized his broship with Bakugou had gotten to the level where they talk about this kind of thing. It kind of makes him feel warm in his chest even if it’s *embarrassing as hell*.

“Nice, I guess?”

Bakugou sneers at him like that’s the wrong answer but there’s a fine dusting of pink at the edges of his cheeks. It’s kind of adorable, in a manly way.

“I mean, what did it- How did you…” Hissing out an annoyed huff, Bakugou looks away. “Nevermind.”

And whoa, no, if they’re this close there’s no way Eijirou can let him run away from this kind of thing. Bakurou’s obviously struggling with something and it’s *amazing* that he’d trust Eijirou with that.

“It was nice,” Eijirou repeats as he tries to ignore his own embarrassment so he can maybe help. “It was… wet? Hot. Made my heart pound. And my mouth was kinda sore after. I think the other person was the same way.”

If he gets through this conversation without dying of shame, Eijirou will pray to every god in existence everyday.

“Did you… Afterward, did it change anything with that person?”

Eijirou tilts his head. “I mean. Yeah? It made us both aware that we kinda… you know, the *physicality* of it-”

“Goddamn it, *not like that*,” Bakugou interrupts with irritation, a few soft pops coming from his hands. It doesn’t put Eijirou on edge anymore, often as it happens. “I mean- in your… In your…”

Eijirou blinks as he tries to decipher what that even means. Does he mean- Oh no, Eijirou is not ready to talk about *sex* with Bakugou, they are *definitely* not there yet! “Like… Did we get past second base?”

“No! Shit, that’s not what I- Fuck you, Shitty Hair, *fuck you so goddamn much*.”

Wow, this is *really* getting to him to drop that much rough language. Bakugou cusses a lot, but usually he spreads it out a bit more. Eijirou really sympathizes with his manly struggle to figure out- Oh. Oh, this is about feelings.

“I mean. Yeah, it made us closer for a while, until we stopped,” Eijirou says because feelings he can do, feelings are *so* much easier than- well. *Other* things. Understanding your emotional core is the first step to true manliness! “I wanted to be around them more and… kiss them more. Or just hold their hand.”

When there’s no expletive filled rant after, Eijirou is sure he’s on the right track here.

“I thought about them when they weren’t around,” he says. “We hung out more, went places together. I guess we were dating? But not officially. It was nice, though. We made out a *lot*.”

Bakugou looks up toward the sky, his brows furrowed tight and the corners of his mouth creased with tension.

“Did you…” he starts and then his jaw snaps closed again before he glares at everything that isn’t Eijirou. “Why did you stop if it was so *nice?*”

“Oh. Uh.” Eijirou scratches the back of his head. “Well, they got interested in someone else for real so it made sense to stop with me. Cheating is *not* manly.”

That finally gets Bakugou’s intense gaze back onto him. “What do you mean ‘for real’?”

Being Bakugou Katsuki’s friend means having to figure out a lot of how he thinks and feels through intuition and subtle undercurrents to his words. He’s so loud and obnoxious that most people can’t see the guy under it who *desperately* craves attention and has no idea how to form close bonds. It’s the first thing Eijirou noticed about him, after his obviously crabby outward personality.

Bakugou hates doing useless things and he definitely doesn’t talk about anything that isn’t important to him. So for Bakugou to ask a question like *that*… Oh.

“You like someone,” he says before he can control his mouth. It prompts the expected blow up and Eijirou patiently waits for Bakugou to tire himself out.

Still, that’s a thing to get his head around! Since they met, Bakugou pinged as probably asexual or somewhere around it, considering his complete lack of interest in… well, basically anyone. Eijirou has never caught him subtly checking out some girl’s chest or a guy’s ass or anything else. It’s like other people are around strictly to give him something to fight against or brag to. He can barely imagine that changing.

But if Bakugou’s interested in someone, it might be the first time that ever happened to him. Eijirou smacks his fist down into his other palm. *That’s* what this conversation is about! No wonder he’s so flustered.

“It’s okay if you do,” he says when Bakugou finally winds down a bit. “There’s nothing wrong with wanting to touch someone or wanting to date them.”

“You’re so damn sure,” Bakugou bites back with a glare, but he hasn’t walked off. That’s basically permission to keep going.

“Do they like you?”

The red on Bakugou’s cheeks deepens and even the tips of his ears are pinker now. “...Yeah.”

“So what’s the problem?” Eijirou tilts his head a bit to see Bakugou’s face a little better because Bakugou won’t look at him again. “If you both like each other then you should try it out. Worst case, you figure out what you don’t want and the next time is easier.”

“I don’t fucking *know* if I do,” Bakugou says like he’s pulling a tooth for every word. He kicks a bit of grass, fingers flexing at his sides but not popping off any more tiny explosions. “This isn’t what I thought it was supposed to feel like.”

Eijirou gives his shoulder a squeeze. “Welcome to the human race where nothing makes sense and the points don’t matter.”

That gets him a sneer but he’s got way thicker skin than most people. You kind of have to with a friend like Mina. She goes for the *throat*.

It gets dropped after that but Eijirou's sure Bakugou will bring it up again the next time they're alone. He's got a lot of thinking to do and Eijirou does *not* envy having to. The last time he did was when he figured out he liked some girls as well as most guys and wow, he wouldn't wish that on anyone.

Watching Bakugou as he escapes back towards the dorms, Eijirou figures he'll check on him after the break. Wouldn't be a good bro if he left his friend hanging. And maybe by then, he'll tell Bakugou to call him Eijirou and maybe Bakugou will let him use Katsuki. With honorifics of course, he's not shameless!! The thought still makes him feel bright and happy inside. He carries that feeling all the way to his room.

The first thing he notices is the beeping. Mostly steady, very little variation. Not quite loud but insistent, unwilling to be ignored. Then it's the sound of rushing air in a regulated cadence, in and out like taking breath. It matches the feeling of air against his mouth and nose, making it easier to just let his body continue breathing steadily on its own.

His body feels… far away. Not quite real. He's not sure he's actually still in it. If he tried moving he thinks it might crumble to nothing, so he doesn't. There will come a time to move again, just not yet.

Sometimes he thinks he hears voices, understands a word or two as if hearing them from underwater. Not nearly clear enough.

He doesn't know how long he's floated in that strange between place or how long after he starts thinking about it he keeps floating. One moment, he's wondering if he has toes or ever has. The next, he's opening his eyes and the world exists again.

Toshinori doesn't stay conscious for very long. There's a whirlwind of activity when he wakes, a clattering of dissonant voices that shout over him and confuse him and overwhelm him.

The next time he wakes, it's quieter. He takes his time to appreciate that quiet and pick out little sounds of people, probably a room or two away. There's something closer, too. Tapping fingertips on glass. Just the one.

He opens his eyes again and takes in the hospital room in all its bland greatness. And it *is* great because Toshinori's pretty sure he shouldn't be alive right now.

"Oh," says the person at his bedside and Toshinori turns his head slowly, just enough to look. Naomasa's eyes grow warm and thankful. "Good afternoon."

Toshinori tries to say something and coughs instead. It's enough to summon one of the nurses. They switch out the full oxygen mask for a nasal cannula but warn him they'll switch it back if his oxygen levels drop. They take his vitals, fuss over his pillows, make him drink most of a cup of water, and finally leave with a parting shot to Naomasa not to tire him out.

"How long?" he asks once they're alone again.

“About three weeks.”

“Did he-”

Naomasa sighs a little.

“We thought so,” he says and it’s a tone Toshinori knows well, one that sets him immediately on edge. “We found remains. Verified they didn’t belong to anyone else and seemed to match up with what little we have on file for him. All signs point to him being dead.”

It should be comforting. It isn’t. Toshinori has known Naomasa far too long to accept something as unclear as that. “Why don’t you believe it?”

Naomasa studies his face. “Midoriya seems to think he’ll be back within a few months. That he’d transferred something of himself into what’s left of Shigaraki, wherever he is.”

“Then he probably has.”

Toshinori closes his eyes and feels, suddenly, so very *ancient*. At least Midoriya’s alive and apparently recovered, if Naomasa got a chance to speak with him. That’s something. The mission wasn’t an entire wash.

“Was anyone else hurt?” he asks when he’s able.

“Endeavor had broken ribs and a concussion. Hawks was worse off, touch and go for a day, but he’s already been released now. Eraserhead had some internal bleeding among other things. He’s also back to work now. Midoriya was caught in a dream quirk, but he’s been broken out of it already.” Naomasa hesitates, like he’s trying to figure out what Toshinori can handle in his delicate condition. “He escaped custody with Hawks soon after.”

Sounds complicated. Toshinori can’t quite muster the will to get sad or scared or angry about it. He must be on a wicked cocktail of drugs right now, considering everything he feels seems to be under a blanket. It’s a wonder he’s this coherent.

“What happens now?” he asks. Naomasa pauses again. Something complicated flows over his face so Toshinori just watches and waits. It will come out eventually.

“For you? Retirement,” Naomasa says finally. “Are you… Do you have any idea what state your body is in right now?”

“No. I can’t feel it, mostly.”

Is he not worried about that because of the drugs or because he’d already figured that was the case? Toshinori isn’t sure.

“You nearly died. It’s a miracle they managed to save you at all.”

Which means it’s worse than before. If it’s bad enough that Naomasa’s saying retirement like it’s a done deal… Toshinori flexes his fingers. There’s pain, distant and muddled, but he

thinks he maybe feels all of them. He thinks he feels both hands and arms, anyway. He tries with his toes and feels *nothing*.

“Oh,” he says. Yeah. That would do it. “How much of me is left?”

“Enough,” Naomasa says. “You’ll live. That’s what I care about.”

It’s not until later when a doctor comes by to speak with him that Toshinori gets the full accounting for what All For One took from him that day. His muscle form is gone, the embers of One For All entirely cold. He *did* lose two fingers on his left hand, but he has the rest of them and at least it’s his non-dominant hand. It had also been entirely severed but they were able to reattach it with only minimal nerve damage, they just hadn’t been able to find his fingers soon enough to do the same with them. His spine was also damaged, several fractures of his vertebrae, but somehow his spinal cord remains intact. They did some sort of magic in his torso to keep his reduced and battered organs chugging along but that part matters a lot less to him than the rest.

His legs are gone. One just above the knee, the other higher up his thigh. Neither had been recovered from the scene to attempt reattachment. They move the sheet to let him see it, make it real. He wonders when it’ll stop feeling like he’s looking at someone else’s body instead of his own.

He’s definitely retired at this point. Sure, there’s the option of prosthetics, but he’s not a young man anymore. He doesn’t have the time to adapt to them and still fight the good fight, even if he hadn’t lost his muscle form. Distantly, he hopes Nedzu will still have some kind of use for him at UA. What else is he supposed to do with his time if not helping to cultivate the next generation? Surely, there’s something. Surely, he can still be useful.

Toshinori sleeps and the next time he wakes up, he’s not nearly as drugged out of his mind. It makes all the news hit a little harder but he’s been doing hero work for a while. He’d always known eventually he’d be sidelined if he managed to survive that long. And losing his legs isn’t the end of the world. Once he’s adjusted, learned how to accommodate his new normal, he’ll still be able to be independent. That’s something, at least.

“Has the media plastered this face on the news yet?” he asks when Aizawa visits.

“Not yet. You still have some level of anonymity, if you want it. We were lucky that the fight wasn’t noticed until it was over and no one tagged along with emergency services. They covered the destruction and clean up efforts, though.” His hands are stuck in his pockets, his posture as lazy as ever, and that’s almost comforting. Even if Toshinori is a husk of what he used to be, Aizawa’s treating him no differently than he ever did.

He looks up at the ceiling and wonders if he can really just let himself fade into the background of history. Pretend that he isn’t - *wasn’t* All Might. Just a regular citizen. Just Yagi Toshinori. It’s probably the coward’s way out, hiding away like his current - and now *only* - form is something to be ashamed of.

“I guess Midoriya’s prediction came true,” Toshinori mutters, barely noticing he’d said it aloud until Aizawa’s eyes narrow.

“Which one?”

“He’s specific, his wording.” That’s something Toshinori is only now really starting to think about. “Every time he’s talked about my death… He’s always called me All Might.”

Aizawa sighs. “I think most of the time he really did mean you, either as All Might or Yagi.”

“Maybe so.”

He doesn’t stay much longer. Toshinori gets a string of visitors who don’t talk about his injuries except to say they’re happy he’s still around. He smiles and thanks them and pretends everything is fine.

Eventually, that will be true. He’s sure of it.

Dr. Garaki Kyudai always knew he was destined for great things. That his brilliance was just waiting for that one chance, that shining moment when everything would align. His ideas would have gotten him thrown out of medical school or his specialization internship and residency, but Kyudai also knew how to be discreet. A child more prone to taking a pet apart than stroking it has to learn that.

And now, all that hard work is about to pay off. Before him is his greatest creation, a perfect being just waiting to be unleashed on an unsuspecting world that had been stagnant for far too long. Shigaraki Tomura had known that. His sensei, his *master,* had known that. And now Kyudai knows that. The only way to bring humanity to the next era of their evolution is to destroy everything first. Destroy the old so that the new can be rebuilt on its ashes.

“You’re almost there,” he says to the sleeping, floating body before him, casting eerie green light over most of the lab reflected from the enrichment fluid. “Just a little longer and you can take your rightful place.”

His eyes slide over pale skin rippling with strength, pale hair floating around a still face. For a moment, he wonders how long it’ll take his creation to turn on him, but… That depends entirely on who’s in it when it wakes.

The legions he’s been building will wipe away the stale concerns of the present. Kyudai smiles. *Soon*, he thinks. *Soon it will all be worth it.*

His perfect creation will force humanity into the future.

Chapter 35

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Kiddo is… maybe a little intense these days. Jin tries not to take it personally when he snaps at him. Kiddo's still one of the best bosses he's ever had. Hasn't even hit him *once*. But the intensity doesn't seem to be helping Kiddo along with his plans. It's more like something's building and twisting inside him, and none of them know what to do to help.

He's gonna snap and murder all of us, that's what'll happen!

Jin shakes the thought away. Even texting Himiko doesn't quite distract Jin from that problem. He sighs, sends her a new cat meme, and then gets back to base to confirm his latest kill. Their list of targets has been eaten away steadily, might even be complete by the time he gets there. The pace is frantic but not impossible. At least Jin isn't bored. He just…

Sometimes Jin wonders if Kiddo's vision of the future is actually what he wants, too. It seems, maybe just a little, to have gotten off track. Sure, there's a lot going on that he'd like to nip, but… Well. Not like wars are ever bloodless (*When have I ever hesitated to kill when I could?*), he's sure this is fine. Jin's not really a big picture guy anyway.

The base is crowded when he gets there. Everyone's checked in, even Himiko who sends Jin a tired but cheery smile, and Kiddo's checking over the kill list with what has become his usual level of focus. He glances up at Jin after a few minutes.

"Successful?" he asks and Jin doesn't have to ask with what.

"100%!"

Kiddo's attention goes back to the list as he crosses off a few more names. He nods after a moment, looking around at them. It's only the inner circle and Jin still doesn't know how the hell he got trusted like this. Then again, Hawks is here too, so…

Spies and outlaws welcome! He's not a spy anymore. *Not with that attitude!*

Jin shakes it and realizes Kiddo had started talking.

"-can wait until the new year," Kiddo's saying, the final kill list folded in his hands. "He's not going anywhere. His support system is non-existent and I doubt Garaki even knows he exists to try and fold him in. I want eyes on him, but we can set up a schedule instead of having one person sit on him for the next week."

"Aww, are you giving us Christmas off?" Hawks asks, the corner of his mouth quirking up. "What a nice boss"

"Do you *want* to work on Christmas?" Kiddo shoots back with a narrow look. Hawks lifts his hands in placation.

“Point made.”

They go over a few more boring things and then scatter to their respective whims. Jin almost goes to his room and then pauses, looking back to Kiddo studying the big map on the wall like it might give him more answers than it has the last hundred hours he’s spent staring at it.

He seems lonely. *What a chump.* Jin wonders if there’s something he can do. *Ain’t my problem*.

He can’t quite make himself leave, so he walks closer instead. The moment Kiddo notices him is obvious, even if he doesn’t turn around.

“What are you doing during the break?” Jin asks.

That doesn’t seem to be what Kiddo is expecting, considering the confused bunching of his brows.

“Doesn’t matter.”

Jin shrugs. “I don’t have plans. *We should do something together!*”

The look he gets is probably the most emotive Jin has seen Kiddo since he’s been back. He counts it as a win even if it’s negative. Kiddo turns back to the map and Jin has no pressing reason to *leave*, so he doesn’t.

There’s no one who’d want to see Jin or hear from him that isn’t already part of this crew. His family is either dead or disowned him a long time ago. But… He brightens as he thinks of something.

“We could visit your mom?”

Kiddo goes very, very still. He doesn’t turn around, doesn’t answer, but Jin’s sure he’s listening.

“Come on, how long has it been since you saw her? *What an unfilial son*.”

“Fuck off,” Kiddo says through gritted teeth. Dangerous, but…

“We don’t even have to go in,” Jin insisted. “We can just look in the windows.”

He’s not even sure why this seems so important. All sides of Jin are in agreement though. It can only help Kiddo to see his mom alive and… maybe not *well*, but probably better than the last time one of them checked on her.

It’s usually Jin. He kind of feels responsible after dragging her out of Shigaraki’s clutches. *She means nothing to him.*

The harsh glare that Kiddo sets on him isn’t so much *intimidating* as it is just… protective? Self protective. Kind of like a wounded animal snarling at you when all you want to do is

help them? That's what it seems like. Jin just stands and waits and wonders where he got the *gall.*

"You're driving?" Kiddo asks finally.

"Yeah? Unless you magically have a license. *Strap in and go buck wild, kid."*

Kiddo glances away, fighting with himself. Then his whole body sags as he sighs like he's letting go of the ten billion things on his shoulders, at least for a little while. They leave the base and climb into a car Giran had acquired for them from… somewhere. It's nondescript and without Jin's mask on, there's no reason for anyone to pay much attention.

They drive in silence. It's uncomfortable, weighs them down and turns the air thick and oppressive. Jin doesn't let himself look over to the passenger side. Kiddo doesn't look at him either.

It's dark by the time they get there, having been dusk when they left. Jin parks at a business two buildings away and then walks with Kiddo towards the long term care hospital Midoriya Inko has been staying at. Going inside is, of course, not a great idea even if Kiddo was willing to. Jin's sure someone would notice that under the thick jacket, he's wearing a costume and could extrapolate what else. Jin leads Kiddo up a hill that overlooks the side of the building where Midoriya Inko lives. He settles down to sit in the dead grass, waits for Kiddo to sink down next to him, and then points out the right window.

Midoriya Inko never closes her curtains, which has made it a lot easier for them to check in and make sure she's still around. Through the window, Jin can see her talking to an orderly with expressive hands. When she smiles, he hears a faint intake of breath beside him and has to look.

Tears roll down Kiddo's cheeks as he stares at his mother with all the longing he's refused to show. There's a purity to the look on his face. An innocence. It's a pain Jin doesn't really understand, estranged as he's been for so long, but he doesn't need to understand to be there for Kiddo. He doesn't need to say anything.

They stay there for hours, watching Midoriya Inko go through her evening routine. Eventually, she gets into bed and the light switches off. There's not enough light from the street lamps to see anymore. Jin's fingers went numb a while ago and he flexes them idly as he waits. This whole thing was for Kiddo after all, so he'll wait until Kiddo's had his fill.

Kiddo doesn't thank him later, when they've finally left the hospital and gotten back to base. He just goes to his room and closes the door quietly behind him. Jin figures that's probably fine. *So rude though*.

By the last day of school before the break, Todoroki still hasn't cracked. Shouta's not sure if he's getting prodded at home by his siblings or not, but he's shut even tighter than before. Shouta's got his siblings' testimony and that of Dabi, confirmed as the thought dead Todoroki Touya, but if he wants this to stick, it'll take everything he can get.

He'll try again after the break. At least Todoroki isn't going home for it.

Students file out of the classroom, some sprinting with exuberant joy to start their first afternoon off. Some of them will be back for specialized training over the next ten days, but the rest get to be lazy and will suffer mightily at the start of the third term. Shouta almost smiles at the prospect of breaking them in day one.

It's only as he's turning to leave himself that he notices one student that hasn't left yet. Bakugou isn't slated for cleaning duty today but stares right back at Shouta with purpose from his desk. It's blatant enough Shouta quietly closes the door to the hall and then goes to lean against the chalkboard.

"So?" he asks.

"You know about the time loop," Bakugou says and the only surprising thing about him knowing is that he waited this long to come talk to Shouta about it. He has a hunch Bakugou found out during the dream and that was nearly a month ago, unless he'd overheard something before that. For such a smart kid, some things can take Bakugou so long to process. Maybe he only cares now because he knows he's integral to it all.

"That's privileged information. But I suppose you're involved now."

"He said he watched me die." There's anger in Bakugou's voice, hints of offense. "Do you fucking believe that?"

Yes. Yes, Shouta definitely does. His reluctance to believe had been steadily eaten away by too many right guesses and the honest, fatalistic *need* Midoriya keeps showing again and again. Need to be listened to, need to be believed, need to be successful in his one mission.

"I'm working under the assumption that it's true," Shouta admits and watches the way Bakugou's jaw tightens and grinds.

"You believe that *I* am dying over and over, but that fucking nerd-"

"From Midoriya's testimony, he's *also* dying over and over. That's how the loops restart."

Bakugou looks away, getting up from his chair like he can't stand to not be moving. "That sounds like a lot of bullshit."

Well. He's not wrong.

"Did you have a point in confronting me about this?"

"I want in."

Shouta frowns. Like hell is he letting another teenager onto this case when he *knows* what they're up against. And when he knows what kind of wrench Bakugou could throw into it. "No."

The look on Bakugou's face is pure, determined rage as he squares up to Shouta like he means to fight him for the right to be involved.

"I'm not *asking*," Bakugou says with blazing certainty. "I'm just letting you know what I'm gonna do."

"I'll confine you to the dorms," is Shouta's answer and Bakugou's eyes narrow.

"You can *try*."

"You're getting really close to insubordination that could result in expulsion," Shouta warns him. There's a flicker of unease, a crack in Bakugou's confidence, but he pushes past it anyway.

"Fine. As long as I'm involved."

Shouta studies him for a few quiet seconds as Bakugou refuses to stand down. It might be useful, having someone around that Midoriya is so obsessed with. And it *is* an obsession, Shouta's pretty sure about that now. Just because he's certain there are romantic feelings involved doesn't negate that Midoriya's entire life has been focused to an unhealthy degree on this one person for who knows how many years. The time loop is just reinforcing it.

"Just what happened in that dream to make you so concerned?" Shouta asks. They only have the sketchiest understanding of just what went on in it, considering Bakugou had skimmed over most details and Midoriya gave even less before he escaped.

Another flicker, this time followed by pink rising up on Bakugou's face.

"I saw him in a different light," Bakugou mutters, glancing off with embarrassment.

Ah, so this is probably a sex thing. Shouta's not surprised if Midoriya had the reins. He's seen how Midoriya looks at Bakugou, why wouldn't he want to get laid in his perfect dream world?

Shouta studies him until Bakugou manages to look him in the face again. Embarrassed, yes, but also not about to drop this. Ugh, save him from fucking *teenagers*.

"I'll consider it," he says finally and Bakugou just nods, grabs his bag, and leaves without another word. Shouta stays behind for a bit, rubbing a hand over his face. Okay. He can make this work. If anything, they can probably use Bakugou as bait and he's plenty skilled enough to get himself out of danger if it comes to that. That's the one thing he's never doubted when it comes to Bakugou. The real trick is keeping Bakugou in line long enough to do what needs to be done without going overboard.

Shaking his head, Shouta leaves the classroom and almost immediately bumps into Hizashi. They manage not to collide, but barely.

"Shouta! I was looking for you," Hizashi says cheerfully and Shouta feels something like happiness to be missed, but he keeps that shoved deep in the back of his mind.

“Do you need something?” he asks.

“Walk with me.”

Suspicious but Shouta doesn’t have anything pressing to do right this second so he follows at Hizashi’s side in the empty hallway as Hizashi babbles about his day, something he saw on the news, an upcoming subject for his radio show… The constant flow of words is kind of relaxing, since none of it actually matters. Shouta lets himself get lulled by it.

“-then a third year *confessed* to me and Shouta, I am never going to get used to that,” brings Shouta right out of that lull and into full attention.

“*What?*”

“Confessed. Letter and everything! It was super old fashioned and kind of adorable?”

Shouta blinks.

“I let her down gently, of course,” Hizashi assures him, patting Shouta’s shoulder. “There’s only room for one special person in my life and that’s already taken.”

What? Hizashi’s dating someone? When the hell did that happen? Why hadn’t he said something about it? Usually, Hizashi can’t keep a secret to save his life. Shouta *always* knows when he’s interested in a woman. He forces himself to keep looking forward as that rolls over his mind and does uncomfortable things to his chest.

“You haven’t mentioned her before,” Shouta hears himself saying and it doesn’t even sound as hollow as that makes him feel.

“Huh?”

“This… one special person.”

“Oh, uh.” Hizashi picks at his nails awkwardly. “We’re not… He hasn’t really…”

Shouta stops dead. *He?* Hizashi only goes another two steps before he pauses to turn around and look at him.

“You like guys?” Shouta asks and Hizashi’s brows shoot up to his hairline.

“Did… Did you think I was *straight?*”

Said like it’s the most ridiculous thing Hizashi has ever heard, but really, who could blame him? Half of the heroes Shouta knows are just as flamboyant and bonkers and most of *them* are straight. He wasn’t going to assume anything that hadn’t been made obvious about his… best friend? Only friend? Shit, Shouta needs to meet more people.

“I’m pan,” Hizashi says and Shouta can’t quite look at him anymore.

“Ah.”

Well, this is awkward. If Shouta thinks about it, yeah, there have been a couple guys that seemed maybe a bit too handsy with Hizashi over the years, but Shouta had just taken it as the overly friendly nature of most limelight heroes. Obnoxious but not necessarily meaningful. Now he has to wonder which of them might have actually been a date rather than a friend.

All this time Shouta had let feelings grow and fester in himself because of the comfortable knowledge that nothing could ever come of them and now… Well. It probably still wouldn't. If Hizashi was interested in anything more than friendship with him, surely he'd have signaled it before now.

They start walking again but there's a level of distraction now. He keeps feeling Hizashi looking at him from the corner of his eye, like he's searching for something, and Shouta does his best to be as blank and unreadable as he can. He knows Hizashi won't take it as disapproval. HIzashi knows him better than that.

"I'm going to visit the shrine near my place on the first," Hizashi says after a while.

Shouta makes an acknowledging sound.

"You should go with me. Maybe bring Eri? I'd like to welcome the new year with you."

That has Shouta stopping again. This time Hizashi stops with him but neither of them look at one another. He's reading too much into it, Shouta's sure. There's no reason for this to be anything other than a friendly gesture since neither of them have living relatives anymore barring Eri. Even though Shouta hasn't joined him for that tradition since they were students. Even though he'd just confirmed Hizashi has the potential to be interested in men. Even though…

"As friends?" his terrible, traitorous mouth says before he can stop it and he feels Hizashi stiffen at his side.

"Yeah," Hizashi says with a hesitant, careful tone. "Unless you want something else."

It's a leading question, an invitation, but there is no way in hell Shouta should respond to it with the truth right now when he's this off base. He barely trusts himself when he says, "It is. What I want."

"Okay. Then yes, of course as friends."

Shouta nods and then makes an excuse to get the hell out of that situation right after. He goes home without stopping for anything, ignoring the few others in his path so he can shut himself behind a locked door and mentally scream about how fucking *stupid* he just sounded. He's worse than some of his goddamn students. Shouta rakes his fingers back through his hair and then starts his age old tradition: *repression*.

It seems almost pointless to plan for something they have so little information on. Naomasa gratefully takes a fresh cup of coffee Sansa hands over and then peers at the documents

littering his desk as if they might start to give him more.

Shigaraki's file starts and ends with mystery. They don't know where he came from. There's a hint about a possible connection to Shimura Nana, who had died decades ago. She had a son but after he was put into the system as a child and aged out, the trail goes cold. He surely didn't disappear but without a criminal record or some idea of just where he'd gone, there's not much Naomasa can find.

It's possible Shimura Kotaro had a child that became Shigaraki Tomura, but there's no way to confirm that. Whatever All For One did to him, Shigaraki's DNA isn't a familial match to Shimura Nana now if it ever was before. The sample barely read as *human* with the amount of damage they discovered. That pointed comment Edgeshot heard might have just been to throw All For One off his game rather than truth.

Officially, Shigaraki was declared dead. Unofficially, the police are pretty sure that Midoirya is right and he'll be back in some form, considering someone took the effort to steal his body. There's been some strange whispers in the underworld that their informants have come across, past the fact that more and more of the criminal underground and adjacent are throwing in their lot with Kiddo.

A flash of memory, Midoriya's heartsore expression in the hospital, is there and gone in an instant. Naomasa rubs his tired eyes. No. The boy is a known manipulator. Seeing this kind of activity, he can't help but think every soft moment of vulnerability he's ever seen was an act, a carefully modulated appearance to make Naomasa underestimate him. Just because Midoriya hadn't *lied* doesn't mean he's told the *whole truth*, and often omissions can be just as useful in painting a specific narrative. Naomasa feels had.

A sixteen year old boy would not be able to do this, but a thousand year old man probably could.

The door to his office opens as Tanuma arrives, looking haggard and ready to drop. Then again, he's been undercover for weeks trying to track Midoriya's recent movements to figure out some kind of pattern. Naomasa waves Sansa out as Tanuma collapses into the chair across from him.

The door has only just clicked closed when Naomasa asks, "What do you have?"

"A fat load of nothing," Tanuma says, even as he passes over a thick file. But when Naomasa's flipping through the carefully organized sheets, he sees what Tanuma means. The only important info is stuff they already know and the rest all seems random. The people Midoriya has recently bumped off, the ones he's brought to his side, the ones he's bribed and extorted, there's no pattern to any of it.

"Not all of these are known agents of All For One." That had been their primary theory, that Midoriya was just dismantling All For One's support system from the ground up so he'd have no one at his side if he did come back the way Midoriya was sure he would. Midoriya had already taken out the league, after all.

“No. His aims are getting broader. At this point, I think he’s trying to build his own empire.” Which is not good at all for someone who’s shown they have the intelligence and charisma to do so. They share an uneasy glance. “Maybe he thinks being the man on top is the easiest way to keep everyone in line?”

“It’s a dangerous game either way,” Naomasa says as he sits back in his chair. Midoriya’s aims and actions are as chaotic now as they were when he first got started. Even with what he knows about Midoriya’s motivations, at least what he’s been *told*, Naomasa can’t quite figure out how to predict him.

“It’s too bad he’d recognize Sir Nighteye,” and that has Naomasa’s eyes flashing up to the calculating expression on Tanuma’s face. “It’d be nice to get a hint of what his next day is like.”

Midoriya would *definitely* recognize Sir Nighteye… but he might talk with him anyway. It’s been a little weird, the way Midoriya skirts certain heroes and plays at being friendly with others. The only one they know for sure is a target is Endeavor, but so far the protective outfit watching over him and his family haven’t noticed anything out of the ordinary. If Midoriya’s planning to make a move against him, there’s no sign of it yet.

“It’s something to try,” Naomasa says, already reaching for the phone. “We know the general area that Midoriya’s headquarters is in, even if no one’s been able to actually locate it. If Sir Nighteye were to get close enough…”

“The kid’s probably arrogant enough to push his luck meeting him.” Tanuma gives him a tired smile. Naomasa doesn’t think it’s arrogance though. If he’s taking the time loop as factual, and Naomasa’s seen plenty enough proof so far, it’s simple familiarity. Midoriya knows how far he can push anyone because he’s hit that limit before in a previous loop.

With that in mind, Naomasa dials Sir Nighteye’s agency and grimly sets himself up to defend his idea against a man that’s plenty smart enough to poke every imaginable hole in it. If anything, Sir Nighteye might have a better one.

Chapter End Notes

Sweet, I finally get to add that secondary couple.

Chapter 36

Chapter Notes

> Have some fluff, you know, as a treat. Before I emotionally destroy you again. SOMETIMES I CAN BE NICE TO CHARACTERS! Just... sometimes. I try not to make a habit of it.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

January

When Shouta agreed to visit the shrine with him, Hizashi saw a golden opportunity. He'd spent all week getting ready for this, using the fact that he had only one apprentice student that needed specialty training to prepare the perfect day. His apartment has been deep cleaned, he's got a killer menu planned for lunch (after getting some help from Nemuri, who was filled with the strangest glee) that both Shouta and Eri are sure to enjoy, games for Eri to get into the spirit, and a nice area set up on his balcony for if they decide they want to watch the sun come up. It won't be the *first* sunrise of the year, having happened this morning, but it could be *their* first.

He's getting ahead of himself, but it's hard not to. He's jittery with nerves and expectations and possibilities. If he can manage to keep Shouta from noticing anything's off, it'll be a miracle. This isn't a date, it's an outing amongst friends, but he can at least showcase what it *could* be next time, right? His heart keeps racing when he thinks about it.

You like guys?

The conversation has echoed in his mind all week, the bewildered look on Shouta's face burned in for perpetuity. A look that had a strange, very encouraging amount of *intensity* behind it. Shouta has no idea how expressive he can be when someone knows what to look for and Hizashi has made a study of that since they were teenagers and he decided the quiet kid in the corner was prime real estate for friendship. He doesn't always understand *what* Shouta's feeling of course, but he can usually tell if there's something more to his stony silences or focused stares.

Hizashi still can't believe Shouta thought that he, of all people, was *straight*. He definitely remembers bringing boyfriends around him before, but maybe they'd been too subtle for someone like Shouta to take notice. Expecting the women Hizashi brought around to be paramours was probably an acceptable assumption, but automatically assuming the same of the men without more obvious signs might have just been impossible with their heteronormative society. Makes him wonder what else Shouta thinks of him that's utterly wrong. But, then, Hizashi hadn't thought Shouta could be interested in *anyone* since he's

never dated and now he's pretty sure he has a chance. There could be plenty of things Hizashi has gotten wrong over the years. He's definitely game to find out if Shouta will let him.

As friends?

It is. What I want.

It *wasn't* what Shouta wanted, solid 100% sure. He just doesn't know what Shouta *would* want. A platonic partner for harmless skinship, a boyfriend to romance him, a *sex*friend to take off the edge? Does Shouta even know?

To be honest, Hizashi isn't even sure if Shouta is a *virgin* or not. They've never talked about sex in their long friendship, a boundary Shouta hadn't expressly set in place but that Hizashi knew to respect even when they were students. Watching Shouta's disinterest and downright discomfort with "locker room talk", especially after Oboro died, made it clear he needed that boundary and Hizashi is nothing if not flexible in his friendships. Even Nemuri barely teases him like that and never for long.

It still makes him giddy thinking they could be more. That his little on-again, off-again crush might become something after all. He'd be thrilled with just holding Shouta's hand if he is as aspec as he's always seemed. Fuck, he's got to reel this in before Shouta and Eri arrive so he doesn't embarrass himself by doing something stupid, like blurting out how *special* Shouta is to him.

Hizashi slaps his hands against his cheeks, squares his shoulders, and gets to cooking.

Hours later, after his veritable feast is laid out and ready to go, impressive if he does say so himself, Hizashi cheerfully welcomes Shouta and Eri into his apartment. Hizashi dutifully takes Eri's thick winter coat and then gasps dramatically at what he finds under it.

Where Shouta found the dress Eri's in Hizashi has no idea but he's absolutely delighted. She looks like a princess in fluffy layers of pale blue that flounce around to her knees, white leggings under to keep her nice and warm. The last layer or two of the skirt are white and patterned with snowflakes, as is the bodice, making her look like a little ice princess. Even her hair is in a charming updo with a snowflake themed hairpin. That can't have been Shouta's doing so he wonders if maybe Nemuri came by to help get ready.

Hizashi just about *dies* at the cuteness either way. "What a pretty princess that's graced me with her presence!!"

Eri ducks her head, her cheeks burning bright pink, but she seems pleased as she toddles her way into the apartment. Hizashi offers Shouta a bright look that's reciprocated with a serious nod. Shouta hadn't done much more than throw a coat over his usual clothes, but that's fine. It's special enough that they're all here together. Practically beaming, Hizashi shuffles them both towards the table.

"I didn't know what all you might have tried before," Hizashi says as he helps Eri into her chair, "so I just made anything I could think of. It'll be great leftovers later!"

He… definitely went overboard. But Eri looks mesmerized by the osechi he put together, stuffed with as many different things as he could think of that a little girl might not have encountered but would probably like. Her eyes jump from one compartment to the next with interest and only a little trepidation. Only about half of them are *traditional* parts of an osechi spread, but Hizashi's pretty sure Eri will like what he's prepared better anyway. Along with the more traditional New Year's fare, he'd also prepared a few more everyday things just in case she likes none of the rest. Some of the dishes are definitely for Shouta's benefit, favorites he's observed over the years. Hizashi is totally *not* showing off the perks of possibly dating him, absolutely not.

"You didn't have to go this far," Shouta mutters under his breath, shooting Hizashi a very pointed look, but Hizashi just grins wider.

"Yes I did."

Lunch ends up being a pretty entertaining affair. Eri's hesitant and careful but it seems like a fire's been lit under her as she stubbornly tries everything a little at a time. It's easy to tell what she likes and what doesn't sit well with her, even if she doesn't outright say so. Watching her nose scrunch up at the kazunoko makes it impossible for him not to laugh, but he smoothes it over by offering a little more of the datemaki that had her eyes shining earlier. Shouta seems pleased enough with the spread or at least with how much of it Eri actually eats. Considering how he's complained about feeding her, Hizashi counts it as a win.

And it's just nice, observing the two. Maybe Shouta won't outright say Eri's his kid but it's pretty obvious to Hizashi. If Shouta doesn't end up formally adopting her once the court proceedings against the living members of the Shie Hassaikai are over, Hizashi will eat his shoes.

When they've finished eating way more than any of them intended, Hizashi waves his guests over to the little living room where he'd set up a few fun games. He listens as Shouta explains them and eases Eri into playing while Hizashi packs up the leftover food for the fridge. (He's going to be eating leftovers for the next week but Eri's bravery made it so worth it!) A few of the favorites he puts together into a container for Shouta to take back with them later.

The three of them spend a couple hours teaching Eri to play the new games and enjoying themselves. It's the most relaxed Hizashi has felt in years and he's pretty sure Shouta is pleased as well. His smiles are a little softer at the edges and more numerous, especially every time Eri sneaks a victory. She's getting more confident as the days pass and it's been wonderful to watch. Sometimes, she even smiles back at Hizashi, too.

He'd timed things so that when they get to the shrine, it's not as crowded. There are still more people than Eri is used to and Shouta lets her hide her face against his neck as he carries her through the crowd with Hizashi dutifully clearing the way in front. It feels… good, not doing this alone. Hizashi only keeps in the habit because it *is* habit, but when his parents were still alive, he can remember looking forward to this visit. Doing it *alone* tends to be filled more with memories and bittersweet longing. He still would, of course. He thinks his parents would want him to.

It's a lot better with Shouta and Eri, and Hizashi finds himself hoping they'll come with him again next year.

The actual praying doesn't take long. Shouta quietly explains what they're doing and why as he helps Eri through it. She's determined to do everything right, like normal people do, because she's a normal person now, and Hizashi's heart just about bursts. He takes a stealthy picture with his phone to commemorate the moment. Once they're done, she's right back in Shouta's arms and they move aside for the next group.

Eri starts peeking up around Shouta's shoulder and gets curious about the omikuji so many people are holding. They take her over to get one and then draw their own because she'd be self conscious if she was the only one, right? Without even reading it, Hizashi's sure Shouta got some terrible luck given the scowl on his face and barely keeps from laughing at him. Instead, he takes Eri's slip and reads out the fortune (chūkichi, a middle blessing, just what she needs) before explaining the kanji to her. Eri's definitely behind in learning them and they might as well take the opportunity to teach while she's so invested. He shows her his own (a simple kichi which he'll definitely take over bad luck anyday) and they badger Shouta into showing his (Hizashi was right, it's the worst possible choice and he doesn't feel bad about teasing Shouta about it.)

Tying her omikuji to the shrine's designated tree is something Eri's reluctant to do and she grips the strip with uneasy possessiveness until after Hizashi and Shouta have tied theirs. With a little coaxing reassurance and prompting to make a wish, Eri ties hers as well.

The three of them linger for a while, letting Eri watch others go through the same process and looking over good luck charms for sale. She worries about Shouta's bad luck and Hizashi lets her pick out a charm for him, much to Shouta's chagrin. He still takes it though and that makes Eri smile soft and secret into his shoulder.

Hizashi gets another secret picture of that, too.

They return to his apartment after that. Eri's snoozing in Shouta's arms, tired from her exciting day with so many new experiences, and for a moment Hizashi pretends this is a normal sight. That there's nothing abnormal about seeing Shouta and his not-quite-daughter (yet) relaxing on his couch as Hizashi makes coffee. He pretends he can have this and feels greedy.

As friends? rings teasingly in his ears. He doesn't let himself outwardly react to it as he carries two mugs into the living room. Shouta accepts his gratefully, having missed most of his normal naps that day, and Hizashi settles in next to him, maybe a little closer than usual. If Shouta minds, he doesn't mention it.

"Thank you," is what he says instead, staring at his coffee. "For today."

"Of course! Eri's first New Years in freedom needed to be a perfect day. She deserves that."

Hizashi sneaks a glance over and finds Shouta's gaze locked on him. He stiffens with surprise but doesn't look away.

“For me, too,” Shouta says with a strange sort of intensity that sends a shiver down Hizashi’s spine. “Thanks.”

“O-oh. Yeah, sure. Anytime,” Hizashi manages to babble out.

With a slight nod, Shouta looks back at his mug and the moment breaks back into something more normal.

Shouta and Eri don’t end up staying the night to watch the sun rise, but that’s all right. Hizashi sits on his balcony the next morning and feels the first rays of warmth on his face. He stays there until his need for breakfast overcomes his sentimentality and then goes inside, but not without telling the morning, “Happy New Years, Shouta.”

The soft feeling in his chest is new. He thinks he likes it.

It’s never been all of them at once. They’ve done missions in twos and threes, but now the entire main crew are at Dabi’s side because it’s time. It’s finally time to start what he’s been craving and begging for.

Yesterday, most of them took on Re-Destro. It was an easier kill than Dabi had expected. They took some injuries but they were minor and are barely felt today after using one of their healers’ services. Dabi’s ankle is sore, walking on it is more distracting than painful though, and nothing would keep him away from this mission.

Twice has been observing the security force around Endeavor for weeks now, studying their schedule and habits. That makes it easy for Kiddo to choose a time and place to strike and Dabi is so very *ready.*

“Steady,” Kiddo says under his breath, eyes locked on the heroes of the security force. There’s one great point of failure in their coverage and Dabi’s almost vibrating as the seconds pass by, as they wait for the hole in protection that will let him take the first step in his revenge.

He’s going to take everything from that son of a bitch one piece at a time. Knowing there’s an active investigation into his family life already is just the beginning.

“Twice,” Kiddo says and the man moves at once. A dozen copies of various crew members spread out from him to litter the ground outside the Todoroki estate and move in a coordinated effort to overwhelm the security force at its weakest, right after the night/morning change out leaves them at their lowest number of protectors.

“Spinner,” Kiddo says and he drops to race through the chaos towards the front gate. A second later, it explodes in a flurry of splinters against Spinner’s ridiculous sword that doesn’t seem quite as ridiculous now. There’s a snarl of indignant anger and Spinner narrowly dodges a ball of flames aimed for his head.

Dabi doesn’t need to hear Kiddo to know it’s finally time. He’s on the ground and running for the busted gate with Toga and Hawks flanking him. When Endeavor steps into the space his

gate used to stand at, Dabi sees his eyes widen with surprise, likely due to Hawks' presence. It makes him want to tear those eyes out of his skull.

Surprise gives way to anger and doesn't in any way slow Endeavor's reaction as Dabi starts the attack by sending out a roaring wall of blue flames. Endeavor busts through it with little trouble but then has to immediately dodge around a feather sword as Hawks rushes past them to engage.

Dabi will give him this. Hawks isn't the number two hero for nothing, but there's a reason Endeavor's higher ranked and it's not just popularity.

Toga darts past Dabi to run distraction against Endeavor as Hawks knocks him back into the estate's front courtyard. Spinner's joined Twice in keeping the security force in check which leaves Dabi free to do whatever the fuck he wants. He makes his leisurely way past the gate to where Hawks and Toga are tag teaming Endeavor's attention. He's showing remarkable restraint but Dabi guesses he just doesn't want to burn his own house down.

"I'll burn it for you," Dabi mutters to himself. He knows none of his siblings are home right now. No further human collateral damage. His fingers curl into fists and he sees the blue glare of his flames light up against the stone walkway. Watching Hawks drive Endeavor back after he's knocked Toga several yards away, Dabi sees his opening and charges in with a savage grin and death on his mind.

Blue eyes that match his own dart over to meet Dabi's gaze before Endeavor gets a lucky break and catches the scruff of Hawks' jacket. He jerks Hawks hard enough into the wall next to the front doors that Hawks' body breaks through layers of plaster and wood. He's still turning with the momentum so by the time Dabi gets there a second later, he's already brought up his other arm to knock away Dabi's blast.

Undeterred, Dabi presses the attack just like Endeavor taught him so long ago. He dodges under and around fire covered fists, keeps in close so his enemy can't make use of his mid or long range attacks, forces Endeavor to choose between taking hits and burning down his house. It won't be long before that particular choice tips in the other direction.

There's a moment as Endeavor falters, when his eyes widen and his breath catches, and Dabi thinks somehow he *knows*. His fire hadn't been blue then, hadn't burned so hot, and Dabi knows that's exactly what Endeavor's thinking to convince himself that Dabi isn't a mirage of the son he lost. The son he abused and threw away.

No matter how hard he'd been trained once, how good he is now, Dabi's body can't hold up to a prolonged attack like this. He's covered in sweat, head starting to ache fiercely as the heat pushes him past his limits. Whether Endeavor's fire or his own, he's cooking in his own defective skin.

Dabi's vision swims for a second and then he takes a solid hit to the chest that knocks him half way back across the courtyard. He rolls to his feet as red flashes past him and Hawks is back in the frey after who knows how many minutes he'd been either unconscious or dazed. There's a definite shift in his fighting style that suggests injury but Dabi just uses the time to catch a breath and drop as much heat as he can. His coat is half destroyed anyway so he sheds

it as he pants. That won't be enough, he's already overtaxed himself, but like fuck is he going to drop out of this fight. Not when he's waited so goddamn long for it.

When Toga goes down with a pained scream, Dabi's feet move before he can think. He's got her in his arms and carted outside the wall in what feels like seconds, and then he's racing right back in to use an opening Hawks makes for him and blast Endeavor with everything he has. He's never measured just how hot his flames get but he knows it's in the thousands of degrees and that's what flows as his fingers press over most of Endeavor's face.

He doesn't register the smell of burning flesh and hair, barely notices feathers hooking in his shirt to haul him out of the way as fire *explodes* off Endeavor's entire body. It's not enough and Dabi's caught in the blast. He hits the ground, body rolling across the stone walkway and into grass that scrapes harshly across burned skin he actually still has feeling in. Then a large fist is slamming into his chest, smashing him against the ground and not just knocking the wind out of him but crushing his ribs, breaking his body down, *killing him all over again*.

Dabi's wide eyes meet Endeavor's, identical blues of two very different men who should never have met this way. Endeavor hits him again, breaks him further, and then draws his fist back ready for the kill strike Dabi was once trained to make. It's over. His pitiful resistance isn't enough. Dabi stares into his father's burned, enraged face and knows he's going to die-

Black and bright green falls from overhead as a body hits Endeavor's back, stabbing down into his shoulder blades. Endeavor rears up to knock him off, but Dabi notices the moment his flames suddenly disappear. Watching him turn, Dabi sees the red remnants of two quirk destroying bullets smashed against Endeavor's back. Endeavor reaches out for one of his usual fireballs but nothing comes.

Endeavor's been gelded, the quirk he so cherished and abused permanently locked away. Dabi wishes he could see his face.

He floats a bit after that, consciousness swimming so that moments flash in and out of his reckoning. He's not fully there when Kiddo kneels over his body and yells unintelligible words at his face, nor a second later when suddenly he's been thrown over Twice's back to go… somewhere else. A blink and he's being laid down, there are more voices that make no sense, and everything hurts so very much.

Dabi sees Kiddo's face again, thinks he feels pressure on one of his hands, and then lets the darkness take him.

Surprisingly enough, the break Mirai needed to locate a tighter area for the location of Kiddo's HQ is another kidnapping of Recovery Girl, which he'd been unhappy to find out had become a regular occurrence. They hadn't exactly been tracking her but follow a nondescript car through the eerily quiet abandoned office park after spotting one of Kiddo's known crew members escorting her into the car.

Half the buildings here have been condemned but Mirai knows they're populated. Homeless squatters, drug dealers, and various villains likely make their homes here or at least use it for business. There'd been an earthquake a while back that damaged enough of the local

infrastructure to move everyone out, but getting the government funds to fix it all has been an on and off concern that's more often than not off as other issues took precedence.

Mirai isn't here to complain about government spending and apathy. He's here to follow the car and get as close to the crew's HQ as he can before the distraction quirk redirects his attention. In the passenger seat, Mirio's just as focused but Bakugou in the backseat stays annoyed as he watches the scenery pass. They get quite a bit closer before Mirai forgets what he's supposed to be there for. He stops the car and gets out, glancing around as Mirio does the same. They meet each others' eyes but Mirai sees the same confusion in Mirio's as he feels.

"Sir, look over there," Mirio says and Mirai starts to when he pauses and frowns and then checks his watch. Something is written on the underside of his arm- Oh. Mirai frowns, annoyed that his attention keeps trying to sway elsewhere.

What an aggravating quirk. Effective and useful but aggravating.

"What the hell is wrong with you?" Bakugou asks, squinting at both of them as he gets out as well. "*That's* where we're going."

He points at a building a little way off that Mirai finds so uninteresting he wonders why anyone would want to go there when there's so much else- He clenches his jaw and turns to Bakugou. Unaffected? Then he must be authorized, someone given clemency against the distraction quirk. That makes sense, knowing his connection to the villain Kiddo. It's an unexpected boon but one he'll absolutely use.

"There's a quirk active in this area that makes it difficult to focus," Mirai says, keeping his eyes on Bakugou because it keeps him in the moment. "You appear to have been marked as an authorized visitor, like Kiddo's associates. We do not have that luxury."

Mirio looks back at them, blinking as he comes back to their purpose here. He doesn't try to look at the building, doing the same as Mirai in focusing on Bakugou.

"We may be able to follow you to the building," Mirai continues and sees as Bakugou catches on.

"Fine. I'll take vanguard," Bakugou says as he straightens up and then turns, heading for the right building. Even now, Mirai has to work at concentrating on following Bakugou rather than actually getting to their destination or his attention wanders. He has to pull Mirio with them as Mirio gets distracted twice as much. He's still young, Mirai doesn't hold it against him.

He feels it, the moment they get through the field of the quirk. He feels it in the way he doesn't have to fight to keep his eyes on Bakugou, how he's able to take in more than just the boy without needing to follow whatever else has entered into his attention. Letting go of Mirio, he takes the opportunity granted to him to get a better look at the building, makes a mental note of the number on the half broken front door, of the street they're on. He'll cross reference it later to get more information.

Before he manages to say anything further though, the front door is pushed open and Kiddo himself steps outside of the safety of his HQ. The way his eyes immediately fall on the three of them, it's clear he came out to meet them purposefully.

"Why the fuck did you bring him here?" Kiddo asks, glaring at Mirai with tired, oh so tired eyes. He looks like he hasn't slept in weeks, his skin bruised purple under his reddened eyes and face pale. The costume he's wearing makes it impossible to tell what condition his body might be in but Mirai's more drawn to the blood splashed and smeared across the front of it. No rips, it had come from a victim or multiple victims. The hood is hanging back, leaving Kiddo's messy curls free, and his mask sits along his collarbone like a second mouth. There's blood on it as well, still runny and red. Fresh then. *Very* fresh.

"He seemed the best way to get your attention," Mirai says because there's no question as to which of them Kiddo is referring, stepping forward to put Bakugou and Mirio behind him as he motions for them to be silent.

"Now isn't a good time."

"Now may be the *only* time." They'd taken the effort to kidnap a powerful healer, likely some of that blood is from one of his followers if not all of it. That doesn't mean Mirai can give up this chance to get some - *any* - information about his next moves.

Kiddo grits his teeth. His eyes dart around Mirai, likely to Bakugou and Mirio, then back to him. "Fine. But you stay over there. Don't take another step. Don't try to touch me. That won't end well for you."

That has Mirai narrowing his eyes. With as detailed and varied as Kiddo's information about heroes is, he can't discount that Kiddo knows his quirk and what it can do. Is the warning meant to be the danger of Kiddo attacking him or perhaps what he might see if he does look into his future. Either way, he'll have to take that chance if he's able to close the distance.

"You've been busy building your empire," Mirai begins and Kiddo just keeps glaring at him. There's a minute trembling to his fingers hanging at his sides. Exhaustion? Likely. If he's not sleeping, it's probably the least of his worries.

"The best way to make the underground safe is to be the guy on top," Kiddo says. It doesn't sound like the truth. It sounds like a rote response.

"Is that what you're working towards? Being the 'guy on top'?"

"No one makes a move without me authorizing it. No one starts shit without knowing I'll put it down with prejudice if I don't like it. No one endangers my-" A wince, a hiss of annoyance, then, "No one breaks my rules."

Mirai considers that. Kiddo's young in body but the time loop situation, whatever explanation behind it is the truth, would account for either mental aging far past that or at least the feeling of it. The strain is starting to be impossible to ignore. Anyone pushed hard enough will snap. It's just a matter of whether they hurt themselves or others when it happens.

He doubts Kiddo will be constrained to only hurting himself.

“What fucking rules?” Bakugou asks, his patience running out. “So what, you’re making yourself some kind of king?”

Kiddo flinches, barely noticeable. “It’ll keep you safe-”

“Did I ask you to do that, you damn nerd?!” Dodging under Mirai’s hand when he pushes past him, Bakugou storms up to Kiddo and makes the villain take a step back as he gets up in his face. “I don’t want your protection!”

From behind him, Mirai hears Mirio cuss under his breath. He glances back to his intern and twists his fingers into a few signs. Mirio stiffens as he catches on, expression going grim. Disagreeing with him or just uneasy about going against Kiddo? Mirai knows Mirio had been getting close to him when he was UA. Still, whatever his misgivings, Mirio nods and then starts towards Bakugou and Kiddo where Bakugou is doing an excellent job at distracting the villain by berating him. He’s been the only real weakness Kiddo has to exploit.

When Mirio comes up to Kiddo’s side, the strain on Kiddo’s face gets worse as he’s caught between Bakugou’s annoyance and Mirio’s more gentler approach. It likely wouldn’t be enough on a normal day, but right now… It’s exactly what Mirai needs to make his silent approach. He’s all the way behind Mirio when Kiddo spots him. Green eyes go wide, almost *frightened*, before he opens his mouth to say, “No, *don’t-”*

Mirai’s fingers make contact and then his world devolves into pain and confusion. He doesn’t get the download of a day’s worth of experience like usual. Instead, he’s inundated with countless options that stream at him all at once. Every single action, every single word seems to branch off into its own line of possibilities that branch further off into infinity.

He’s overwhelmed before he even realizes what’s happening and there’s nothing he can do about it. It’s like entire books of a single day in millions of people’s lives have been crammed into his head all at once and there’s no hope of sorting through any of it. There’s no hope of knowing for certain what’s actually useful and he wouldn’t be able to retain it anyway. It’s been years since Mirai overloaded his quirk but he recognizes the tremendous pain streaking through his skull and it’s so much worse than ever before, so much worse than he thought possible. It won’t just end in a month-long migraine like when he’d searched far into Toshinori’s future.

Oh, he thinks to himself above the noise and confusion of an infinitely known and unknowable future. *That’s what Kiddo meant.*

And then his mind starts to collapse so his body shuts down against his will to prevent disaster.

Chapter End Notes

Is there a common tag about Endeavor revenge...? I won't use it to preserve the surprise satisfaction, but still I wonder.

Chapter 37

Chapter Notes

Warning for an oblique passive suicide reference.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

There are a lot of things Keigo didn't think he'd ever do. Joining a villain organization is definitely up there but he knows himself and his own gray morality, there was always a possibility. Something he hadn't expected though was forcibly ruining the career of someone he'd looked up to.

Keigo's not stupid. He knows Endeavor is and always was an asshole, but there's still something about him that Keigo has never been able to look away from. So knowing he'd been instrumental in taking Endeavor down? Yeah. He hadn't expected that. He doesn't regret it, though. One look at a closed door, behind which Recover Girl and three other healers are doing their best to keep Dabi alive, and he can't regret it. No matter what else Kiddo and the rest decide to do with him, Endeavor will never be a hero again.

Spinner drops down to sit next to him, startling Keigo out of his thoughts. "Here."

The cup ramen probably only cost *maybe* 100 yen but he's noticed Spinner's the type to scrimp and save and make every yen count so there's meaning in him choosing to share his stash. Keigo's just not sure what that meaning is. He still takes the cup and lets it warm his chilled fingers.

"So I guess you've hit your point of no return," Spinner says and… Well. He's probably right.

"Guess so."

"It hasn't hit the news yet, but give it a couple hours."

His hero license might not have been revoked before since there was the illusion of him infiltrating under HPSC orders, but there's no way it hasn't been now. Which means everything he's worked for in his life, all the things he's endured, have been rendered moot.

Keigo stares harder at the door and doesn't let himself think about whether it was worth it.

"Sometimes," Spinner says, relaxing into the couch a bit more, "I think about what it might have been like if I'd gotten into that hero school."

Blinking, Keigo finally looks away from the door to stare at him. "*You* wanted to be a hero?"

“Doesn’t every kid?” He shrugs a little as if he hadn’t just blushed. “I mean. I figured more heteromorph heroes might help with… Well. You know.”

Maybe Keigo knows *vaguely* about the discrimination heteromorph quirks get, but it’s not like he really understands it. Not the way Spinner has had to all his life.

“I worked a whole summer once as a kid just to get a Gang Orca hoodie,” Spinner admits and then covers his face as he groans with embarrassment. “If you ever tell anyone else, I’ll hit you.”

Keigo snorts and finally starts eating his noodles.

“But that didn’t happen, obviously.” Spinner waves a hand dismissively, the other still covering half his face. “I wonder sometimes though. If I might have been able to change things from the inside.”

“It’s possible but not probable.”

Keigo might have been a very well trained pet of the HPSC, but that doesn’t mean he ignored the less heroic things going on in the organization or hero world in general. Hell, he *perpetrated* some of it. What else could state sanctioned assassination be other than villainous? The ends don’t always justify the means.

That’s something he’s having to grapple with following Kiddo, too, because Kiddo doesn’t give a shit about what he has to do to reach his goal.

Speaking of Kiddo, the boy himself comes storming back in after only having been gone for maybe a quarter hour and with him-

“Is that *Sir Nighteye?!*” Spinner shrieks.

Behind Kiddo, the hero is hanging limply between Bakugou and Togata. None of them react to Spinner’s panic, instead concentrating on getting Sir Nighteye situated on an uninhabited couch. There’s blood on his face, leaking freely from his nose and the corners of his eyes and- and his ears? Keigo gets up to get a better look.

“What the hell did you hit him with?” he asks and Kiddo gives him a strained look.

“His own quirk,” he says, which explains nothing- Oh. Or maybe it did. Oh wow, Keigo hadn’t even imagined what kind of clusterfuck Kiddo’s future must be.

Togata starts wiping Sir Nighteye’s face clean with a handkerchief but Bakugou steps back once he’s been relieved of his burden and is instead staring at Keigo with an unreadable look on his face. Well, shit. Keigo guesses maybe he’s going to have to deal with backlash about his turn to villainy faster than he thought.

“Are there any healers we haven’t called yet?” Kiddo asks.

“There’s one that didn’t respond earlier,” Spinner says. “I’ll try her again.”

“If she doesn’t answer, find someone else to kidnap. I don’t know how much exactly damage he’s done to himself-”

Bakugou makes an offended noise. “He’s a *hero,* you idiots! Just take him to a hospital. They’ll pull out all the stops. ”

They all pause and Kiddo, somehow, doesn’t manage to look as embarrassed as Keigo, who really should have thought of that first.

“Toga,” Kiddo calls and she steps out from where she’s been hanging in the entrance to a hallway just watching them. “Did you ever get a license?”

She blinks, pointing to herself like she’s not sure he actually means her. “I- no? I think Jin’s the only one of us that can drive. Other than Hawks.”

And he *definitely* can’t go. Keigo’s way too recognizable. Signing a little, Kiddo pinches the bridge of his nose.

“Okay. Wake Twice up. He can crash again once Sir Nighteye’s been dropped off somewhere safe for the heroes to pick up.”

As if Twice hadn’t already pushed himself to the limit in the attack on Endeavor and then fetched Recovery Girl anyway because he’s got the best rapport with her. If Toga manages to wake him, Keigo’s sure he’ll be down again for a while after handling this. Hopefully, they won’t need his quirk for at least a couple days.

Togata gets up, turning to face them with a serious expression that looks wrong on his usually cheery face.

“It’s okay, Midoriya. I can drive,” he says. “Sir’s been teaching me. I can get him to the hospital.”

Which doesn’t mean he’s licensed yet, but that’s a lot less of a concern. Kiddo considers that, glancing down at the unconscious hero and then back to his student. If Kiddo were really as much of a pragmatist as he thinks he is, he’d kill both of them here rather than risk Togata being able to find his way back again.

Thankfully, he isn’t.

“Are they gonna still be affected by that fucking distraction quirk?” Bakugou asks and that’s a good question. The only one of them who knows how it works is Kiddo. No one else has contact with whoever’s controlling it, Keigo just one day stopped being affected.

“They won’t be authorized,” Kiddo answers and then looks back to Toga. “Ride shotgun. Once they’re through it, let them leave.”

Toga gives him a messy salute. She’s seemed better since Kiddo came back, more stable and cheerful even if he’s gotten more distant.

Keigo ends up being the one to retrieve Sir Nighteye's car and bring it in closer, then he helps Spinner haul Sir Nighteye back out again. It's a hassle getting him into the backseat with all those long, gangly limbs, but they manage. Then Togata and Toga slide in after and head off with him.

"Do you think he'll be okay?" Keigo doesn't mean to ask.

"Yeah," Kiddo says, eyes on the car slowly disappearing ahead of them. "He'll probably be awake by tomorrow or the next day."

"So it's happened before?"

A sigh and Kiddo closes his eyes. "Yeah."

Keigo's own reflexively narrow. That was a very *loaded* 'yeah'. "So what's the catch?"

"He…" Kiddo shakes his head and turns back to their front door. "Don't worry about it. He'll be fine in a couple months."

A couple *months?* Just how badly had Sir Nighteye fucked himself over trying to read Kiddo's future?! But Keigo knows from experience that when Kiddo decides not to talk, he won't change his mind.

"...What are you going to do about Bakugou?" he asks instead of trying because Bakugou's still inside where he'd refused to leave with Togata.

"I have half a mind to stick him in a fucking *vault* for the next four months," Kiddo mutters bitterly.

That'd be a sight to see.

"Since I'm obviously *not* doing that, I guess we'll clear an office for him and have Giran source another camp bed."

"Seems reasonable," Keigo says even though it isn't. They're surely going to get blamed for Bakugou's kidnapping but what's one more strike against their record?

Kiddo's still staring at the door and making no move to go back in. Taking the cue from him, Keigo doesn't either. Maybe Kiddo wants to talk? That would probably be a good thing, actually. Even if it should really be either Toga or Dabi here instead of him. Keigo's kind of shit at this kind of thing.

"Why does he keep…" Kiddo trails off and glares at the door, his hands twitching at his sides. "*Fuck*."

Keigo snorts and gets a dirty look for it. "Hey, no worries, I'm on your side. I don't want Bakugou here either. He's got a promising career ahead of him, wouldn't want to jeopardize it any more than it already has been by his own behavior."

"...Yeah." As if that's what Kiddo's actually worried about. He looks back at the door. "I don't know how to shake him."

"Are you actually trying that hard?" comes out of Keigo's mouth before he can stop it.

Kiddo stiffens. There's a few seconds of silence and then he doesn't exactly relax so much as just… give up.

"No," he says miserably. "I need to, though. It's dangerous for him to be near me while I'm taking care of threats against him."

"You know…" Keigo scratches his cheek, considering how best to put this. "Maybe it's okay to let him stay for now."

"*What*." Oh, that is not a good tone. That is a stabby tone.

"Hear me out. There was a death flag right before New Years, right?" It takes a moment but then Kiddo nods and doesn't try to stab him, so Keigo must be doing something right. "When's the next one?"

"We already prevented it. The MLA's been neutralized."

"And the one after that?"

Kiddo has to think about it for a moment. "Mid-February, if the Shigaraki nomu decants by then. Mid-March if there are complications."

"So, you've got at least a month to just not have to worry about him dying as far as you know, right? Why not enjoy his company for a while?"

He blinks, staring at Keigo like he's speaking a completely different language. "I… Is that… really okay…?"

There aren't many times Keigo sees the kid in Kiddo, by his own effort, but it's shining through as brightly as the sun now. All that uncertainty and uncomfortable need, a healthy dose of desperation under it all.

Maybe it's not exactly the best idea but… Keigo's been watching Kiddo be miserable for weeks. For *months*, honestly. Has he ever not been miserable since starting this loop? Why *not* give himself a little bit of happiness for a while? Something real and tangible instead of the fantasy that had pretty much broken him for a while. Keigo can't see this making anything else *worse*.

His only outward response is to shrug, but it seems to be enough. Kiddo stares another few seconds, eyes huge and vulnerable, then looks back at the door. Taking a deep breath, he finally steps forward and goes back inside. Keigo's under no illusions that he's actually *solved* anything but if his boss can unwind for a bit? Sure. He's for it.

He heads after Kiddo with that thought in the forefront of his mind.

This is probably the greatest medical victory of her life, and yet, Chiyo will probably never be able to admit to it. She waves off the other three healers Midoriya's people brought in to assist her and turns to her patient. At this point, whether he lives or not is entirely up to him.

She'd been surprised when Midoriya and the others dragged medical equipment into their makeshift clinic room. The equipment was random and haphazard but Chiyo mostly found what she needed to keep Dabi alive long enough for the other healers to arrive. Only one of them actually worked in the medical field legitimately, a nurse from a major hospital, and Chiyo's pretty sure she'd been brought in by force. That she worked just as hard to save Dabi's life is a testament to the calling she'd given herself to. It's a sentiment Chiyo wholeheartedly understands. The other two were backstreet butchers for the most part, but their quirks had been useful under Chiyo's careful direction.

And now she's alone and listening to this young man breathe because she'd pulled a damn miracle out of her ass. He shouldn't be alive and yet… Chiyo didn't ask what happened. She doesn't want to know. The news had only just started with a flash of Endeavor's face when Twice showed up at her door looking two steps from fainting. Considering the burns she'd seen on some of the others, there's no question that they were involved.

The less Chiyo knows, the better.

She looks down at Dabi's face and her belly churns. So young. All of Midoriya's crew are so young. Half of them are adults but…

At her age, most people seem young. There's a point when she sees them as adults but it's far later than any legal definition most of the time. This one is, in many ways, still a child. Reactive and twisted with pain, so stuck in the past that he can't grow… She's sure the others have similar stories. Just because she doesn't know their stories doesn't mean she can't recognize what it's done to them.

That absolutely doesn't justify whatever they've done that got Dabi so messed up. Now that she's relatively sure his heart will keep beating - and she will repeat that to herself as many times as she needs to forget how many times it had stopped - Chiyo leaves the makeshift clinic and goes into the main room. Three of the crew are there to greet her.

Toga looks up expectantly, slathered in a fresh coat of burn cream. Spinner's not burned but his bruises are deep and numerous. Hawks has probably lost enough feathers that he won't be flying for a bit and has nearly as much burn cream on him as Toga.

Oh yes. They were definitely involved in whatever's going in with Endeavor.

"He'll probably live," she says and some of the tension drains out of the room. "That doesn't mean he's going to be up for any of your normal shenanigans for a while, even if you kidnap me again to use my quirk, which he might not even survive anyway."

Only Spinner has the decency to look at least a little ashamed.

"We're mostly into recon at this point, right?" Hawks says with a sideways glance towards the wall where all their lists and maps are posted for anyone to see. Chiyo isn't sure if it's

hubris or just no one thinking it might be a bad idea.

She makes sure not to actually read any of it. Maybe over the serial kidnappings, she's gotten a little fond of them. Maybe it's just more plausible deniability.

"Where's your boss?" she asks. They look at one another with varying levels of discomfort. "Don't tell me he's already out again."

"You know how boys can be," Hawks says with a shrug.

"No, no, just…" Spinner waves a hand vaguely towards one of the hallway entrances. "He's…"

"He's hopefully getting laid," Toga finishes, bright and shining. "I think it'd be great for his mood!"

Chiyo rolls her eyes. Well. She supposes he's at that age, right? Absolutely nothing she wants to think about but also nothing she's stupid enough to think she can prevent. "Okay. Who's taking me home?"

"We're not waking Jin up again," Toga says with a frown.

Spinner glances at Hawks and then winces. "Uh. I guess me."

That doesn't sound like someone who's confident in their driving skills. She doesn't ask if he's got a license. If they crash, she can probably save their lives.

"Let's get going, then," Chiyo says as she heads out along a familiar path to leave. Spinner sighs but he follows her out to take her home.

Awkward does not begin to describe the feeling in this room. The amount of history currently trying its best to smash them into the stained and torn carpet seems almost to be alive itself, something that wants to bite and tear chunks out of them. It's probably the most uncomfortable Katsuki has been in a long time.

Across the room in a wobbling, dented chair, Deku's eyes haven't left him in… Fuck, how long have they been in here? Katsuki's skin prickles under his attention. Shifting back from the edge of the small camp bed he'd parked his ass on when Deku took the only other place to sit, Katsuki leans back on his hands and tries not to break first.

Deku hasn't said a word since Katsuki followed him in here and frankly, Katsuki doesn't know what to say either. When he looks at Deku, he gets vague flashbacks to the dream, to the life Deku apparently desperately wants more than anything else and that includes him. A life he's pretty sure he…

But for a little while, I just wanted to see you get everything you want.

He's not necessarily saying he doesn't want that. Some of it. Parts. Maybe.

“How did I die last time?” Katsuki asks so he doesn’t have to think about it.

He hears a soft, quick intake of breath, then, “Shigaraki’s nomu. Snapped your neck. It was quick.”

“Fucking mundane.” Hopefully, it was at least using some kind of strength quirk.

Deku’s quiet. The uncomfortable sensation of being watched just magnifies the longer silence stretches between them. It picks and needles at Katsuki’s self control like the most annoying insect. If Katsuki thought it would do anything, he’d beat the shit out of Deku and be done with it, but… It won’t do anything. It won’t even make him feel better.

I’ll wake up. I’ll give this up.

A hundred tiny moments flash through his mind, so many little ways he’s hurt this version of Deku compounding into a guilt Katsuki hasn’t decided to accept or not. He shouldn’t have to. It’s not as if Katsuki has been anyone except himself and if that’s the person Deku’s stupid enough to fall in love with, then he’ll have to deal with the consequences.

Knowing it’s Deku’s own fault doesn’t help him a goddamn bit though.

“How long would you have stayed in that dream?” he asks. His voice is quieter than he meant but fuck if he’s going to correct that now.

“I don’t know.”

Finally Katsuki can’t stand it anymore. He looks over, meets Deku’s dull green stare, and hates him just a little more for being this fucking defeated. How the hell does Deku think he’s going to win Katsuki’s heart if he isn’t willing to fight destiny for the chance?

Except he is, kind of. Trying to change what triggered the time loops. Trying to save him.

It doesn’t matter how long, it doesn’t matter. Nothing matters until I get it ***right-***

“This loop is already trashed,” Deku says and Katsuki stiffens as Deku’s gaze finally, blessedly slides off him to sit somewhere on the floor. Except it doesn’t really end the weight of Deku’s attention on him. “I could have stayed in there until someone put me out of my misery.”

“Why do you-”

“The loop went off the rails months ago because I fucked something up. All Might’s down. My mother will probably never fully recover. Shigaraki’s nomu is in the one place I can’t get to it, just waiting to decant… The only thing I managed to do right this time was getting Eri to Aizawa.”

It’s not even defeat anymore in Deku’s voice. It’s apathy.

“The hell you have,” Katsuki growls and Deku looks at him with vague surprise. “Aren’t you on a mission to save my life? Do I look fucking dead to you right now?”

Deku's stare grows more intense like he's grasping for any lead Katsuki can give him, any shred of hope he might impart. But Katsuki's not the kind of guy for hope. He'll *beat* his happy ending out of fate if it takes everything he's got.

Didn't Deku call him a *symbol of victory?*

"If you can't believe in yourself, believe in me," he says, getting up to approach Deku and loom over him. Caging Deku in his chair against the wall with his hands gripping the arm rests tight, blocking out everything else Deku could possibly look at. "I'm going to blast the shit out of that stupid nomu. I'm going to prove your stupid time loop destiny crap wrong and *survive*. Don't think for a fucking second you get to give up on me."

The way Deku's chest rises and falls in a quick, unsteady rhythm. The way that wet sheen in his stupid eyes gets even glossier. The way his hands twitch like they want to reach out, to touch him. All of it doesn't fucking matter if Deku's so far gone he can't see the Katsuki of this present standing before him instead of the ghosts of every other him that failed to stay alive.

"I'll save *myself*," he says and Deku swallows, unable to take his eyes off him.

Deku's mouth opens, closes. Opens again. And then he nods as his eyes overflow.

"Okay."

The expectation and pressure break. Katsuki doesn't move at first, still braced over Deku, still forcing him to confront what's real in front of him. It's easy to lean that last bit further and close his eyes as his mouth finds Deku's.

There were hundreds of kisses exchanged between them in the dream world and at the time, they'd felt so good and right and perfect, but this is better. The way Deku makes a sound like a sob, reaching up to cup his hands over Katsuki's cheeks. The way Katsuki slides to his knees between Deku's spread legs. The way the floor is hard under his legs and the air is cold and their angle is off due to their varying levels.

It's better because this is real and whether Katsuki loves Deku or might love him someday or never will, he's decided he wants *this* at least.

Deku's fingers slide back into Katsuki's hair as he pushes himself out of the chair to straddle Katsuki's lap and let himself get wrapped up in Katsuki's arms. His lips are an insistent pressure against Katsuki's and open easily to his urging. There's nothing special about the way Deku tastes or the soft noises that escape his throat as they take each other apart bit by bit, second by second, but it doesn't have to be. Katsuki will claim this for himself anyway.

"You don't get to lose faith in me," Katsuki says into the tiny space between them and feels the shiver run down Deku's back. "I'm not leaving you."

"Promise?" Tiny, weak, strained like he'd tried his best to hold it back and it escaped anyway.

Katsuki rests his forehead against Deku's and curls his fingers tight in the back of Deku's shirt.

"The fuck do you think," he says as the corners of Deku's mouth twitch up into a helpless sort of smile. And then Katsuki pulls him back in to kiss him again.

Chapter End Notes

See, I can write BKDK without it ending terribly.

Chapter 38

Chapter Notes

Sup y'all, I live

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Mirai opens his eyes and doesn't know where he is. There's an unfamiliar light fixture above him, unfamiliar sounds pinging repetitively in his ears, and unfamiliar scents assaulting his nose. He frowns, squinting at the blurry edges around everything- Oh. Someone must have removed his glasses.

His head hurts, a rhythmic pounding that makes it hard to think, hard to concentrate. There's something he needs to remember but he has no idea what it might be. He doesn't know why he's *here*.

And someone is breathing nearby.

He turns his head after noticing the slightly uneven cadence, something slightly congested but somehow familiar-

Emaciated body. Blond hair hanging scraggly and uneven. Deeply hollowed cheeks,wide mouth, and-

"All Might?" he asks. His voice is barely above a whisper and sounds hoarse.

"Ah… Good morning, Mirai," All Might says with an awkward smile. It's not familiar enough for Mirai to have seen it often. He can't remember if he's knows this form well. Probably not.

"What…"

"Don't worry, it's just quirk backlash. The confusion will fade."

Backlash… Yes, he thinks he remembers about that. Mirai frowns and reaches up to rub his aching head. His hand shakes, weakened by whatever he did to himself. Who did he try to read? What had he seen? It falls through his fingers like sand.

Mirai stares a little harder at All Might, sure there's something he's missing. Something he was supposed to tell him… His thoughts won't settle and make sense. It's terribly inconvenient.

"How long?" he asks and isn't sure what he's referring to.

“You were brought in two days ago,” All Might says. “It’s evening now. They weren’t sure if you’d wake today or tomorrow.”

Hm. Vexingly unspecific. He wonders how long All Might has been waiting with him. He wonders why it seems like it should be a surprise he’s here at all.

“The doctors think the confusion will lessen in a few days, maybe a week. Whatever you saw put a great amount of strain on your brain and body. It may be longer before you can use your quirk again.”

Which makes sense. Mirai thinks it does, anyway. It feels like it should.

“Do you remember any of it?”

Not as such. It’s… Mirai gets the impression he saw something unprecedented, something horrible and beautiful both, something that will shake him to the core once he can remember it all, much less understand it.

“Kiddo,” is what he says and then it takes him a few moments to figure out why. The important thing he saw has to do with Kiddo, right? It was… “Time loop?”

“Yes. He’s professed a belief that he’s stuck in one.”

“It’s true.” That Mirai knows to be right, even if he’s not sure why. When All Might draws in a sharp breath, Mirai glances back over at him. He can’t read his expression, too blurry and complicated, but then he’s having trouble concentrating on it at all.

“I see.” All Might offers him a weaker smile, looking away as he gets caught in his thoughts. Thoughts that likely make more sense than Mirai’s right now. “Thank you, old friend.”

Mirai makes some noise of acknowledgement and then he drifts back to sleep as All Might taps away frantically on his cell phone.

February

Things have been quiet, but they aren’t able to give Kiddo that long to rest. They still have plenty to do before the next conflict Kiddo’s predicted will happen. As Jin gathers the others to their main meeting spot in the headquarters, he suddenly pauses.

“Is Bakugou part of the group now?” he asks with a blink.

“Not if Kiddo has anything to say about it,” is Dabi’s easy answer, not even looking up at Twice from the map he’s perusing. His voice is just a little off, a little too slow from the painkillers. He’s only been walking again for a day and even then, he’s probably not going to be upright all that long. Coming back from the beating Endeavor gave him is lucky enough, they can’t really expect more than this right now.

The only bright side is that his quirk doesn’t seem to have been affected, except that it’s harder to control when he’s doped up like this. Thankfully, they don’t really need him to

control it when all he has to do is set a building on fire.

“So, should he be here for, you know, this?” It seemed like Kiddo was worried about tarnishing Bakugou’s reputation before, but maybe that’s changed? “The extra firepower could be useful!”

“Not with a recognizable quirk like that,” Spinner says. “Kiddo would never allow it.”

True. What a waste, but Jin’s months into vowing to follow Kiddo wherever he ends up leading, so if the boss says no, the answer is no. Shaking his head, Jin helps finish the setup. They haven’t waited long before Kiddo comes out to join them. He’s looking better, less ragged at the edges, less cold. Less like a corpse just going through the motions because it doesn’t know what else to do. Bakugou’s good for him. It’s too bad he can’t stay.

“I still think I should go with you,” Bakugou’s saying as he follows behind Kiddo.

“You’re not joining this one. You’re too recognizable.”

Spinner shoots Jin a smug look. Jin sticks his tongue out at him and then realizes Spinner can’t see it since he’s got his mask on. They turn back to watch the soap opera that is Kiddo’s boyfriend.

“So I don’t use the quirk and I cover my hair.”

“You aren’t used to fighting quirkless.”

“Fuck that, I’ll be fine.”

Kiddo gives Bakugou a narrow look. “*I* can’t have you there.”

Oh, Jin is not comfortable at all witnessing the way Bakugou’s expression softens just a little. It’s too intimate, too couple-y. He looks away and is glad his mask covers the flush he feels in his cheeks. Just because he supports his boss doesn’t mean he wants to see it. There’s being supportive and then there’s being an unwilling witness to schmoopy teenage makeouts.

“It’s not time yet, but just be patient,” Kiddo says and Bakugou just sighs.

“Fine.”

With a nod, Kiddo turns to Jin. “Follow us down. You’re driving him back to UA.”

Jin salutes him like a soldier and goes out to where the car is parked. He’s not surprised when he ends up walking past Kiddo and Bakugou to get it unlocked and started, nor when he glances up and finds them sucking face.

Get a room, guys!

Never in Jin’s life did he think he’d be privy to his boss’s love life, but here he is. Witnessing lovey moments he probably shouldn’t. Jin tugs off his mask and then fidgets with it while he waits. There’s kind of something inspirational about it, though. If someone as damaged and

cutthroat as Kiddo can find love, maybe there's a nice girl out there waiting for Jin, too. *He's gonna die alone.*

They break apart finally but exchange a few quiet words between them before Bakugou turns resolutely to the car. As they drive off, Jin sees Kiddo watching them until they're out of range.

The drive is quiet, kind of awkward. Jin taps on the steering wheel and doesn't let himself glance over to the teenager sitting next to him. Kiddo's lover only softens up for Kiddo, even if Jin kind of wishes he hadn't seen that. That's gotta be fate.

Surely fate can be nice to Jin as well. Probably not, but still a nice thought. Makes him all gooey inside thinking about someone to fawn over and give all the nice things to, anything she wants.

As they get within range of UA, Jin finds a spot to park so Bakugou can get out, but the kid doesn't open the door right off. He stares ahead, brows furrowed tight like he's thinking hard. What about? Jin has no idea but he's pretty sure it's about-

"Don't let him get hurt," Bakugou says. Bingo, right on the money.

"Kiddo's precious to us. We'll look after him."

With a huff, Bakugou flexes his fingers before balling up his fists. "Get him through this alive and whole, or I'll blow every one of you to fucking dust."

Is that the part of Bakugou that Kiddo likes? That confidence in his abilities Bakugou seems to be filled to the brim with? Probably, Jin's heard that folks like that in a partner.

"Trust me, if he gets hurt, it's because the rest of us are dead," Jin says. *Or because he betrayed us.*

He doesn't share the last part.

Bakugou gets out of the car and walks away without another word. Until he's safely through the gate to UA, Jin watches to make sure no other criminals take a shot at him. It's pretty well known that Bakugou is precious to Kiddo and he's got plenty of people in the criminal underground just salivating at the chance to take him down a peg if there's an opening. Only the way Kiddo made it *very* clear what will happen to anyone who crosses him has stayed their hands.

Jin stares at the UA gate for a little longer and then drives back to headquarters. They've got a raid to plan.

The Kiddo case just keeps getting messier and messier.

The more Naomasa looks into the claims against Endeavor, the harder the HPSC breathes down his neck trying to get him to drop it. Bad enough that one of their top ten heroes lost his quirk, seemingly permanently, but to have that same hero accused of child abuse? Their

media team has to be spitting blood at the very idea of that going public, which explains why they've been so aggravating.

Naomasa knows that the HPSC are important and do good work, but he *hates* dealing with them. Anything that might put them in a bad light becomes ten times harder to manage. If this abuse has been going on as long as he thinks it has, they've had to have worked overtime to cover it up because Endeavor is *not* a subtle man, and that'll be terrible press. Deservedly so.

Since the villain Dabi, Todoroki Touya, is involved in the Kiddo case, that means the abuse charges will be affected by it as well, which lands both cases on his lap to oversee. The attack on Endeavor is theorized to be revenge, leaving the number one hero powerless as Dabi might have felt before. Sympathies aside, it was still a crime, still went too far, still Naomasa's problem. Vigilantism is illegal for a reason.

It's enough to make a man rethink his life choices.

The quiet period seems to be over when it comes to Kiddo's crew movements. Bakugou Katsuki was returned to UA without explanation and the interview with him had been less than fruitful. Bakugou was uncooperative and cagey the whole time, but he hadn't lied when he said he didn't know the specifics of what Midoriya plans to do next. Midoriya had been careful to keep him out of the loop while they had him, likely knowing Naomasa would be involved in interviewing Bakugou after the fact.

Both Togata Mirio and Bakugou insisted that Bakugou's time there was voluntary but that he had not joined the crew. The problem is that when Naomasa asked that of Bakugou, his quirk had alerted to a half truth that left him in suspicion. He'd informed UA, who weren't entirely surprised, and they swore to report any suspicious behavior from either boy. At the least, Bakugou is confined to campus.

What little the police informants have been willing to share about Midoriya's plans has barely helped at all to predict what might happen next. Most of the underground are either terrified of Midoriya or too loyal to him to snitch, which is fairly impressive for anyone, much less a sixteen year old. Even Naomasa will admit to that. The last time he saw anything of the like was back when All For One was active. The similarities are daunting, especially knowing the familial connection between the two. For all that Midoriya seems disgusted with All For One, he's taken several of his lessons to heart.

The longer he goes without seeing Midoriya, the easier to see him as the villain he is rather than a *child*. Midoriya has proven time and again to be extremely efficient in getting what he wants done. His cause just makes him more likely to dismiss potential collateral damage. That explains why they've had three freak warehouse fires that burned hot enough to cremate most of the contents but left just enough to identify the remains of several dozen nomus. Damage to the surrounding buildings has been minimal so far, non-structural, but not absent. There's a lot of repairs to make.

Naomasa had hoped it wouldn't come to this, that they could make Midoriya see reason and cooperate alongside the police and heroes to ward off this terrible future he's so sure about… He should have known better.

He's contemplating another cup of coffee, grimly aware that he isn't going home anytime soon, when his phone rings. Lifting the receiver, he answers, "Detective Tsukauchi speaking."

"Hello Detective, this is Dr. Akai from Central Hospital."

Immediately, Naomasa straightens and starts dreading the worst. "Has something happened?"

"In a way. Some months ago, the villain Kurogiri was placed in our care," she starts, voice measured and calm. "Through his treatments, we determined his makeup is close enough to the nomus we've studied to declare him to be one, just a very specialized one. We were able to complete a DNA screening to determine who he was made from."

Oh, he is not going to like that. "Who is it?"

"Tests confirm that Kurogiri was once Shirakumo Oboro, a student at UA who perished during his work study. We believe his corpse was stolen soon after death for the purpose of forcibly mutating his quirk."

Naomasa drags a hand down his face. That case was one of the first hero deaths he'd had to contend with on the force. He hadn't seen the crushed remains of Shirakumo's body but those who had were quiet for months after. Seventeen, a great career just beginning, so much potential wiped out in a moment.

"You're sure?" he asks because he has to, even though his quirk detected no falsehood.

"We are. There were significant changes made to his body that affected his DNA and his quirk appears to have been merged with several others using Cloud as the base component, but enough was present to identify with certainty."

That just muddies things worse. Naomasa looks down at the files covering his desk around empty coffee cups.

"This news cannot spread," he says and Dr. Akai makes an affirmative sound. "Have you informed the HPSC?"

"Yes. They are considering removing him from this research facility back to a higher security location."

Of course they were. If word got out that someone out there can reanimate the dead and mutate their quirks, he can't even imagine the level of panic that would cause.

"Please keep me informed of their decision. I want to know the moment you receive the transfer order."

"Of course. I'll be in touch."

Naomasa hangs up and rubs the heels of his hands against his closed, aching eyes. What the hell is he supposed to say to Eraserhead and Present Mic?

Shouta didn't mean to be here and witness this, but when he'd noticed signs of odd movement in the area… Well. He's a hero first and foremost. Heroes that don't follow up on things like this are either shit at their job or turn up dead from surprise threats that get out of hand.

Creeping up on the warehouse is easy. Three people he suspects are guards have already been rendered unconscious outside. The windows along the bottom floor are blocked with paper taped to the glass, but the upper ones are clear. He climbs up so he can look inside and then his blood runs cold.

Before him are rows of clear containers large enough to hold several men, or one large being. Only a few are empty. The rest contain monstrously deformed bodies he recognizes through thick glass as probable nomus. No two of them are the same, all twisted and mutated in different ways, but all of them large and far too dangerous.

He's fairly sure these aren't just stored dead specimens and the idea of these things being turned against unsuspecting heroes or civilians makes his blood run cold. Small bubbles flutter up through the thick fluid the creatures are floating in and looking closer, he's fairly sure each of them are fitted with some kind of breathing apparatus customized to their particular shape. Here and there, he catches tiny, unconscious twitches. These things are all very much *alive.*

Movement through the containers has him shifting back to keep from being noticed, but he might as well not have. The person walking between the rows doesn't even look at the windows. Shouta waits until they're closer and almost sighs when he recognizes the sharp green and black costume of Kiddo. Of *course* Midoriya is caught up in all this.

Midoriya stops at a container near enough to the window that Shouta's able to see what he's doing. Clinically with motions that almost seem rote, Midoriya shuts down the container controls, turning off each function one by one. The bubbles stop, the light illuminating the fluid shuts off, and an alarm starts that Midoriya cuts off immediately. One by one, Midoriya ruthlessly leaves each nomu to suffocate or drown.

The thing is, Shouta isn't sure he'd do any differently. There's no sign that a nomu can be restored to the person they'd once been. Certainly none of them seem to be thinking anymore. This is probably the most humane way to deal with them, especially in such high numbers.

Shouta waits until Midoriya has moved on to further rows before he quietly breaks in through one of the more remote windows. He catches up to Midoriya quickly, watching him finish out the last of the nomu on this level. There seem to be three levels in all, the top two filled to the brim with the same containers. When Shouta glances down the open column in the center of the building, he freezes.

There are more nomu on the ground floor and *none* of them are in containers or restraints of any kind. They barely move, ignoring everything around them to simply stand closely in an unorganized herd. Their eyes focus on nothing, they make no sounds. A quick calculation of how many of them could be stuffed into a building this size only makes Shouta more tense.

Forcing himself to turn away from the sight, Shouta gets back to watching Midoriya. There's only one row of containers left on this floor and Midoriya doesn't hesitate to shut off what have to be life support systems for every one of them. When he finishes, he tugs out his phone and taps out a message, likely letting his team know he's completed his work. Midoriya slides the phone back into his uniform and then looks up straight at Shouta.

There's no surprise. Shouta wonders if they've met like this before.

"There aren't any humans in this building except us," Midoriya says. Whether he means only he and Shouta is debatable. "In twenty minutes, we're going to destroy it. You should leave."

Shouta glances to the shut down containers and their floating monstrosities. "How do you plan to handle the ones on the ground floor?"

"They won't run."

It's hard to imagine any living creature wouldn't try to save itself, but the nomu don't think and no one has witnessed any injury prevention action on their part. Their minimal brain activity seems entirely centered on maintaining bodily functions until they're ordered to do something. Even then, the orders likely have to be very simple.

"The other three warehouse fires. That was you," Shouta says, already certain.

"Yes."

"Are there more that you know of?"

"No. Not in storage."

Then there were probably more *out* of storage, Shouta figures. He purses his lips and looks back to Midoriya's face. Determined, unrelenting, unwilling to be persuaded. He's got more life to him than the last time Shouta saw him. Maybe the weeks Bakugou spent with the crew had done him well. Whether that's a good thing or not for heroes is debatable.

"What's your next play?" Shouta asks despite doubting he'll get any usable information. However, Midoriya studies him for several seconds like he's debating it anyway.

"The police didn't bother giving the other locations I told them about more than a cursory look, other than where the fight with All For One occurred," he says, shrugging his shoulder. "Like that's all that might be important to them. There's more cleanup before Shigaraki makes a move."

Shouta's eyes narrow as he considers that. Due to his injuries, he'd stayed largely uninvolved when that area was searched, but he knows there'd been quite a bit of worrying material found. If the other locations are similarly kitted out…

There'd be considerable resistance to anyone looking into the other sites if they're active. Midoriya's main team is fairly small with quirks that would leave them at a disadvantage against multitudes of nomus, but Shouta doubts that will stop them.

“You should turn yourself in,” Shouta says, meeting Midoriya’s unimpressed stare on even ground. “Even if it’s just to me. We have similar enough goals.”

Midoriya snorts. “You’ve given better speeches.”

“Figured honesty might work better.”

There’s a moment when it looks like Midoriya might be considering it, but that passes quickly.

“You should go. We’re going to start spreading the accelerants.”

He turns his back on Shouta as if to make it clear how little threat he feels from it. Were this anyone else, it might come across as arrogant or insulting. It’s not that Midoriya thinks Shouta can’t interfere, though. It’s that even if he does, there will just be another chance later.

Shouta can’t even argue that it wouldn’t be in the nomus’ best interests to be put out of their misery. He gives the dying nomus a last glance and leaves. Climbing up to a nearby building, he watches the building burn a brilliant, almost blinding blue that fades several minutes later into a more normal orange, and then makes sure the fire doesn’t spread.

It’s after emergency services show up to handle the fire that Shouta makes a call to Tsukauchi. Regardless of what he thinks about Midoriya and his aims, it’s Shouta’s duty to report any hint of his plans to the police.

If anything, maybe it will take on some of the work at preventing a terrible villain from wreaking havoc away from Midoriya’s team.

With the warehouses handled, there’s only three more sites that might cause them any trouble. Spinner’s pretty sure that’s their next big move, he’s just waiting for Kiddo to confirm it. As they gather at the table like usual, their fearless leader arrives next to Twice, having had a few words with him in the hall.

Kiddo glances at his phone, sends off a message, and then takes his place at the head of the table.

“So,” he says, glancing between them all. “We’re going to let the police and heroes handle the labs. Eraserhead should have already gotten them sniffing around them. There’s no way they won’t investigate further if they think that’s my next move.”

Startled, Spinner checks and finds everyone else seems as surprised as he is, except Dabi. But Dabi is still on the good drugs for his healing injuries so he doesn’t count.

“Are we doing something more fun?” Toga asks with a brighter look in her eyes. “We could go to the beach!”

Oh yeah, this crew could totally just stroll openly onto a beach. That’d be the biggest story of the day, Spinner’s sure.

“Not quite, but it should prove a lot more personally satisfying.” Kiddo tugs a flash drive out of his pocket and sets it down on the table. “This is what Gentle Criminal stole for me. A complete download of the HPSC files, including their top secret archives.”

To be honest, Spinner had forgotten about that particular caper. It’d seemed like such a useless departure, but he has to admit the resulting video had been entertaining. La Brava certainly gets better at editing with every one she makes.

Still… What did a bunch of hero data mean for them? It’s not like they’ve enough heroes to kill for that to be worth much (yet. Because who knew when one would interfere too much and Kiddo might give the order to remove them?).

“Something tells me, I’m not going to like this,” Hawks mutters to himself, arms crossed and expression lazy even as he stares intensely towards the flash drive.

“Probably not. There’s a pretty big file on you and the list of women the HPSC was hoping to breed you with,” Kiddo says with a tone that is so dry, it almost seems like a joke. Thing is, Kiddo never jokes.

Hawks blanches. “I should… probably not be surprised.”

“Nope.”

Dabi’s fingers tap a random rhythm on the table as he considers the drive. “Are we taking them down, then?”

The HPSC will be crawling with heroes at all hours of the day. Hell, most of the *clerical* staff have strong quirks that will prove troublesome even without hero level skills. Spinner’s teeth grind a bit, but this is the closest he’s ever felt to fulfilling his own goals in a long time. Taking down the HPSC would be *amazing*, considering how much of the corruption of the hero system could be traced straight to their policies.

“I think it’s outlived its usefulness,” Kiddo says, the barest cold smile on his lips.

Spinner knows it’s probably because Kiddo decided the HPSC is a threat to Bakugou Katsuki, but he’ll take it. The HPSC has made it doubly difficult for heteromorphs in general for years, all while putting a few of the lucky ones on pedestals to pretend they aren’t. Spinner’s heartbeat quickens and his fingers flex at his sides, more than ready to start tearing through those bastards.

“Giran should be bringing along anyone he thinks will be useful in either distracting the heroes or assisting our team. You’re free to nominate anyone you know of that might fit the bill,” Kiddo says as he slips the drive back into his pocket. “We have one week to plan, mobilize, and execute this attack.”

That’s a tight as hell timeline but somehow, Spinner is pretty sure they can do it. From the borderline savage looks on his teammate’s faces, he’s not the only one.

Chapter End Notes

A bit transitionary with a lot of little parts, but lets goooooo!

Chapter 39

Chapter Notes

> You ever worked on a chapter for months but hated everything you wrote for it, then decide to delete it all to start over only to finish the damn thing in a day?
>
> Warnings for blood and violence

See the end of the chapter for more notes

It starts quietly. Relatively so, anyway. In that it isn't quiet at all but could be a lot worse.

All at once, power through the full HPSC complex flickers before an alert goes out that they've switched to backup power. When Tanaka Shion glances out the window, she sees the lights and signs have gone out for at least a full block if not more. Ah, not just them, then. Perhaps a villain attack somewhere had taken out part of the grid again.

Shion turns back to her computer and preemptively saves everything she had open. Depending on how much damage there is, it could be hours before full power is restored and there are far more important things in the building that need the backups right now. Her home office will be comfortable enough. She locks her laptop and closes it before poking her head into her boss's office.

"Work from home?" she asks cheerfully, which just gets an absent wave without him even pausing his phone call.

Stopping by her desk, Shion slips her laptop back into her bag and starts gathering her things. It's been a busy week, she deserves a day with her cat curled up on her lap! It's not like she can't work while petting Ajisai until his fur falls off! That fat old cat deserves a little pampering.

Several others of the clerical staff are packing up as well without much worry. Outages happen, she lives far out enough that she probably still has power at her apartment. And if not, well. Free day off! Humming cheerfully to herself, Shion heads for the stairs since all but the emergency elevators will be offline. Two floors isn't much and she *had* skipped cardio in this morning's workout (that extra fifteen minutes of snoozing were vital!). Others are already making their way down, smiling back when Shion greets them.

She's out the door when someone's hand catches her wrist and something sharp presses to the small of her back. Shion freezes.

"Act naturally," a quiet, calm voice murmurs near her ear, "and I won't take out all these people in one big explosion."

Shion isn't a hero, her quirk isn't useful for fighting or escaping. She's gone through plenty of training for situations like this, being that the HPSC has to be ready for random attacks, so she follows that training and cooperates. She lets the man lead her through the crowd and then into an alleyway nearby without causing a scene. At least he doesn't seem to notice her hand drifting into her pocket to press the distress signal button built into all government issued phones.

There are others waiting in the alley, easily distinguishable as villains even if she didn't recognize most of them. The man holding her lets go and steps around her, sliding his knife back into his sleeve. Kiddo is so much smaller than Shion imagined, having heard about his exploits by many a disgruntled hero and police officer. The stories make it hard to keep in mind how young he is. Even knowing that, the calm, even look on his face makes her shiver.

"Toga," Kiddo says and Himiko Toga skips over to Shion's side with a wide grin.

"Oh, she's pretty!" Toga says like a chirping bird about to catch the worm. "Good choice, bestie!"

Then Shion has to smother a cry of pain as Toga plunges a needle into her to extract her blood. Minutes later, Shion is staring at herself wearing an expression that is utterly alien.

"Your keycard," Kiddo prompts and Shion hands it over. "Thank you for your cooperation."

Right out of a hero manual, this kid really makes her brain hurt.

"Did you signal for help before we got to the alley or after we entered it?" he asks and she feels her insides turn to ice.

"What signal?" she asks but Kiddo just stares at her until she mumbles out, "At the entrance."

Kiddo nods like he expected nothing less. Then they hand her a set of sweats and make her change into them, strangely considerate enough to only have Toga watch to make sure she didn't make a run for it. Toga pulls on her clothes and fluffs her hair a little before leaving the alley, gesturing in ways Shion never would.

If anyone doesn't cotton on to this being an imposter, Shion will have a *lot* to say to them.

They tie her up and gag her, Kiddo even testing to make sure the rope isn't too tight on her limbs. Around her are a dozen or so villains and criminals, several from the most wanted list, ones known to be in Kiddo's crew and ones not. She does a double take when recognizing Hawks, remembering his recent reclassification to villain and feeling just a little less hopeful for the situation. He doesn't spare her a glance, his eyes distant in a way she recognizes. He must be listening for something, waiting for some kind of signal.

"Everyone ready?" Kiddo asks, looking down at Shion's phone. There are a few quiet positive noises. "Team C, go."

Several break off and leave. Team D goes next, three more gone. Team B is a single person. By the time Team E goes, there's only two left. Dabi is the same tall, terrifying villain she

remembers from briefings, looking at her as if she were nothing more than a yappy little dog that doesn't deserve his attention. Kiddo kneels down in front of her and shows her a text conversation.

TS > requesting pickup

Unknown Number > Who is this? How did you get this number?

TS > one block north of hpsc hq

TS > between the corner store and burger place

Unknown Number > What is?

TS > noncombatant restrained but unharmed

TS > requesting extraction from hazardous area of incoming villain attack

Unknown Number > Police are on route.

Unknown Number > What is your hero ID?

Unknown Number > Please keep yourself safe.

There's probably never going to be a day that Kiddo makes sense to Shion, but that's not her job. She just watches as he sets the phone down next to her and then leaves with Dabi like the others had.

The next time someone tells her how boring their jobs are, Shion is going to kick them in the face.

If lives could be, in totality, a mistake, Nakamura Haruto's certainly is. That's the only explanation he can muster for what he's seeing before him.

The bomb is small, subtle. Somehow, it got through security and the regular sweeps by specialists. Somehow, it got under Haruto's desk. He'd been packing up to leave when he dropped a pen and reached to retrieve it, only to glance up and see some weird *thing* taped up along the back wall of the desk, wedged into the corner to make it half impossible to find. Half impossible if you aren't Nakamura Haruto, the bitch of Murphy's Law.

Before dedicating himself to deskwork, Haruto had dreams of being a hero. He'd even gotten into a hero school, though in the general education track. While his luck quirk could be useful in battle if applied right, he never managed to impress anyone enough to get moved to the hero track. Then he graduated, failed the provisional hero license exams, and that was about when he gave up on it all.

But he never forgot the supplementary hero lessons he'd taken trying to become a hero, and he'd gotten particularly good at accurately calculating just how fucked he was in any given situation. Disabling bombs is not something he should try; they're just as likely to go off at

random to inconvenience him as they are to fizzle out on their own because he's around. There's no ominous countdown on the thing, probably remotely activated or the person who left it here would be coming back to properly arm it later. If Haruto were a villain, then a blackout would be a perfect time to do that-

Unless they're behind the blackout? He needs to call this in. Haruto reaches for his desk phone, but the line is out. He pulls out his cell phone and it's dead. God*damn*it, why couldn't this have been a *good* luck day?! He hasn't had one in a while, he's due!

Okay. No panicking or things will just go downhill faster. Moodily, Haruto grabs his things and hurries for the door, nearly plowing right into his boss behind it.

"Sorry, sorry, I was-" He shakes himself and points back to his desk. "There's a bomb! Can you call it in? My cell is dead and-"

And… There is a lizard heteromorph standing next to his boss that Haruto immediately recognizes. Why is someone from the most wanted list standing next to his boss? Why is someone from *Kiddo's crew* standing next to his boss?!

A smile spreads over her face that is nothing he's ever seen before. His heart thuds against his ribs in a quickening beat as the hair on the back of his neck stands. *This isn't his boss*.

"Let's talk in your office, yeah?" she says, not even trying to pretend, like she already knows he knows.

Five minutes later, he's tied up and gagged as the two villains do something to the bomb under his desk. Just his fucking luck, see if he ever works another extra Saturday shift again! Well, if he ever does *anything* again. Are they just going to leave him here to die? Did his luck really turn *that* bad?!

But when the two villains leave, Spinner has Haruto thrown over his shoulder. Well. That could be considered good. He's not going to blow up. But does this mean he's a hostage? That seems worse. What if he gets tortured? He knows *some* secrets someone might torture him for!

He tugs at his quirk but it won't activate. Fucking *Murphy!*

Being that he's facing behind the villains, it takes Haruto a little while to realize where they're headed. He's rarely ever up this high, usually only to deliver reports or messages that someone decided couldn't be emailed, but he recognizes the really nice breakroom that is just *unfair* compared to the one on his floor. There's an *espresso machine*-

Wait, are the villains going after the president?!

To Haruto's horror, more villains are showing up behind them. None as highly known as Spinner and someone who is almost definitely Toga Himiko under his boss's face, but he catches a few faces he recognizes from defunct gangs that Kiddo has taken out over the last year and a half. None of them seem particularly concerned with Haruto, not even when Spinner hands him off to a brute that could probably crush Haruto's head between his thighs.

The brute isn't necessarily *gentle* with him, but neither does he seem all that interested in pointlessly intimidating him. Haruto resigns himself to just being a bag of flour slung over his shoulder.

It turns out that the president's office is exactly where the villains wanted to go. Haruto hears them engage with her guards and since the brute holding him doesn't move forward to help, he's pretty sure the sounds of bodies hitting the floor are from them. Great. They're doomed and with his luck, Haruto's going to be blamed for jinxing everyone.

Three of the other villains rush past the brute as a door opens, probably for the office. There's shouting, something that has to be quirks going off, but the brute doesn't have the decency to turn Haruto around to see it.

After a several minutes, things get quiet again. The brute gets going and Haruto grunts as he's soon dropped on the floor, another small-time crook standing over him. At least this lets him twist onto his back and take in the half destroyed office. Oh, gross, someone had a slime quirk and that shit is *everywhere*. They're going to spend a fortune cleaning this place up if it isn't blown sky high. The guards he'd expected are just unmoving lumps on the floor. Haruto can't tell if they're alive or not.

Madam president's eyes meet his for a second before she turns her attention back to Spinner and Toga Himiko, who's shed the disguise and looks so weird in his boss's too large clothes.

"I don't know what your leader thinks he's doing-" madam president starts, only for Spinner to derisively snort.

"A lot more good than *you*," he says with an underlying anger that seems personal. "Sit down and stay quiet. You don't have anything to say that we want to hear."

How did these guys manage to take madam *president* captive so easily? Does that mean her guards are terrible at their jobs or that these guys are just that good? He doesn't like either option. Madam president isn't allowed to sit back at her desk, but she'd probably hit the panic button the moment the door opened, so they might get rescued. He glances towards the brute, who eyes him right back with a distressingly hungry look, only *more* distressing due to his shark-like teeth.

If he gets eaten, Haruto is going to haunt the shit out of these people.

Kaede appreciates the routine of her life. Every day, her meals come at the same time. Her training follows the same track. Her friends complain about the same things. It's reliable, comfortable. She likes comfortable.

She does wonder what the sky looks like, though. It's been long enough that she's forgotten. They don't talk about the world outside much. No sense in missing something they'll never see again. If she even lives much past her baby's birth, that will be a pleasant surprise. Unlike Kyo, Kaede doesn't have much in the way of fight in her. Kyo rages and grumbles and makes trouble for their keepers all the time, but Kaede just watches and fights between exasperation

and admiration. It's not that Kaede wants to be like Kyo, but there is a small part of her that might enjoy it for a day, just to see what it's like.

Across their main living area, Kosuke's busy writing and writing and writing like usual. She's not sure why he writes. It's not as if he'll ever be able to publish anything, but it keeps him busy and quiet, so she supposes it's all right. Her weaving is much the same. They won't let her baby be wrapped in something she's made, but the fantasy of it keeps her hands working the shuttle through line after line.

The door to their cell opens and Kaede freezes because it's too early, they're supposed to still have another hour before subject change out! But Kenta's stumbling inside, pushed by one of the orderlies or guards or someone who isn't one of their own. Setting aside her shuttle, Kaede rises and goes to him, worried over how pale his face is.

"Did something-"

"It came true," Kenta says, grabbing her hands outstretched towards him. Still pale, his face breaks into a breathtaking smile. "My dream-slide, it was- It came true. It's *happening*."

Her heart turns to ice even as Kenta lets go to grab Kyo up in his arms, twirling her around as she hits him on the head lightly, her version of lovingly. But Kaede is less concerned about what they're doing and more with what Kenta had just said.

"The time- so we have, what. A half hour?" Kyo asks.

"Less!"

A hand comes to rest on Kaede's shoulder and she flinches despite herself, looking up to the soothing calm of Kosuke's face. Everything is easier when he's around. She'd have preferred Kenta as her partner but… Kosuke is probably better suited anyway. He stands with her in quiet support as Kenta and Kyo run around their cell rooms to gather things. They knock stuff onto the floor in their hurry, step on more, even collide with each other a few times only to laugh it off.

"I will pack for you," Kosuke offers. Kaede swallows down the growing lump in her throat and lays a hand over her distended belly.

"We- we don't *have* to go," she says, barely above a whisper. He studies her face before slowly nodding.

"Yes. You don't."

She looks away at his perceptive words, almost wounded by them even though she should be well used to it by now. Kosuke's always seen right through her.

"Don't leave me alone." Her hands curl in the front of his shirt as she steps closer, enough that her belly presses to his. "Please don't. We don't have to go."

He reaches up and covers her hands with his. Leaning forward, he presses their foreheads together.

“I’m sorry,” he says so soft, so loving. The gentle rock she’s leaned on since they were children first brought to this place. “But I *want* to go.”

The betrayal leaves ash in her mouth. She tears her hands from him and goes resolutely back to her seat. The shuttle shakes when she tries to get back to work. Behind her are the sounds of everyone else getting ready to leave their safe, comfortable home and, maybe less importantly, *her*.

She almost doesn’t notice when the door opens again and this time there are two men she doesn’t know, who aren’t dressed like guards or doctors, who have no idea what they’re breaking by coming here. Kyo and Kenta sling their bags onto their shoulders immediately, stitched together in secret as they dreamed of escape over the years, but Kosuke hesitates. He stands near the door as Kyo and Kenta shuffle out with the tall, scarred man, and at his side is a boy dressed in black and green.

Kosuke opens his mouth and then closes it without saying anything. She can’t speak either as she watches him turn and leave with the boy. The door closes, the lock engaging right after, and Kaede is left terribly, terribly alone in the most comfortable of cages.

There’s not much that surprises Yamazaki Reina anymore. She’s been through plenty in her life, certainly more than most. When her office door opens a while after the villains took control of it, a boy walks through that has been nothing *but* surprises.

“I was wondering when you’d show up,” she says, not bothering to stand from the chair they’d graciously allowed her.

“Apologies for being late,” Kiddo says with a smile. “I was a little busy stealing the latest results of your experiments. You’re almost as bad about hoarding people as my father.”

Ah, yes. This is the only living family to All For One, isn’t it? Reina narrows her eyes and considers how she might yet get out of this situation. Kiddo’s lethal and easily so, he won’t spare her if she can’t be useful to him.

“I almost feel sorry for you,” he continues, walking through his gathered cohorts without looking away from her. “You still think you’re going to live through this.”

Good to have confirmation of his plans. “What is it you think this is going to accomplish?”

“Oh, it’s mostly a moral boost,” Kiddo says. There’s no sign of a lie, she’s more than half sure he’s telling the truth. “Don’t worry, we got Yokumiru occupied elsewhere before this all started. He’ll run a much cleaner ship than you ever tried to.”

Well, if there was ever a silver lining. No one is supposed to know Yokumiru was hand chosen to succeed her, should the worst happen. Somehow, it isn’t all that surprising that Kiddo does.

“If you’re going to kill me, I’d rather you get it over with.”

Kiddo shrugs a shoulder, his green eyes no more or less impressed. “I do this every time I’ve killed you so far, but there’s someone who’d never forgive me if I don’t *keep* doing it.”

That’s all the warning she gets before Kiddo slaps her across the face so hard that she tumbles out of her chair. The insult stuns her, especially since Kiddo isn’t known for random cruelty. If he’s displeased, he kills you. Simple, end of story. There’s never been much in the way of torture or abuse signs in any of his victims. Perhaps they’ve simply missed it before. Reina shifts up to sit, one hand covering her burning cheek.

“That’s for the time quirk experiments,” he says.

How the *hell* had that been leaked- But his time loop story. How many times does he think he’s lived through this, how many of them were right under some version of hers nose?

“A bit dramatic,” she says, stalling more than anything. She knows her signal went out, where are the heroes?

“She’s a dramatic kid.” Kiddo’s shaking the sting out of his hand. He then offers it to her to help her off the floor. This boy continues to confuse her at every pass. “I need to hit you a second time for someone who’d never ask me to.”

“That doesn’t exactly make me put any trust in you.”

“I’m not known for lying.”

Which is true. Once they finally catch him for real and manage to keep UA from throwing their weight around, his exceedingly truthful testimony and continual acknowledgement of his own crimes will make it easy to lock him up. No matter that he’s a minor or quirkless, he’ll be in tartarus if it’s the last thing she does.

Reina lets herself be pulled up and for some reason *is* surprised when he slaps her again, just as hard. This time, she just stumbles back several steps but manages to stay standing.

“There,” Kiddo says. “It won’t make up for what you put them through, but at least I can say I gave you a shot for each.”

“I don’t suppose you’re going to share who they are.”

“One of them isn’t born yet.”

“Ah, this must mean I live, then.”

“Not anymore. I’m about to murder you for the sanctioned assassinations you ordered Takami Keigo and Tsutsumi Kaina to carry out.”

There’s barely enough time for her eyes to snap wide before cool metal slides across her throat so easily, she barely feels it. Only the flood of hot fluid gushing down her front makes the act actually real. She stumbles, falling to her knees even as she tries to steady herself on her chair. Around her, she hears the others murmuring things she can’t quite make sense of. Her eyes lift to Kiddo’s face as she slumps down onto the floor and he doesn’t look away.

The last thing she hears are explosions somewhere nearby, the last thing she feels is a rumble in the floor under her, and then she's gone.

There's not much of a fight, is the thing. Or, rather, it's less of a fight and more of a cat and mouse game between villains and heroes outside the half demolished remains of the HPSC HQ building smoldering away. The villains keep doing hit and runs and don't even seem to be trying to *accomplish* anything except time wasting.

Or, maybe, just keeping them out of the way.

Nishiya Shinji doesn't like this at all. He's caught several of the criminals but no one big name enough to be behind all this and no one willing to admit who is. It takes most of a half hour after the bombs went off to get anyone through and actually start searching the rubble for survivors. With how useful his quirk is for apprehending multiple targets, Shinji remains outside to stave off the villains still trying to bogart his and the rest of the heroes' attention. Like they're buying time for someone else.

Whatever went on in the HPSC before the bombs went off, they don't want the heroes to find out yet. It stinks of a mastermind and Shinji has the worst feeling it's that newcomer everyone's been talking about. He redoubles his efforts to catch and detain every criminal he can in his branch prisons for the police to take. Just how many people does this group have with them-

Something red catches his eye, gone too quickly to be sure what it was, but he's been doing this a while. He knows what that is even before the second feather shoots past him to pin a support person to one of the still standing walls. He might be the *only* one who realizes just who is in this fight. If the turncoat Hawks is here, there's a good bet that new villain Kiddo is as well. And Kiddo isn't known for taking part in the plans of others. This situation is even more dire than Shinji thought.

The only weird thing is that the other big names associated with him are missing and Hawks hasn't shown himself either. The idea of a man like Hawks playing such a remote support role… Just what does Kiddo have on him? And why hasn't at least that pyro joined in? The only fires have been those caused by the bombs. His jaw tightens as he catches and restrains another common criminal that seems to have been left as a sacrifice, just to keep the heroes busy.

Shinji uses a free second to flip on his radio. "The villain Kiddo is here. Evidence of Hawks, south wall, no sign of the others."

There's some chatter, people wondering if Hawks might be working alone, of what this stunt might have been trying to accomplish. It matters little to Shinji. He won't be helpful one-on-one with Hawks and he has his own duty here. Gathering himself, Shinji redoubles his efforts to get the low level criminals out of the way as quickly as he can, if only to then be free to join the rescue efforts. Or, maybe, just to watch the others' backs as they do the same. Who knows what this villain is after?

Then something comes over the radio that has him going cold inside.

“Bodies found, ten, throats slit,” someone reports.

Right after, “It’s… It’s madam president. And the top administrators. They’re…”

“Somebody get that news helicopter out of range! There may be more bombs and we can’t let this get out yet!”

“Right, I’m on it- I- Oh no.”

“What?!”

“It’s… already on the news. There’s been a data leak and…”

Shinji turns the general channel off and sets his radio to only notify him of emergency orders. He can’t think about all that right now. There’s a job to do and he’s going to get it done.

Chapter End Notes

Just some good, old fashioned mayhem.

Chapter 40

Chapter Notes

Got some drama to wind up...

Warnings mostly for discussions of violence and the death penalty, not much more I can think of.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Nedzu doesn't sleep much. He's crepuscular by nature and tends to take cat naps during the day to counter his inclination. When the attack on the HPSC started, he'd been in one of those naps, but the attack had only barely ended when he woke. That makes it easier to snap fully awake when the call comes in.

UA of course sends licensed year two and three students with rescue inclined quirks, those that aren't already working with the hero they're interning with. He coordinates with the police to decide which site the students should head to, as there are six other than the HPSC that also need looking over from the villain attacks that were *definitely* orchestrated to coincide and distract. It's a simple, effective strategy, one taught about in later UA classes.

What Nedzu doesn't know is why the villain Kiddo would do this. His trademarks are everywhere, it can have had no other mastermind. This will only increase ire from the police and heroes, put a greater importance on catching and stopping him. It's an effective way to get attention, which never seemed like Kiddo's actual goal.

Nedzu narrows his eyes at media feeds from five different news channels, trying to make sense of it all. Just what could be the connection between this attack and protecting Bakugou Katsuki?

An alert sounds and he brings up one of his web crawlers' feeds, one that constantly searches for topics relating to HPSC activities. Then he freezes. It's… a mission file? Fully available *on the internet?!* Immediately, Nedzu pivots his attention entirely to figure out the full scope of what has to be a *massive* data breach. He knows a second later there will be no containing it, either. The data dump has already been put out into multiple archives and sites, more of them popping up even as he tries to grasp the level of damage.

The data is mostly uncategorized, a dirty grab and dash, except… In each of the documents Nedzu opens, all traces of personal data about the civilian identities of listed heroes have been scrubbed out of them. That would have taken *months* of careful work. He follows his hunch and can't find anything dated after October. That… Hadn't there been an attack on the HPSC around then?

Nedzu finds the report detailing it. As far as anyone knew at the time, nothing had been taken. Now, it looks more like someone had just been very good at covering their tracks. Even Nedzu hadn't found anything before. Well. At least now he knows what that had all been about and that Kiddo was involved. This data dump isn't exactly Kiddo's style though, not unless he's wanting the rest of them to figure something out instead of just telling them. *Mission accepted, young man.* Within two hours, he finds what he's looking for.

Operation Chronos. He barely has to scan the next line to know what this involves. The title is a little on the nose for his tastes, but it makes sense. A long term study of quirk morphology and evolution is what it calls itself. Eugenics is a lot more suitable. There's data for four generations, spanning back to the dawn of quirks. The original six participants must have been first generation quirk users. After them, the notated generations are short. The parents were at oldest twenty-five when their first child was born, at youngest eighteen.

Their lives had been short as well. None of them survived past thirty-five, nor had they passed naturally. Over the years, only five time adjacent quirked individuals had been added to the project, begetting children and dying relatively young after, just like the other participants. There are four living subjects currently, a child already on the way. Three are unaccounted for.

Sometimes, Nedzu can't help but hate humanity. It takes him a little while to decide what he'll do next, long enough to finish a cup of tea and regain his rationality. He needs to talk to the only project survivor recovered from a bunker under the HPSC building. Only then will he have a better idea of the answers he's seeking and where he might find them.

The person who had set Midoriya Izuku on his endless loop of time hasn't been born yet. Nedzu is fairly sure he's looking at her ancestors.

Naomasa expects the call. He even expects it after he's ready to collapse but before he's had a chance to rest at all, and he's not wrong. The cheery bells of his ringtone only make his headache worse.

"What were you thinking?" he asks, his voice a lot more tired than accusatory.

"I had an objective to accomplish," Midoriya says like he didn't murder ten people or take out a huge chunk of the power grid or blow up a building or orchestrate a half dozen major villain attacks in other locations at the same time to spread the hero pool thin or…

It makes Naomasa want to scream, but he just doesn't have the energy. "What was the objective?"

"To take the HPSC out of the equation." It's a half truth. Naomasa is too tired to figure out what's behind it right now. "Even without the leak, it'll take months before they might be an appreciable roadblock, but I doubt they'll ever be as powerful again."

"What else?"

"Rescue. You should look at the released documents."

Away from his terrible couch, outside of his messy office, the world is a crazy mess of destruction and emergency services. The rescue efforts in the rubble of the HPSC HQ have been mostly called off after nearly eight hours of finding no more bodies alive or dead, even with quirk assistance. At least, other than the HPSC president and her entire top level staff. As far as anyone can tell, they're the only casualties.

Instead, rescue efforts switched to finding the dozens of people that keep showing up bound and gagged in the immediate area of the HPSC, all of whom had one or another villain capture and extract them from the building before the bombs went off. Half of the villains even left messages on the emergency hotline number or hero text line as to where to find them. It's bizarre but at least that answers the question about why they keep not finding bodies. As each name is taken off the list of missing persons, everyone's stress has been taken down a notch or two.

This isn't going to be resolved anytime soon. Not after the data dump someone (Midoriya) released to the internet as heroes arrived on scene, but the immediate urgency has gone down. Naomasa drags his hand down his face and thinks of the long nights ahead. He's already been alerted to a growing public uproar over what Kiddo threw down without explanation, knows there might be riots, protests, who knows what else. The fact that this is coming on the heels of multiple villain attacks at the same time that hampered a response to the HPSC's distress signal will only make it all worse.

"There are better ways to reveal government corruption," he says.

"I left out personal information about any heroes listed in their files."

"That's not even close to what I'm talking about."

There's a pause, then Midoriya says in full, unvarnished truth, "It doesn't work other ways. The higher ups just entrench themselves deeper, pay off anyone that might step in, and infect other agencies to keep causing trouble. This way, it makes a public impact and forces others to pay attention."

Naomasa knows that. Doesn't make any of this any easier to accept.

"Anytime they get involved near this time, Kacchan dies," Midoriya adds, a little quieter. "It's better to hit them hard enough that they won't recover for at least half a year."

Truth. At least as Midoriya believes. "Are you *trying* to make yourself a bigger target to even more people? Because that's what you're doing."

"There's not enough of a downside for me to care about that. And at least now if I make a loud enough move, there should be plenty of quick responses."

Shutting his eyes tightly, Naomasa rubs the grit out of them. Villain, he reminds himself. *Villain*, not traumatized child. Even when Midoriya was willing to lean upon heroes to safeguard Bakugou, it didn't change his general method of cold, deadly practicality.

“You might actually get sentenced to death after all,” Naomasa mutters as he feels a hundred years old.

“That’s fair,” Midoriya says with barely any inflection. “I will probably already be dead by the time they could try me though, whether I save Kacchan or not.”

The fatalistic outlook Midoriya has isn’t going to change anytime soon. Naomasa really needs to stop thinking it will.

“Who were you trying to rescue?” he asks, and there’s silence on the other end for nearly a minute.

“The future,” comes almost soundlessly. And then the call ends. Naomasa resists the urge to throw his phone across the room and instead drops it down next to him so he can bury his face in his hands.

With the very loud, very public execution of the HPSC higher ups, there’s no path for Midoriya to take towards the light anymore. If he’s captured, he will be tried as an adult for his *hundreds* of crimes and most likely put to death because he’s proven just that dangerous. After everything with All for One, they won’t take chances just locking him up. Midoriya won’t try to save himself, either. No show of remorse. There’s not going to be any last ditch rehabilitation program or pardon, nothing UA or Naomasa or even All Might can do to save him from it.

Naomasa hates that he still wants to.

If Yoshida Himari were a less optimistic person, she’d think being removed from her holding cell by a bunch of villains was a sign to stop trying to be anything but what her villainous quirk obviously predisposes her to be. She’s certainly been told she’d end up a villain enough times to believe that by the other kids in the training program.

“Do you remember anything about your family?” Hawks asks as Himari just stares up at him. She at least recognizes him, if no one else. He’d taught some of their lessons before he turned into a villain. She shakes her head and Hawks sighs. “Yeah, I figured as much. What about your surname?”

“...Yoshida.”

“Group B?” a lizard man nearby asks.

“Yup.”

Himari doesn’t know what the groups mean, but she lets Hawks lead her over to sit next to another kid taken from his holding cell as well. The villains start talking to someone else and Himari studies them all. They’re all grownups and none of them are the boss. The boss is younger with eyes nearly as big as Himari’s.

When he comes over to talk to her and the boy with her, Himari doesn't know what to think of him. He kneels down in front of them so she doesn't have to look up at him, and then smiles gently in a way that *should* make her scared. That's the way the handlers smiled before asking her to use her quirk.

"It's been an exciting day, hasn't it?" he asks, still smiling. "Don't worry. We're looking for your families so we can get you back to them."

Does she even *have* a family? Himari's not sure. Her earliest memories are the handlers telling her what to do. Telling her to *use her quirk-*

"Do you want me to be a villain?" she asks, interrupting the villain. "Because of my quirk."

He blinks with surprise. "Oh. No, no you can do what you like. We're just-"

"Then can I be a hero if I stay with you?" Why she asked that, Himari doesn't know. Except, these villains aren't really acting like villains. They seem a little rough, but none of them have been mean like the handlers. "My quirk is bad, but I'll work really hard!"

"That…" The man closes his eyes for a second, drawing in a deep breath. "No, not if you stay with us. But I have a friend who may be able to help you become one if you still want to when you're old enough to go to a hero school."

That's more than she'd hoped for. "Even though my quirk is bad?"

"There aren't any bad quirks. It depends entirely on how the person uses their quirk, and you seem like a good person."

She brightens. She's still really scared by all this, but he sounds so sure and she's so relieved.

"Okay. I want to be a hero."

"We have to try and find your family first, but I'll talk to my friend."

The smile on Himari's face hurts for how wide it is, but she lets herself daydream as the man talks to the other kid beside her.

Yuga's day started off so perfectly. His hair fantastic, his clothes sparkling exactly how he likes, and he'd gotten four of his classmates to smile at him. Maybe he isn't letting himself foster any *closer* friendships with them, but it's nice that they like him enough for that. It makes the rest a little easier, even as his guilt grows.

Then at lunch, he receives a new order. It's… simple. Sort of. All he has to do is report on Bakugou's normal schedule, figure out his habits. That's something Yuga already does! Maybe Bakugou is sad about not being around his villain boyfriend (*is* Kiddo his boyfriend?) or mad at something said villain boyfriend has done (but seriously, are they dating?! Scandaleux!). Maybe he needs cheering up.

Just because he's gathering intel for shady characters doesn't mean Yuga has to *act* like a villain. He's… No one's going to get *really* hurt, right? Bakugou can hold his own nine times out of ten.

He keeps fretting about it all through the day until he's heading back to the dorms, only to get dragged around to the backside of the building and crowded by a very familiar looking figure.

"We need to talk," Kiddo says, sounding friendly, which probably means it's fake. He'd done that in the classroom before, Yuga knows better than to trust it now!

And how did Kiddo even get on the grounds?!

"Ah, it's been too long!" he says while frantically trying to figure out how not to die.

"I'm evacuating your parents," Kiddo replies, and every bit of warmth in Yuga's body disappears to leave ice behind. "That text message earlier was the last piece I needed to track the ones watching you."

"...What?"

"I'm evacuating them to a safehouse as we speak. All for One's goons won't be able to find them, trust me. I've done this enough times before."

Yuga's mouth goes dry. "You… know?"

Something about that seems to make Kiddo a little sad, but he's still crowding Yuga up against the back of his dorm, a place where Kiddo *should not* be able to just saunter up to anytime he likes! Bad enough that even though All for One is supposedly dead, his cronies still find ways to threaten Yuga and his parents!

"I know everything," Kiddo says. His eyes are so big, Yuga feels like he's drowning in them. They make him want to believe. "Your debt to him has been cleared. Don't ask me how, I don't want to make you have to lie more than you already have."

It hits as sharply as one of Kiddo's knives and Yuga's belly clenches tight. The deliberate choice of *cleared* rather than *paid* sits even worse inside him.

"You're not a bad guy, Aoyama. You're just a guy who loves his family, wants to live, and got caught up in something way too big for you to handle."

"What's going to happen to my parents?" Because this could just be *another* villain extorting him and he's already spent so long being scared of everything falling down around him.

"They'll stay at the safehouse until I've taken out All for One for good. Then they're free to go, no strings."

Yuga suddenly can't move, his body locking up no matter how much he wants to run. It's not the casual intent to kill that shocks him. It's- "He's actually alive?"

“Of course he’s alive,” Kiddo says, like it’s a foregone conclusion and he’s not shattering any sense of safety Yuga has ever felt. “And he’ll probably stay alive until *I* find him.”

It should be comical, but Yuga can’t laugh. No matter how pure and angelic Kiddo’s features can be, he’s a cold blooded killer with no intention of reform.

“I’ll be watching over you until we’ve rooted out the last of his informants that know anything about you,” Kiddo says. “Those loose ends need tidying.”

“Why are you telling me this?” There’s no good reason to! What if Yuga tattles?!

Kiddo studies his face for a little while, but Yuga doesn’t know what he’s looking for or what he sees. He’s almost afraid to know.

“Because you don’t deserve to live in fear for accepting a tool to bring you into a better life,” is what Kiddo finally says as he steps back to give some space between them. It sounds too much like something a hero would say to have left the mouth of such a successful villain. “Give me an hour, then go to Aizawa and tell him *everything*. It’s time to come clean.”

Come clean and probably be kicked out of the school? Probably get murdered by terrifying villains? Probably get his family killed because a villain told him what he desperately wanted to hear?

“It ends better if you tell him first, before he finds out on his own. Because he *will* find out otherwise. Show him he can still trust you now to do the right thing.”

Kiddo gives his shoulder a squeeze. Then he backs off and pulls something out of his pocket. Yuga doesn’t have time to see it properly before it emits a blinding burst of light that leaves him slamming back against the dorm wall just to keep himself steady. He rubs at his stinging eyes and isn’t surprised Kiddo’s gone by the time he can open them again.

“Au revoir, mon ami,” Yuga whispers to the empty air. The tears he’s wiping away aren’t completely from the soreness in his eyes as the tension inside him finally breaks.

By the time Yuga feels able to handle other people again, Kiddo’s hour has ended and Yuga mostly isn’t feeling like shattered glass. He takes a deep breath and then goes to find Aizawa.

“Trying to extrapolate from incomplete data is a fool’s errand,” Mirai says as he flips a page of Kiddo’s notebook over. Fool he must be, trying to do exactly that. “If we accept this as fact as far as he knows-”

“We do,” Tsukauchi says. He looks nearly as bad off as Mirai does. When was the last time he had decent sleep?

“Then it stands to reason that only Midoriya would be able to fill in the blanks.” He flips another page. “Knowing that, I don’t understand why you’ve brought this to me. I haven’t recovered my quirk usage yet.”

“We wouldn’t ask you to use it on him when it dropped you into a coma last time. We just want your honest thoughts on what those empty sections of time might contain.”

There isn’t nearly enough information for that. Mirai glares down and turns back to the pages just after “Kacchan dies”, slated for the coming April. Everything before that is meticulously detailed. Everything after reads more like the rough outline of a novel. Points of interest, specific future events, but nothing to piece them all together cohesively. There are a few notes here and there, possible triggers, but little else. Those parts obviously hadn’t mattered to Midoriya.

Mirai wonders how much of those Midoriya still remembers and how long it’s been since he lived through them. How much of this is literal and how much symbolic. The thought of their world, their current way of life being destroyed so completely makes Mirai almost want to laugh, but… He’s seen it. Most of the information he’d gotten from Midoriya was lost when his mind became overwhelmed by it, but there are still pieces here and there. Reading over the future timeline, he’s starting to match those pieces to the events.

“Where is Recovery Girl now?” he asks without looking up.

“At UA, last I checked. Why?”

“I need to see Midoriya and she’s the best chance any of us have to getting to his base unless we want to use Bakugou again.”

Tsukauchi sucks in a harsh breath, slumping when Mirai finally glances his way. He scrubs a hand down his face with conflict spreading over it. “You’re right. I’ll send a message her way and see what I can work out.”

Mirai nods and starts to turn back to the notebook when Tsukauchi’s phone sounds off with a message alert. He glanced at it and then does a double take before reading the text closely. A hushed curse leaves his lips.

“Trouble?” Mirai asks, eyes narrowing.

“They really did it,” Tsukauchi says. His voice is faint, breathy. “They gave the order.”

“Order?”

Looking skyward, Tsukaichi slips his phone away in his pocket without answering the text. He takes several moments to recover from whatever order he’d been given, plenty of time for Mirai to consider a few possibilities that would bother a man like him. He’s wrong on all counts.

“The Prime Minister has called for bringing Kiddo to the top of the most wanted list. He’s being blamed for the HPSC attack and to be brought in immediately by any means necessary.” Which makes sense, considering the trouble that boy has caused- “Dead or alive.”

Mirai stiffens. What? He’s only heard of such an order once, years ago. Before All Might managed to defeat All for One without killing him. “That’s going too far.”

“Is it?” Somehow, Tsukauchi sounds almost as helpless as Mirai suddenly feels. He’s still not well enough to apprehend Midoriya himself, get him behind bars to keep from allowing his death instead. There are plenty of other heroes that might not have any other choice if faced with him. “Kiddo has toppled the criminal underground and rebuilt it under his rule in less than two years. He’s killed dozens, possibly hundreds by now.”

But Mirai can hear it in Tsukauchi’s voice that he’s disturbed despite his own attempts to justify the sanctioned potential murder of a sixteen-year-old boy *who thinks he’s doing good*.

“He’s been without remorse when discussing his crimes and freely admitted to having others planned. He’s-”

“I need to speak with him *immediately*,” Mirai interrupts because Tsukauchi’s spiral isn’t going to help them in the least. “Contact Recovery Girl and see if she can arrange it. Barring her, Bakugou.”

Tsukauchi’s lips thin but he nods and draws out his phone again. Who knows how long they have before someone manages to cross Midoriya’s path at the worst possible moment? How many bodies might be left behind. The most dangerous animal is a cornered one.

Mirai gets his own phone and dials up the number of possibly the only person who might be able to get Kiddo to see sense. He’ll need all the help he can get.

Chapter End Notes

Someone needs to tell Kiddo to stop upping the ante.

Chapter 41

Chapter Notes

I don't know why I keep letting myself get stuck on a specific pov that just keeps not working. Chapters get done so much faster if I don't think about it so much.

We got a month change finally, but it's really only been like two weeks since the last chapter.

Warnings for ableist thinking, allusions to suicide, allusions to genetic alterations

See the end of the chapter for more notes

March

“He won’t listen to me,” Toshinori says for the fifth time, rubbing a hand down his face. “Not like this.”

“Something tells me he’s seen plenty of this form,” Mirai counters with a stern look that makes Toshinori feel at least thirty years younger, if not more. It’s blisteringly cold, the way Mirai often looks at other people. Ever since that raid on the Shie Hassaikai, where he’d gotten his chance to air out his grievances against Toshinori’s “stupid march towards his own death”, Mirai had loosened up a little. None of that shows now. It’s all Sir Nighteye on duty.

“Not like this.” Broken down past the point of use. Legs gone, bad candidate for hero grade prosthetics due to, of all things, his *age.* If it hadn’t been that, it would have been his dead quirk. There’s something almost funny about it not being, even if Toshinori can’t muster up the will to laugh at it all. *All Might* is the one that was able to smile in any situation. *Toshinori* doesn’t have to.

The civilian grade prosthetics they fit him for are more trouble than just using the wheelchair. He’s spent his recovery building up muscle in his arms and chest so he can cart himself around instead, and he’s gotten pretty good at it. It’s not much, but Toshinori will take the win right now. He’s trying that whole “hopeful acceptance” thing to mixed results.

“There’s no one else with any chance to get through to him,” Mirai says. Which means either everyone else has tried and failed, or Midoriya just hasn’t been willing to talk to them.

“Looking at me will upset him.”

Mirai’s eyes narrow and Toshinori doesn’t let himself look away. No amount of shame he feels for what he is now (isn’t anymore) will make him back down. He knows he’s right. He knows he’ll just make things worse if he does as Mirai wants.

“You’re coming with me,” Mirai says as he unfolds his arms. “They said you stopped going to physical therapy.”

“I can do it fine on my own. I’ve been through enough injuries to know what to do.” Not *amputations*, but the theory isn’t that different. Doesn’t matter if he keeps forgetting his legs are gone because he keeps *feeling* them. The phantom ache hits as he reminds himself of it, and Toshinori grits his teeth.

“Not like this,” Mirai says without regard to Toshinori’s feelings on the matter. “You should be listening to the professionals.”

Fine. Mirai wants to play it this way? Toshinori will play it this way, too. “The other therapist keeps yapping about regaining my autonomy. One would expect you to respect it.”

Mirai twitches with offense, but he’s always been a straight laced sort of man. Even when he gets pigheaded and stubborn about it, he’ll cave. Toshinori just has to wait him out.

“I never took you for the type to abandon a troubled boy with no one else to lean on,” Mirai says, the bastard. That was *low.*

“Now wait just one minute-” Toshinori starts with rising irritation.

“No,” is the curt interruption. “You’ve been wallowing. It stops now.”

“I am a grown man.”

“From here, all I see is a sullen child.”

On instinct, Toshinori reaches for the familiar warmth of One For All and feels nothing. It hurts more than it should. Yes, he’d had the quirk for at least twice as long as he hadn’t, but it isn’t actually his. It never was. Good thing Togata isn’t here to see the likeliest outcome of a One For All user that hasn’t died yet. He might balk against a destiny Toshinori had forced on him and that he couldn’t have understood the full ramifications for when he agreed to take it.

No. Toshinori isn’t being fair about this, but he can’t find it in himself to *be* fair right now.

“He needs you,” Mirai says, quieter this time. *Damn it.* All at once, the energy saps out of Toshinori and his joints ache fiercely, a lifetime of breaking his body over and over catching up with him all at once. It’s certainly not the *guilt* that threatens to choke him to death- Who is he kidding? It’s absolutely the guilt.

Running a hand back over his hair, Toshinori finally mutters, “What outcome are you angling for with your plan?”

“Two birds, one stone. Maybe this gives us the upper hand when it comes to Kiddo, at least enough to get some idea of his next move, maybe it will also get you out of your house.”

Go touch grass, as Togata might say.

“Why are you doing this?” he asks.

As he expected, Mirai doesn't give him a quick answer. He weighs out his words in his mind, no doubt trying to calculate the most effective ones. It could almost be considered quick, the amount of time before Mirai says, "Because All Might has never been the part of you I admired most."

Toshinori flinches and looks away. Memories flood through him and he's back in that hospital bed, years ago, with Mirai begging him to retire before this life took his. The doctors had barely been able to save him that time. One For All was almost *lost*. It still took him far too long after that to find and train a successor, and Togata will be a *wonderful* symbol of peace, but…

He wonders, suddenly, if this is how his own master had felt.

If this is how *he* felt in other timelines, giving One For All to a young, quirkless boy with green curls.

"Shit," he mutters.

Half an hour later, he's in Mirai's car in perfect order again, going to talk with a boy he'd helped mold into ruthless purpose.

Keigo knows why Kiddo agreed to this. He gets it, he'd definitely make the same choice, but he still sends feathers through not just the parking garage but every building within three blocks of it. Just because he doesn't find anyone waiting to spring out for the arrest doesn't mean they aren't there, but it at least makes sure the more destructive heroes aren't around.

"What are you getting from this?" he asks despite already knowing. He just wants to hear how Kiddo might lie to himself about it.

Kiddo's lips twitch into a sad impression of a smile before dropping again. "Maybe I just want to see him alive."

Which is fair, Keigo supposes. He refuses to leave Kiddo to face this on his own though, no matter how the brat tried to convince him before giving in mostly so they wouldn't be late. Of course, Kiddo's version of 'late' is still about a half hour early, so they had plenty of time to scope the place for traps, bugs, and enemies.

It's still so weird to consider other heroes to be enemies. Though, it's really only because most heroes aren't willing to take that final step for removing dangers to the public. If it weren't for that specific difference in philosophy, Kiddo would never have to resort to his favored methods.

A sleek but understated car turns into the garage, drawing Keigo out of his thoughts. It pulls up to the space on the other side of a concrete barrier Kiddo had sat himself behind, then Sir Nighteye steps out. He gives Keigo a narrow look (also fair, but Keigo wants to be more offended by it) before stepping around the car to pull out… Ah. Collapsible wheelchair. Somehow, he'd kind of forgotten about this part. It doesn't look like what he'd been expecting, but he supposes it's a better design for someone who doesn't want to get pushed

around. No arm rests, easier access to the large wheels and their round handles, shorter back. No foot rests either, for obvious reasons.

Sir Nighteye's broad body hides most of the view as a figure pulls themself out from the care and onto the chair. By the time he closes the door, All Might is already situated. The emaciated form under baggy clothes, all that's left of the once mighty hero, shakes Keigo to his core. He doesn't let this show on his face and a glance at Kiddo finds him similarly emotionally masked. Sir Nighteye takes no action to assist as All Might makes his way around to the front of the car on his own power. There's that stubborn pride, nice to see it still exists. The rumors he's been able to pick up on All Might's emotional state hadn't been hopeful.

"Kiddo," Sir Nighteye greets. Another hard look Keigo's way before he begrudgingly adds, "Hawks."

"Been a while," Keigo can't help but say with a grin that just sours Sir Nighteye's expression even more.

"Play nice," Kiddo tells him with a side eye before turning his attention entirely onto All Might. "This could have been avoided."

"Young man-"

"All you had to do was let me kill him first."

All Might sighs. "You know I couldn't do that."

"Should have left the moment she broke the cuff," Kiddo mutters to himself as if he hadn't heard that. He glances off, lips pressed in a tight line.

"We came to warn you," Sir Nighteye says, cutting off that line of conversation. "Due to your recent actions and with All For One presumed dead, *you* have been put to the top of the most wanted list."

Keigo whistles. Kiddo barely looks fazed.

"That usually happens earlier," he says with a slow blink.

"It's been decided that you must be brought down." There's a pause as Sir Nighteye visibly gathers himself before finishing, "Dead or alive."

Startling, Keigo jerks his gaze onto Kiddo, but his boss doesn't look surprised.

"That usually happens earlier, too," is all he has to say on the matter. He crosses his arms, shifting to lean up against one of the cement support columns. "Well. You're definitely out of the fighting *now*. If this timeline fails, I promise I'll put you in a coma next time so you can't get hurt like this."

Keigo is pretty sure that's equal parts comfort and threat. From the look on All Might's face, he agrees.

“What are your next moves?” Sir Nighteye asks, changing the subject with all the grace of a newly hatched bird. “What could possibly be made better by making yourself such a target?”

“Maybe we’re just bored,” Keigo says and is ignored.

Kiddo tilts his head as he looks over Sir Nighteye’s face for several moments. “What would happen if someone called in a sighting of me?”

For a most wanted? All nearby and available heroes would be called to the scene to try and overwhelm him by force or just keep him occupied until someone with a well suited quirk can get there. The faster it happens, the better. Kind of hard for a villain to get ready for a random deluge while waiting for the heaviest hitters to arrive.

“You’re using yourself as *bait?*” All Might sounds almost offended on his behalf, and frankly? Even though Keigo knew about this, he’s offended too. But he’s been offended for weeks now without anything coming of it. He doubts that’ll change anytime soon.

“It’s the easiest way to make sure the strongest heroes descend on my location.” He could stand to sound less smug about it. “And so that it’s easier for them if they have to put me down like a feral animal.”

Over Keigo’s *dead body.*

“You shouldn’t be so quick to throw away your life. This is a dangerous game you’re playing, young Midoriya,” All Might says.

“Not really,” is the not even a little bit flippant response. “We’re out of time for being careful. I’ve narrowed down the lab where Shigaraki’s nomu is incubating. My team is hitting it tomorrow.”

Keigo shoots him a sideways glance. They’re apparently moving the mission up by a whole week? Well, it’s not like they aren’t prepared already but Spinner and Twice are going to complain about it.

“Might as well nip it in the bud,” he says without letting on about his surprise.

“We’ll kill Dr. Garaki and Shigaraki’s nomu, if it isn’t ready to decant,” Kiddo continues. “That’s enough to avoid the apocalypse and keep you and Kacchan safe.”

Except it hasn’t been before. Keigo knows without even asking. They’ve all been busting their asses getting ready for this and doing all the little tasks Kiddo asks that never seem connected, but Keigo is pretty sure they’ve all been to nudge chance a little more in their favor.

“And if you fail?” Sir Nighteye asks, jaw clenched.

“It won’t be hard to restart.”

None of them are okay with the reminder of Kiddo’s ease with suicide. It’s probably the only thing Keigo and Sir Nighteye have ever agreed upon in their lives.

“This can’t be the only way,” All Might says.

“If there was another, I’d have already found it,” Kiddo replies.

Sir Nighteye looks between them, glances at Keigo, and then turns his full attention onto Kiddo. “You’re telling us too much. You have no intention of letting us leave.”

“Of course I don’t,” Kiddo says with a smile. “You’re going to be locked up safely until tomorrow

evening. Either my team will let you out then or UA will receive a preprogrammed message letting them know where you are in two days.”

It isn’t that easy, of course. Still, Sir Nighteye can’t fight off all of Kiddo’s inner circle by himself. Not when he has something to protect. Even when it turns out one of his sidekicks is around as she comes out from under some kind of cloaking quirk effect to help, there’s not much difference. They just capture and take her, too.

Keigo tries to feel bad about this, but Kiddo’s right. They’ll be safer this way.

This is his greatest creation. His magnum opus. And it is so *beautiful.*

Human shaped the nomu might be, only somewhat thicker around than Shigaraki had been, but the strength he’s packed into it is sure to bring about his master’s great empire easily. There’s enough extra mass for any sort of transformative quirk that gets used on it. Hair that’s truly white now hangs in tangled clumps as the incubation fluid drains away, leaving his nomu hanging by the nutrition cables. Garaki untangles it carefully, knowing the moment the nomu wakes-

A slim hand curls tight around his throat, one finger lifted from muscle memory but the other three plenty to cut off Garaki’s air. That’s the problem with nomus that have any sort of mind left over. They tend to react negatively to others being in their personal space. Still, this at least proves to be an excellent test over whether said mind actually exists now.

White eyes open before the balls roll down for crimson irises to be visible. They focus on Garaki’s face for a few seconds before something more than instinct shows behind them and it lets him go. Garaki falls back to the ground, sputtering as his creation steps out of the tank by himself. Already mobile, such *perfection*.

There are enough quirks stuffed into this body for his benefactor’s purposes, either due to Garaki’s hand or his own. That even conflicting quirks coexisting is a triumph of science on the level of inventing the steam engine. Kurogiri might have turned out a successful prototype, but he doesn’t hold a candle to this creature.

“Clothes,” he chokes out, waving one hand wildly towards the pile left out on an examination table along with a towel. There’s no answer, just the rubbing of cloth against skin and hair. The used towel flops to the floor next to him. Garaki’s barely gotten his breath back, but he struggles up to his feet anyway to look over the nomu.

When dressed, it's harder to notice that it isn't human. Garaki was so very careful to maintain Shigaraki's shape, just as All For One bade him. A victorious laugh bubbles up in his sore throat. The nomu turns and gazes at him before slowly smiling.

"We have work to do," All For One says as the last button of his shirt slides into place.

Indeed, they have such great work to undertake.

The lab is empty when they get there. Dabi was afraid this would happen with the time they'd had to spend getting All Might, Sir Nighteye, and the sidekick corralled uninjured into the newest safehouse Giran set up for them. There are twenty dotting the city now, plenty of ways for them to rest, reload, or disappear. Now, one will just have to function as a hostage holding cell. They've got several of the lackeys watching over them with strict orders to keep them comfortable. It took entirely too long to get that all set up.

He doesn't tell Kiddo that he told him so. It'd just make Kiddo sigh.

Not that Kiddo isn't already sighing. He runs a hand down his face as he glances around again, as if their targets might suddenly appear. "We took too long securing Nighteye and All Might."

Point to Dabi. The victory gives him a bit of a thrill despite the situation.

"I still don't understand why we did that in the first place," Spinner grumbles to himself. None of them deem it worthy of reply, considering Spinner has made a habit of grumbling about heroes. It's one shared with several others of their number.

"Toga, anything in the news?" Kiddo asks instead. Nearby, Himiko pulls out the jailbroken, untraceable smartphone she mostly uses to play Candy Crush. It works just as well to check on news feeds, police radio channels, and internet chatter.

"Nope, looks clear, bestie."

That doesn't seem to settle Kiddo at all. "Shoot a message over to Twice and Hawks. Let's get moving."

"Boss?" Spinner asks despite already moving to follow orders.

"If they're already gone, we need to get to UA," Kiddo says grimly as he turns to leave. "Before it's too late and this timeline becomes unsalvageable."

Maybe they don't all get Kiddo's time travel thing, but they know what he'll do if he thinks he's failed in his mission. Sharing a glance with the others, Dabi decides that's not something he's willing to witness.

"You heard him," he says when the others hesitate, but they hadn't needed much in the way of encouragement to get going. None of them want to see that, either.

Something lit a fire under Bakugou's ass. Shouta has an inkling into what it was, but not the *intention.* It seems like everything ends up going back to Kiddo and his schemes to save those precious to him. A couple weeks assisting with disaster cleanup is enough to frustrate anyone just as much as it exhausts, but Bakugou still has way too much energy. Something's driving him harder than ever.

Is it just his need to be seen as strong pushing him like this? In front of Shouta, Bakugou forces his body ruthlessly to give him ever more focused explosions with his control sharpening after every one. The sheer destructive power at his fingertips is far greater than any of them know, Shouta included. This boy will become a high ranked hero if he lives that long.

The attitude will need some honing first, though. Not everyone can get away with Endeavor's level of belligerence. Which just reminds him of one of his other problem children. Todoroki still only uses ice. Nothing any of them have said or done has made a dent on the walls built around his quirk and heart. At this point, Shouta's not even sure if the fireside will be help rather than hindrance.

Shouta's had students with mental blocks in the past, but Todoroki's icy exterior hasn't cracked at all despite several attempts by other students. He's polite but firm with them. It's no different with Shouta or any other teacher as far as he's been told. Some of the other boys are still trying to be friendly with him, but only Uraraka of the girls tries for more than cordial acceptance with him. She's one Shouta keeps an eye on as he considers how best to hone her soft skills further. Most of the class is a wash for that sort of thing, but Uraraka knows how to smile when she'd rather stab someone.

He makes a mental note to never advise bladed weaponry to supplement her quirk.

Well. Regardless of Todoroki's attempts to prove himself to be an island, Shouta has a duty to look after him in any and every way he can. The abuse investigation is ongoing, hampered by Todoroki's refusal to talk about it and his older sister growing protective of their now quirkless father. There's been some talk about seeing if Eri can restore him, but in light of the allegations, that's been set to rest for if Endeavor is ruled not guilty.

Ugh, this is why Shouta has spent so much of his time refusing to get close to people. Having personal stakes in their lives is exhausting, and he has enough trouble just dealing with the Kiddo situation.

And then an explosion that Bakugo has nothing to do with blasts through part of UA's outer wall near enough to Gym Gamma for rubble to knock against the building. Shouta's out the door a second later to take the situation in, but the heavy duty barrier has already shot up from the ground to make UA into a veritable fortress. Shouta digs his phone out of his pocket with it already ringing from exactly the person he needed to speak with.

"What the hell was that?" he asks immediately as he runs toward the wall. There's more wreckage than brick and plaster there. Metal shrapnel of some sort litters the grass with fire flicking up from several pieces.

“A bus,” Nedzu says. “The cameras shorted out just before it hit. We don’t know if anyone got onto the grounds. Can you confirm?”

“No one in sight and I got here quickly.” That doesn’t mean he didn’t miss anyone, of course. “Assume someone did.”

“I’ve already alerted all other teachers to follow intruder procedures.”

At least the non-hero classes will be safe as long as no one gets any stupid ideas into their heads and no villains bust down the internal barriers no doubt already slammed shut over the windows and inner walls of the school.

A shout from behind finds his class heading his way because of course they would. Only a few of them have anything approaching self preservation instincts. It’s not an uncommon problem with heroes, no matter how hard Shouta works to beat that lesson into them.

“Vlad King has begun a sweep of the school,” Nedzu says.

“We’ll handle the grounds.”

Shouta ends the call and shoves his phone away into his pocket. It’s time to see how much his students have learned.

“Teams of three,” Shouta starts, guiding the students into organizing themselves and then sending them to scout different areas of the school with strict orders *not* to engage. The moment they see someone they don’t know, they’re to contact him instead. He’s reasonably sure they’ll listen.

If not, he can always expel them after all this blows over.

Chapter End Notes

Buckle up folks, time to make some more chaos

End Notes

Bootleg Carrd

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!